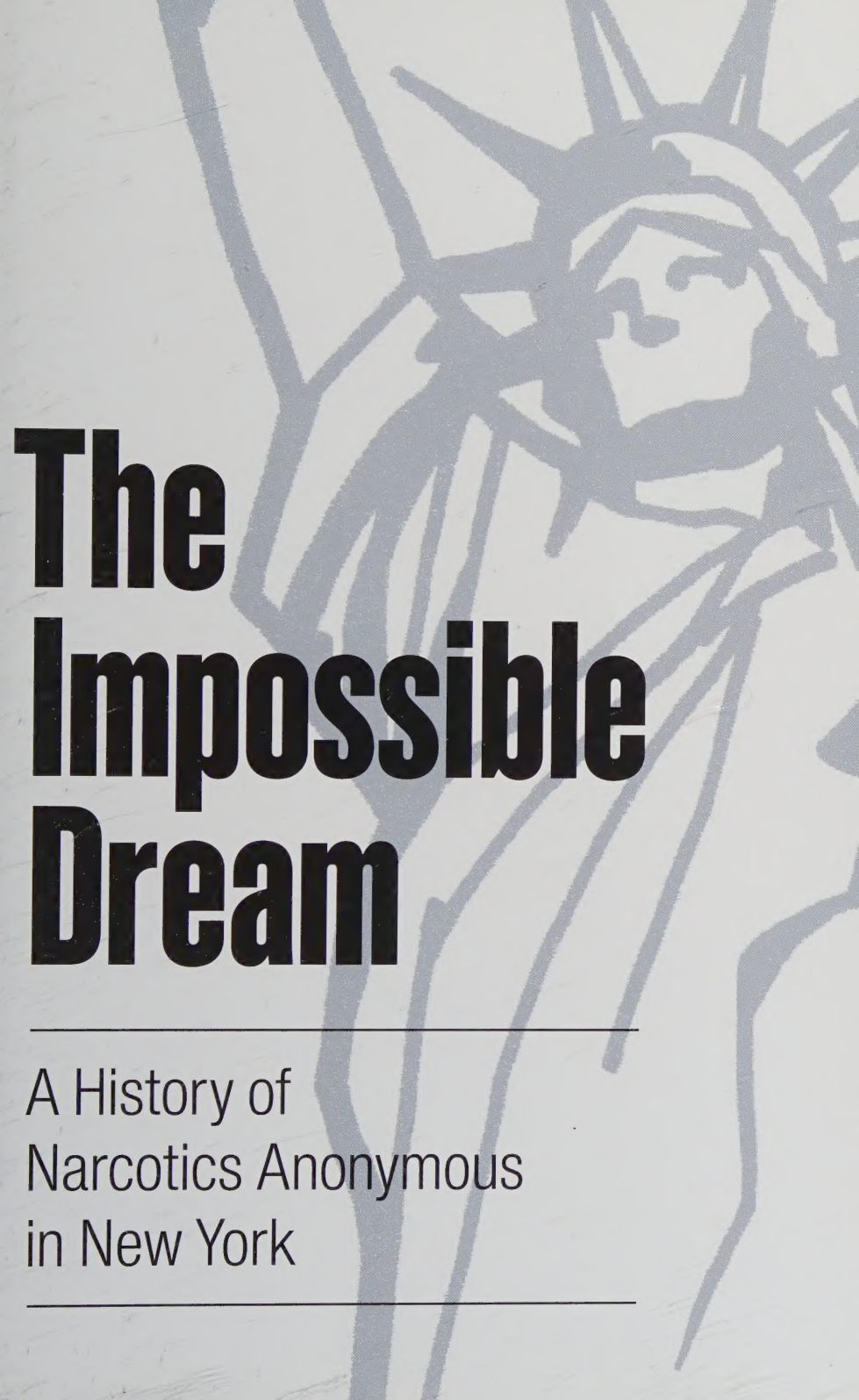


The Impossible Dream

A History of Narcotics Anonymous in New York

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©2015

The Impossible Dream:
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To our predecessors
Who are heard again in their own voice
And in stories about them told by addicts who are still here.

"Give us your sick, your tired, your humbled addicts, yearning to be FREE."

—Theme of WCNA 13, 1983

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PREFACE

". . . that this may truly be your work, not ours, in order that no addict, anywhere, need die from the horrors of addiction."
—Literature Prayer,
Narcotics Anonymous, fifth edition, p. xvi

There was an overflow of old-timers at the anniversary, and members of the Ad Hoc History Book Subcommittee of the Greater New York Region were working the room, tracking them down, then leading them to a quiet spot and turning on the tape recorder. Answering our questions was not a simple task. It required dredging up memories of events that happened thirty years ago when most of them were still in the fog of early recovery, but the effort seemed to awaken long-dormant brain cells. Time and again, up came the information we needed—names, places, and events not thought about for years—the collective oral history gathered for this book. Then came the final question: "From your heart, what was it like, getting clean back then?" and up came the feelings, tears and laughter, as the significance of that time was revisited from a perspective of multiple decades in recovery.

A hundred and forty interviews later, having gathered and transcribed recollections of trusted servants from every county in the Greater New York Region who got clean before mid- 1985, plus interviews with many non-addicts who helped us during our formative years, we began writing. At this point we were amazed to find that these scattered bits of information slid together like pieces of a giant puzzle, revealing a synchronicity that we didn't expect to find. It is the story of how many addicts seeking recovery in different

parts of the region, often without knowledge of each other, started Narcotics Anonymous meetings in their own neighborhoods, each playing a role in a drama that was greater than any of them knew.

By necessity, much of this history is based on collective memory, as writing things down for future reference was not high on anyone's agenda back then. There are gaps in our archives of Area and Regional minutes, early meeting lists are rare and often undated, and World Service records of registered meetings in New York City for that time are not available. When, after diligent effort we have not been able to find written sources, we have followed a principle of journalistic integrity which requires that facts without reliable written documentation be corroborated verbally by three independent primary sources—people who actually witnessed an event. In the interest of objectivity, we have included conflicting versions of oral accounts when documenting a number of controversies in our early history that exist to this day.

We also had an obligation to respect the principle of anonymity, the spiritual foundation of our fellowship. Attribution of facts quoted from the interviews is by first name and surname initial, with the member's permission. Where this was not received we have used pseudonyms. In addition, because this is a narrative history, told by addicts, it is also full of opinions and commentary. These are expressed anonymously and in quotes throughout, including contrary opinions for balance. Epigrams that introduce the chapters are excerpts from interviews, and are also anonymous.

Initially, the parameters of this history book were 1981 to 1985, the years between the first meetings in New York City and Freedom I, the first regional convention, but as word of the work we were doing spread throughout the fellowship, we began to receive information from NA researchers around the country about the existence of Narcotics Anonymous meetings in New York as far back as 1949. At first we were skeptical, but after collecting stacks of documentation from many sources, including some recent discoveries, plus having the good fortune to interview several addict advocates who played a role in events that took place in the

1950s, we extended the time frame. This early history is told for the first time from a New York perspective—NA as it was then—in the city with the most punishing anti-addict policy of that era. The title of this book cannot be fully understood without it.

Unlike other 12-Step histories, there are no stars here, no founders' photos to hang on the meeting room wall. Instead, you will meet the most unlikely combination of people ever assembled to bring about a miracle. They represent the full spectrum of human diversity that is uniquely New York. Ex-cons and punk rockers, drugstore cowboys and junkie girls, bookmakers and bookkeepers, gutter hikes and Wall Street brokers, juvenile delinquents and pill-popping grandmas, made men and clergymen, debutantes and desperados, hustlers, scammers, cat burglars, upright citizens, street people, scary people, misfits of every stripe, some of them nuts—this ragtag group of characters is what the God of our understanding assembled to bring Narcotics Anonymous as we know it today to New York. The incredible things they accomplished between 1981 and 1985 is the impossible dream we celebrate in this book. Our aim has been to give this history continuity—where it came from, how it got started, why it disappeared, how it reappeared, and how it grew—from two meetings to the fourth largest region of Narcotics Anonymous in the world. At last, after eight years, we have a book, and our task is done.

In loving service,
The Ad Hoc History Book Subcommittee
of the Greater New York Region

PART I

Our Way of Life

"There are no coincidences in NA."

Big Jay, a recovering addict from Brooklyn, moved to Florida in the early nineties where he met Jack, an original member of the Key West group, one of Florida's earliest meetings. Jack was dying of cancer and asked Jay to come to his house and go through some old NA archives. "There were many boxes, and this poor guy spent four hours with me on his hot screened-in porch while I went through the papers and stuff. I don't know where he got them, and I wasn't really interested, but I did it for him."

Then he saw something that got his attention. It was a copy of incorporation papers for Narcotics Anonymous, Inc., issued by the State of New York and dated March 1951. His discovery set him on a quest to find out more about this heretofore unknown history.

Meanwhile, in Pennsylvania, another recovering addict named David F was browsing in a used bookstore when a title caught his eye. It was *Monkey on my Back*, written in 1953. "I bought the book for three bucks. I read the chapter about Danny C and NA in New York City in the fifties, and that's what lit the fire in me." David called the World Service Office and was put in touch with Greg P, who was also interested in NA history, who put him in touch with a man in charge of a Manhattan Day Top Village. He told him about Dr. Charles Winick, who was actively involved with NA back then. "I tracked him down. When he told me NA was incorporated I called Albany and got the papers in the mail."

Independent of each other, these addicts made contact with other people in the fellowship who were curious about this hidden history, and they started sharing information. What finally emerged is the story of Narcotics Anonymous as it was then in New York City, where for the first time addicts seeking recovery met openly, in public places they thought were safe, only to be raided by the police. And still they kept on going, for 20 years, in spite of an anti-addict environment that was vicious in the extreme.

Chapter 1 The Legacy of Danny C

"How can you get to where you're going if you don't know where you've been?"

He was born in 1907 in the little town of Humacao on the east coast of Puerto Rico. His father was a Danish sea captain and his mother was a native of Puerto Rico. When Danny C was three years old she died in childbirth and his father died the following year. At the age of five he was adopted by a medical doctor from the United States, a single woman, and he spent his childhood living on the grounds of a Missouri hospital, accompanying his mother on her rounds. "He was a prepossessing blue-eyed little boy, charming in manner, quiet and obedient," she wrote.[1]

Danny grew up secure in the belief that one day he would also become a doctor, a useful member of society, and his mother was proud. "His diplomatic, gentlemanly behavior would put to shame most American children." But when he was sixteen years old unforeseen events derailed that happy future. Instead of becoming a doctor, her adopted son would later describe the next 25 years of his life as "the existence of the damned, of abject misery and slavery of the most vicious kind."

> I was suffering from an abscessed eardrum, and my mother gave me morphine to relieve the excruciating pain. I liked the feeling it gave me. In spite of my interest in medicine, I did not know what addiction was or how it was caused, and "narcotics" was only a word to me. After my ear was operated on, the medication was discontinued. I asked my mother for more of the little

white pills. She refused.[2]

But Danny knew where the pills were hidden in the kitchen, and like a kid stealing cookies, he helped himself. "I associated daily with dozens of doctors and nurses, yet none of them suspected that I was taking drugs. But in the stranger-than-fiction way in which one addict invariably encounters others, a barber in the hospital asked me what I was taking and I showed him my morphine tablets. Then he told me about heroin." The older man showed him how to skin pop and became his supplier. One day he disappeared and Danny soon became violently ill. Unable to find out the cause of his alarming condition, his mother called in other doctors, who were also at a loss.

> As I lay writhing in agony, believing that I was dying, I remembered how the morphine relieved the pain in my ear and asked a nurse to bring me some. She left the room but did not return. Instead my foster mother and another doctor came in. Dawning awareness in her eyes, my mother stood by while the doctor administered morphine. A person suffering from withdrawal illness becomes completely well as soon as narcotics are taken. It was then that I saw the horror in my mother's eyes and learned I was a drug addict.

His mother was never able to acknowledge how her son had become an addict. She attributed it to a "psychopathic" personality, a common opinion of the medical establishment of that time. "Having studied such problems all my adult life, I am forced to the conclusion that some are constitutionally inadequate, emotionally, and withdrew any further support and interest."[3]

Teenage Danny began his sojourn through hell, in and out of jails and institutions, now and then able to stay clean long enough to hold down a job. His wanderings eventually brought him to New York City. There he didn't use drugs for three years, fell in love, got

married, became a father, and then the compulsion to use drugs returned, stronger than ever. In 1935, at the age of 22, he became part of the first group of prisoner patients to enter the newly opened U.S. Public Health Service Hospital outside Lexington, Kentucky. For the next 13 years, Danny C got caught in the hospital's revolving door of release, relapse, and return.

The Narco Farm

Jointly run by the Bureau of Prisons and the U.S. Public Health Service, this hospital-with-bars was the first public institution in the country where addicts could go for treatment, and the only medical facility in the world where addiction research was conducted on human beings. Medical researchers at what was often called the "Narco Farm" had been given the mandate to discover a scientific cure for addiction. Patients who volunteered to be subjects at the hospital's Addiction Research Center were studied while they went through a program of detoxification followed by re-addiction to various kinds of narcotics, including the new synthetic "wonder drugs." Researchers would then observe their withdrawal and test them for the drug's side effects and addictive potential.

At that time few people objected to these experiments. Doctors found them useful, because they had yet to fulfill their mandate and continued to be baffled over the nature of addiction. The pharmaceutical industry also had no objections as they could profit from selling the new drugs once the Research Center had deemed they were safe. Nor was there any public outcry because most people thought addicts were moral degenerates. As for the addict volunteers, "The guys on research had a great life. I mean, hey, would you rather wait around for some kind of dope to be shot into you or work on the farm?"[4]

Addicts Anonymous

By Danny's seventh trip to Lexington in 1947, he was in a state of

hopeless despair. His wife had divorced him and remarried, his son didn't even know who he was,[5] his kidneys were failing, and he was convinced that he would die an addict. On that trip, Danny was introduced to something new at the Narco Farm. It was a group called Addicts Anonymous, founded earlier that year by Houston S, a highway engineer from Montgomery, Alabama, and a member of Alcoholics Anonymous since 1944.[6] Houston had befriended a man named Harry, who was addicted to the morphine that he took for his hangovers. He had taken the "cure" at Lexington but had relapsed soon after his release. By attending AA meetings in Montgomery, Harry had been able to stop drinking, but his drug use continued until he was arrested and readmitted to the Narcotics Farm.

Houston S was baffled over the failure of a program that worked so effectively to curb Harry's compulsion to drink but did nothing for his compulsion to use drugs. Although addicts could not attend closed AA meetings, where they could study the 12 Steps and other aspects of the program, they were allowed to go to open meetings as long as they remained silent about their drug use. Despite all these restrictions, a few addicts, among them Dr. Tom in Shelby, North Carolina, had managed to stay clean this way. Bill W, a founder of AA, called them "straight addicts,"[7] and although Bill had high regard for Dr. Tom, he was generally ambivalent about having drug addicts attend Alcoholics Anonymous meetings.

> It is a strange fact that we alcoholics are very, very intolerant of people who take "dope" and it is just as strange that they are very intolerant of us. I remember meeting one, one day, in the corridor of a hospital. I thought he was an alcoholic, so I stopped the man and asked him for a match. He drew himself up with great hauteur and said, "Get away from me, you damned alcoholic!"[8]

Houston S had no personal experience with drugs other

than alcohol, but he was supportive of addicts seeking recovery in AA meetings. Although he had little success with helping Harry stay off drugs, he remained "convinced that the twelve Suggested Steps would work . . . if conscientiously applied."[9]

In September 1946, when a job-related move brought Houston to Frankfort, Kentucky, 20 miles from the hospital at Lexington, he sought out the medical director, Victor H. Vogel, MD, told him what he had learned from working with Harry, and volunteered to start a group in the hospital that addressed the special needs of addicts. Doctor Vogel accepted his offer, and the first meeting of Addicts Anonymous was held on February 16, 1947. Some months later, Harry returned as a voluntary patient.

It was at the Narco Farm that Houston S would become a towering figure in the history of Narcotics Anonymous. At that time, not only was it uncommon for recovering alcoholics to work with addicts, carrying the AA message into prisons or institutions was not a fellowship-wide established practice, and it was often met with resistance from within AA, making Houston's service to the addicts at Lexington all the more significant.[10] There he and other volunteers from an AA group in Frankfort introduced to a small group of prisoners and voluntary patients the program of Alcoholics Anonymous—with one significant change. When they read the literature Houston told them to verbally or mentally substitute the word "drugs" for the word "alcohol." It was the first 12-Step meeting in the world where addicts were not only allowed but encouraged to talk about their problems with drugs.

"After a month of sullen silence, Danny began attending these meetings, which were a new feature since his last trip,"[11] but he was turned off by the religious aspect of the program. "Like most addicts, I didn't care anything about God. It might work for those drunks, but not for us."[12] Danny said he was not a complete stranger to prayer. He had prayed for drugs in desperate situations, but never for the kind of spiritual guidance that Houston was talking about. "I still wouldn't talk...but I did some listening. Harry came back one time and told us his story, and I was impressed by what

Houston had to say."[13]

Back in New York City, however, with temptation for sale on every corner, he relapsed once again after what he called "a period of enforced abstinence."[14] Having lost all hope, he tried to commit suicide. After recovering in a local hospital, he was sent back to Lexington for the eighth time.

It was during this trip that Danny hit his bottom, a place that addicts describe to people who have never been there, as the moment they finally realize that the only way out of the hole they have dug themselves into is to stop digging.

> He was alone in the darkness of his room. Without conscious volition he began to pray. He spoke humbly in the darkness, saying that he was powerless to help himself and that, if he was to continue living, only God could help him. This, Danny claims, was his first honest prayer.[15]

When Danny awoke the next morning, he was aware that something momentous had happened. His previous concept of recovery as a state of self-enforced abstinence had changed. "Everything Houston and Harry had been saying suddenly made sense. . . . There was a lawyer from a southern city there at the time, and a Midwestern surgeon. They were in the same mood I was—disgusted with themselves and ready to change. The three of us used to have long talks with Houston every Saturday morning, besides the regular meetings."[16] The first time he heard Harry talk about how he had followed the 12 Steps of the Alcoholics Anonymous program and lost the desire to use drugs it had seemed incomprehensible. Now he began hearing other recovering addicts say the same thing, that the compulsion had been "miraculously" lifted. Then he experienced it himself. To any addict who has had this experience, no further proof is needed.

An idea had begun to form in Danny's mind. He began studying the AA literature that was used at the Addicts Anonymous

meetings, taking notes on where it applied to his own experience and where it didn't, and where Houston had made important changes. His idea then changed into a plan, and he instituted a correspondence club with former patients. It is also likely that he was active in the drafting of a pamphlet the group was working on at that time called *Our Way of Life*, the first piece of 12-Step literature that spoke directly to addicts.[17] Upon his final discharge from the hospital in March 1949, Danny was ready to fulfill his mission—to start Addicts Anonymous meetings in New York City—with one change. He would call the group Narcotics Anonymous[18] to avoid the confusion of having two 12-Step groups called AA.

Dolly Berry, An Addict's Only Friend

While Danny was a patient at Lexington, he had heard about a Salvation Army "Sallie" named Dorothy Berry, a native of Greenwich Village who worked out of the Women's House of Detention on Greenwich Avenue and West 10th Street. Major Berry was the Salvation Army's Eastern Territory director of the Correctional Services Bureau for Women and in that capacity she had been convincing New York law enforcement officials to send female addicts to Lexington as an alternative to incarceration. Although affectionately called Dolly, this unassuming woman[19] who had made the rehabilitation of addicts her life's work was a force to be reckoned with in her dealings with legislators, law enforcement, prison officials, and other service organizations. At that time, she was probably the only person who had the connections and the commitment to help Danny C get Narcotics Anonymous started in New York City.

When Danny told her of his plan, Dorothy Berry offered him a Sunday afternoon meeting at the Women's House of Detention. Not only was he providing a resource that had previously not existed, "He had one asset no social worker had—he had experienced every conceivable degradation that addiction brings and managed his escape."[20] Although the meetings were well attended, Danny had

no illusions, remembering how skeptical he had been at his first Addicts Anonymous meetings. Knowing the addict's typical mind set, he also kept the talk about God to a minimum. One inmate described his impact: "It might not have done any good the first time you heard Danny, but sooner or later you decided to try his way."[21]

Danny remained in frequent communication with Addicts Anonymous and the many former patients in the New York area who received issues of *The Key*, their newsletter. Major Berry was another liaison, regularly meeting women she had referred to Lexington upon their release. She developed the radical opinion that the rural isolation of the Kentucky method didn't work. "Geographical cures, away from familiar surroundings, are not the answer. So many who think they are cured begin to use drugs again when they get back to their home city. It is better to face the problem where the addict is living."[22]

But these women who had just been released back into the real world were not keen about going to meetings in the House of Detention, and there was no place at all for the men coming out of Lexington to go. Narcotics Anonymous needed to be held outside of an institution, and for that to happen in New York City circa 1950, it had to be done by someone in a position of authority with impressive powers of persuasion. Like Dolly Berry. Even so, she was unsuccessful for months (for a while they met on the Staten Island Ferry) due to the prevailing attitude that addicts congregated only to exchange information on how to get drugs and the money to pay for them.

Finally she persuaded members within her own organization to provide a meeting space in the Salvation Army's Lowenstein Cafeteria, part of their complex at 535 West 48th Street between 10th and 11th avenues, a block from the West Side piers, in an area of Manhattan called Hell's Kitchen. The neighborhood had long been dangerous, and that section of the waterfront had now become a port of entry for a lucrative heroin operation, run by Charles (Lucky) Luciano, recently deported to Italy.[23] A neighborhood controlled by

an international heroin cartel was hardly the ideal meeting place for a group of addicts that wanted to stop using drugs, but it was their only option.

Although there is indication in later newspaper sources that the first meeting opened in late January or early February, the earliest documentation is from the Lexington, Kentucky, *Herald*, dated April 26, 1950: "There is reported to be one other small group of Addicts Anonymous [sic] operating in New York City, organized by a former patient at the hospital here who corresponds regularly—the first in the world to operate as a combat team against addiction."[24] Four people showed up at that first meeting, and most likely they were also former patients, as it was too risky to allow addicts to attend who were still using. Each week new people kept showing up, and their numbers doubled, then tripled by June. An account of these early meetings describes a familiar scene: a cafeteria with "stacked chairs on tables, a floor damp from scrubbing, and a janitor who was always ready to turn out his lights for the night. . . . But they could talk and smoke and they had a place where they could meet and encourage one another. For the first time the addict was actually wanted in a positive, helpful community-based program."[25]

Just showing up at this Narcotics Anonymous meeting took a lot of courage, and not just because of the bad neighborhood. As soon as they walked through the cafeteria door they were breaking the loitering law, which made it a crime for addicts to congregate, but they didn't even have to be congregating. An addict could also be arrested for standing alone on a street corner without a "valid explanation."[26]

As far as the law was concerned, there was a great disparity between being addicted to alcohol and being addicted to drugs. It was not against the law for alcoholics to go off the wagon, but it was a federal crime for addicts to go back on drugs. Alcoholics could be arrested for their behavior, but addicts could be arrested just for being addicts. They didn't have to be caught selling, or intending to sell, or in possession of drugs or drug paraphernalia to be breaking

the law. Merely having track marks on their arms were grounds for an arrest on the charge of "internal possession" of a narcotic.[27]

Musicians had a special reason for staying away from an NA meeting. They were required to apply for a cabaret card, issued by the NYPD Division of Licenses, before they could perform in a place where alcohol was served, which pretty much applied to any nightclub, including all the famous jazz clubs on 52nd Street. For musicians seeking recovery from addiction, attending an NA meeting put them in double jeopardy, risking their livelihood as well as a drug conviction. Even musicians who had never used an illegal drug in their life could lose their cabaret card. "I could be dying and my best friend would leave me in the street like a dog...and I couldn't hate him too much. He could be as clean as the day he was born and lose his job and his police card just for being with me."[28] Musicians who applied for a reinstatement of their cabaret card were at the whim of the NYPD, which had the power to prevent any musician, even superstars like Frank Sinatra and Billie Holiday, from performing anywhere in New York City where liquor was served. From her 1948 drug conviction to her death in 1959, Billie could only perform here in concert halls. This heavy penalty was unique to New York City. "In Philly, Washington, Boston, or Frisco I was a citizen. I could come and go, live and work where I pleased without asking anybody. Not in New York," she told her biographer.[29]

Harry Anslinger: Every Addict's Worst Nightmare

Shortly after the NA meetings started at the Lowenstein Cafeteria, Major Berry got a call from someone in the police department who asked her why she was permitting known addicts to congregate on Salvation Army property. For a while she was able to convince the NYPD to back off, and they even gave Danny personal police protection when he was threatened by gangsters in the neighborhood.[30] However, the Federal Bureau of Narcotics (FBN) under Commissioner Harry J. Anslinger was not so accommodating,

and instead of staking out organized crime figures, his agents regularly staked out NA meetings.

One critic wrote of Anslinger's thirty-two years as the head of the Narcotics Bureau: "He spent much of his lifetime ensuring that society stamp its retribution into the soul of the addict."[31] In the commissioner's opinion, "An addict is a psychopath *before* he acquires his habit."[32] Unfortunately, this was also the prevailing attitude among leading physicians and psychiatrists of the day, including doctors who worked at Lexington. Even the adoptive mother of Danny C believed that her son was a psychopath because his father was much older than his mother! [33]

Having been stigmatized in this way, Danny C had an opinion about addicts being natural-born psychopaths: "Combing an addict's history to find an underlying disturbance proves little if anything," he wrote. "What many experts still have to learn is that the use of opiates *causes* mental disturbances."[34]

According to the Federal Bureau of Narcotics, addicts were not only psychopaths, they were criminals, responsible for 95 percent of the crimes committed in the United States,[35] a dubious statistic that would be repeated for decades. Treatment of these "spectacles of moral degradation" was useless, Anslinger declared, and rehabilitation a pipedream. Incarceration was the only answer, preferably in remote locations where they could not commit violence and contaminate society. The addict as violent criminal was also a view commonly held by members of the New York Police Department Narcotics Squad. Their solution was to "remove procedural obstacles [i.e., the law] which make convictions more difficult."[36]

Not everyone agreed with Anslinger's view of the addict as a violent criminal, particularly in a city where 87 percent of the registered addicts were heroin users. According to Peter Terranova, head of the NYPD Narcotics Squad from 1951 to 1957, "These people [heroin addicts] are very docile and they don't go in for vicious crimes."[37] He wasn't the only law enforcement official who disagreed with "Anslinger the Gunslinger." Dr. Charles Winick, a

psychologist and life-long advocate of addicts, especially musicians denied the right to work, was familiar with members of the New York FBN during those years. "Several working narcotic agents quit because of their disgust over what they were required to do."[38] Winick also agreed with Terranova about the passive nature of heroin addicts. In his essay, "Addiction and Its Treatment," Dr. Winick explains to his peers why jazz musicians call each other "cats."

> Perhaps because they are symbols of passivity. The pet cat traditionally does not play with others, is relatively aloof, and provides a kind of passive companionship. The cat owner has to court the cat, as opposed to the more outgoing and affectionate dog."[39]

For Harry Anslinger, New York City was the epicenter for all the things he despised the most: the most drugs, the most drug peddlers, the most drug users, and the most jazz and jazz musicians. Although he was contemptuous of all addicts, for some reason his greatest fury was directed at these musicians and their "decadent" life style. "Jazz," he wrote, "grew up next to crime."[40] The only place where he tolerated them was behind bars at the Narco Farm—"hundreds of great musicians—Chet Baker, Sonny Rollins—the best jazz band in the world."[41]

Against these overwhelming odds, the prospects for Narcotics Anonymous taking root in New York City could not have been worse, or the need for it greater. But help was on the way.

Our Way of Life

For the first few months, the fledgling NA group kept a low profile. Then word of its existence burst on the scene in an article in the June 18th, 1950, edition of the *New York Times*, and it was shocking. "Group Here Helps Narcotics Addicts" was the headline. What followed was a positively glowing description of how "an

informal society of former addicts" had been helping other addicts by using an adaptation of the program of Alcoholics Anonymous." Group members did not promise the usual bogus "cure," but it did offer a "dedicated 'way of life' in which they pass on the benefits of their experience to other sufferers." According to the article, although Narcotics Anonymous had only been in existence for five months, it had already grown to sixteen members and the meetings had expanded to two nights a week, Tuesday and Friday. What most impressed the *Times* reporter was that not a single member in those five months had relapsed. "Compared with the usual high percentage of backsliders among 'cured' addicts, this is an extraordinary record."

Here was something radically new and promising, a group run not by corrections officers or medical doctors or the clergy or social workers but by addicts who weren't using drugs—the only people who could truly understand what it meant to be an addict who failed at every attempt to stop. It was a revolutionary idea, belying the old adage, "once an addict, always an addict," and quite possibly the first good news about addiction recovery those "other sufferers" and the people who cared about them had ever heard.

The *Times* reporter was also the first to publish direct quotes from the pamphlet *Our Way of Life,* "prepared by the local chapter." It is not unlikely, given his skills as a writer in future publications, that during Danny C's last trip to Lexington he participated[42] in the drafting of this pamphlet. It was written under the guidance of Houston S and other local Alcoholics Anonymous members, and its introduction gives full credit to the AA fellowship. It also gives credit to *A Way of Life,* an AA pamphlet written in 1939 by a newly sober alcoholic,[43] but *Our Way of Life* hardly resembles the earlier pamphlet. Its outdated language ("ex-rummies," "death or the bug house") and upbeat tone ("CURED!") would have little appeal to addicts.

Addiction Is a Disease

In addition to the guidance of the Frankfort group, the authors of

Our Way of Life had access to information from Dr. Victor Vogel and the mountains of data the Addiction Research Center had gathered over fifteen years. Much of this information directly contradicted the anti-addict sentiment that had been promoted for decades by the FBN. According to the Narco physicians, addicts "are criminals because they violate narcotic laws, but research has shown that they pose no serious problem in criminality. . . . These experts concluded that addiction itself is not responsible for any major trend in crime. Compared with the problems arising from the use of barbiturates and alcohol, narcotic addiction is not a great public health hazard."[44]

At Lexington, patients learned they weren't morally inferior. They weren't a menace to society, only to themselves. They weren't mentally inferior, either. In fact, years of intelligence testing at the hospital showed that addicts scored above average. What they did have was a serious illness that Dr. Vogel defined as "a chronic disease with a tendency to relapse."[45]

In the 1940s the so-called disease concept of addiction was still controversial within the medical community and was even debated within the AA fellowship. Bill W was ambivalent, calling it an "outside issue."[46] But these doubts are not reflected in *Our Way of Life,* where the disease of addiction is called "a shattering sickness, physical, emotional, and spiritual," and "an underlying illness that steadily grows worse, never better."

What Is an Addictive Drug?

The pamphlet begins with a list that specifies all the addictive drugs, legal and illegal, that addicts must refrain from using: "Alcohol, sedatives (phenobarbital, seconal, nembutal, luminal, chloral hydrate, amytal—the barbituric acid derivatives), narcotics (morphine, codeine, merperdine [Demerol], heroin—any and all poppy derivatives or synthetics)."[47]

It is significant that alcohol is the first addictive substance on the list, leaving no question that, as far as the members of Addicts Anonymous were concerned, alcohol was a drug. But the inclusion of the barbiturate family was undoubtedly controversial outside

their fellowship and in the medical community. Sedatives were popular drugs, widely prescribed despite a 300 percent increase in deaths by barbiturate poisoning between 1940 and 1950, causing "more deaths than by any other poison."[48]

Because the federal government had not classified barbiturates as an addictive drug, patients were not even eligible for admission to the hospital for use of this drug. Nevertheless, the findings of the Research Center's recent barbiturate study were so disturbing that within the hospital it was "definitely classified as an addictive drug," and its use in treating withdrawal was curtailed.[49] In spite of the risks, barbiturates continued to be widely prescribed and were used in hospital treatment programs for withdrawal well into the sixties.

The Mystery That Defies Medical Understanding

The only aspect of addiction that the doctors at Lexington could not explain was the powerful compulsion to use drugs that caused so many patients to relapse soon after they were discharged from the hospital. They wondered whether the addict who did manage to overcome that compulsion "must be hit by some mysterious spark within himself to make him abstain in the face of temptation."[50] This "mysterious spark" that cannot be explained by medical science is the spiritual awakening—the great promise of the Alcoholics Anonymous program—but in *Our Way of Life,* language that evoked of a religious connection was carefully avoided. It concludes with the *Serenity Prayer,* not the *Lord's Prayer.* It frequently substitutes the word "God" with "The Great Reality," a term that appears in early AA literature: "Addicts Anonymous is the Great Reality which has expelled our obsession."

Much of the language in this pamphlet has a ring of familiarity because it borrows from the AA literature, slightly reworded for addicts to strengthen their bond of identification. Whether the fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous was assisting the newly formed groups of Narcotics Anonymous on the West Coast or on the East Coast, the spiritual awakening was then and still is the

same: that the compulsion to use will be lifted and, by following the 12 Steps, we will be given "the guidance and love we need to live fulfilling, spiritually oriented lives."[51]

The New York Version

The most significant difference between the original *Our Way of Life* and the New York edition is that methadone was added to the list of addictive drugs. This synthetic opiate had been developed by German scientists to solve an opium shortage caused by the blockades of shipping lanes during World War II.[52] It became commercially available in the United States in 1947, and in 1948 the Research Center at Lexington conducted the first U.S. trial. Morphine addicts who had gone through withdrawal were re-addicted, put into an abrupt withdrawal, and then given methadone. The findings were that it "quickly alleviated their symptoms."[53]

Believing they had at last discovered the holy grail the hospital had been mandated to find—"a drug with all the painkilling properties of morphine with none of its addictive qualities—"[54] the researchers immediately replaced morphine and barbiturates with methadone in their detox program. Dr. Vogel found that methadone was "almost as attractive to addicts as morphine or heroin."[55] The addition of methadone in the Narcotics Anonymous pamphlet may have been the result of what Danny C learned from being a participant in this trial or from the 115 addicts who took part in it during his final trip to Lexington, and the medical findings must have confirmed what Danny had known since his unforgettable first withdrawal from opiates at the age of sixteen: *"A person suffering from withdrawal illness becomes completely well as soon as narcotics are taken.*[56] Danny's hard-won experience had taught him early on how to identify an opiate, no matter what pharmaceutical name it was given.

Other small but significant changes were made in the New York Narcotics Anonymous pamphlet:

- Deletion of a reference to a "phenomenal" recovery rate,

which may have reflected the reality of success for a group outside an institution.

- Pronoun change: "They" and "their" changed throughout to "we" and "our."
- The terms "drug addict" and "drug addiction" changed to "addicts" and "addiction." Nevertheless, the group in New York never made the giant leap in understanding from "powerless over drugs" to "powerless over our addiction" made by Jimmy K and California NA.

Another very small and seemingly inconsequential addition speaks volumes about the difference between meetings held within the protective confines of an institution and meetings held in the outside world. To the phrase "No feeling of self-pity, no resentment, no remorse," Danny added "no fear."

The Raids

Sometime after the publication of the June 1950 *New York Times* article, Narcotics Anonymous lost its meeting space at the Lowenstein Cafeteria (the actual date is uncertain) and for a time the group was without a meeting space until Dorothy Berry secured a new home for them at the McBurney Y, then at 215 West 23rd Street. It was definitely an improvement—a busy midtown commercial neighborhood, much safer than Hell's Kitchen, with a number of subway lines just a block or two away. The McBurney Y became a faithful friend to NA, providing them with a meeting space for the next twenty years.

Sometime after the move to the Y, The NYPD narcotics squad began to raid meetings. According to Charles Winick, "Several activists blocked the raiding of NA groups by law enforcement authorities."[57] For reasons that remain unknown, there is no record of these raids in any of the New York papers even though, in the wake of the highly supportive article about the group that had appeared in the *Times*, news of a raid by the narcotics squad would have made for some lurid headlines. Without a doubt, had the story

been published (and why it was not is speculation), it would have been the end of Narcotics Anonymous in New York City.

A number of concerned New Yorkers independently became interested in trying to help NA. One was Burton Lindheim, the journalist who had written the *New York Times* article. Another was Winick. "I was a graduate student at the time. We were concerned when we learned that the local office of the Bureau of Narcotics was interrupting NA meetings at the Y and arresting everybody there on the grounds that they were doing something wrong. I got to know Danny Carlsen quite well. He took a beating from the narcs in the New York Police Department. He was very visible and articulate, an effective advocate for what was then a new idea."[58] But he says it was Major Dorothy Berry who saved the day. "She was a sweetheart. She took the lead in the negotiations with the police department. Peter Terranova was the inspector in charge." How fortunate that at that crucial time Dorothy had an ally in Terranova, one of those rare law enforcement officials who understood the nature of addicts and addiction.[59]

More people of good will came forward as well. Burton Lindheim had also been in touch with Dr. Arnold Bernstein, a noted clinical psychologist and psychotherapist who was interested in addiction research. Bernstein agreed to join in an effort to put together an advocacy group for the group called Narcotics Anonymous, Inc., whose function would be similar to the Alcoholic Foundation, AA's legal trust that was formed when that fellowship was in its infancy, with a similar list of civic-minded individuals making up its Board of Trustees.

According to Dr. Bernstein, "Harry Anslinger was a formidable person who hated drug addicts and as a result influential people were afraid to be connected with them."[60] The commissioner had recently waged an ugly battle with the New York Academy of Medicine after it published a report that was highly critical of his policies. He even singled out certain members, calling them "crackpots," and referred to hospital and clinic detox programs as "morphine feeding centers."[61]

With this obstacle in mind, the organizers of NA Inc. persuaded Marie Nyswander, MD, the foremost authority on the medical approach to working with addicts, to be part of the legal trust. As an "Anslinger man" (she later fell out of favor) her name had a special impact on members of the New York medical community who feared retaliation from the FBN. According to Winick, "We got together informally, we had no name, and so we formed the National Advisory Council on Narcotics (NACON) of Narcotics Anonymous Inc. It was just a letterhead, but we made a lot of noise, we got press coverage through the *Times* editor, and we helped NA get into other places where they might meet."

Dorothy Berry and Burton Lindheim were signatories of the incorporation papers of Narcotics Anonymous Inc., issued March 19, 1951. Danny C signed as the sole recovering addict. The names of twelve influential citizens appear on the NACON letterhead as members of the Board of Directors,[62] including Winick and Bernstein, but both state that aside from its incorporation papers and a letterhead, NA Inc. did not exist. "I never went to a Narcotics Anonymous meeting," said Bernstein. "The Board never met. I only met Danny once. We never raised any money. People might help them out in other ways, but no one was about to write them a check." The purpose of forming N.A. Inc. was solely to meet the group's greatest need: "to help legitimatize this vulnerable group of drug addicts." The group was never raided again.

Jackie Robinson's NA Crusade

"Robbie Racks Dope Racket" ran the headline in the April 28, 1951 issue of *The New York Age,* a Harlem newspaper, announcing a campaign, spearheaded by the Brooklyn Dodgers' star, to drive narcotics racketeers out of Harlem and "establish Harlem chapters of Narcotics Anonymous."[63] The drive was launched by a presentation of Robinson's play, *Dope,* an exposé on the narcotics scourge, at the Union Settlement House on 104th Street in East Harlem. Robinson called the anti-racketeer campaign "one of the

most important events that has ever come to this section of New York. I know this kind of neighborhood and how tough it can be on kids. I grew up in one like it."

Just how tough was not described in the article because that information its readers already knew. Three blocks north of the Union Settlement House was the headquarters of the 107th Street mob. Several years earlier, when the Cosa Nostra divvied up territories in New York, the East Harlem division of the Mob was the biggest in the city in charge of smuggling and distributing opium from Mexico.[64] In a very short time, by selling heroin at bargain-basement prices, the Mob's heroin profits grew from tiny to spectacular and also created an epidemic, especially among young people, their target market, which was rocking the nation.

The 107th Street mob wasn't all the Robinson campaign was up against. There was also Bumpy Johnson, the "Toast of Harlem," loved by famous entertainers. Dispensing with their usual all-in-the-family restrictions, Cosa Nostra had allowed Johnson to operate as an unofficial crime boss on the streets of Harlem.[65]

That still wasn't the extent of the kind of David-and-Goliath action undertaken by this campaign. The East Harlem Protestant Parish, an activist storefront church and sponsor of Robinson's play, was another crusader against invincible foes. The church had found a "critical linkage of the narcotics problem to police corruption, that cops were being paid off." [66]

To put the courage of Jackie Robinson in another perspective, he chose to spearhead this campaign at a time when he was receiving regular death threats for breaking major league baseball's color line. Nothing more was written about his play, and NA meetings in Harlem would not happen for another 30 years, but the positive impact Robinson had on addicts and their advocates at the time can never be diminished. The churches and institutions of East Harlem—the Protestant Parish, the Union Settlement House, ENTER, St. Cecelia's, Our Lady Queen of Angels—became welcoming sanctuaries for generations of addicts to come.

Spreading the Word

That same month Narcotics Anonymous celebrated its first anniversary at the McBurney Y. Once again, the *New York Times* was there. Ex-Addicts Recite Gains ran the headline. Another laudatory article. Group Helps Shake Off Dope's Shackles, appears in the popular *Brooklyn Daily Eagle*, announcing that the event "marked a new era, one in which the ancient superstition that there was a shame attached to addiction may be wiped out."[67]

Two weeks later, NA received its first national attention in *Time* magazine ("The White Stuff," May 7, 1951), which resulted in a flood of requests for information from people around the country as well as hundreds of referrals from local welfare agencies, hospitals, prisons, churches, and physicians. Fortunately, around this time Rae L, a former dancer, became an active member of the group. Like Danny, she was a native of Puerto Rico and had been addicted to opiates since her teens. She had heard about him while a prison patient at Lexington and later met him at a Women's House of Detention meeting. Upon her release this dynamic woman became another moving force in Narcotics Anonymous.

Although the group's numbers kept growing, only a few members had sufficient recovery to be of service to others. There was much for a few people to do. "The whole group takes a lively interest in a new member, putting him at ease," wrote Dr. Nyswander in her book, *The Addict as Patient*. "A new member is assigned to the care of an older member, and whenever the going is rough he calls his patron who usually insists they meet to talk things over. When a member relapses a group effort is immediately directed toward getting him off drugs."[68]

Although the group was too preoccupied with the next crisis to seek publicity, journalists had a way of seeking them. *Family Circle* featured NA in an article about the teenage heroin epidemic ("more deadly than the H Bomb") in October 1951. Shortly afterward, when another mass-market periodical, *People Today,* asked for an interview, the group broke their anonymity in a publication

for the first time. Danny explained: "Some of us here have even volunteered to have our pictures taken to help drive home the addiction problem. We know we're not criminals or degenerates—but sick people trying to get well."[69]

That year Terry Morris, a journalist for *McCall's* magazine, asked Danny for an interview. She had managed to convince her editors to publish his story because he had been a teenage addict and could talk about the teenage heroin epidemic that was alarming parents around the country. Years later she wrote about her association with Danny. Normally he was a closed book, reluctant to talk about himself, too guarded to ever reveal his emotions, but the interview with Morris provides a rare portrait of Danny C, human being.

"He blew hot and cold when I proposed writing an as-told-to story, terribly tense and fearful and suspicious, but I managed to convince him. Working with Danny C was an agonizing experience—the details of his life as an addict: total physical, mental, and emotional degradation, imprisonment, so-called cures, suicide attempt—all of it utterly appalled me. Danny was in frail health and at times he broke down in our interviews. When he did, I wondered whether I was asking too much of him."

The author submitted the article, "Drug Addiction: My Single Track to Hell," to *McCall's*. "It held no punches. It had a stripped-down, stark style I had never used before, but it was appropriate to smack home points Danny wanted to make. The editors were extremely moved, I received my check, and the article was never published."[70]

Danny was not surprised.

By its second anniversary Narcotics Anonymous had also secured another meeting location at the Presbyterian Labor Temple at 242 East 14th Street, where they were also given a tiny office. NA now had three meetings a week: Tuesday and Friday night at the McBurney Y and Wednesday night at the Labor Temple. More than 200 people attended the second anniversary.[71] The word that addicts were sick people trying to get well was spreading like ripples in

a stream, and the effort to get that message out to mainstream America was succeeding beyond anyone's expectations.

Contact with California

On January 2, 1952, Danny wrote a letter to Mrs. Dorothy S, a member of Jimmy K's Alcoholics Anonymous home group, the North Hollywood Club.[72] It is the first documented contact between New York Narcotics Anonymous and the group that Jimmy K and others were in the process of forming in California. Danny was responding to Dorothy's request for information and a copy of *Our Way of Life*. He then comments at length on a topic that they had discussed in their last communication. It reveals the dilemma recovering addicts sometimes faced on both coasts when they went to meetings of Alcoholics Anonymous:

> Unfortunately, what you say is true about the prevalence of addiction among so-called "recovered" alcoholics in A.A. Sometimes, alcoholism is the basic problem and sleeping pills or narcotics are used as a "substitute" by the members. But they cannot be practicing members of A.A. and live the program if they fool themselves in this way. I'm not denouncing the addicts. I mean it sincerely when I say that I love them—they are my brothers and sisters.
>
> Addicts must have their own groups. They can use the A.A. program—with modifications, as we do. But their groups must be dominated by "addict thinking." They must have the mutual understanding and help that is so necessary to the success of this program. . . . One of the things an addict has not yet devised is a way to deceive a fellow addict.

Bill W often expressed a similar desire for exclusivity.

Throughout the 1950s he continued to reject the concept that alcohol is a drug by talking about "straight addicts," a term he used for addicts who were "not alcoholics." In one letter he wrote, "AA meetings are open but it does not follow that non alcoholics will necessarily be received with wide open arms." In another he discussed the idea of having "Barley-Poppy groups" for people who were "dually addicted."[73]

Issues of *The Key*, the newsletter of Addicts Anonymous, during that time reveal how this basic difference of opinion about the nature of addiction also was a dilemma for former patients attending Alcoholics Anonymous meetings in their hometowns. (Although addicts undoubtedly received a warm welcome in some AA meetings, they were more likely to be motivated to write to *The Key* about their problems.) An alumnus in Las Vegas wrote in a 1952 issue that "all manner and kinds of people are made welcome, the thieves, con men, crooked gamblers, etc., but "NO DOPE ADDICTS" permitted in AA."[74] The issue of barbiturates, "well known as the crutch of many alcoholics," was addressed in "Acceptance in Outside Groups," an article in the May 17, 1953, issue of *The Key*. It included the following quote from a local AA publication in Texas that would certainly cause many an addict to read between the lines: "It is our studied conclusion that there is no place in the fellowship of AA for the narcotic or barbiturate addicts. The average alcoholic knows nothing about these addictions; therefore can be of little help in giving sympathetic understanding to those victims."[75] A similar point of view about barbiturate users is expressed in the AA pamphlet, *Sedatives and the Alcoholic*: "Pill-takers are often psychopathic personalities and AA members should only concern themselves with the disease of alcoholism."[76]

Addicts in California also had problems trying to get clean in Habit Forming Drugs of Alcoholics Anonymous, a group founded by Betty T, who had been a member of Addicts Anonymous at Lexington in 1950. According to Jimmy K, "They had a little meeting in their apartment down in Santa Monica, but before you could get in the door of their meeting, you had to admit you were

an alcoholic as well as an addict. . . . Well, you know, most addicts were not going to do that."[77]

Apparently, members of the New York group of NA resolved the problem by distancing themselves from local AA meetings. In 1954 Bill W wrote a letter to Betty T that shows how little he knew about the fellowships for addicts on the East Coast.

> What can you tell me of the progress of those other groups which at Lexington and here in the East go under the names of Addicts Anonymous or Narcotics Anonymous? At times I pick up very second-hand stories to the effect they are making progress but not so much as they might if they really came to grips with the 12 Steps and had proper hospitalization. . . . Meanwhile, the main transmission belt to the addict will be from our AA members who had also suffered addiction and they should surely be allowed attendance at open AA meetings just as everyone else is. [78]

The 12 Steps, to be clear, were not discussed in open meetings of Alcoholics Anonymous, which were the only ones these addicts could attend, but thanks to Houston S and the Frankfort Group, both Addicts Anonymous and Narcotics Anonymous had always made 12-Step study an essential part of their program.

Aside from Danny's comment in his letter to Dorothy L about addicts needing their own meetings where "addict thinking" prevailed, there was also a practical reason for New York NA members to distance themselves from local AA meetings, and that was the prospect of making every member in the room vulnerable to arrest on the charge of consorting with a known addict.

Danny the Executive Director

Although the title under Danny's signature on a letter looks grand, in reality he was the leader of a group that was so strapped for

funds he had to ask people requesting literature to mail him a few three-cent stamps. A vivid portrait of him in action is provided in *Monkey on My Back*: "By eating one meal a day, living in a tiny room, and wearing shabby clothes, Danny made his relief money stretch to cover the cost of the phone and necessary trips." But the more publicity the group received, the greater the financial burden became. After a national magazine featured the group, "they were flooded with requests for help but only $2 came in the mail."[79]

In 1953 Narcotics Anonymous Inc. launched an ambitious fund-raising campaign to raise $60,000 to provide addicts with treatment facilities, psychotherapy, vocational counseling, a revolving fund to send addicts out of state for hospitalization, and a prevention campaign aimed at teenagers.[80] The results were dismal—many good wishes but no money. Nevertheless, by some kind of loaves-and-fishes miracle, the group kept their meeting doors open, their numbers kept growing, and articles and books about them kept multiplying. Even more amazing than the amount of media attention they received was the universal praise for what they were doing. Maybe the time has come to give the early New York NA members some credit for the contributions they made in changing the stereotype of addicts as spectacles of moral degradation while offering them the hope of recovery through a 12 Step program of their own.

The Saturday Evening Post published a long article about Alcoholics Anonymous in 1941 that was full of praise for the fellowship. It was instrumental in removing the stigma of alcoholism and promoting the rapid growth of AA, which at that time was not widely known. In the magazine's August 1954 article, "These Drug Addicts Cure One Another," the editors gave the same generous treatment to Narcotics Anonymous. The hope was that when these encouraging statements broke through to mainstream American thinking it would help thousands of suffering addicts find their way back to a "normal, sometimes humdrum life." But that was not to be.

"The Human Type"

- Around a table in a kindergarten classroom is a group of people so typically average that the reporter thinks he's wandered into a parent-teachers meeting by mistake.—*People Today* (12/5/51)
- I was stunned at the type of persons I met. More than a few show business types, an actor whose name has decorated Broadway marquees in lights three feet high. After the meeting I went out for coffee with a Wall Street lawyer, a hat buyer, and a taxi driver. There's no class line in N.A.—Betty Sorenson [a pseudonym] in *Confidential* magazine. (11/53)
- The strongest memory I have of the meeting was this bond that exists between the NA members. . . . The feeling of mutual ease and trust in the group leads to frank discussions leavened by humor and quick insights.—Nat Hentoff in *Down Beat* magazine (5/5/54)
- Medical textbooks teach which "types" of persons become addicts—inferior people, weaklings, psychopaths . . . criminals skulking on the borders of society. Therefore the doctor or nurse suffering from exhaustion might easily rationalize that narcotics can't hurt him, because he isn't the type. Many of these people are superior, and know it. I believe that when they are taught the truth, that they only have to be the "human type," that the high addiction rate in their field will take a sharp drop.—Daniel Carlsen in *Really Living* (1958)
- A few addicts [now] have found a way back from the nightmare alleys of addiction to a normal life which may seem humdrum enough at times but which when lost, then regained, is found to be a glory.—*Saturday Evening Post* (8/7/54)

Dying Clean

Twenty-five years of hard drugs and hard living, followed by six years of non-stop service to NA, had taken a toll on Danny C's health. On one of his last trips to Lexington, doctors had removed a

cancerous kidney. "I am sure that if I had been taking drugs at this time, I would not be alive today," he wrote, "but because there was no narcotic in my system to disguise the symptoms and reduce pain, I was able to have the malignancy removed."[81] Unfortunately, it came back. The last mention of his service to addicts was in a March 9, 1955 *Down Beat* article about Stan Getz and other musicians who were seeking help for their drug problems. "They keep in touch with Danny Carlsen of NA." After a long illness, he died of lung cancer at Montefiore Hospital in the Bronx on August 19, 1956, refusing the morphine that would relieve the horrific pain of his last days because he wanted to die clean.[82]

He also died penniless. "When news of his death reached his friends and supporters," wrote his friend Sherman Patrick, "they rallied to provide funds for his burial. . . Brigadier Berry received call after call from wealthy citizens who had taken an interest in Danny and N.A., all of whom were sending money toward burial expenses. At least two people offered to pay the entire bill."[83] Enough money came in to pay for the services of Frank G. Campbell, New York City's most prestigious funeral home, but Danny was buried in an unmarked grave in the pauper's section of a plot owned by the Salvation Army. (In 2011, a group of Narcotics Anonymous members, together with Donna Carlsen, Danny C's granddaughter, paid for the installation of a headstone.)

Before Danny became an addict, he wanted to be a medical doctor like his mother. Addiction destroyed those plans, but in the words of Sherman Patrick, "This man who had done so much to help addicts had instead become a true doctor of the human soul."

Backlash

One day short of a month before Danny died, the United States Congress passed the Narcotic Control Act of 1956, the most punitive anti-drug legislation in U.S. history. The final assault to maximize the criminalization of addiction began in 1951 with the passage of the Boggs Act, the first to provide Commissioner Anslinger's

long sought-after goal of mandatory minimum sentencing. At last, Congress had taken away the discretionary sentencing power of the judiciary and handed it over to the prosecutors.[84]

But Anslinger continued to push for even more severe penalties, and he found a willing partner in Senator Joseph McCarthy of Wisconsin. While McCarthy was whipping up the Red Scare (fear of Communism) the commissioner escalated the hysteria with a new threat: the "Yellow Peril." Ever since the Communists came to power in China, he claimed, they had been flooding the United States with heroin, aided by organized crime. The Communists' aim was to "make narcotics a new 'sixth column' in their drive for world domination, and Americans are their prime target."[85]

Instead of doubling their efforts to go after organized crime, they went after addicts. The Narcotic Control Act was quickly passed by both houses of Congress, virtually without dissent, and signed into law on July 18, 1956. The mandatory minimums of the Boggs Act were increased to five years for possession, ten years for sale for first-time offenders, life without parole for third-time offenders, and a discretionary death penalty for selling heroin to a person under eighteen.[86]

Although the new law failed to curb the use of illicit drugs, it did have an immediate chilling effect on anyone who wanted to help addicts. No more stories appeared in magazines about addicts helping each other—a virtual media blackout after the 1955 *Down Beat* article. When the American Medical Association and the American Bar Association issued a joint protest over what they perceived as a reign of terror—mass raids, warrantless arrests and phone-tapping, conviction without proof of sale or possession, travel restrictions, mandatory registries of known addicts—the commissioner accused them of "playing directly into the hands of the nation's communist enemies."[87]

Meanwhile, in New York City, the NYPD narcotics division doubled down on "clearing the streets of criminal addicts...to stop further contamination of the public,"[88] an attitude a *New York Post* reporter called "more repressive than anything Anslinger

proposed." He describes how drastically the situation had changed in New York City by January 1958:

> Even the crypto religious ideas at the root of Narcotics Anonymous seem foredoomed to failure outside an institutional setting because of the shadow of the law. Major Dorothy Berry . . . sums it up out of bitter experience: "The 12-step approach of Alcoholics Anonymous won't work with addicts unless you could try it in the lobby of the YMCA."Virtually the only place left where addicts . . . can meet in safety is on hallowed ground.[89]

Father Dan Egan, a Jesuit priest who would play an important role in the revival of NA in New York, described what those meetings at the McBurney Y were like: "Looking back, they were the saddest, seediest looking people I could imagine. I don't think any of them were clean except for Rae L."[90]

No more doctors, nurses, lawyers, or other professionals attended these meetings. No more war heroes or famous actors. No more musicians. When a police commissioner was asked about how long a well-known jazz musician would have to wait to have his cabaret card reinstated, the reply was "Maybe forever."[91]

Not quite. In spite of all the bad news, in May 1959 Narcotics Anonymous Inc. was part of a coalition that managed to strike the first blow in ending the police card system when they won a class action suit that reinstated the cabaret card of jazz trombonist J. J. Johnson ("the fastest trombone player alive"), setting a legal precedent for other musicians. According to Charles Winick, "It turned out that the police card system was illegal . . . a disgrace for the NYPD."[92]

That was NACON's first victory. The following month brought another, this time for all addicts, when on June 5, after much persuasion by NACON and other advocates, Mayor Robert Wagner approved a program for a ten-day methadone detox

treatment in certain city hospitals. "It was difficult," says Winick, but the mayor reluctantly agreed." Five days before that victorious announcement, Billie Holiday had been admitted to Harlem's Metropolitan Hospital in Harlem in critical condition from kidney failure and cirrhosis of the liver. According to her biographer, "There were no withdrawal symptoms as she had drugs on her. Going through withdrawal in her condition would have killed her."[93]

On June 12 a nurse found a small amount of heroin in a tissue box by her bed. Instead of notifying medical authorities to arrange for a methadone detox, she called the police, who arrested Billie and put her under a 24-hour guard. Soon after that, Manhattan District Attorney Frank Hogan had her arraigned at her bedside and even ordered her to appear before a grand jury. When people read about the arraignment in the newspapers all hell broke loose, with pickets in front of the hospital and letters of outrage pouring into the DA's office from around the world.[94] She died in the hospital on July 17, 1959, with two policemen standing guard outside her door. If law enforcement could treat an icon like Lady Day so badly, what hope was there for the ordinary addict?

Only a fellow sufferer could sum up what this most punitive time did to the soul of addicts everywhere, this from the writer Alexander King: "There is no aspect of American life that is more hemmed in with sinister medieval taboos, more burdened with lurid, rancorous prejudices, and more encumbered with morbid, shrivel-headed self-interest than the law enforcement end of the narcotics business. . . . It pays a lot of people, and pays them damned well, that somebody, somewhere is permanently hooked on dope."[95]

Chapter 2 The Long Bad Dream

For twenty years our fellowship remained small and obscure.
--"Tradition Ten," *Narcotics Anonymous* basic text

The new people coming in can never imagine all the pain and suffering that went into starting NA. People who said there has to be something better than this, hope shattered each time, but always hope that someday, somehow, some way, we were going to get out of this. This bad dream.
--Father Daniel Egan[1]

Eventually this story will have a happy ending, but not yet. Not for a long while. The 20 years mentioned in "Tradition Ten" of the *Basic Text* were the late 1950s to the late 1970s, and they can be called the Dark Ages of Narcotics Anonymous.[2] In California the fellowship survived a near-death experience in 1959, when for a brief time there were no meetings at all. Individual groups in other states were also in survival mode, but there was no real fellowship like there is today, or even an awareness that meetings existed in other parts of the country. Motivated by fear of law enforcement, many groups went underground. Jimmy K called the NA meetings in Southern California "rabbit meetings" because they kept hopping from place to place to stay one move ahead of the police. "Newcomers would drive around the block four or five times to make sure there wasn't a stake-out,"[3] but they were so successful in their secrecy that rarely did people in other states know NA in California existed.[4]

Although the McBurney Y remained safe from police raids, after Danny C's death in 1956 it was the only meeting in New York outside of an institution. Urban addicts had a special need for the

kind of protection that Dolly Berry and Narcotics Anonymous, Inc., provided. Addicts living in a car culture could drive undetected to secret meetings, but one law enforcement official described how vulnerable they were in a place like New York City: "The guy standing on the corner, he's almost got a sign on his back. These guys are just arrestable."[5] Addicts could enter and leave the McBurney Y in the safety of a crowd, and even go for coffee afterward across the street without being molested by cops, but the only addicts who could meet without fear of going to prison were inmates who were already in one.

"NA Out"

When Billy D was 17 years old he went to his first NA meeting in the Brooklyn House of Detention. It was 1957, the height of the young people's heroin epidemic, and many decades later he still vividly remembers his first encounter with NA. The meeting was chaired by a recovering addict who was "definitely a dope fiend, a ruddy-complected Irish cat, big, a lot older than us, and he seemed to be like really dedicated to get something going. He did most of the talking and we asked questions. I think I went to three meetings. They would bring them in weekly, and they called it Narcotics Anonymous, yes it was." When Billy D got out he went back to using for another 25 years. (In 1983, a few months clean, he and two others started the Lifeline group in Kingston, New York, the first NA meeting in Ulster County.)

The climate of fear caused by the harshest federal drug law in U.S. history restricted the growth of Narcotics Anonymous across the country, but while the fellowship struggled to survive on the outside it flourished behind bars. That prison meetings were successful at all was something of a miracle because of "flat time," a system that did not allow for a reduction in time served for good behavior. Even without that motivation, the number of 12 Step meetings for addict prisoners kept growing.

In New York and California these groups were called

Narcotics Anonymous, in other cities they were called Drugs Anonymous, but in many prisons they still called themselves Addicts Anonymous, and the influence of this seminal group is clear from the very beginning of NA history. The announcement of California's first NA meeting in 1953 and its earliest piece of literature both include "Our Purpose," reprinted word-for-word from *The Key*, the newsletter of Addicts Anonymous.[6] The first piece of NA literature in New York, *Our Way of Life*, also originated with this prison group. Until the 1960s, when the *Little White Book* began circulating among recovering addicts across the country, the unifying message of Narcotics Anonymous was *The Key*, which the prisoner patients at Lexington sent to hundreds of penal institutions in the United States.

On the West Coast there was a large Addicts Anonymous meeting as early as 1957 at the federal penitentiary on Terminal Island in Los Angeles, but that same year a Narcotics Anonymous meeting was formed at Soledad Prison.[7] The group's handbook, "dedicated to all those confined members of the human race who have the disease of narcotic addiction,"[8] included the 12 Steps and the 12 Traditions of Narcotics Anonymous, evidence of a connection between this prison group and California NA. The go-between was undoubtedly Jack P, a member of Alcoholics Anonymous who was active in bringing about the birth in 1953 of Narcotics Anonymous in California. He was also involved in the formation of the Los Angeles AA H&I Committee and had developed contacts with a number of law enforcement officials who were sympathetic to programs for addicts in prison.[9]

The influence of the California fellowship extended as far north as Washington State, where Jimmy K sent tape-recorded meetings to a group that had formed at the Washington State penitentiary at Walla Walla.[10] Ironically, at a time when California NA was struggling hard to exist on the outside, it was alive and well on the inside, where inmates by the hundreds in correctional institutions up and down the West Coast were answering the call of "NA out!" to leave their cells and go to a meeting.

The same connection existed on the East Coast, where for many years *Our Way of Life*, New York NA's only piece of literature, was printed by inmates in the vocational training program at Rikers Island. On the back page the Department of Correction expresses gratitude to NACON and the Salvation Army for permission to distribute the pamphlet to inmates. While the number of institutional meetings kept growing, the number of groups outside an institution stayed the same—one—at the McBurney Y.

"Tuesday Night at the Y"

A rare glimpse of what these meetings were like is provided in a long interview NA member John M had with the Reverend Daniel Egan, a Franciscan friar of the Atonement, in December 1999, just two months before his death. In it Father Egan, then 83 years old, talked about his long association with the fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous. His order had assigned him in the mid-1940s to work at the Women's House of Detention on Greenwich Avenue and West 10th Street, where most of the inmates were heroin addicts, but nothing in his religious training helped him provide in this new assignment.

> An ordained priest brings two thousand years of church experience to his ministry, but I had no preparation here. Christ never met a heroin addict. I had one hour of priest training for alcoholism and that was that. Like a parole officer, I imposed going to AA meetings as penance when hearing confession. As for drug addiction, that was never mentioned. Wanting to find a way to help, I started researching and found no answers, only facts. Not even the Women's House of Detention had any answers, even though the staff dealt with them every day. I was bewildered. Why did I keep seeing the same women coming back soon after they were released? Wasn't this place run by the Department

of Corrections? What was I correcting?[11]

Father Egan then decided the answer must be medical. He began his new research by persuading the medical director of Belleview Hospital to offer assistance to addicts going through withdrawal. The doctor allowed Egan to set up a kind of pilot program, "a few beds," but Egan quickly became discouraged with the medical approach when the women were discharged and went right back to using.

One day, on the second floor of the House of Detention where the professionals worked, Father Egan found a mimeographed paper folded in three. "It wasn't done with any finesse. It asked questions: 'Are you tired? Have you had it? Can you see any way out? Maybe you're ready to try an NA meeting.' These meetings were held Sunday afternoon in the House of D. The expressions were new. . . I began to hear them so often."

But Father Egan did not pursue the group called NA. He had come up with a new approach, to provide these women with a place where they could go once they were released from an institution and get the support they needed to get off drugs for good. Advocating for these addicts became his grand obsession, a ten-year struggle, and court officials saw him so often they started calling him the "junkie priest." (Father Egan chose to make that epithet a badge of honor and made it the title of his autobiography, *The Junkie Priest.*) Finally, in 1960, he opened Village Haven, a sanctuary right across the street from the House of Detention where they could meet and talk. One of the women he persuaded to attend was Fran O. She has vivid memories of that experience:

> I went to one of his meetings. We all got arrested as we walked out. There were about six cops and a paddy wagon right there. They took us all in, locked us up, and as soon as they found someone on parole they sent them back to prison. People on parole couldn't be in the same room as us. That was the law. They also picked

> people up for "internal possession." All you had to do was be high. That was a crime then.

The news devastated Father Egan. "There's a certain triumph to failure at a certain time in your life, a hopelessness that transcends everything. . . . My desire to help these people was feeding into my need to be needed. It felt good, but nothing changed."

> I thought, there must be some help, some place, but I was so busy going in different directions then I didn't concentrate on what this NA was that they were talking about. I didn't stay with one thing because I was doing everything and doing nothing. I found out through Dorothy Berry, a wonderful person in the history of NA. She told me about a Danny Carlsen, who with her help had started the first public meeting, which he chose to call Narcotics Anonymous.

Father Egan soon became the official chaplain for the Tuesday night meetings at the McBurney Y, unaware that his presence was a Narcotics Anonymous tradition violation, or even that there were traditions, or that NA in California was very keen on following them because they had learned by painful experience that not following them had almost been the death of their fellowship. But his presence eased the comfort level for addicts who were fearful of getting arrested.

> The meetings were so safe they were even announced. They were more non-addicts than addicts—nurses, doctors, social workers, sincere and honest, who wanted to find out about it. The closest thing I remember to a closed meeting, where it was just addicts and nobody else, was at Bickford's right across the street... They would just sit there and drink coffee and talk, and there were no cops. But in the meetings Rae was doing it all.

> It wasn't a real fellowship, one addict helping another. The providence of God is a mysterious thing. California had easier laws, no tough, tough, tough laws like New York.

A New Leader

After the death of Danny C, Rae L, a former dancer with a dynamic personality, had taken his place as the "leader" of Narcotics Anonymous in New York City. Their lives before recovery had many parallels. Like Danny, Rae L. was born in Puerto Rico, became an addict by age sixteen, had been in and out of jails and prisons for nineteen years, and was also sent to Lexington, where she heard about Danny. She met him in 1950 at one of his Sunday afternoon meetings in the Women's House of Detention, and described that first encounter to a friend, Sherman Patrick.

> Sick, emotionally and physically to the point of desperation, she grasped this chance because "the man he had with him was one of the worst. I knew that if NA helped him I surely had a chance." Upon her release she became the second moving force in NA's fight for the addict.[12]

Within three years of assuming leadership after Danny's death, Rae L had put Narcotics Anonymous back in the news with a joint celebration in November 1959 of her nine years in recovery and the opening of their new headquarters at 219 7th Avenue. The well-known television newsman Gabe Pressman covered the event for CBS.[13] The November 13, 1959 edition of the *New York Times*, ever faithful, headlined their story, Ex-Heroin User Feted on 9th Year Without It, a challenge to the prevailing belief that no addict could stop using drugs for long without eventually relapsing.

Of the one hundred and twenty five friends and twenty five addicts who attended was Barney Ross, the most famous recovering

addict of his day. The movie *Monkey on My Back* (tag line: "It jabs like a hopped-up needle"), which had just been released, was based on his story. A former Hall of Fame boxer and World War II hero, Ross had become addicted to morphine in a military hospital, where he was treated for chronic pain from shrapnel. He hid his addiction to morphine and then heroin for three years until he sought help from Dr. Herbert Wieder, a psychiatrist who later became a founding member of the board of directors of NA Inc.

Dr. Wieder suggested that he go to the Federal Building and turn himself in to the Treasury Department so he could be treated for narcotics addiction at Lexington. "All over the country young kids on dope were ashamed to turn themselves in. If they read about Barney Ross doing it, they might come forward too."[14] He was released in January 1947, shortly before Addicts Anonymous was founded, and had been an outspoken advocate for addicts ever since. Now, with more than eleven years clean, Ross was living proof of the promise of long-term recovery from narcotics addiction.

Another influential guest at the celebration was Anna M. Kross, the first female commissioner of the New York City Department of Corrections. A reformer and an early champion of women's rights, she was never shy about expressing her often unpopular opinions, especially within the criminal justice system, such as angrily criticizing the Manhattan District Attorney's office for their treatment of Billie Holiday in her final weeks of life. When she toured the newly constructed Women's House of Detention, regarded at the time to be the finest example of humanistic treatment for incarcerated women, she called it "a skyscraper Alcatraz." Commissioner Kross also took the controversial position of suggesting that the United States should consider trying the British system of legally administering heroin and morphine to registered addicts by physicians: "I can't vouch for the fact that the [British] system would work here, but I can vouch for the fact that the system we have now is *not* working."[15]

Anna Kross had been part of the coalition that urged Mayor Robert Wagner to make his radical shift in the city's drug policy

in allowing for detox treatment in municipal hospitals. She also convinced him to establish the Office of the Narcotics Coordinator, run not by law enforcement but by the New York City Department of Health, with a medical doctor for its director. She also must have been the one with the clout and the will to convince the City to waive its rule about not hiring convicted felons so that Rae L could take a job in this newly created department, a position she would hold for the rest of her life. When Narcotics Anonymous could not pay rent on their 7th Avenue headquarters, it moved to Room 425 of the Office of the Narcotics Coordinator at 325 Broadway, and eventually NACON also had its office there.[16] At this point, the future of NA in New York became entwined with the City government, another Tradition violation that undoubtedly contributed to its failure to thrive.

Nevertheless, New York NA's alliance with three powerful institutions—the New York City Department of Corrections, the Office of the Narcotics Coordinator, and the Salvation Army's Women's Correctional Services Bureau headed by Dorothy Berry—did result in some remarkable achievements. Under Rae L's leadership the group started NA meetings by mail for incarcerated addicts in fourteen cities in ten states, plus three foreign countries, and kept up a lively correspondence with them all. Two churches in the Bronx, St. John's Chrysostom Catholic Church on Hoe Avenue and the Fellowship House at St. John's Augustine Episcopal Church on 165th Street, provided them with meeting spaces, a courageous first step by religious institutions in New York City. The Fellowship House also gave them office space with a mimeograph machine where they printed a monthly newsletter with a mailing list of five hundred.[17]

In the early sixties Vito L attended those meetings in the Bronx. A heroin addict since the age of ten, he had grown up in the Tremont section of the Bronx. He got clean in New Jersey when he was 21 by going to AA meetings, where he ran into a friend from the old neighborhood who took him to an NA meeting in the Bronx. "It was on 165th Street, a Protestant church, I think, and there was

another NA meeting not far from there. That's how I first met Rae." Unlike the meetings at the Y, the Bronx meetings he went to were closed.

> It was just Rae and a tight clique of recovering addicts. If there were social workers there they didn't open their mouth. Rae was very controlling about what you shared. If you talked about what you were doing when you were using she'd cut you right off. "We're here for the solution. We all know how to use." She'd do that to everybody. "What are you doing today? Are you working the Steps? Are you reading the *Big Book*?" She was very big on that.

Two years later Vito L moved to California but kept in contact with Rae L. Over the years he says they had conversations about the Danny C era and the California fellowship.

> What I'm telling you now is hearsay, but this is the way she told it to me. She said Jimmy K would call Danny wanting to merge the two fellowships and kept going on about Traditions, Traditions, Traditions. When Danny said, Look, in New York we can't get involved with Traditions, the California people just couldn't understand and Danny got a resentment. Through the years she got a number of letters from California and wouldn't respond to them. "We have to function and we're not ever going to get into that discussion." Evidently, if they followed the Traditions they couldn't have done whatever they were doing with the Department of Health. There was something about a grant or a stipend, the rent being paid, something to make a legal connection with the Department of Health, independent but connected to it, so NA wasn't just a stand-alone group.

Addicts trying to form Narcotics Anonymous in New Jersey were even worse off than addicts in New York. According to Hughie C, who got clean in one of the meetings Rae L started in Newark, "At that time if you were convicted of a drug-related offence you had to carry a photo ID card at all times, the first picture ID I can remember seeing anywhere. The call was that two card-carrying addicts couldn't be in the same place. In Newark we were under the umbrella of the United Way. That's how we duked it out. And here's another Tradition violation – we accepted a free meeting place from a Catholic social agency that also met under the umbrella of the United Way." Things were bad enough in New York, but Newark NA had to be under multiple umbrellas, including sponsorship by the mayor and the police chief, to meet in safety. (Unfortunately, their protectors, Newark Mayor Hugh Addonizio and his police director Dominick Spina, were later convicted of organized crime corruption.)[18]

The Thirteen Steps

Among the many Tradition violations in this early history, something called the "13 Steps" is particularly controversial. This adaptation of the 12 Steps of Narcotics Anonymous is often attributed to the Salvation Army, but there is no written documentation for this claim. (Although Dorothy Berry did write a twelve-step guide she called "The Thou Shalts," it clearly is meant for Salvation Army staff who were working with addicts.)[19] Nor has evidence been found that the 13 Steps were written during the lifetime of Danny C.

The earliest mention of the 13 Steps is oral history, interesting but uncorroborated to date: In 1957, at an Addicts Anonymous meeting at Terminal Prison Island in Los Angeles "they had two podiums. One had AA 12 Steps, and the one for addicts had 13 Steps."[20] The earliest written documentation is in a 1961 issue of *New Look*, the newsletter of an NA meetings for inmates that Rae L started at the Michigan State Prison at Jackson. The first appearance

of the 13 Steps outside of an institution is in a 1964 Cleveland NA newsletter.[21] The group was started by Ed Dimond of the Salvation Army, with assistance and literature from Dorothy Berry and Rae L. The 13 Steps are also included in "A Short History of Narcotics Anonymous," written by Sherman Patrick, describing the NA meetings in the Bronx in the 1960s. These written sources all point to Rae L as the source, if not the author of the 13 Steps.

The Thirteen Steps

(From "A Short History of Narcotics Anonymous")

1. Admit the use of narcotics made my life seem more tolerable, but the drug had become an undesirable power over my life.
2. Came to realize that to face life without drugs I must develop an inner strength.
3. Make a decision to face the suffering of withdrawal.
4. Learn to accept my fears without drugs.
5. Find someone who has progressed this far and who is able to assist me.
6. Admit to him the nature and depth of my addiction.
7. Realize the seriousness of my shortcomings as I know them and accept the responsibility of facing them.
8. Admit before a group of N.A. members these same shortcomings and explain how I am trying to overcome them.
9. List for my own understanding all the persons I have hurt.
10. Take a daily inventory of my actions and admit to myself those which are contrary to good conscience.
11. Realize that to maintain freedom from drugs I must share with others the experience from which I have benefited.
12. Determine a purpose in life and try with all the spiritual and physical power within me to move toward its fulfillment.
13. GOD HELP ME. These three words summarize the entire spirit of the 12 preceding steps. Without God I am lost. To find myself I must submit to Him as the source of my hope and my strength.

In the context of our own time the 13 Steps are baffling, but according to Rae L they were not a replacement for the 12 Steps but

a supplement, like a study guide.[22] Seen in that light, particularly with a focus on literature for incarcerated addicts, it is possible to see how this literature could have helped them meet special needs. The Soledad NA group did a similar adaptation, revising two of the Twelve Traditions of Narcotics Anonymous to address a lack of funds.[23]

The 13 Steps address a number of issues not in the 12 Steps of AA or NA. Neither mentions the pain of withdrawal, but at a time when a medically supervised detox was more or less nonexistent in prisons, the 3rd and especially the 13th Step, with its cry of "God help me!", apply to that situation, no laughing matter for an addict going cold turkey in a cell. There also is nothing in the 12 Steps about sponsorship. The emphasis on the group as sponsor and self-sponsorship in the 13 Steps address a situation unique to inmates both during and after their incarceration. When asked how many addicts her group had helped over the years, Rae's response was, "Only God knows, as once they are rehabilitated they get lost in the mass of society, many of them not wanting anyone to know that they are former addicts."[24] Once released, these prisoners would have had plenty of reasons to disappear into the crowd, undergo the perils of self-sponsorship by isolating themselves from other recovering addicts, or cover up their true identity in AA. Under these circumstances, you could wonder how any of them managed to stay clean on the outside.

The Pendulum Swings Again

Shortly after John F. Kennedy's inauguration in January 1961, a member of his White House staff paid a visit to Rufus King, chair of the American Bar Association's Criminal Law Section.

> He came to my office with the aura of the JFK White House and said, "Fill me in on Anslinger." I gave him the tape of a debate I had with him that was broadcast on NBC Monitor Radio. He told me later that JFK sat

> on the corner of his desk in the Oval Office and listened to that tape and he heard Anslinger ranting and raving, and he and Bobby [Kennedy, then attorney general] made up their minds that he had to go.[25]

Not long after that meeting, Anslinger announced his retirement. The new head of the Federal Bureau of Narcotics was Harry Giordano, a pharmacist, and the first high-ranking FBN official who was not from law enforcement—a sure sign, people thought, that progress was being made in a more humane treatment of addicts.

Another light-at-the-end-of-the-tunnel moment came the following year with Robinson v. the State of California, a unanimous U.S. Supreme Court decision that ruled in favor of an addict! The plaintiff was a California heroin addict who had been convicted of "internal possession" for having track marks on his arm. The Supreme Court overturned the lower court decision on the grounds of cruel and unusual punishment, declaring that addicts had no more control over their drug use than diabetics had control over their disease. Only two experts were cited in the opinion, written by Chief Justice William O. Douglas—doctors Charles Winick and Marie Nyswander, founding board members of Narcotics Anonymous, Inc. Although the ruling did not apply if possession was involved, at least it was no longer against the law to be an addict. What a victory this was, at long last!

Members and advocates of NA New York were also well-represented on the invitation list of another hopeful event that year, the White House Conference on Narcotic and Drug Abuse, chaired by Robert Kennedy. When JFK addressed the conference, he said it had been assembled out of an urgent need for scientific knowledge about addiction, about which the President declared, "There is no field where we have so few facts. We need evidence."[26] Among the invited speakers were Dorothy Berry, Rae L, Dan Egan, Houston S, and doctors Nyswander and Winick.[27] All these individuals would continue to play a major role in the campaign for a more humane treatment of addicts.

New York's Governor Nelson Rockefeller had also been invited to speak at the conference, and he was destined to exert a far greater influence over the lives of addicts, present and future, than any other speaker who was there. The legacy of his father, John D. Rockefeller, was benevolence toward AA, helping it flourish in its early years so that countless alcoholics and their families could lead happy and successful lives. Tragically, the son's legacy would be drug-sentencing laws that have ruined the lives of countless addicts and their families and continue to do so to this day.

"Just Drop a Dime": Civil Commitment

The acceptance by people in high places of the disease concept of addiction should have been an indication of better times ahead, but that was not to be the case. Although addiction was now officially a disease, it was to be treated as a *contagious* disease, which meant that addicts had to be removed from society so they wouldn't infect others. In addition, that treatment must be compulsory because many professionals viewed addicts as lacking the motivation to seek such treatment.

To solve that problem, the New York State legislature passed the Metcalf-Volker Law, which funded the renovation of prisons into hospitals where addicts could be confined for up to three years. The program was called civil commitment. These hospitals were also research centers where medical experiments could be conducted to find a substitute drug that wouldn't result in withdrawal symptoms but "at the same time will allow the addict to enjoy the euphoria he so desires."[28]

An important aspect of the Volker Act was particularly damaging to Narcotics Anonymous in New York. The Office of the Narcotics Coordinator was mandated to draw up a "clear, efficient, and comprehensive registry of all drug users in the city" —who they were, where they lived, and how they became addicted —and the development of that list, which quickly grew to 23,000 names, was under the supervision of Catherine Hess, MD, Rae L's boss.[29]

Narcotics Anonymous was now inextricably involved in the State of New York's effort to identify, control, and in some cases incarcerate addicts desperately seeking a way to stop using drugs.[30]

New York officials promoted this program with a campaign called "Just Drop a Dime," encouraging people to report addicts to the coordinator by telephone. They also circulated attractive brochures that one fellowship member recalls "looked like an invitation to go to a dude ranch" as a way to induce addicts to voluntarily commit themselves. In 1964 Tom M was one of the victims of this deception.

> I had reached a point where I was totally out of my mind, hallucinating, shooting dope, shooting speed. They were advertising this program, that you could "drop a dime" and get some help for yourself, or for an addict in your family, or an addict that you knew, and they would send you to a hospital. That was the biggest lie anyone ever told anybody. People started turning themselves in, getting certified by three judges. I made that phone call, I got certified, and instead of going to a hospital they sent me to a state prison up in Sullivan County—for a year. They did nothing to treat my addiction, nothing. I was scared out of my mind but I wouldn't let anyone know it. Everybody stayed away from me. I wouldn't talk for months and months and months. Then this guy called Shaky sent down a cigarette through the pipes from the cell upstairs and he talked to me, this kid. That broke the craziness in my head, to be able to talk to somebody. As soon as I got out of prison I started using again and I used for another nine years.

Drop-a-Dime also targeted families. Fran O recalls in an interview how "parents were turning their kids in because it was advertised as help, and they were stunned when their kids ended

up in prison. It was awful."

One year after the law went into effect, half the addicts enrolled in the program (the ones lucky enough not to be sent to prisons converted into so-called hospitals) had disappeared, causing an uproar among high-level officials, including Rae L's mentor, Corrections Commissioner Anna Kross, and New York State Supreme Court justice John Murtagh. "Why would the addict not flee?" he protested. "The best he could expect in these institutions was experimentation and the feeling of being a guinea pig. The distinction between civil and penal commitment is an exercise in fine semantics."[31] The only support for the law came from the Federal Bureau of Narcotics. New York NA now found itself in an untenable position, but as troubling as it was to be in a situation where their lone ally was the FBN, their credibility was about to suffer another blow.

Two states, California and New York, had led the way in developing the mandatory rehabilitation of addicts, and in both states the approach had been a very expensive failure. Nevertheless, in 1966, the U.S. Congress passed an even worse version of civil commitment called the Narcotic Addiction Rehabilitation Act. This one called for the incarceration of people simply on the possibility they *might* be addicts, which meant that anyone listed on the Narcotics Coordinator's Registry could be locked up for "rehabilitation" for up to three years. Even more alarming was the provision that "anyone who in good faith believes a person is an addict" could institute proceedings.[32]

Conjuring up visions of a 20th century version of the Salem Witch Trials, the New York Civil Liberties Union and a number of state legislators sued on the grounds that "the law made the assumption that every addict was a danger to society and must be removed to places where they can do no harm. . . . To deny a person liberty, to confine him for a period of up to three years, when he may not constitute any threat at all to society, should shock the conscience of anyone dedicated to freedom."[33]

They lost, as did groups litigating in other states, and addicts

everywhere tried to lay low.

Dr. Nyswander's Accidental Miracle

One of the most outspoken critics of civil commitment was Marie Nyswander. The year she spent working at Lexington had convinced her that the punitive approach was not only wrong, it was a disaster. She regarded addicts not as criminals but "human beings with an extra dimension of perception that comes out of having been at the very bottom. ...and they may come back with a clearer vision of themselves and other human beings than most of the rest of us are likely to get."[34] Her experience since then had only strengthened that belief, and the solution, in her view, was medical.

In 1964 she received a research grant from the Rockefeller Institute to find an alternative to morphine in heroin detox programs. Since her time at Lexington, methadone had been widely tested to ease the suffering of withdrawal, but it had not been found as effective as morphine. Dr. Nyswander and her colleague, Dr. Vincent Dole (whom she later married), conducted a pilot project on two heroin addicts in which they doubled the usual methadone dosage to match the high doses of morphine the patients had been given, and then kept increasing the dosages to as much as 120 milligrams a day:

What happened next, she said, was one of those accidental medical discoveries. "Striking alterations in behavior and appearance were taking place in the two patients. One began painting pictures. The other went back to school. Both lost their craving for heroin. From two slugabeds they turned into dynamos of activity." After giving the patients a full battery of tests, Doctors Dole and Nyswander concluded that "methadone had no deleterious effects anywhere."

The City of New York then funded an expanded project in a number of "inner city" hospitals (a new term for the word "ghetto"), and the researchers were euphoric over the results. Two more hospitals were funded, enough to treat a thousand patients

with this new miracle drug, methadone. At last, a drug that could not only block the craving for narcotics but allow addicts to lead a normal life. Methadone, reported the press, was "the best hope for smashing the illicit traffic in narcotics."[35]

"Abstinence Is Not the Goal"

In their expanded research program Doctors Nyswander and Doyle also discovered that opiate use created a permanent biochemical change in the brain. As a result of this brain alteration, the doctors concluded that methadone maintenance, like insulin for patients with diabetes, might be necessary for the rest of an addict's life. This new scientific finding about addiction, that it was a chronic disease with no possibility of a cure, required an entirely new approach to rehabilitation. "What it comes down to," said Dr. Dole, "is that we take care of the pharmacological problems, leaving the addict, and everyone else, free to turn his attention to other problems. It does not strike me as relevant whether these patients ever get off methadone."[36]

Not everyone was so enthusiastic about the new miracle drug. Reverend Stephan Chinlund, associate director of the East Harlem Protestant Parish Narcotics Program, lived right next door to Dr. Nyswander's office. He observed that massive doses of methadone *did* change the behavior of the addicts in his program. In fact, he claimed it reduced them to a "semi-vegetative state." Pete, an addict in his program, was another detractor. "Man, this is synthetic heaven you're giving people. So long as you're on it, you can't enjoy the things you can do when you're normal, like a sunset or a sunny day. You don't make sick people better by keeping them sick." Or as one young addict succinctly put it, "Man, I don't want to die while I'm still alive."[37]

Nevertheless, the numbers of methadone clinics kept multiplying, and throughout the sixties, while cheap heroin flooded the streets and the number of addicts exploded, so did the number of patients treated with this new miracle drug. New York City soon

became the center of the methadone industry, which it remains to this day. The new direction of addiction treatment—substitution, taking a drug to satisfy the craving for another drug—was also more in keeping with the times. The slow growth of Narcotics Anonymous across the country—from five meetings in 1964 to thirty eight in 1971 while drug use statistics quadrupled—reflects the unpopularity of total abstinence during the era of sex, drugs, and rock 'n' roll.[38]

No Hugs Allowed

Meanwhile, the numbers of therapeutic communities (TCs) were multiplying. The original TC was Synanon, which, according to Jimmy K, may have actually grown out of Narcotics Anonymous meetings that were held at an alcohol rehab called Shier's Drier in southern California. These meetings were run by Cy M, who was briefly active early on. In a 1984 interview, Jimmy K says he stopped going to Shier's Drier when it was under Cy's influence. It had become "this domineering you're-going-to-do-it-this-way, hot-seat type of group. Well, I figured, Oh shit, here we go again. This was before there was Synanon. That's the type of thing we were germinating at the time."[39] The hot-seat approach became the foundation of the "Synanon Game," founded by Charles Dederich in 1958.

What is ironic about the possibility that Synanon originated in Cy M's rendition of a Narcotics Anonymous meeting is that the philosophy of NA is the polar opposite of Synanon, and other therapeutic communities like Day Top and Phoenix House, which in their early days also adopted the Synanon approach:

"We will love you until you learn to love yourself." In the Synanon Game, which critics called "attack therapy" and Dederich called "intense group interaction," members took turns sitting in the "hot seat" to be verbally assaulted by the group. There was only one restriction: "No physical violence or threat of violence."[40]

"The God of our understanding." In Synanon, charismatic

authority figures were the higher power, to which members surrendered out of fear of humiliation. The founder of Synanon told his biographer that when he first started the program, "it became apparent that the meeting took on a different quality when I maintained a strict and rigid control. I became the inquisitor and the leader of the group. . . . Psychologically I knew the addict was emotionally immature—a child—and I treated them as such."[41]

"We are sick people." Instead of acknowledging that addiction is a disease, the founder's belief was, "We do not begin with a presumption of sickness . . . we rather assume that people behave badly not because they are ill, or ill-willed, but because they are stupid." As such, they required a sequestered environment in which "we remove those factors which engender and reinforce stupidity."[42]

"Alcohol is a drug." In some therapeutic communities, after a year or two of withdrawal from society, members were rewarded with "drinking privileges." The lucky ones later found their way to NA.

For a time the Synanon approach attracted many more members than did Narcotics Anonymous and a lot more attention from the media, including a Hollywood movie, while the fellowship of NA, with its concept of total abstinence, was a "radical minority point of view at the time."[43]

"Savage City"

Before the heroin epidemic of the mid-sixties, people in some areas of Harlem and the South Bronx "slept with their doors open, helped raise another's children, and sustained a powerful sense that life was improving."[44] Chris J was a child growing up in Harlem at that time. He lived in a two-parent home and life was good.

> My mother worked as a nurse all her life, my father worked all his life. My parents were good people. I really had no reason to use drugs. I hadn't been beat up,

> sexually abused, so many things that I hear happened to other people, but I started using drugs when I was around 16 years old, just experimenting, and in the experimentation I got caught out there. By 1968 the drugs became very rampant. That's when you've got the cowboys they called them, Frank Lucas, Frank James, Frank Matthews. They came from down south and they began to distribute a lot of heroin throughout the five boroughs, but basically based in Harlem. Eventually a lot of people were getting busted. The American Gangster thing started. In 1969 alone I got busted seven times and had 17 charges. It destroyed my whole family. They couldn't understand why their child was like that.

For years five Mafia families in New York had controlled the country's heroin market. Now they had some fierce local competition, driving the prices down and the potency of the product up. "At one point they were selling caps of dope for a dollar a cap and the drug would be so strong that four people could OD on one cap. People were losing their children by ODs more than anything else. It just destroyed not only the individual and the family but the community and people who were trying do to good."

The skyrocketing profits from the sale of heroin created a situation in which "the old rules for pad money for dope went out the window."[45] Harlem congressman Adam Clayton Powell Jr. accused the police in his district of protecting sellers, naming names on the floor of the U.S. House of Representatives. Hand in hand with the complaints of widespread police corruption were complaints of police brutality, resulting in the "long hot summers" of civil unrest. Police corruption was the most rampant in the neighborhoods where the drug epidemic was the worst: Harlem, Bedford Stuyvesant, Brownsville, and the South Bronx. It was all over, but "here was paradise."[46]

The city had descended into urban madness, a time when no

one felt safe, anywhere. But it had a new mayor, John Lindsay, a liberal politician who walked the streets of the inner city during the riots, listening to his constituents, and he responded by establishing the Civilian Complaint Review Board. In retaliation, the Patrolman's Benevolent Association launched an advertising campaign in defense of the police. Billboards all over the city broadcasted the message: THE ADDICT, THE CRIMINAL, THE HOODLUM — ONLY THE POLICEMAN STANDS BETWEEN YOU AND HIM,[47] further enflaming the city's fears.

That same year Governor Nelson Rockefeller was running for reelection, but he already had his eyes on the White House. Handicapped by the U.S. Supreme Court ruling that addiction was not a crime but a disease, followed by the failure of his costly civil commitment program, he went on the campaign trail with a message that would appeal to voters caught up in the addict-as-criminal hysteria of the time. On November 1, 1966, just days before the election, he spoke at a rally in Brooklyn about the new "reign of terror" by "drug slaves" compelled to steal and ravage, and called for the imprisonment of the now 25,000 addicts on the registry of drug users in the city (the one being kept by Rae L's boss in the Office of the Narcotics Coordinator) because the only solution was quarantine. Electing his opponent would mean that these 25,000 addicts would be "free to roam the streets, mug, snatch purses, to steal, even to murder, or spread the deadly infection that afflicts them, possibly to your son or daughter."[48] He easily won reelection.

The Disappearance of Narcotics Anonymous in New York City

The last person known to have attended the meeting at the McBurney Y was Jim M from Detroit, and he found out about it through word of mouth. In 1968 he was in the city on business, having recently gotten clean in AA in his hometown.

> I was staying in a hotel in midtown and got a directory for AA. I asked where this meeting was and they said,

> "What are you looking for? Drugs or alcohol?" I said either one. I'm an addict, and they said, "Come with us." I was shocked there was a drug meeting. It was a walk downtown, busy street, and the meeting wasn't in a church. It could have been the Y. I wasn't paying much attention. About 15 people were there, but no clergy or social workers. I couldn't share if there was because I wouldn't trust them. I enjoyed the whole thing, first NA meeting I'd ever been to.

He then told a story that shows how much the attitude toward addicts had changed across the country, even in prisons, where NA had once been welcomed.

> Back in Detroit I tried for years to get NA going but it was so poorly received back then. It was like, can't you go away and please die? But they had real good meetings in the Jackson State Penitentiary. The room was packed, 12 tables, 10 guys to a table. Then one day a shrink told me this was going to be the last meeting. I said, "Are you kidding me? Can't you see how successful this is?" He said, "These men are happy to see you coming and all they talk about are these meetings." I said, "That's wonderful," and he said, "No, this is a place of punishment not pleasure." That was the end. A done deal.

It was Rae L who instituted those NA meetings in Jackson State Penitentiary, and the latest backlash may have caused her to change her focus. In 1968 she took part in a panel discussion about drug treatment before a group of nurses in Syracuse, New York, which was covered by a local newspaper. The panelists talked about the effectiveness of Phoenix House, Day Top Village, Exodus House, and the New York City Rehabilitation Agency, but nobody, not even Rae, mentioned Narcotics Anonymous. She was not

identified as being a leader or even a member of NA, but instead she described working in a City program that sent members "into the streets to confront addicts and try to turn them around."[49]

The same silence about Narcotics Anonymous is found in Marie Nyswander's 1968 biography, *A Doctor Among the Addicts.* Although she mentions the success of therapeutic communities, she has not a word to say about NA. Dr. Nyswander's biographer comments on her "almost fanatical attachment to science, with small regard for anything that couldn't be subjected to scientific methodology."[50] In spite of her rare compassion for addicts, the spiritual component of Narcotics Anonymous was not something that could be studied in a lab.

The last written documentation yet found about NA in New York during this period looks like a packet of their literature in the World Service archives. It includes a report dated October 1970 about a prison group that was updating a piece of literature called "25 Questions." After that date, nothing has been found, so far, about the fate of Narcotics Anonymous in New York.[51]

Rae L died in 1972 at the age of 58. Whatever happened to Narcotics Anonymous after her passing is another mystery, but it is likely that without her leadership it did not survive. In the few documents that exist from the post-Danny era, no other member of the group is mentioned by name. What we do know is that recovering addicts in the New York fellowship who got clean in the early seventies say they never talked about their former drug use back then. They often buried that information so deeply that they even managed to hide it from themselves, and revisited that period in their lives for the first time during interviews for this book. "This is a revelation to me," said one, "that I could so completely forget that I was once a junkie."

From the beginning, Narcotics Anonymous in California had been nurtured by Alcoholics Anonymous, and addicts there benefitted from the wisdom, experience, and encouragement of recovering alcoholics. Without the help of people in AA who could provide them with guidance in the 12 Traditions, and the

unfortunate disconnect they had with NA in California, NA in New York was doomed to fail. What's amazing is that it lasted as long as it did.

The End of the Narco Farm

For two decades Addicts Anonymous remained a force of influence that extended far beyond the prison walls at Lexington. It even managed to keep going after the death in 1963 of its guiding light, Houston S, and was still in existence as late as 1968, when the last known issue of *The Key* was published, but it could not survive a sequence of events that would lead to the downfall of the U.S. Public Hospital at Lexington.

By 1967 a Synanon-style program called Matrix House was established at the hospital, run by "ex" addicts hired by the federal government. Rumors soon began to circulate that these employees were bringing drugs and weapons into the facility and abusing patients. By 1971 the director had been convicted of these charges, and Matrix House was disbanded.[52]

On the heels of that scandal came another, the revelation that the Addiction Research Center had been funded by the CIA in the 1950s to study the effects of LSD. Not long after this bombshell, a whistle-blower revealed that for 40 years the U.S. Public Health Service at the Tuskegee Institute in Alabama had been conducting a research program that gave participants syphilis without their knowledge and then withheld treatment. In response to public outrage, the government closed the research center at Lexington as well, and 1973 the facility was transferred to the Bureau of Prisons.[53] Few mourned the loss of an institution that for decades had failed to keep the vast majority of its discharged patients off drugs.

Richard Nixon's War

Early in his presidency, at the peak of the drug epidemic, Richard M. Nixon declared the first "war on drugs," and the opening salvo

in this war was the Drug Abuse Law Enforcement Act (ODALE), which was a war not on narcotics traffickers but on addicts. It authorized their mass arrests on the street, buy-and-bust operations, and a "no-knock" policy that allowed for surprise raids on suspects' homes. In New York City the police narcotics division instituted a similar get-tough policy called Operation Drugs. Criticism of these programs was sharp and widespread. A *New York Times* editorial even called ODALE "police terror."[54]

Once again, none of these procedures reduced the crime rate. Concerned that President Nixon would not be reelected because of this failure, his administration vastly expanded the methadone treatment program,[55] with more addicts treated in New York than in any other city. The program backfired: not only did it do nothing to reduce the crime rate, illegal methadone use soon exceeded that of heroin, causing three times as many deaths by overdose in New York City.[56]

The American public was now so frustrated over the failure of governments on every level to win the war on drugs that in a 1973 Gallup poll, 70 percent supported even harsher drug penalties. Governor Rockefeller also acknowledged this failure. "Despite the massive effort . . . we are regrettably still immersed in the tragedy of drugs and drugs addiction." But his solution was to do more of the same. "We must redouble our efforts to eradicate this dreaded cancer [that] could lead to the ultimate destruction of our society."[57] The pendulum was about swing again, more drastically than before, and with long-lasting effects.

Cruel but Not Unusual: The Rockefeller Drug Laws

The humanitarian approach of the New Frontier, which had once been the cause of so much enthusiasm and hope, was now scorned as "coddling criminals." In New York, Governor Rockefeller delivered a message to the State Legislature in early 1973 that the time had come to "frighten drug users out of their habit and drug dealers out of their trade. . . . We must take these stern measures

that, I have become convinced, common sense demands."[58]

In September 1973 the legislature passed a drug sentencing bill that became known as the Rockefeller Drug Laws. It instituted mandatory minimum sentences of 15 years for anyone, first time or repeat offender, who was convicted of a Class A felony (selling two ounces or possession of four ounces of a narcotic drug, including marijuana), and maximum sentences comparable to those for first-degree murder. Once released, these felons faced parole for the rest of their lives. Not only were sentences exceptionally severe, they were inflexible. Judges were handcuffed, regardless of the circumstances: If drugs were found inside a car, every person in the car was charged with possession, even if the drugs were in a locked container in the trunk. A person caught associating with people using drugs, even if that person wasn't using—mandatory minimum. If anyone insisted on a trial and was found guilty—mandatory minimum. A sixteen-year-old who sold drugs to a fifteen-year-old? Mandatory minimum, in prison at least until age 31.[59]

If there was anything left of Narcotics Anonymous in New York by this time, it had gone deeply underground. A long-time member from Brooklyn recalls the first time he heard about these clandestine meetings.

> When I was growing up in the sixties, I idolized the older guys who we called dope fiends and the way they dealt with life, like nothing fazed them. I didn't know they were junkies. I thought they were players. Cool, suave, dressed to the hilt, it looked like they didn't walk, they floated, when they went down the street. These were the guys who I first heard talk about Lexington, Kentucky. I didn't know what they were talking about, but they were trying to warn me away from the route where I was headed.
>
> By the time I was using and they knew it, they'd say, "Leave that stuff alone." One guy in particular,

Sonny, a distant cousin, who told me, "If your moms ever finds out it will kill her." I said, "I know what I'm doing." He said, "No you don't." Sonny had been to Lexington. One day he said, "Come with me." "Where?" "Uptown." "What do they do there?" They talk." He's talking about leaving the Lower East Side and going somewhere that's not my neighborhood, and I'm thinking white/black. I don't recall him saying it was an NA meeting, but do recall him saying it was for people who had a problem with drugs. I said, "What else do they do?" "They support each other, help each other stop using drugs." "How?" "By talking." Then he asked me had I been busted for drugs. "No." "Then you're okay." But I didn't want to go. By that time, not only was I using, I was dealing.

One day I was having a drink in the after-hours spot where we picked up our drugs on Ninth Street between C and D—funny thing is, there's a meeting there now across the street—when these two guys came in who I knew were cops. I thought I was busted because I was dirty, with pockets full of what we called half-a-loads, packages to sell, but I got lucky. They were there to pick up their envelopes. But within the year I was busted for drugs. The next time Sonny mentioned that meeting to me, I told him I was documented, registered, and I was not going anyplace where I would be volunteering to go to jail.

Within a few years it became evident that the Rockefeller Drug Laws were not achieving any of their goals. They didn't frighten addicts out of their habit. They didn't lower the crime rate. In fact, it doubled and then tripled, overcrowding the prisons. Upon being forced to sentence a man to fifteen years for possession, a Supreme Court judge called the law "stupid and irrational. An absolute barbarous atrocity . . . as if he had committed the most

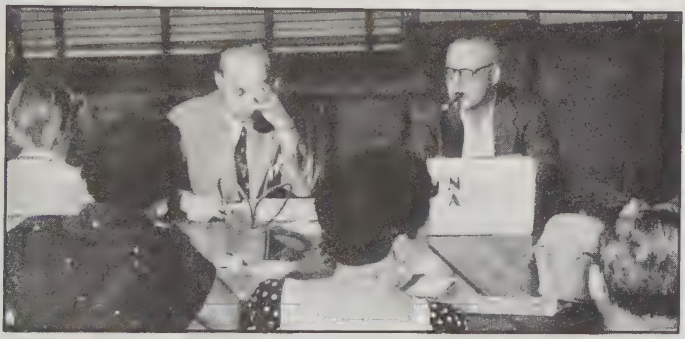
serious crime that can be committed, namely that of taking a human life."[60]

New York addicts seeking for a way out of their misery had a few options. They could enroll in the methadone project and "stand in line at the clinic for the rest of my life." Or they could go to AA, identify themselves as an alcoholic, and never speak about their drug use. Many addicts built a strong foundation of recovery in that program. Or they could leave the state. Many did that, too, and found an NA haven in Florida, Pennsylvania, California, all the while missing the old neighborhood. For addicts who didn't want to go on methadone, or attend AA, or leave New York, where hope for better times ahead had been shot down over and over again, there was little reason to believe that the long bad dream would ever end.

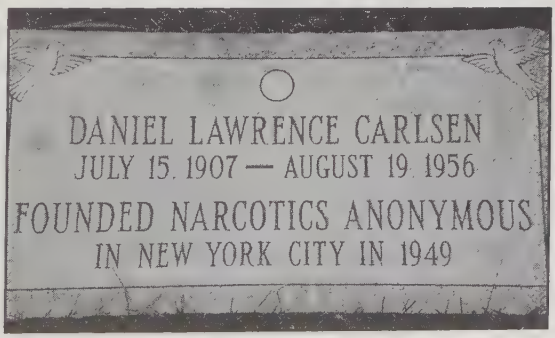
But the Higher Power had other plans.



Salvation Army Major Dorothy Berry counsels an inmate in the Women's House of Detention. Photo credit Salvation Army National Headquarters Archives, courtesy Danny M, carrythemessage.com



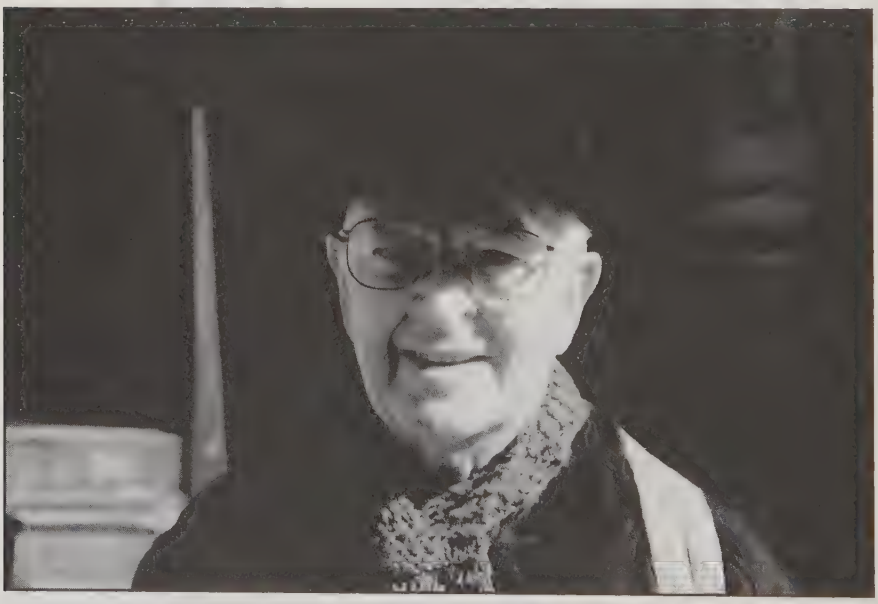
Danny C (left) conducting an NA meeting. Saturday Evening Post, 8/7/54, photo credit Harry Saltzman, courtesy Danny M, carrythemessage.com



Flushing Cemetery, Section 27/East, Plot 48. Photo credit Danny M



Rae L's ninth anniversary party. Left to right: Rae L, Major Dorothy Berry, Corrections Commissioner Anna Kross, and former boxing champion Barney Ross. Courtesy Boyd P and Chris B, carrythemessage.com



Father Dan Egan. Photo credit Danny M.

PART II

The Hundredth Monkey

While studying a group of wild monkeys on an island off the coast of Japan, scientists observed that some of the younger monkeys had started washing the dirt off their food before they ate it. Pretty soon the older monkeys on the island were doing the same. When the practice reached a certain number, the food-washing immediately spread to colonies of monkeys living on nearby islands, and then to monkeys on the mainland of Japan, all wanting to eat clean.

This phenomenon, called the "hundredth monkey effect," describes how Narcotics Anonymous as we know it today finally came to New York. It is the story of many people with a desire to get clean who started meetings in their own neighborhoods, simultaneously and without knowledge of each other. Carl Jung, who didn't believe in coincidences, coined a word for it—"synchronicity, a deeper underlying reality" that sounds very much like what our 12-Step founders called "The Great Reality, deep down within us"—the mysterious unifying "higher power" that unites us all.

NA in New York City had disappeared but it didn't die. It was resuscitated, life breathed back into it in the safety of AA-sanctioned "two-for-one" or "clean and dry" meetings that sprang up more or less simultaneously in Manhattan, Brooklyn, Queens, and the Bronx, where addicts could talk openly about drugs. The people who began these meetings, plus others who discovered them and felt right at home, went on to start Narcotics Anonymous, the real deal, duly registered by the World Service Office.

Within three years, NA had spread to all five boroughs of New York City; to the counties of Westchester, Orange, Ulster, Rockland, Putnam, and Duchess in upstate New York; and to Nassau and Suffolk Counties as far as the North Fork on the easternmost tip of Long Island. From the spring of 1981 to the spring of 1983 the number of meetings tripled, then tripled again by the spring of 1984. In a span of three years the New York fellowship grew from two meetings to 140, and its membership from a baker's dozen to 4,000. And that was just the beginning.

Chapter 3 Stepping Stones

"I'd been around too many people who said they were sober. So I got a good foundation in AA and then we started clean-and-dry meetings so we could all hang out together. They were stepping stones for us, flight decks, and eventually we all came to NA."

During the early 1970s a number of attempts were made to start Narcotics Anonymous meetings in downstate New York, but none of them lasted for long. Instead, New York State's first registered NA meeting opened 350 miles north of New York City in Rochester, just a few miles from the Canadian border. How this group got started was something of a bi-coastal miracle, manifested by the persistence of a 23-year-old addict at her wit's end in New York and the guidance and infinite patience of Jimmy K in California. Together they overcame an NA disconnect between the two states that had been going on for more than 20 years.

In 1972 Lin A's drug use had become so out of control that her dealer told her she was not going to do business with her anymore. "I panicked. You know you've got a serious drug problem when your dealer tells you that you need to get help." Lin considered seeking treatment at a local hospital, but that would require her to become listed in the New York State registry of known drug addicts and she was terrified of the consequences. With no other alternative available at that time, a friend convinced Lin to attend a local meeting of Alcoholics Anonymous with her.

> I went faithfully for a while, but I just couldn't relate. After the meetings I'd go to a bar, have a couple of drinks,

> and contemplate how the 12 Steps might help me with my drug problem. Then I met a woman named Cheryl at one of these meetings who told me she had heard about a program called Narcotics Anonymous. She gave me some literature about a meeting she had heard about in New York City. One was a booklet called *Our Way of Life: An Introduction to Narcotics Anonymous* and the other was a single sheet of paper called *The Thirteen Steps*.[1] My hands shook, I was so excited. Certain things in the booklet grabbed my attention right away: "We believe that alcoholism and addiction are basically the same . . . however, there are differences...we have had to modify the AA program to meet our own needs." I already knew there was a physical difference. After a detox alcoholics were pretty much okay, but you could suffer for months withdrawing from drugs. I looked up at Cheryl and said, "I'm not crazy. It's not just me!" "Keep reading," she said.[2]

The 13 Steps were unfamiliar to her, but the third step, "Made a decision to face the suffering of withdrawal," grabbed Lin's attention because of her many painful attempts to detox on her own. The 12 Steps in the booklet, however, were the same as the ones used by AA, with a slight but important modification.

> Every "alcohol" had been changed to read "drugs." To drive that point home, there was a long list of drugs that addicts had to abstain from, and alcohol was just another drug! If I was going to stay away from all drugs I had to have a program like NA where I could fit in. I couldn't use substitute words or a substitute program. I needed the real thing.

The booklet was printed in Rikers Island. On the back cover she read that NA meetings were held at the McBurney Y on 23rd

Street. In her mind she was already on the bus to Manhattan, but when she dialed the number listed in the pamphlet it was no longer in service. When she got the Y's current number a woman told her the meeting no longer existed. Disappointed, Lin had no recourse but to continue going to AA, but she now did so with a chip on her shoulder. "People in these meetings didn't believe they were addicts. They thought their problem was alcohol." One night, after she kept insisting that alcohol was just another drug, "they kicked me out."

Her friend then arranged for her to attend a few NA meetings that were held in a drug and alcohol rehab in a small town north of Montreal. For a weekend she experienced the "real thing. They gave me a small white booklet about NA, but this one had a brand new concept: 'powerless over addiction.' I felt an odd mixture of excitement and relief, that after all these months of searching I was about to come home."

Jimmy K's "Popcorn Groups"

Reservations about the need for total abstinence delayed that homecoming for a while, but she hung on to the little white booklet with the California phone number on the back cover. Finally she came to the end of the road—suicide or an NA meeting—but trying to locate one in California was the New York experience all over again. After a frantic night and a day of telephoning people all over the state of California, she got connected with a man in Sun Valley who said he could help. "My name is Jimmy," he told her, "where are you calling from?" Rochester, New York, she told him. "Well, I tell you, we don't have any meetings in New York. We've been trying to get NA started in New York City for a long time. I tried to get a hold of someone about meetings in Harlem, but nobody knew where they had gone to. I call these "popcorn meetings" because they pop up every once in a while and are never heard from again."

When Lin told him about her phone call to New York City, Jimmy told her that those NA meetings were different from what

they had in California. "They didn't have the Traditions to guide them like we did," he explained. "They had two meetings and hadn't grown in twenty years, but the big difference was, they didn't use the Steps. They admitted they were powerless over hard-core drugs, mainly heroin and morphine. You can have an anonymous program for every kind of drug. Out here we got down to what we had in common—addiction."[3]

"But where can I find a meeting?"

"How long have you been clean?" he asked.

"Since last night."

"If you've been clean for twenty-four hours you've got something to offer the addict who wants to stop using," Jimmy assured her, but Lin was not convinced that she was ready to take on such a responsibility. "How can I start a meeting if I've never been to one?" she wailed. The only Narcotics Anonymous meeting she had ever been to was conducted in French!

> He said he'd help me. "I'll send you a starter kit. If you want to start a meeting in your house, don't do it for too long, only until you get yourself a place where you can pay your own way. In the meantime keep going to those AA meetings even if you feel you don't fully belong there. The main thing is not that they understand you but that you learn to understand them. That will help you learn to understand yourself."

A few days later Lin received a package that contained audiotapes, colorful pamphlets, more little white booklets, and a guideline for starting meetings. "I read them like a starving puppy," Lin remembers. At that time she lived in Fairport, a suburb of Rochester. She asked Father Vincent Collings of the St. John of Rochester Catholic Church if he would let them have a place to meet, and he offered her Friday nights at the rectory.

Four people attended that first meeting. Two local radio stations agreed to run public service announcements, and not long

after they started airing, Lin arrived at the church one Friday night to find two policemen sitting in a Monroe County Sheriff's car parked in the rectory's driveway. When Lin asked the priest why they were there, he told her not to worry. It was illegal for addicts to congregate in New York State, but as long as the meetings were held in the rectory they were protected under the church's sanctuary law, a tradition that went back to the Middle Ages, he informed them. "Just don't congregate outside. You're not protected once you leave the building."

In the following weeks, the police stakeout of their meeting place in this nice suburban neighborhood effectively drove away newcomers. Even the core group stopped showing up, and on most Friday nights Lin sat there alone. Finally she told the priest that they needed to look for a place to meet in downtown Rochester. That's where the addicts were, and with a lot of activity on the streets, they wouldn't be so obvious going in and out of a meeting.

On Friday, August 31, 1973, the group opened its doors at the First Universalist Church at 150 South Clinton Avenue in downtown Rochester, right across from a park frequented by addicts. Their numbers started to grow, especially after an article about the first NA meeting appeared in the local paper. One Friday night Lin came to the church and found a man waiting outside the door. She asked him if he was there for the meeting and he said, "What kind of meeting?" "Narcotics Anonymous," she said, and invited him in. Shortly after that a group found out that two people who had come to a few meetings had been arrested for parole violation, and two cops sitting in a patrol car outside the church every Friday night became a regular occurrence.

> The last straw was a story on the local news about a big drug bust, and cops said they weren't out to arrest addicts. They were after the big, bad dope dealers. That's when I really got mad. Trying to look like they cared about addicts! I took some white books I'd gotten from Jimmy and went down to the police station, the

narcotic's division, shaking and praying the whole time, and they directed me to the sergeant. I flung the little white books on the sergeant's desk for emphasis and told him, "I'm sick and tired of your bullshit. You say on the news that you're trying to get pushers and junkies off the street, but you bust them when they come to a Narcotics Anonymous meeting. If you think we're trying to sell drugs, come to our meetings, but do us favor. Come undercover because you're scaring the addicts."

They did sit in on our meetings, sporadically, and then one night I came to the church and the patrol car was back. One of the cops gestured me with a hooked finger and I thought, oh God, help me now. He rolled down the window, pointed to a man in the backseat, and said, "Get this addict out of our car because if you don't I'll bust him." I took him in. After that the cops left us alone.

Later that year Lin flew out to California to experience what a real, established Narcotics Anonymous meeting was like. She stayed three weeks and attended every available meeting in the LA area, making three a day at Moorpark, the mother of all NA meetings in West Hollywood; Long Beach; Encino; and the Cri Help and Impact institutional meetings—"fifty recovering addicts in one room. I couldn't believe it." To save money, she slept on the couches of members who were glad to help out a visiting addict from New York.

Lin also met Jimmy. "I found out he was the founder of Narcotics Anonymous. He told me it began when he got together with three or five others from AA because addicts were being kicked out. But Jimmy was the primary person who hung in there. He'd go yank addicts out of AA meetings and take them home so they could talk about addiction in his kitchen in a way that to this

day AA doesn't believe."

Having thoroughly absorbed what "real" NA meetings were like, Lin flew home more determined than ever to make sure that NA in New York was here to stay.

Road Trip

Jimmy K had put them in touch with a man named Terry on the North Shore of Long Island (it may have been Smithtown or a nearby subdivision. Lin can't remember exactly where it was). Jimmy had sent Terry a packet of literature, but they were still meeting in his home because he was having trouble finding a meeting place. "Jimmy kept telling us that our group needed to go down there and support them. He seemed to be under the impression that it was just a hop away. Finally I told him it was 350 miles from Rochester to Long Island, but all he said to that was how great it would be for both groups to get together and support each other."

In the fall of 1974 four members of the Friday night meeting (being the only one, the group never found it necessary to give itself a name) got in a car and drove to Terry's house on the North Shore, a block and a half from the beach along an inlet of Long Island Sound. They had their first meeting that night in Terry's kitchen, using the format Lin had learned in those Southern California meetings. "There were seven of us, and afterward we all just sat there in tears. The power of addicts going to any length to help one another. I'll never forget that feeling."

Like other popcorn meetings that failed to survive in the 1970s, this Long Island group didn't last long enough to get officially registered, but as far as can be determined, it was the first "for real" Narcotics Anonymous meeting—using approved NA literature and the California format—in the New York Region. Another Long Island popcorn meeting opened around that time in Selden, a small town in Suffolk County. Members of the Plymouth meeting in Philadelphia contacted them to give them support, most likely at Jimmy's request.[4] The Selden group met in a church, had

received literature from California, and lasted a few months before closing due to the relapses of members. This would become the pattern for these isolated popcorn meetings in and around New York City. Throughout the seventies, the addicts' only hope was Alcoholics Anonymous or the rare treatment program that would admit them, often on the sly.

Harlem AA

The longstanding ambivalence toward addicts seeking recovery in Alcoholics Anonymous was not universally shared by individual AA members, especially in Harlem, where people had coped for years with waves of heroin epidemics on their doorstep. Another explanation for their acceptability was that, "Uptown, shooting dope and drinking wine went together. Few were pure alcoholics."

Many a desperate addict wound up at Harlem's oldest and largest AA meeting, the St. Nicholas Group, founded in 1947, which met at the historic St. Philips Episcopal Church at 204 West 134th Street. Among these desperate cases were Lucky and Goat, where they became well founded in the Steps and Traditions as they were practiced by members of Harlem AA. "I remember in the 1970s when Goat came in," says a longtime member of the St. Nicholas Group. "He was running for his life because he had stolen from the Mob. Lucky? Oh boy, he was a train wreck." These two uptown addicts, and others like them, brought to New York Narcotics Anonymous in its formative years an approach to recovery that later became known in the New York NA fellowship as "the Harlem Way."

The Salem Group was another Harlem AA meeting with an open-arms policy toward addicts. It met at the Salem United Methodist Church on 129th Street and 7th Avenue, and it was where Kenny M had his first experience trying to get clean in the late 1970s.

> I stumbled into the meeting, and there were about 150 people there. David C, who eventually became my

sponsor, was celebrating his first anniversary. It was a tradition in Harlem AA meetings, which later carried over into NA, that the celebrants would hand out these flowers, little boutonnieres, and they would pin them on people who spoke for you. When David got up he said, "I'm an alcoholic and a dope fiend." As soon as I heard that I thought, this is the guy I need to talk to. When they asked for people there for the first time who wanted to say hello, I raised my hand and said I was a drug addict and a potential alcoholic. That got a big laugh. At the end of the meeting David took me to the front of the room—I was the only white guy there—and put his arm around me and said, "You can celebrate with me here next year if you don't use one day at a time." That was my first exposure to the Salem Group and for me it was earth-moving.

Another AA group took care of addicts in a different way. It met at the Colonial House (then the Colonial Park Restoration Center) on 8th Avenue and West 144th Street. According to Chris J, there was a room behind the AA meeting where addicts could meet. "They used to say, 'There's a meeting for you back there.' It was like a secret. The AA group gave us protection because we couldn't have our own. It was called the Convent meeting, and it was the first two-for-one AA meeting in Harlem where you could talk about drugs." (In 1982 it became Just for Today, one of the earliest uptown NA meetings.)

ENTER House

Angel Ibanez, a non-addict advocate, grew up in East Harlem, also called El Barrio for its high concentration of Hispanics, and over the years he watched what drugs were doing to the neighborhood. "In Harlem the drug scene was streets and avenues, block by block, and you could watch it from tenement windows close to the street.

It wasn't as devastating as when it was in the projects, where it was vertically stacked. That's the difference. In Harlem you could stop it block by block. You could corral it. You couldn't do that in the projects, and there were more projects in East Harlem than anywhere."

The neighborhood also had the highest crime rate in the city, the most poverty, blight, arson, gang wars, and an open-air heroin market on 105th Street from 1st to 2nd Avenue. Sales were off the charts as the price of a bag of dope was cheaper than a bag of weed. Yet, lining these meanest of mean streets was a similar concentration of institutions that had been helping addicts since the days of the Jackie Robinson anti-racketeer campaign.[5]

And then there was ENTER, acronym for the Ecumenical Narcotics Treatment for Effective Rehabilitation, at 252 East 112th Street, New York City's first 12-Step residential treatment program for addicts. It opened its doors in 1972,[6] and owed its existence to a coalition of churches and church leaders—Our Lady Queen of Angels at 228 East 113th Street; Reverend Floyd Massey Jr., a well-known Baptist minister and NAACP activist; and St. Cecilia's Church at 120 East 106th Street—and it was headed up by Father Raymond Hand, the tough, charismatic, much-loved Capuchin-Franciscan friar and parish priest at Our Lady Queen of Angels. It also had the protection of the Kennedy family name. Photos of Father Hand posing with Jack, Bobby, Ted, or their cousin Joe Gargen were prominently displayed on the walls, a reminder to visiting politicians or law enforcement officials that making trouble for ENTER House would have its consequences.

The program was strictly for drug addicts (they had another facility for alcoholics called ABLE House) and the average stay was eight to twelve months. ENTER used the AA model, substituting the word "alcohol" in the literature with the word "drugs." It was housed in a former convent for the Capuchin sisters of Our Lady Queen of Angels. Like many addicts who later became active in NA, Scotty A went through the program. "That place used to be a nunnery where the nuns prayed all the time. That's why we always

felt there was a spirit in ENTER House. A lot of people got clean there." Over the years it became a training ground for recovering addicts who later became counselors, among them Gene G, Chris J, Spadey, Goat, and others, where they learned how to modify the AA program to help addicts get clean, stay clean, and recover.

Angel Ibanez worked there from 1975 to 1985 as a photography instructor, one of many enrichment programs the facility offered. "The philosophy was, we take people living at the bottom of the barrel of life, the people nobody else wants, and when they get clean there's not anything they don't know and understand. From the ten years I spent in this environment, I believe in the myth of the Phoenix—that you can rise from the ashes. I saw these addicts when they came in and I saw them when they left—memorable people like Chris and Spadey, whose reputations preceded them."

Clean and Dry at St. Paul's

After Tom M's "just drop a dime" experience with civil commitment in a converted prison (see chapter 2), he went back to using drugs for another nine years before he got clean in AA in 1974. He had heard about NA in the late sixties from a counselor who was going to take him to a meeting she knew about in New Jersey "but she died and I never got there. I knew I needed it because I heard too much talk about leaving my drugs out in AA. So I got a good foundation in AA and then we started Clean and Dry. Somebody says they're an addict, they belonged. I didn't care where they came from. I needed that support. We all hung out together and eventually we all came to NA."

Clean and Dry, a Sunday evening meeting at St. Paul the Apostle church at 459 West 59th Street, was the first AA-sanctioned meeting for addicts south of Harlem. It was right across the street from Roosevelt Hospital, which early on offered addicts a treatment program that used the AA model. Clean and Dry became a convenient springboard for addicts when they were discharged back into the real world, and it drew in recovering addicts from as

far away as Farmingdale, Long Island. In 1971 Laverne W got clean in AA in Chicago and by 1973 he was working as a counselor at the New Hope Sobering Up Station out in Farmingdale. "I heard about the Clean and Dry meeting by word of mouth. I had a friend who had a problem with drugs who was new to the alcohol program and she needed the identification, so we would come in for the Sunday night meeting. It wasn't an easy drive, but it was a very interesting meeting with lots of identification."

A few years later, Laverne participated in starting the Breakthrough alcohol program at Gracie Square Hospital, where one of the people he counseled was Frankie G. "I took him to the Clean and Dry meeting and he fell in love with it. He was a charismatic guy." This meeting for the "dually addicted" is one of many that brought together people like Tom M, Laverne W, Frankie G, and others who went on to play active roles in the soon-to-be astonishing growth of Narcotics Anonymous in New York.

Veritas Villa

John T from the Bronx relapsed twenty-two times in a four-year period trying to stop drinking by going to AA.

> I hardly would call these relapses, because I was snorting heroin and coke and doing a lot of valium all the time I was going to meetings. I knew younger guys who were doing the same thing and all of us kept relapsing, but we didn't tell anyone that we were using so they couldn't reject us. My sponsor, an old-timer, kept asking me, 'What's wrong with you? I just don't get it.' Back then in AA they were so strict you couldn't even use aftershave because of the alcohol content, so how could they accept that I was doing a couple lines of coke and smoking a joint before going to a meeting? Finally I told my sponsor I was using and he said I had to stop. On Thanksgiving Day 1970 things came to a

head and I put everything down.

John went back to school and became an alcohol counselor for Consolidated Edison Company of New York, a regulated utility providing electric, gas, and steam service in New York City and Westchester County, where he was a counselor in their newly launched program of intervention for workers with alcohol problems that became the flight deck to long-term recovery for many a member of NA. The counselors quickly discovered that after these employees went through detox they relapsed in short order. They were successful in getting Con Edison to expand the program to include treatment as well as intervention.

Once the program was up and running, it didn't take long before the counselors realized that many of their clients also had major problems with drugs other than alcohol, and nobody was dealing with them. One of their resources was Veritas Villa in Sullivan County, run by Jim C, one of those rare AA old-timers who made no distinction between alcohol and drugs. When John T and a group of Con Edison counselors paid him a visit, asking him to set up a treatment program for their addicted employees, he told them, "I'll do this."

For a while, however, this treatment was by the backdoor as the Villa had a contract with the NYPD. There was a time when the department's policy was to fire anyone on the force who was found to be a member of Alcoholics Anonymous.[7] Although that policy had changed, the NYPD still didn't want their police officers to be in rehab with known lawbreakers. John T came up with a solution: "Of course, some of the cops were addicts, so I would counsel them unbeknownst to the P.D. Jimmy would tell me who they were and I would go up and meet them in a diner."

Con Edison negotiated similar contracts with other hospitals and rehab facilities in New York State, among them Long Beach, Brunswick, and Freeport hospitals on Long Island, Lincoln Hospital in the South Bronx, United Hospital near Port Chester, and Harris, near the Villa, where a Dr. Damico worked with the sickest addicts

that nobody else wanted, including the ones who were desperate to get off methadone. The Con Edison counselors insisted that their clients have access to 12-Step meetings within the facility, no matter what their addiction was, and because they were bringing in a lot of clients they were able to influence the development of programs specifically for addicts. Insurance companies did not cover treatment for addicts, so the counselors made sure their clients drank alcohol before they were admitted. Once they were in the facility, and their addiction had been acknowledged, the counselors worked directly with the staff.

One of the counselors John T worked with at Brunswick was Lucky, a man he knew from the street. "Lucky got straight in Harlem AA, which was different from my own experience in the Bronx. Down there the pain was identifiable right away. When I was a couple of years straight I went to an AA meeting up in Riverdale and there he was, shaved head, wearing a three-piece suit, the only black guy there, and we talked about old times. A lot of his friends and a lot of mine had bad things happen to them out there, and then to sit and be close together in recovery—you talk about healing."

Bed-Stuy Two-for-One

In the 1970s addicts who wanted to qualify for a hospital detox had to get drunk enough to register positive in a Body Alcohol Content (BAC) test. But there was another alternative, and Ron B, also known as Kumba, went that route in 1975.

> Therapeutic communities, TCs, like Day Top, Phoenix House, and Samaritan Village took addicts right off the street, even runaway kids. I went to a TC on Harts Island, but I had problems with their "scare them straight" approach. One of their mottos was "If you split you die." If somebody left the island and OD'd they would call all eighty of us out to the pier to watch them bring the body off the ferry and put it in a cabinet in their

morgue until it was claimed. I didn't have much faith in these punitive methods, but what really bothered me was the drinking privileges, which we got after we'd been there for sixteen to eighteen months. A lot of the counselors were so-called recovering addicts who had gone through the program, and they would go out on weekends and come back falling-down-the-stairs drunk. My problem was I had always used alcohol as a chaser for whatever drug I was taking, even though I knew that "real" dope fiends didn't drink. These guys used to pounce on me with remarks like, "You ain't no real dope fiend if you're drinking that shit," but I knew that alcohol had been the start of the addictive process for me at the age of nine, and so I split.

Ron B was first introduced to Alcoholics Anonymous in 1976 at Kingsboro Rehab in Brooklyn. "At Harts Island they used what they called the scientific method, and God was never mentioned. At Kingsboro that was all I heard. In the beginning they had to drag me out of bed to get me to those meetings, but a man named Mr. Bradley kept showing up every Thursday night and he kept telling us the same thing: 'Bring the body and the mind will follow. Don't worry about the mind for now because you ain't got none. The mind will catch up eventually.' I finally got the message and I've been clean ever since."

After his discharge Ron B started attending AA meetings in Brooklyn. "I read in the preamble that the only requirement for membership was a desire to stop drinking and I rationalized, "Well, it doesn't say anything about stopping anything else!" He also started identifying a number of addicts who were saying out loud what he was keeping to himself. "There was this guy who always said, 'My name is Henry. I'm an alcoholic and I feel like shooting some dope.' The so-called straight-up AAers got real quiet whenever he said this. Pretty soon other addicts began talking about their desire to use drugs, or tried to. Some scolded us from the floor,

others from the speaker's chair, so we dope fiends, six or seven of us, got together and decided to start a meeting for ourselves in each other's homes. Most of us came out of TCs, but we found the encounter method wasn't suitable for us outside the institution, so we just discussed our drug anxieties and other things we couldn't mention in the meetings."

In 1978 the manager of the New-Prospect Halfway House at 566 Sterling Place offered them the TV room on the second floor, and when word got out the group quickly grew. The facility was one of several "sobering-up stations" run by the city in what they called "skid row" neighborhoods as an alternative to jail.[8] They called the group the Weeksville Two-for-One, because people could openly talk about both alcohol and drugs.

One of the members of this meeting was Frank P. He had spent two years at Project Return, a TC patterned after Day Top, but after his release "drinking privileges took me right back out."

> I mostly drank but also indulged in drugs, pills—everything. I knew I was an addict but I had "forgotten" about all the things I had done in the past. I first met Ron at an AA meeting in 1978 and asked him to be my sponsor, but I kept going back out. It wasn't until he made me mad when he told me he didn't think I could stay sober that I did, just to show him, and then I started liking how I was feeling—waking up in the morning and not having to throw up, eating, smelling food—and Ron's been my sponsor since Day 1 in January 1979. But it wasn't until I started going to the meetings in the homes that I got in touch with remembering that drugs were a part of my life too. A place to talk about addiction seems to be the key.

Two addicts, Bashir and Tom B, attended the two-for-one meetings, but they started talking about a group Bashir had heard about called NA. It was strictly for addicts, with no need to identify

themselves as alcoholics before they could share about drugs. With that minimal knowledge, they started a group they called Welcome to Sobriety. Because they weren't an AA-sanctioned meeting, they met in each other's apartments to avoid trouble with the law, but they did use AA literature, changing the language to focus on their drug use. These early NA meetings are often called "renegade" because they weren't registered by any fellowship, but there was another reason for maintaining this unofficial status. "It's called fear," explains Willie T. In the late sixties he had declined a recovering addict's invitation to an underground meeting uptown, but ten years later he was trying to get clean in two-for-one meetings and was picking up on things certain members were being cautious not to say.

> Here's the piece that people forget — the double jeopardy aspect of the Rockefeller law. I went to one of these AA meetings where you could talk about drugs as long as you ID'd yourself as an alcoholic. I heard one addict share that he couldn't "go through the tunnel" and thought, "Oh my God. He couldn't because of that G-D Rockefeller law. I remembered the days when I couldn't go to Jersey to cop because I first was supposed to go to the police station and report what my business was in New Jersey and how long I was staying. I thought, he's using code words because he's a documented addict in close proximity to other addicts and if he got taken in for that they'd pull up his record and incarcerate him for being in violation, even though he's already served his time. It created such an element of fear. That's why we had to be so cautious, the double jeopardy aspect, and why it took NA so long to get going in certain parts of the city.

Welcome to Sobriety met for about a year before it closed in 1980 when both Tom and Bashir relapsed. But Weeksville meets to

this day. Another two-for-one meeting opened at the Mid Brooklyn Sobering-up Station at 599 Ralph Avenue. In 1983 Bashir kept a promise to himself and, with the help of Ron and Frank P, they resurrected Welcome to Sobriety, renaming it Welcome to Recovery, and that same year the first registered Narcotics Anonymous meeting in Bed Stuy, Free at Last, opened its doors at the Ralph Avenue sobering-up station.

Both Sides of the Coin

Kevin F and Michael F got clean in May of 1978 and rented a house in Jackson Heights, Queens. It quickly became a haven for other recovering addicts in the neighborhood who were struggling to stay clean. Kevin F's older brother, Buddy F (who was also Michael's father) had thirty years of sobriety and was sympathetic to the difficulties these young people were having in the AA meetings out in Queens. An entire generation had gone through adolescence at a time when drug use was not only condoned but more or less required if they wanted to be accepted by their peers. By the late 1970s it was so widespread that alcohol treatment professionals had coined a new word for it—dual addiction—and the only place to send them after detox and treatment was Alcoholics Anonymous.

Adding to the flood of new AA members was the practice of mandated attendance by courts and employers. In addition, hospitals had expanded their treatment programs because many health insurance plans now covered alcoholism, and these programs often included busing patients to the nearest AA meeting. In some groups the newly sober began to outnumber the old-timers, creating a crisis they had never before encountered. Top this off with all the addicts flocking to meetings wanting to talk about drugs and it's not difficult to understand why so many people in AA felt as if they were under siege.

The influx of young people into AA had become such a problem that the fellowship started meetings specifically for them and even a Young People's AA Convention. But a number of AA

old-timers were aware that just about any newcomer under the age of thirty who came to meetings with a drinking problem also had a problem with drugs, and they realized that the fellowship wasn't coming to grips with the real problem. One of them was Frank B.

> In the beginning AA people didn't want to be bothered about anyone with drug problems, but we didn't go by that. The way we thought was, if you had an addictive personality you could get addicted to shoe polish. Whatever problem you had, whatever you wanted to straighten out and talk about it, we didn't care. I knew, and other people knew, that in a few years young people coming into AA would no longer be just alcoholic. They'd also be smoking pot and doing other things, so we knew we had to open up and change.

To these old-timers the solution was obvious: these young people didn't need their own groups or special conventions. They needed meetings where they could talk about drugs. There was an AA group that met one night a week in a small storefront on 59th Street and Roosevelt Avenue, and they got approval from the owner of the building to start another AA meeting there on a different night. With the help of Buddy F, Frank P, and other old-timers, Kevin F and Michael F opened Both Sides of the Coin in October 1978. It was unique for its time as the only meeting where addicts could gather that was not under the protection of a church, sobering-up station, hospital, or other institution. But there was protection of another kind. "Let's not whitewash our history," says one of the members who attended early on.

> The sign said it was a moving and storage place, but the storefront was actually a bookmaker's establishment. The owner was a known guy in the neighborhood and he gave it to us for free. We met in the back room. But there were no pure dope fiends coming in off the

> street. We were all from AA, we used AA literature, we identified ourselves as being clean and sober, not addicts, and the basis of our conversation was alcohol with narcotics on the side. We called it Both Sides of the Coin because we dealt with both sides of our addiction.

Although eventually some older AA members started going to Both Sides of the Coin, in the storefront days nearly all the people were young. The oldest was Kevin F at age 25, and a person with more than six months clean time was the rare exception. Another was the presence of women. One of the first to attend meetings at the storefront was Terese W, a friend of Kevin F and Michael F: "It was packed. There were a few old-time drug addicts who got clean in AA, but there were so many young people you felt like you belonged there. It was wild and dysfunctional because we were all brand-new, but it was our meeting."

So many young people in one place attracted the attention of the police, but Frankie, the AA old-timer, knew the cops and resolved that situation. "The cops came when they saw all the kids sitting on the floor. They said, 'What's going on?' I said, 'This is an alcohol and drug program. They're trying to clean up their life.' They told me, 'We won't be back.' That was the only time they showed up."

Not only did people from AA start flocking to the meeting, Kevin F got a job working at a methadone clinic and started sending people over, as did the methadone clinic at Elmhurst General Hospital. Then the word spread to the meetings at sobering-up stations in Brooklyn and Clean and Dry at St. Paul's. Just as the storefront space was about to reach maximum capacity, the owner went out of business. Using the same slight distortion of the truth that had worked in securing the storefront, Kevin F and Bob G approached the sexton of a church on Woodside Avenue and 61st Street. "We told them we were an AA group, but when he came to the first meeting and heard us talking about drugs he threw us out." By August of 1980 they got a meeting space in Elmhurst Hospital,

and now that they had the credibility of being located in a medical institution, AA Intergroup added them to their meeting list.

Ed D had been twelve-stepped by Bob G the following December, and he recalls getting clean at Both Sides of the Coin with gratitude.

> I didn't even know it was an AA meeting. I thought it was a drug program run by the hospital. I walked in off the street, just stumbled in, still high, had never been to a rehab, so I was just out of it, but I knew Bob G got clean and I was going to meet him there. And yes, it was somewhat crazy and there was not much focus on recovery, but there was no better place for a newcomer to stumble into. Though most of us disagreed on just about everything we were all on the same page when it came to the newcomer or the person out there who needed help. There was none of this "Here's a meeting list with some numbers. Give us a call." We got the newcomer's number and that person got a barrage of phone calls. I remember waking up to them early in the morning: "What meeting are you going to today?" "Do you need a ride?" "I'll meet you there." Then, after the meeting it was sitting in the diner to all hours. We made it downright difficult for the newcomer to get high. I still see that today when newcomers raise their hand at a meeting. During the break or afterward I see the people who got clean back then seeking them out, talking to them. It's like that behavior got ingrained in us from back then. I know that attention kept me coming. I am forever grateful that Both Sides of the Coin was my first meeting.

It's Possible to Live Clean and Dry

Lucky from Harlem became a counselor at Brunswick Hospital, where many people who later became NA members went for treatment. One of them was Tommy E, a hard-core addict who had "abused every drug known to man."

> I was the first druggie Con Ed threw a net over, in 1978, and I met John T in his boss's office that first day. They sent me to Brunswick for detox. I was also detoxing off of methadone, which is harder than getting off heroin. I also had the mentality of the typical methadonian—if it's so hard to kick, why bother? As far as I was concerned, I was there for one reason: to save my job. It was the last vestige of self-esteem I had left. Everything else was gone. So when I met Lucky on my third day of detox I was in really bad shape. He was a street guy and I identified with him tremendously. He was a black version of Mr. Clean, one of those guys who look naturally powerful, but he was a gentle soul. We sat for about an hour and a half in a room by ourselves, and I didn't share with him, he shared with me. He told me about watching a street dog while he was leaning against the wall on 114th Street and thought the dog looked like he was in better shape than he was. I broke down and sobbed.
>
> I walked into that room filled with despair, bullshitting and jiving and trying to get out of the detox and go use, and I talked to this guy Lucky and my life turned around. I walked out of that room with an overwhelming sense of hope. So for me the craving to use was lifted from jump street. I went to rehab, I realized I had a disease. My ass hit the ground hard enough my ears popped open, and for the first time I

was really listening. I knew I had a second chance at life and I grabbed it. All the time I was there I was in constant touch with John, and when I got out he became my sponsor. He was my sponsor and best friend until he died.

Other Con Edison workers, among them Mike B and Henry M, were going in and out of the same doors and having similar life-changing experiences. In time, Tommy E, Mike B, Henry M, and John T would become the core group of "the Con Ed Crew," but in 1978 they were still a few addicts struggling with their recovery in AA.

Meanwhile, the more addicts John T counseled, the more he began to come to grips with his own denial. Like many recovering addicts who got clean in the Dark Ages of the early seventies, he was able to "forget" his years of hardcore drug use. Now that buried history began to resurface.

As I listened to their drug stories, I kept saying to myself, My God, I did this, and worse. I started to realize I was living a lie of omission. I wasn't suffering because I was a dry drunk. I was an unclean addict, and I still felt crazy a lot of the time. I had hallucinations, nightmares. I couldn't cross a bridge without having a panic attack. I'd be driving someone to rehab across the Tappan Zee Bridge, sweating in fear, praying out loud, all the while telling my client that someday he'd be well like me. Finally I sat down with a sponsee I'd known a long time and started talking. He said, "You know what? You're telling my story here," and then, finally, I had to say to myself, I'm an addict.

When he shared his situation the other Con Edison counselors, they all admitted they had a similar problem. Clients and counselors alike, they all had nowhere to go. "Finally it dawned on us. We

had to do something. That's when we started the Clean and Dry meeting."

The Con Edison crew found the Clean and Dry meeting at St. Paul's, and for a time they made the trip down from the Bronx to attend it, but they needed one closer to home. One of them had a contact with the director of counseling at Montefiore Hospital, another recovering alcoholic, and he understood immediately the importance of what they were doing. "I've got a pill problem and I never talk about it either." He provided them with a room at the hospital and a coffee pot. Once again, a little distortion of the truth was necessary:

> We decided to name the group It's Possible to Live Clean and Dry, but Intergroup said they wouldn't put it in their meeting list, so we shortened the name to It's Possible, and even then they fought it, so we decided to dope-fiend them. We had thirty, forty people calling Intergroup from different places, asking about this group Clean and Dry, where was it, when did it meet. I kept bugging them, disguising my voice three different ways, until they agreed to put us in the book, but they said we couldn't use the words Clean and Dry. It didn't matter. The word was already out that anybody could come in and say they were an addict. It didn't matter what you said, you were welcome.

The first meeting was held March 2, 1979. The group used AA literature and format with an open discussion. Pretty soon recovering alcoholics were flocking to the meeting to talk about their secret problems, and when the Con Ed Crew went to AA meetings they scouted for likely candidates in need who didn't know what kind of a meeting "It's Possible" really was.

When counselors at rehabs conducted exit interviews, they recommended that patients go straight from the facility to the Montefiore meeting. The word also spread on the street, and soon

"junkies who had never been to rehab or a 12-Step meeting before were coming out of the woodwork from all over." Like the other stepping-stone meetings in this story, the group still meets "at Montefiore Hospital, just a different room."

The Florida Connection

Instead of being sent to prison for 15 years in 1969, Paul E, a 21-year-old from Bayside, Queens, was given the alternative of going on Dr. Nyswander's newly launched experimental program of methadone maintenance. With his blocking dosage of 120 milligrams a day, plus frequent intervals of heroin and other drugs, Paul E was pretty content. For a while. "I got married, I ran a company, I was financially successful, and at the rate I was going I wouldn't have made it to 23, so methadone probably saved my life. But in 1975 I just broke down in a very dramatic way. My parents pulled some strings and got me into a high-end mental hospital on the North Shore where I attempted suicide, and still I hadn't bottomed out."

Next came mental hospitals, more suicide attempts by heroin overdose, more arrests, and, finally, the dreaded Creedmoor State. In the summer of 1979, now on disability, he decided that it was probably a lot easier to be strung out in Florida than in New York and moved to Fort Lauderdale. There another of the series of serendipitous events that are the spiritual markers of our early history propelled him into his first meeting of Narcotics Anonymous.

> One day in February 1980 an article on the front page of the *Miami Herald* titled NARCOTICS: A SEARCH FOR NEW HIGHS caught my eye. It turned out to be an interview with two junkies and one of them told my story. They had just begun the first meeting of a 12-Step program borrowed from AA called NA. I waited a couple of weeks, then called the phone number that was in the article. A redheaded, muscle-bound surfer dude named

Curtis drove me to a meeting in Fort Lauderdale. The whole way I was abusing the living daylights out of him, so bad that he refused to take me home. The meeting made no sense, and I said screw it, but two days later I called the number again and got taken to another meeting—dark, dank, old couches. The four or five desperados in there didn't look much better than I did, and I got up to leave.

And this is where the God part of the story comes in. Walking into the room at the exact same time I'm walking out is Mark, a guy who grew up on the same block where I grew up in Bayside and I later shot dope with, who had been asked to speak at this meeting. I didn't need to hear his story because it's my story and he was as bad as me. Here's where I start listening: "I haven't found it necessary to take a drink or a drug for six months." Wow. That was my white-light experience. I look back at the amazing amount of God's handiwork that had to be involved on that night to get this one junkie clean—two Jewish drug addicts from Queens in a Lutheran church 1,200 miles from home, one of them walking out and the other one walking in, the only person who could have possibly impacted me enough to stay.

Paul E and Mark weren't the only New Yorkers living in Florida who would eventually help bring Narcotics Anonymous to New York. There was also Rosalie R, originally from the Bronx, and Maureen F from Jackson Heights, Queens, the former wife of Kevin F who helped start Both Sides of the Coin. Maureen F and Jim, her sponsor's husband, had also attended Paul E's first meeting, and Jim had volunteered to drive him home after Curtis refused.

I was not the driver. I wouldn't have taken him home

either. Paul ranted and raved about the meeting, all the God stuff on the wall, and when he got out of the car I looked at Jim and said, "I'm glad that's over," and he said, "No, you're going to call him every day and check on him and make sure he's okay." I told him I wouldn't have anything to do with the guy. "He's a lunatic." "He's one of your lunatics, and you're going to make sure he keeps coming back." I thought, oh shit. But he ended up being one of my best friends.

Maureen F grew up across the street from Kevin F and his good friend Terry R. "We all came from the same block, home of a notorious gang. I would see Terry and Kevin out the window and my mother would say, 'Stay away from those guys. They're no good.' Kevin was the worst, she said, and so when I heard that I managed to marry him. Most of the kids who grew up in that neighborhood ended up dead and the ones that survived ended up in NA. We are all intertwined."

Maureen F first heard about Narcotics Anonymous in 1978, and her first meeting was in Fort Lauderdale. Other New York ex pats were also part of that scene, so many that a Florida native claimed he was the only one in the meetings who wasn't from New York. "We used to torment him. He'd complain to us, 'You don't have to be a junkie from New York to be in NA.' So the next day we all came in wearing I Love New York t-shirts. We didn't know anything about being nice."

During this time Maureen F was writing letters to Terry R, who was in a New York State penitentiary. Terry says, "I grew up with Kevin Fogerty. We used to steal parking meters together. It's another connection that goes way back. I got clean in AA H&I in June 1979, and when I got out I got involved in Both Sides of the Coin. Now Kevin was clean and working at Bridge Plaza methadone clinic as a counselor, getting people into detox. Kevie brought me in. I was the alcohol counselor in a methadone clinic. Go figure."

Sometime in 1980 (no one is sure about the date) Terry R flew

down to Orlando for his aunt's 25th anniversary in AA, then went to Fort Lauderdale to see his old friend and using partner, Maureen F. "I couldn't believe it when he told me he was in AA." She then asked him if he'd like to go to NA.

> "What the fuck is NA?" he said. He had no clue there was a fellowship that existed for addicts just like him, and I told him, "You can talk about drugs there." That Friday night I took him to the ten o'clock meeting on Pompano Beach called Clean and Serene, and he ended up speaking at his first NA meeting.
>
> Paul E was chairing the meeting.
> I asked him to speak, even though he was in AA. It didn't matter then. If you were clean, you could tell us how you did it. Terry gave us his full drug-a-log, which was probably the first time he was able to do that, and he freaked out, the same way any addict did who went to an NA meeting for the first time: "Oh my God! What do I do to get this going in New York?" I told him I was the institutional chair down here and had all this literature in my trunk. "Take it up there and let me know when it starts. I'll be there."

Terry R has a different recollection. "I yes'd him to death. I had no plans of starting anything. I couldn't walk and chew gum at the same time. I met a guy who had ten years clean in NA and started going to meetings. I met Rosalie and a few other people from New York and they kept telling me I had to go back and start meetings. I didn't even know at that time if I *wanted* to go back." But he did.

New York City Hits Its Bottom

There's a hole in Daddy's arm where all the money goes.
—John Prine, "Sam Stone"

Heroin was king in 1970s New York City. It flooded the streets the entire decade, from the Golden Triangle of Southeast Asia to the Pakistan/Afghanistan/Iran triangle. The heroin flood was cheap, often deadly (98 percent pure), and ten times the volume of the flood in the early seventies.[10] Lines of addicts waiting to cop went down the block and around the corner in certain neighborhoods. "Every addict in the Northeast knew where to buy the best product at the best price. Connecticut, Long Island suburbs, Jersey, all the outer boroughs outside of Manhattan were like retail. East New York and South Brooklyn had some really good heroin, but primarily Alphabet City and Harlem were the place to be. You got much more for your buck, and it was just a business, no time for this racial shit."

Once again, heroin devastated entire neighborhoods, turning them into a war zone. Death by overdose skyrocketed while tourism plummeted. From the ironic "Fun City" of the John Lindsey era to the "New York Shitty City" era of Abe Beame, everyone knew what drugs were doing here because they saw it in the movies of the 1970s: *Panic in Needle Park, Mean Streets, Hell Up in Harlem, French Connection, Midnight Cowboy, Fort Apache the Bronx.*

Nineteen seventy nine was the year it all went down. It was the year drug use in the country peaked, tripling in a single decade, the worst it's ever been.[10] It was also the peak of the drug tolerance era. The stigma was gone, even for heroin. Even very cool people like Lenny Bruce stuck a needle in their arm because it felt so good. "It's like kissing God," he said.

A cascade of other factors contributed to this downward spiral to hell. The city was going broke (Ford to New York: "Drop Dead" ran the famous headline); the South Bronx was on fire. Jimmy Carter, campaigning there, called it "the worst slum in America"; the official planned destruction of the city's most impoverished

neighborhoods, euphemistically called "benign neglect," to hasten the departure of its inhabitants; the utter failure of the Rockefeller Drug Laws to scare addicts straight; the billion-dollar disaster that was Civil Commitment; the closing of state mental institutions, sending addict patients into the streets with no provisions for aftercare; and a new drug policy for the 1980s called "just say no" — it all just couldn't get any worse. What better time for NA to come to New York.

Chapter 4 The First Year: New York City

"God takes certain people and infects them, makes them jump, replicates them. It's amazing."

"The big controversy is who came first. God simultaneously managed to tell these guys, "One week you can have it and the next week you can have it." Doesn't really matter, man. We got it."

Back in New York City, Terry R resumed going to Both Sides of the Coin, now in its new location at Elmhurst Hospital. He also attended regular AA meetings but with a new insight about the nature of addicts and addiction, having had his eyes opened by getting to know addicts with as many as ten years of recovery at NA meetings in Florida. One night, while attending a round robin AA meeting in Manhattan, he had a change of heart about his reluctance to start NA meetings in New York. "One of the old-timers was ranting about how low-life addicts did not belong in AA and how they were taking over their meetings. When it came my turn to share, I said I was going to start the first meeting of Narcotics Anonymous in New York. Two weeks later we had our first meeting, with the help of members of Both Sides of the Coin meeting of AA."

Randee Sue P and Tony D were also at that meeting, two more people waiting in the wings of this story. At that time Tony was having a miserable experience trying to get clean, but Randee Sue P, a punk rocker, had managed to stay off drugs for about five months by going first to Pills Anonymous and then to AA. She has a slightly different recollection of what happened at that meeting.

> I started out in Pills Anonymous on the Upper East Side, but there were a lot of rich people there and I didn't identify. I was a black leather chick and the green leather stuff kind of turned me off. So I started going to AA. I love those people. They helped me get clean, but they kept telling me, "You've got to change everything. You've got to throw away your black leather jacket," and I'd be looking at them like, are you crazy? That's the one thing I really remember, going around for three weeks wondering if I had to do that, but I had to get clean so I kept hanging out in AA.
>
> I met Terry R in an AA meeting. One night we were sitting with Tony D in the second row and there was a big fight going on in the room. Somebody said they were an addict and somebody in the back of the room said they didn't want addicts here. Terry just turned around and said, "Fuck this, we're starting NA." Because, you know, who wanted to be there with those people at a certain level?

Not long after this incident, at a business meeting at Both Sides of the Coin, Terry R said he wanted to start a Narcotics Anonymous meeting and asked for the support of the group.

Taking the Leap

Meanwhile, the attendance at these and other stepping stone meetings kept growing, and new problems arose out of the unusual mix of people who were coming in, attracted to the opportunity to talk openly about their drug use. Among them were old-timers in AA who wanted to deal with long-kept secrets. "They'd come in and say, 'I've been abusing valium for seventeen years,' or 'I realize I'm not—you know—clean. I've never stopped smoking marijuana.' They weren't heroin addicts, street guys, but they were

smoking weed, flim-flamming doctors, prescription junkies, and they were finally coming to grips with what they couldn't talk about anywhere else."

Others were coming from nearby TCs where drinking privileges had become such a problem that the counselors welcomed members of the Clean and Dry meetings in the Bronx, even though they had a conflict with TC policy and their message of total abstinence. "People who were 'graduating' from the TCs were staying on as counselors and they were drunk all the time, full-blown alcoholics. So they recognized they had a problem, although sociologically in their minds there was a big barrier between being an alcoholic and being a drug addict."

Then there were addicts fresh from detox, or on a methadone maintenance program, or straight off the street who had never been introduced to a 12-Step program. "They were afraid to share about things they'd done on the street, afraid of going to jail, and they just didn't trust anyone. Trust was the big thing. Secrets." The confusion and lack of trust among this mix was inevitable. One of the big problems was having no literature that addressed the situation. "We had nothing to hand out about drugs. What we had was borrowed from Hazelden or AA, without changing any of the language, and although we said it didn't matter what the particular substance was, that it was all the same crap and we could talk about anything, when we did the AA readings a lot of old-timers insisted on reading the whole thing—including the part about keep your conversations to alcohol—and you felt alienated."

One of the addicts who were bothered by these lifestyle differences was Michael B, a young Con Edison worker in the EAP program who kept relapsing.

> Mike was in and out of hospitals and rehabs, the whole piece, and he couldn't get straight. It wasn't just an age thing, although that was a big part of it. Sometimes it takes an alcoholic eight or ten years to grow into full-blown madness. A drug addict can do that in two weeks. So the difference in onset is that by

> the time an alcoholic gets sober he's had some positive things in his life—a job, social skills—they're already a part of society even going through the process of becoming an alcoholic. None of this is part of the process of becoming an addict. We're ostracized from society, or we ostracize ourselves—language, culture, dress, everything. I think that's part of what was going on in the Clean and Dry meetings.

Not everyone at these transitional meetings was uncomfortable, however. Richie D was a heroin addict from Astoria who got clean in AA and spoke at the second meeting of Both Sides of the Coin. He had every reason to feel at home with the people there. "I knew Kevin and his brother Buddy, and they knew me and my brothers. We all had learned from guys in AA who had many years before us that the real focus was about helping other human beings." Richie's familiarity with the members of Both Sides of the Coin, plus his good experiences in AA, made him leery of this new thing called NA. He says he never had an issue with living clean in AA, but there were things he didn't know back then that made him reluctant to try something new and untested.

> I came to AA from Samaritan House, where I was taking a rest from the Rockefeller Laws. I was there just to get out of trouble. So I didn't know anything about the joy of recovery with people my own age—that it could be fun—picnics, softball teams, the unity that was second to none. There was nothing like that for addicts. Thank God Terry and Kevin had that foresight and passion and awareness.

Other people were reluctant to take the leap because of fear. "We were scared of jeopardizing our recovery, what little bit we had managed to achieve in AA. We didn't have the sense of security in our own being. What has to be remembered was we were on our

own. We had literature from AA but we were like kids being let out of our family's house to do what we wanted to do. We didn't have a lot of discipline or knowledge about recovery."

Back to Life

One day Mike B came to his Con Edison counselor and announced, "I come to the Clean and Dry meetings and they're great but I heard there's this thing called NA. I want NA." The counselors had also heard there was a 12-Step fellowship called NA out in California and other states and decided to do some investigating. Other members of Clean and Dry got involved, including Henry M, another Con Edison worker who had recently been discharged from the Villa. Tommy E:

> We had heard that NA had been in New York at one time but there was a law about addicts congregating. Then we found out there was NA in New Jersey. Some of the guys got together and went to a couple of meetings out there, so we figured, let's give it another shot. We went to these meetings out in Jersey and learned stuff from them, how to get the literature, the white book, pamphlets from California. Henry did most of the paperwork, and we sent away to California for it. We found out NA borrowed from AA, using the 12 Steps and the 12 Traditions, changing the language a little bit. I had three years clean in AA, John T had eleven, there were others at the Clean and Dry meeting who were very familiar with the 12 and 12, and once we got the NA literature it didn't take a rocket scientist to recognize the different spin NA had on the 12 Steps, and how they would work for addicts.

Mike B went to the Immaculate Conception School at the Holy Rosary Church on Eastchester and Gunhill Road, told the

nuns he was going to start a meeting for drug addicts, and asked for the keys to the lunchroom. John T: "They pleasantly told him to take a walk. He came to me and said they threw me out. The nuns knew me, and I had some professional cred, so I went over and told them I was going to be part of the group and they gave me the key and I bought a coffee pot."

The first meeting of Back to Life was held on Wednesday, April 15, 1981.[1]

> It was held in the school cafeteria. Henry had the group's name carved on a wood plaque and we had another big painted NA sign that we hung on the outside door, and it was perfect—plenty of parking, big cafeteria, nice schoolyard, except there were only six of us sitting around a lunchroom table: Cathy C, who was seventeen at the time (she died of an overdose four years later), Joanne N, my partner at the time, Mike, Henry, John, and myself—and that was it. That was Back to Life. John was the first speaker. At our first business meeting Cathy was voted secretary. I was the first chair.
>
> The meetings stayed small for the first few weeks but then they started to grow. I had a good drinking history. I was always comfortable in AA, and I found loving, giving people there. But NA was like going home. It was buoyant, such energy in the room because we understood each other so much better and we didn't have to worry about anybody saying you can't say that here or readings that made you feel alienated. Everybody in NA was just flying.

Awareness

When Terry R asked members of Both Sides of the Coin for their support in starting an NA meeting, some had the attitude of "Why

bother? We've got our meeting here," but many were interested in this new thing called NA. Others were receptive because they had a resentment. They felt like Both Sides was an "outcast AA meeting." Although it was sanctioned and on their meeting list, some trusted servants had trouble getting AA speakers at the exchange meetings. "We'd send our rep to Manhattan and he'd come back empty-handed because they were afraid we'd send someone who would starting talking about shooting heroin and goof balls, although this wasn't true. We had AA old-timers with thirty or forty years who came to our meetings and were very supportive. They'd tell us, 'Be respectful of the fellowship,' so we were warned." Because of this resentment over feeling like second-class citizens in the AA fellowship, plus the general enthusiasm about having a 12-Step meeting just for addicts, "Terry got a lot of support."

He lived across the street from the Church of the Blessed Sacrament on 93rd Street and 35th Avenue in Jackson Heights. "I went over and talked to Father Valero and asked him can I start an NA meeting here and he said sure, so we started the first NA meeting in the church basement."

The first meeting of the Awareness group was held on Tuesday, May 12, 1981.[2] Paul E came up from Florida and was the first speaker. Also there were Terry R, Kevin F, Bob G, Ed D, Merri D, other members of Both Sides of the Coin, as well as quite a few people nobody had ever seen before, as Kevin F and Terry R had been busy scouring AA meetings for likely NA members. Terry R was the chair until the group held its first elections. Ed D was voted first chair and Larry W was the first secretary. He had been in the methadone program at Bridge Plaza, where Kevin F and Terry R worked, and was detoxing off it by going to NA meetings. (Although no one knows for sure, Larry W may have been the first person to achieve one year clean by going exclusively to NA meetings.) According to the April 1982 NA newsletter, the Awareness group was "totally unaware of the Bronx gathering. . . . Somehow (probably through divine intervention) they soon became aware of each other. Addicts from the Bronx went to Queens on Tuesday nights and addicts from

Queens went to the Bronx on Wednesday nights."

Within less than a month addicts seeking recovery in NA had two meetings to go to, by subway or car pool, and they supported each other "like lost children in the wilderness." At a certain point, Terry R from Queens and Henry M from the Bronx went to an NA Area service meeting in Jersey City to tell them what was going on in New York. At that time, New Jersey NA was already well established, with 19 meetings in 12 cities. A.J., one of the early members, was at that Area service meeting. "They came asking for help. Our reaction was, 'New York needs help from New Jersey? Could you please say that again for the record?'" But according to Terry, before they could even ask for help, New Jersey trusted servants offered to include the two New York meetings on their July 1981 meeting list. The *New Jersey/New York Narcotics Anonymous Meeting Schedule* is the first written documentation from that time of the existence of NA in New York City.

Getting Literature

Communicating with the World Service Office was a challenge in those days. A trusted servant from New Jersey remembers his connection to California was "out in the freezing cold calling Jimmy K from a pay phone. He remembered my name every time I called." In the first few months of NA in New York, Terry R didn't have the magic phone number that ended in bi-coastal addict-to-addict communication. "I would write to the World Service Office in Sun Valley and ask for literature. They would send me a starter kit with seven information pamphlets [one of each] and a white book, which was not enough to meet our needs. They would explain how to open a meeting and then it was like, good luck. So I wrote this letter to the office: 'To Whom It May Concern: It would be easier to get an ounce of pure heroin from my old connection than it would be to get literature from you people. In loving service.' A week later I got a phone call from Jimmy saying, 'We got your letter and we know NA will grow and flourish in New York, so we just sent you

five hundred dollars' worth of literature. Pay us when you can.' Before we even got that paid off they sent us another five-hundred-dollars' worth. That was the start of a friendship I will treasure till the day I die."

Methadone: The First Crisis

That July Nona B, who had moved from Brooklyn to California to get clean, came back for a visit. She knew Greg P from the NA meetings in LA, and he had told her that Terry R was the person who could hook her up with the fellowship that was now up-and-running in New York. Terry brought her to Back to Life, where she spoke. "Before the meeting started I said if there's anyone here who's taken any mood-altering chemicals including methadone, alcohol, or weed, to please refrain from sharing. There was a young man in the back of the room who kept waving his hand, but I didn't call on him. He came up to me after the meeting and said he got a resentment against me because I didn't call on him, and I shined him. I said, 'When you clean up we'll deal with it.' To say the least, I didn't make a lot of friends that night."[3]

The young man was Sal M, and he remembers the meeting very well. He had started going to Clean and Dry at Montefiore Hospital that January "but it wasn't for me. My family knew a woman at Holy Rosary Church who knew a guy who was helpful. His name was Mike and he worked for Con Edison, and he brought me there. I was on methadone, and being an outspoken and philosophical guy, I was talking on and on—I'm on 30 milligrams, I want to go to 50, to 75, doing the methadone math—and she told me to sit down and shut up. 'You're on drugs.' At that point I took my toys and went home. I told Mike I wasn't going to go to this meeting if they tell me I can't talk."

Sal M wasn't the only newcomer at that meeting. It was also Tony D's first NA meeting, but he had a different reaction to Noni's request that addicts who were still using refrain from sharing. According to Rosie B, "Tony was like, well, I'm an insignificant

piece of humanity. Why would you want to hear from me? His self-esteem was so low." Tony had been an addict since the age of 13. Now 41, he had traveled all over the country trying to get clean, but everywhere he went he always ended up using.

Earlier that summer his good friend Rosalie R had come to New York for a visit. They grew up next door to each other in the Bronx and used together, but she had gone to Florida to get clean, had met Terry R on his trip down there, and he had sent her a New York NA meeting flyer. Rosie B: "When she came up to the old neighborhood to visit Tony was getting off. He told her, 'Oh, you came at the right time.' She said, 'I don't do that anymore,' and he looked at her like she had ten heads. She gave him Terry's flyer. She didn't preach, just said why don't you try this?" He took the flyer and said okay, yeah, he'd try it.

> One of the last times he went to cop he was walking up and down 12th Street in Alphabet City where they had a bag called Death and he was yelling "I want death! Gimme death!" He didn't care if he got caught. It had got to that point, helpless and hopeless. There were other tragic things going on, guilt about horrible things he never got over, and he was on the lam from the dealer he ripped off who wanted to kill him, and also hiding from the police. Somebody said the cops are coming, and he jumped out a second-floor window, busted his kneecap. He thought there was a fire escape. Instead of going to the hospital he came limping into Holy Rosary, stoned out of his mind. Rosalie was the one who got him with that message on the flyer—"If you feel you may have a problem with drugs, maybe we can help." He'd used with her since they were kids. When he saw her clean there was no more denying. It was all a fantasy until then, always dreaming of the day he was going to stop.

The argument that ensued after that Back to Life meeting erupted over whether people on methadone should be allowed to share. The problem was that it didn't come under the category of a self-medicating drug. "How do you take a position on a legally prescribed drug that's being dosage-controlled in a clinic? Some of us thought it was a gray area. That was part of the debate in the beginning." One member of the group sought help from California and was told it was "an outside issue."

> A bunch of us didn't agree that World Service could tell us what to do. They had no idea methadone was such a problem here or what to do about it. We were influenced by the maturity of AA about people that come in who were drinking. Let them say a couple of words—hi, I'm here—make them feel welcome. We figured we were sophisticated enough to not let the methadonians ramble on, or to just tell them we'll talk to you after the meeting.

The expanded use of methadone in New York City in the early seventies was "not based on the model whose success [doctors] Dole and Nyswander had demonstrated." Rehab was no longer part of the methadone program. Now it was a maintenance program, administered in "exceptionally high doses," and run like a business with "enormous profit-making potential." [4] Nowhere else in the country was this more the case than in New York City, the birthplace of the methadone maintenance program. John T:

> The money was off the charts. The cost of 40 mg of methadone was 50 cents and they sold it for $30. There was no incentive to detox, and it's a horrible detox. If you went in on 40 mg and were having problems, you'd go to 50. Talk about enabling. Colonies of zombies created by methadone. We used to work with the counselors at places like Bronx State Hospital, go

> over and volunteer our time, suggest to them that they should talk to the addicts and give them some coping skills, but they wouldn't hear of it. It's a maintenance program because if I motivate you off the program I'm out of a job.

A few institutions and medical doctors did object to the way methadone had gone beyond a detox into a lifelong maintenance program. One was a Dr. D'Amico up in Harris, New York, whose specialty was helping "hopeless cases," especially addicts wanting to detox off methadone. Another exception was Veritas Villa. According to John T, "We worked pretty closely with people who were on a methadone detox. How we handled it was, we had to go pick up thirty days' worth at their clinic before taking them up to the Villa, and then the manager would take the supply and flush it down the toilet."

A long-standing New York drug law that prohibits convicted felons from congregating was another problem. That so many people believed that the law prohibits all addicts from congregating only made it more of a problem. Consequently, in trying to reach a group conscience about who could speak at a meeting, these two new NA groups encountered a classic catch-22. Brian P from Queens:

> It was actually easier, and safer, for addicts to be on methadone than it was to be clean. It was also easier for law enforcement. As long as parolees were getting their daily dose of methadone, they could be monitored, and being on methadone was mandatory for drug felons. As clinics did not encourage getting off methadone, the only way an addict could get clean was to violate parole. But the detox is so bad the addicts can't stop unless they're working with each other, like in NA. But the drug laws gave the police free rein to walk into a shooting gallery and bust anyone on parole, and an NA meeting could have been a shooting gallery for all they

knew.

It seemed as if everyone was benefiting from the methadone maintenance program at that time except for the only people who knew what it was like—the addicts. As one described his experience, "It ripped out your soul." Another described it as just another dead end.

> I think it was stronger then. When I hear the doses people are using today it couldn't possibly the same as what I was on. They put me on 90 milligrams and I was whacked. I would tell them this is too much, I'm bouncing off the walls, so they dropped me down little by little. After about a year or two they would detox you down to 10 and you could walk away without getting sick. After a while I realized I could shoot dope again on that lower dose, but I still had to show up every day and stand in line. Back then there wasn't any supervised urine, so I got around that. I was just manipulating the methadone program the same way I was manipulating everyone on the street. To me, methadone was just another dead end. My life was filled with despair.

Former methadonians at Awareness and Back to Life knew only too well that for these addicts, desperate enough to find their way to a meeting, one kind of suffering had ended but another had begun. "The detox was harder than dope where after three or four days the worst is over, but methadone detox goes on for a long time. It's like it gets into the bones, in a more intense way. Then there's also the attitude of the typical addict on the street: if it's so hard to kick, why bother? That was the sad but pervasive mentality among methadonians, and we knew what they were up against."

For some recovering addicts who had fought hard to get off methadone, listening to the babble of the methadonians was intolerable. "One member of our group would be so upset when

they rambled that he'd get up and walk out of the room. Meanwhile I'm sitting there trying to be patient, pretending they want to get clean."

The First Group Conscience Crisis

The methadone situation had been a problem early on at Back to Life, but as their numbers grew it started having a serious negative effect on how many people could share at a meeting. "It had been debated outside the meetings for a while. Some people were purists, very rigid. The older guys like me, people who had a life before they came in, had a different perspective. We were trying to apply what we had learned from the clean-and-dry meetings. This sometimes conflicted with stuff from World Service, methadonians can't talk, la-dee-dah. That each group was autonomous as long as it wasn't affecting NA in general was how we saw it."

The issue was also being debated at Awareness, where the prevailing attitude was "if you think you can be clean and high this won't work." For newly recovering addicts the fear of being around people on methadone was real and troublesome, because the methadonians showed all the signs of being high.

> We felt like they were dominating the meeting. What bothered me the most was when they would nod, just like dope fiends. The only difference was that when they poked their heads up they wanted to talk, on and on and on, like being on an acid trip telling us about all the fantastic things they were seeing, and the problem was they thought they were actually making sense. At what point do we say "enough"? We ended up saying that if you're on methadone you can't speak. It was hard to do that because it is a violation of Tradition, in principle, but functionally we had to do it.

The controversy came to a head at the July '81 business

meeting of Back to Life. "It just so happened that a lot of people from the Clean and Dry group were there that night and stayed for the business meeting. We had a group conscience and the vote was eighteen to two to let the methadonians speak but not to ramble on. We suggested that anyone using a mind-altering drug, including methadone, just state your name and that 'I'm an addict and I'm here to listen.' If they said any more than that we'd stop them. Afterward, the two that voted against it stormed out, taking the literature and the Back to Life sign with them, and telling us we weren't NA."

According to another member who was there, "They were saved from getting put in the hospital that night because there were a bunch of dope fiends in the room that kind of wanted to break the sign over their heads. But calmer minds prevailed."

A second meeting called Back to Life opened at 800 Morris Park Avenue, and for a while there were two meetings by that name. Some of the original members stayed, others went to Morris Park Avenue, to NA meetings in New Jersey, or returned to the Clean and Dry meeting at the hospital. Eventually the Back to Life meeting at Holy Rosary closed.

A few weeks after the big blowup Sal M wound up at the Brunswick Hospital rehab in Long Island. "I met Shari there, who became my wife. I met Lucky, who was a counselor there, and we became very close, and that's when it all took off for me." Nona B had a conversation with Sal a year later. "What he said to me was kind of like this: 'I was so G-D mad at you that I just knew I had to clean up so I could talk at a G-D meeting.' That's how this thing works."[5]

As for the kerfuffle and its fallout within the fellowship, it was revisited in an article in the first issue of the New York City Area Service newsletter in April 1982: "Group conscience in Queens decided that 'current users' would be asked to refrain from speaking at meetings. The Bronx did not agree and could no longer be a part of NA."

As for the members of the original Back to Life group, "It

wasn't a very big deal. We sponsored many addicts from the Morris Park gang. And life went on. . . ."

But the methadone issue only got more intense for the New York fellowship as it struggled to grow. When word about NA spread among drug counselors at the city's many methadone clinics, they began funneling their clients to NA meetings. "The clinics were just dumping them on us. Then they made going to NA meetings part of the requirement for getting their methadone. We had to tell them to please stop, but they didn't." Nevertheless, although it was a tremendous burden in the beginning, with using addicts at a meeting often outnumbering the addicts who were clean, "methadone became a driving force for pushing addicts into NA."

Tony D became another driving force, at 800 Morris Park. Kevin F became his sponsor. After Tony's first meeting Kevin and Terry had taken him out for coffee and said the words that have been the initial spiritual awakening for thousands of addicts ever since: *If you don't pick it up you can't get high.* "Tony was like, what did you just say? Run that by me again. You can be too smart to get the program but you can't be too stupid. Simple. That was the beginning. It lay the foundation to a lifelong mission. He never wanted to be a doctor or even a speaker. He just wanted to help addicts get and stay clean because he knew what their struggle was. It was his struggle."

And Then There Were Three

There is nothing in our Regional archives that documents in writing what happened between the July controversy and the following November, but we do know that by then the New York fellowship had grown from two meetings to seven. The next meeting to open was Clean and Serene in Queens, started by Brian P. He had the experience, rare at that time, of getting clean in Narcotics Anonymous, as the program was already up and running in his hometown of Madison, Wisconsin. He was only nineteen in the

summer of 1980 when he moved to Jackson Heights, where he started attending AA meetings for the first time.

> On Valentines Day '81 I had gotten high and it scared me to death. My sponsor was 40 years older than me and was 25 years sober. His sponsor had 50 years, and he knew the people who started AA. When I told my sponsor I had smoked pot, he said, "You didn't drink, did you?" and it was very shocking to me. In Madison the treatment model was abstinence from all drugs and you went to AA for support.

Brian had been going to AA meetings because in all of New York City he not been able to find a single NA meeting, which had been another shock, so he decided he'd have to start one himself. "I remember talking to AA people who said they'd tried to get NA going and they told me the same story about being busted in an NA meeting, and for that reason they started going to AA meetings so they wouldn't get harassed by the police." Nevertheless, agonizing over his Valentines Day relapse followed by the lack of support over the concept of total abstinence he had experienced from members in AA, he felt compelled to start an NA meeting in New York. "It was a scary thing to do, but it was also clear to me that NA worked all by itself because it worked for me all by itself in Madison."

Brian had already been given permission to hold a meeting in a room at St. Mark's Parish House, on 33rd Avenue and 82nd Street in Jackson Heights, when he saw a notice posted on the bulletin board at one of the AA meetings he went to and recognized the Narcotics Anonymous logo. "It was about the Awareness meeting. I actually went to Terry's meeting to tell them about my meeting. It hadn't started but it was ready to go."

> Clean and Serene met at 3:30 on Saturday afternoon.
> But at the time there were only these three meetings.
> There was no other support for addicts who wanted to

stop using in all of New York, just us. I wanted to start other meetings so badly. I would bring the NA message into AA meetings. I knew it wasn't kosher but I was desperate. Also, they were all white people at these meetings. I said we've got to reach out, there are more addicts than just us, but nobody thought they could go into an African American or a Hispanic community, but I said we've got to break into these areas. They were looking at me like, are you nuts? Even Terry, junkie of all junkies. We had this back-and-forth. It was a challenge for him to have to deal with me, but the combination of the two of us is kind of a miracle. Here he is, with all his street cred, and here I am, this young pothead seminary student from Wisconsin —people liked to pretend they were brushing hay off my shoulder—who actually got clean in NA and thinks he knows everything, and I end up doing this stuff for NA basically for users who were on the street longer than I was alive. That still floors me.

ENTER

Unknown to anyone in the Bronx or Queens, Narcotics Anonymous in New York already did exist, at ENTER. It just hadn't been officially registered, although members of this group had made a number of unsuccessful attempts to reach California World Service for the necessary information and literature.

Chris J found Narcotics Anonymous following the same circuitous route, with the same blind alleys, that so many desperate addicts experienced in the late seventies when the very existence of such a fellowship was all but unknown.

I was at my wit's end and I happened to be on 42nd Street. They had lockers there where for a quarter you could store your stuff. I was looking at the key and saying "God, I need some help." This guy I was with

> said, I know where you can get some. Call this priest. I phoned him. He said are you ready? I said yeah. He said do you have clothes? I said yeah. He said you aren't going to need them. I asked him why. He said because they might have roaches in them. I got mad and he hung up the phone. I can remember so vividly when the movie came out, the *Junkie Priest*, and I said damn, that's the guy I talked to. God had a way of doing his magic. Now I look back on it and see how Father Dan was telling me to leave everything behind and go on a new journey.

But that journey got delayed for several years. After failing to stop using at a number of sobering up stations, Chris J ended up at ENTER in 1980. By then, counselors like Gene Gardener, Goat, Bill Bagley, and others had developed an impressive track record for helping addicts get and stay clean with the 12-Step model, plus the identification that only another addict can provide. The residents at ENTER, usually about 30 men and 12 women, lived upstairs and had weekly meetings in the cafeteria, the biggest space in the facility. When non-residents in AA with addiction problems wanted to come to the house meeting, Chris and another ENTER resident named Spadey started an open meeting with the help of Bill Bagley, a senior counselor.

"Eventually people started saying we've got to have our own literature because we knew about NA from Synanon and that they had meetings in California. Bill Bagley got sent to California to bring back literature and things that related to NA, but the only thing he got was one piece of paper, *How It Works*. It said "addiction" and not "drugs," so we started using that. We also got NA stuff from the Synanon catalog. They had key chains, the same kind they have now, not poker chips. I remember we saved about $36 and ordered key chains and a couple of NA pamphlets." Spadey and Chris put these items out on the table every week "for decoration because they looked nice," while continuing their quest to get information

from NA World Service in California.

In the summer or early fall of 1981 Terry R got a call from Jimmy K. "He said he had got a letter from a place called ENTER in Harlem. They wanted an NA meeting. I went up there and started the meeting." Most likely Terry R was the one who helped get them registered and told them about the meetings in Queens and the Bronx.

According to Chris J, Terry R often attended the ENTER meetings. "At first he was the only white guy there. Then another white guy, Richie, with a big red afro, started coming a lot of the time." Although the word was out that NA meetings were in other places in the city, the people at ENTER tended to stay put. "That's where you remained because that's where your safety net was at and it was working for you, so you really didn't want to go outside of that and have somebody mess you up. Not only did AA people believe there wasn't any long-term recovery in NA, most addicts didn't believe it either. I can remember even at five years clean thinking at some point I'm going to lose this."

But ENTER became a strong attraction for recovering addicts in other parts of the city, especially after the NA members at the facility started Life Begins Again down the street. According to Richie S, "That first big meeting in Harlem was packed, tons of people, because they wanted it so bad. What made getting clean in New York so hard, and why so many people had to leave, was they couldn't deal with getting recovery where you got your drugs. I was a heroin addict so the ghetto was it for me. That's where the drugs were. It's also where I found recovery that's the strongest."

Bleecker Street

If we don't serve the counter culture, then what are we here for?
– Monsignor John Ahern

The Bowery in the early eighties was a far cry from what it is today. Then it was the Lower East Side's down-and-dirty skid row, the national symbol for urban blight. Crime-plagued, burned out ruins,

abandoned tenements, flop houses, men lying on the sidewalks in an alcoholic stupor, it was the original boulevard of broken dreams. Around the corner, "down a trapdoor that led to the subbasement of hell," was the Third Street Men's Shelter, run by the City, and it had a reputation for notoriety even in that neighborhood. It was also the home of the first downtown Narcotics Anonymous meeting in Manhattan. With his usual understatement, Monsignor John Ahern said of his mission there, "Social workers were warned to take the elevator, not the stairs. I took the stairs."

At that time he was Father Ahern. He had been working with alcoholics since the 1950's, and had nothing but praise for the program of Alcoholics Anonymous.

> One of the folks in the parish decided I needed to be educated, so he would bring me into every open meeting AA had for about four and a half years, and I was very much impressed. The odd thing was, at that time I was in grad school and part of the training was to work in the alcoholic unit at Kings County Hospital and we all had a project, a patient. One of my classmates gave a presentation on his patient and gave a glowing report on how this guy was doing. The psychiatrist took off his glasses and said, "You took him to AA. You weren't supposed to do that." So that reinforced what I knew about it. It doesn't work for everybody, but it works.

Father Ahern first learned about Narcotics Anonymous in 1981 when he got a call from Father Terry Atrich, a priest in the New York Archdiocese who was appointed to do research on addiction. "He ran into a fellow called Terry R who was looking for a meeting space after apparently giving a great presentation. Father Atrich asked me, 'You got space for a meeting down there?' and that was it. I had seen AA work, and if there was something that was going to work for people who used drugs, we had to try it."

The first NA meeting list, dated November 1981, includes

a Thursday night meeting on the second floor of the Third Street Men's Shelter, but by March 1982 it had moved to the third floor of the Holy Name Center at 18 Bleecker Street, near Elizabeth Street, two blocks from the city shelter. The center, formerly an opera house, was now a shelter and soup kitchen with showers downstairs for homeless men ("beds kept with great care" was its motto) run by Catholic Charities, which for many years had also hosted AA meetings on the second floor. Although some homeowners new to the block objected to the destitute men standing in line at six a.m. for a shower and breakfast (Father Ahern responded with a polite "They were here before you"), the most vociferous complaints he received about the presence of addicts at Holy Name came from the men they provided for at the shelter. "The real old-timers, some of them burned-out alcoholics, some of them still active, despised the addicts. They said, 'You're letting junkies into the building?' My answer was, 'If they're coming in, they don't want to be junkies.' There was a real hierarchy of snootiness. That faded after a year or so."

On the night of the first meeting, Father Ahern remembers that Terry R arrived early and was sitting on the step outside Holy Name when a woman was mugged coming out of the AA meeting. "As I walked outside, there's Terry running past me with a machete in his hand, chasing the mugger. He didn't catch him and when he came back he said, 'I'm a little out of shape.' I said, 'Put that away,' and he said, 'Don't worry about it. I'm clean but I'm still a little crazy.'" (According to Terry, it wasn't a machete. "It was a 12-inch knife that folded into the handle. I didn't run around with a machete." Priests don't know their knives.)

Bleecker Street became an immediate draw for downtown addicts seeking recovery. There were some problems, Father Ahern recalls, "complaints from neighbors who objected to the motorcycles and "a very exuberant crowd that would gather after the meeting on a very quiet block. There was also a concern that they would be targeted because of the dealing in the neighborhood. This was a time when cops were putting the clamps on Alphabet City. Four

times a day the corner of Bleecker and Elizabeth was like a swarm of bees that would scatter."

Because the neighborhood was filthy and dangerous, it did not appeal to the gentry who later moved in and made it their own, but at that time all kinds of artists lived there, taking advantage of the low rent and the camaraderie. According to Brian P from Wisconsin, "Bleecker Street became sort of an avant-garde meeting, when New Wave was becoming grunge, people on the cutting edge, poetic, artistic. It was certainly a place you didn't want to be without friends, with the Bowery right around the corner. But one thing I was taught early on was if you're doing service, God's business, you're always protected. I had no compunction about taking a train to Queens at two o'clock in the morning, even out of Alphabet City."

One of the artists from the neighborhood who were at that meeting early on was Michael B, a successful tenor sax player. After going to the Beachcomb, a Florida drug rehab, he spent another six months in Florida going to NA meetings. By the time he returned to New York City he had the benefit, rare for recovering addicts at that time, of a solid foundation in the NA program. "Mike got the bigger picture. NA was not just tweaking AA, and he got really involved in service. At first he didn't go on tour. Instead, he took a job in a box factory so he could focus on his recovery and not be stressed out. If you went to a meeting, he was there. Little by little he started twelve-stepping other serious musicians, schlep them to meetings, and hang out afterward."

And Then There Were Eight

November was a banner month for the new fellowship. On the 10th they issued their very own meeting list with an all-caps heading:

NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS NEW YORK CITY MEETINGS

(TWO MEETINGS HAVE DONE THEIR WORK. NOW THERE ARE EIGHT).

The new meetings were Friday night at Morris Park and Getting Straight on Wednesday night at Blessed Sacrament School,

originally at 1141 Taylor Avenue, started by two 90-day wonders, Papo M and his cousin Leno, who got clean in Back to Life. Leno was chair and Papo M was the coffee maker. Altogether, with Tuesday and Thursday night meetings at ENTER, the original Monday and Tuesday night meetings at Back to Life and Awareness, the Thursday night meeting in the Bowery (still at the 3rd Street shelter), and the Saturday afternoon meeting at Clean and Serene, there were now NA meetings in New York City six days out of seven! Two nights with options! A miracle.

On November 18th these eight meetings became the New York City Area Service Committee of Narcotics Anonymous, "a Bona Fide Service Committee and listed as such at the World Service Office, Inc." It was so designated in a letter signed by James P. Kinnon, executive director, whose exuberance can be read into the signature he penned. That Thanksgiving, Terry R hosted a houseful of guests for dinner, including Leah A and her sponsor Rosalie R, who had come up from Florida. "People sleeping in the kitchen, on the living room floor, on the couches, everywhere." Earlier, Rosalie had spoken at Leah's first-year anniversary in New Jersey. Afterward, they went to the Bronx to see Tony D, who was coming up on four months clean, and then to the new Getting Straight meeting. "Rosalie said to Tony, "Funny, I remember shooting dope on the steps of Blessed Sacrament with you when I was 13 years old and do you believe it? That there's a meeting here now?"

There was much to be thankful for, beyond anyone's wildest dreams. In spite of all the odds, and New York City's longstanding bad attitude toward addicts, they were a fellowship now. The day after Thanksgiving they went back to work. Next stop: Brooklyn.

Start Talking About Recovery (STAR)

Matt H got clean in a treatment center in Atlanta, Georgia in November 1981. When he moved to the Greenpoint section of Brooklyn in January 1982, he was unable to locate an NA meeting and phoned people in Atlanta. They gave him Terry R's number.

"I called Terry and he says, 'Meet me tonight.' That was how I got hooked up, at Awareness. The first couple of months we took trains all over the place, Queens and the Bronx, but I knew I needed some wheels to do this thing and stay clean. I scraped up enough to buy a car, they were cheap back then, and I became the transportation. When I had like ninety days Terry said to me, we need you to start a meeting in Brooklyn. I said, oh please, come on. He said, no, you're ready. Let's go. We don't have time to wait. This is very important what we're doing up here."

That March, Matt H and Terry R drove to Bensonhurst in southwest Brooklyn to the New Utrecht Reformed Church at 18th Avenue and 83rd Street, which held a number of 12 Step meetings, and spoke to two women who had started a Pill Anonymous meeting that was folding. "One of them said, listen, we'll give you the spot. Just take it. We took it and that was it. The next weekend we opened up a meeting, had a quick business meeting, and I was appointed chair. Terry came up with the name, Start Talking About Recovery, the STAR group. They he left and we were on our own.

> You didn't realize the responsibility that got put on us. For the first time we've got addicts coming in and some of them were insane. This was a new thing and we didn't know how it really worked, that the majority was going to go back out. You want everybody to stay but that's not the way it's going to work and it frustrates you. I used to call Terry all the time. 'Come on, you've got to come over here," and he'd say, "Don't worry, you'll be all right," and you know something? You talk about faith. Every week people just started showing up.

At first they met upstairs in a big room next to the kitchen, then they got moved down to the basement, next to the boiler. "It was a dingy spot but we cleaned it up and it was cozy. We didn't want too big of a spot. We didn't have the people.

I believe the rent was ten dollars a month. A few of us had a few bucks to put in the basket. We had nothing, no literature, so we made our own, bootleg. Somebody would type a couple things on a piece of paper and I would take it to work the next day and run copies. We had great support from AA in that building. They had three solid meetings there and they said take any coffee cups you want, use the coffee pot, anything we needed they gave us. They said we want you to succeed because we've got a lot of people coming in that apparently we can't help. They need to hear your talk and your lingo.

The meeting started at eight o'clock but I opened up an hour early. Everything had to be ready by the time people got there. I picked that up in the other fellowship. You got a coffee commitment, you don't show up at five minutes to eight. You know what they say, "Don't just come around, come into it." I just really got so busy with what was going on in NA, I think that's what really saved me. I was always in fear of going out. I had hepatitis, I'm sick as a dog, I'm watching guys croak all over the place, oh man, I'm on a serious run here.

For eight months the STAR group was the only NA meeting in all of Brooklyn, population 3 million. One of the problems was transportation. "It was frustrating. I lived in Queens and I didn't have a car, so I had to take two subways and a bus to get there. Besides, the STAR group met on a Tuesday night and so did Awareness. I wanted to go but, hey." There were also Tuesday night meetings in the Bronx and Harlem. Many addicts, especially newcomers, were already insecure about what they were getting into. The attitude was, why take unnecessary risks?

"Going to Brooklyn was like going to a foreign country without a passport." Traveling between Greenpoint and Red

Hook, Brooklyn Heights and Canarsie, or Bedford Stuyvesant and Bensonhurst was not just a matter of navigating chaotic subway and bus lines. "Black or white, get off at the wrong stop and you might find yourself in an unfriendly neighborhood." Nevertheless, after a slow start, Brooklyn would quickly catch up with and even surpass the number of NA meetings in the other boroughs that would soon be sprouting up all over the city.

Life Begins Again

The number of addicts attending the meetings at ENTER reached a point where it was disrupting the treatment of the residents. In addition, the presence of addicts at meetings who were still using ran contrary to the institution's strict policy of total abstinence, which didn't even allow residents to smoke cigarettes because nicotine was a drug. To avoid a violation of the Third Tradition, twelve people, many of them ENTER counselors or former residents, started Life Begins Again, a 2:00 p.m. Saturday meeting at Our Lady Queen of Angels at 226 East 113th Street. The back entrance of the church was just down the block from ENTER on 112th Street.

Among the twelve who started the meeting were ENTER counselors Roger B and Gene G plus Ann D, Dollar Bill, T, Sonny W, Ruben, Goat, Lucky, Spadey, and Chris J. Early on, according to Chris, "In my mind they were the most instrumental members in helping people get to meetings. Goat had a van without seats that he'd fill up. You'd get in the back and sit on the floor. Ruben didn't have a car but whenever he found a suffering addict he'd walk them to a meeting, get them some coffee. He did that till he died. T had suffered so much in his addiction his face was burned up. And they all came from AA."

East 112th Street became a major draw for addicts from all over the city, seeking drugs or seeking recovery, as well as for the NYPD narcotics task force.

> Three doors down from ENTER was a cop spot, so people would be lining up to buy drugs while we were going into the meeting. Right across the street there was a little doorway to the basement of Our Lady Queen of Angels that we went through to go downstairs to Life Begins Again. One day as we came out of the meeting five cars pull up. The undercover special police that made drug raids jump out and say, "Everybody up against the wall." Goat was my sponsor. He said, "Do you think I look like a dope fiend?" and one of us said to him, "Yes, you do." Nobody panicked. Nobody got arrested. We just kept coming out of the meeting.

Horizon: The First Step Meeting

There are very few 1982 NA meeting lists in our archives, and most of them are undated, but the April 1982 list indicates that two other meetings had opened their doors by then. One of them, New Beginnings at Cabrini Hospital, a Wednesday Night meeting on East 20th Street and Second Avenue, was short lived. According to Terry R, "There was a gay AA meeting that was falling apart, and they said we could have it if it was okay with the hospital." Apparently no one sought that approval, because a few months later some members of Pills Anonymous went to the hospital and asked to start a meeting there. "The hospital told them no. They said, 'How come you let Narcotics Anonymous in there?' and we were abruptly thrown out of the building." The group then renamed itself We Have a Choice and met on Friday nights in the summertime in Stuyvesant Park on 16th St and 2nd Avenue until they found a home at the Holy Name Center on Bleecker Street.

The other addition to the April 1982 meeting list was Horizon, the first Step meeting in New York City. The New York fellowship had no NA literature that addressed Step work because it had yet to be published—no *Basic Text*, no *Step Working Guide*. Florida NA members had been making trips to New York to help

addicts learn how to do Step work, but the local membership was determined to have meetings on a regular basis. The answer was Horizon, a Monday night meeting at St. Nicholas School cafeteria, Parsons Boulevard and Union Turnpike in Queens.

Tom M was the speaker at the first meeting. Most members at that time had less than a year clean, three years tops, but Tom was already an "old-timer." Prior to attending NA meetings he had seven years of recovery in AA, plus as many years of service at the first clean-and-dry meeting in the city at St. Paul's, but when he came to the opening of the Horizon meeting "someone said 'He's from AA. He can't speak.' I was still going to Clean and Dry. That meeting kept me alive, and I got a resentment. I couldn't fucking believe I was getting the same treatment that I got in AA from my peers in NA. I almost didn't come back but I needed the other addicts. I needed them and had to be around them."

According to another addict who came to NA with some recovery in AA, "The resentment many addicts had back then toward the 'other fellowship' led to this passion to absolutely dissociate ourselves from it, which is impossible. Like telling your mom she's not your mom anymore." Fortunately, many of these NA members with AA clean time made the decision to stick and stay, helping to guide the fellowship through its difficult and often tumultuous infancy, because their need to be around other recovering addicts was stronger than their resentments.

Like the methadone controversy, problems over policy would crop up regularly as NA New York struggled to grow. With so many fires to put out on a regular basis, forming a policy committee was not high on any group business meeting's agenda. And learning that a group conscience was not one or two willful addicts shouting "you can't do that!" would definitely become an issue on every level of service in the years to come.

"You Can Come Home Now"

The first year of Narcotics Anonymous in New York City culminated with the first Area fund-raiser, the Pioneer Dance, which became an annual event. It was held at 800 Morris Park, and making the journey to the Bronx was part of the adventure. "People who had never been there found their way. It was a bit off the path but we carpooled. Taking the Triboro or Whitestone Bridge was one of the big issues that people fought about on the way there. The dance was held in an old, unkempt gym decorated with white paper tablecloths and blue streamers and a small silver "Happy Anniversary" sign on the far wall. And it was fantastic."

What an accomplishment—what a handful of barely clean addicts had done in a single year—eleven meetings up and running in four boroughs. In the drug capital of the world. In the city that had hated addicts with a special vengeance for decades. John C: "There was an article in the *NA Way* and it was like, hey, guess what? They're meeting in New York City and they're getting clean, and all you motherfuckers who ran away to Florida to get clean, moved to California to get clean, you can come home now."

Chapter 5 The First Year: Westchester / Upstate

"I live right smack in the middle of the state and believe me, it's different up here. NA couldn't have spread in the State of New York without starting in the City of New York. My personal opinion. It was such a powerful influence of natural diversity that it would have never happened anywhere else."

Guy H had been trying for three years to stop using heroin by going to Alcoholics Anonymous, but he couldn't understand anything beyond the obvious fact that his life was unmanageable. "Once I went nine months before I got loaded and told this to an old-timer. She said, 'Congratulations. You're slowly dying of small improvements.'

> I knew the program worked but I wasn't working it. I had lost my family, my job, someone I loved very dearly, and I was living in a Salvation Army shelter in Mount Vernon, and then I just collapsed. I finally surrendered on January 2, 1982, in a shooting gallery. When the guy who was running it left to get cigarettes I got down on my knees and my whole life passed in front of my eyes, and when I got up I didn't want to use anymore. I can't explain it but I knew I was free.

After getting hospital treatment for gangrene in his left arm, Guy looked for somewhere he could go to get help. "Back when I cleaned up there were TCs, Synanon, Day Top, and all those joints, but they didn't have rehab. Nobody wanted to treat heroin addicts other than with methadone, so where does that leave you?" Guy

went to the local methadone clinic for a three-day detox, but before he enrolled he saw a hand-written notice on a wall.

> There were four or five Narcotics Anonymous meetings listed—two in the Bronx, one in Queens, Bleecker Street—and a phone number. I called Terry R and he hooked me up with Henry M in the Bronx. He told me what trains to take as I didn't have a car, didn't have anything except a bad habit. The first meeting I went to was Getting Straight on Beach Avenue, on a Wednesday night, in the basement of a cafeteria of a Catholic school, and I looked into the basement window and saw Tony D and Henry and Papo and Leno sitting at a table. They motioned me to go around to the back. I went down the stairs and found the door but it was locked. Henry came to the door and said, "Are you a junkie?" I said, "Yeah. I'm looking for the NA meeting." He said, "Let me see your tracks." I swear to God. In those days they locked the door. It wasn't about the Rockefeller Laws. I think they locked the door to have some sort of control of the meeting. The neighborhood was pretty rough, and I guess they just didn't want every asshole in the world walking in.
>
> When I walked into that Getting Straight meeting for the first time and looked around the room I knew I was in a place for heroin addicts before anybody opened their mouth. That's the kind of identification I felt. I don't hold a resentment but I remember those days when you mentioned shooting dope at an AA meeting and they said, don't even talk about it. That's just the way it was. You could say that NA was born out of a squeeze. Nobody else wanted to hear what we had to say. So when I found a meeting for people like myself, that's why I stayed and got involved, because I

realized I could really make a difference here.

There were no NA meetings in Mount Vernon or anywhere in Westchester County in early 1982, so Guy started attending the Bronx meetings: Getting Straight on Wednesday and Back to Life on Monday and Friday, getting rides from Tony D in his big Lincoln, as Tony was living in Port Chester at the time.

> Tony had six months when I met him, and we became very close. We called him the king of the first step. When people with lots of time speak at a meeting I hear so many of them say, "I'm not going to talk about drugs." Well, what brought you here? Tony was fantastic at reaching people on a first-step level. He told stories like burning down a motel stoned on methadone. He wasn't complicated but he got your attention. It was a simple program then. I was a mess, trying to put my life back together, depressed, and I'd go to a meeting and in fifteen minutes he would make me laugh and I would forget. Tony had a saying: "One of our aircraft is missing." I didn't show up at Back to Life one Friday night and the next day five guys came to my house.

Back to Life was not like what Guy was used to in Mount Vernon, where he had attended Sobriety Unlimited, which was known as "the Marines of AA" because they separated the men from the woman and had signs on the wall that read NO PANHANDLING and NO 13-STEPPING. "When I first came to Back to Life we sat in the kitchen in the back of the church basement with no heat. It was a meeting for junkies, a pretty rough crowd, and except for a couple of women who came and went, it was all guys until late '82. Henry M was one who called the meetings Drugs Anonymous. He lived right around the corner from Back to Life and he invited some of us over after the meeting. He came out with a coffee cake, then said he had to go back for a knife, and everybody pulled out a switchblade

at the same time—'Oh, I've got one'—and nobody even blinked. We were all in recovery but still carrying a shank in our pocket. That's kind of how it was."

The First Narcotics Anonymous Meetings in Westchester County

Early in 1982 the head of the Substance Abuse Detox Unit at United Hospital in Port Chester, a city on Long Island Sound near the Connecticut border, came to Back to Life. His name was Leo, and he asked the group if they would be interested in starting an NA meeting at the hospital. Interested in the idea of forming a group in Westchester, closer to home, Guy H, Tony D, Jack H, and Steve S met with Leo and a pharmacist who they later discovered was also a patient in the detox unit. When they heard that Leo wanted them to start a closed meeting, for patients only, they said no. According to Guy, "This guy Leo really wanted an H&I meeting, and H&I for us at that time was going to people's bedsides and talking to them, or to the shooting gallery and dragging them off to a meeting. We also knew the best meetings are in church basements. That's where they thrive."

But the negotiations with Leo continued, and two more recovering addicts, Dave M (Big Dave) and Ray H, also from Port Chester, got involved. A few months earlier, Big Dave had gone to Florida with a friend who had heard about NA meetings down there. Big Dave had managed to stay clean for two years by going to AA, but what he experienced at the Delray Beach meeting was not what he expected.

> I knew I had found home within the first twenty minutes. The people were younger, like myself, and they were much more forthcoming about their feelings and what they had been through. It was truly magical. To me, the beauty of NA, what made it different, was that alcohol you could get legally. The big part of

addiction was the copping, the lifestyle, the characters, a lot of people who had done time, a lot of people who were nuts. I didn't like everybody but I loved them.

Big Dave lived in New Rochelle, a ten-minute drive from the hospital, and Ray H, who also had two years clean in AA, lived in Port Chester. It was 35 miles from Port Chester to Awareness and 25 miles to Back to Life, but convenience was not the only reason he was interested in starting a meeting in his hometown: "I had heard about NA from a guy in AA, but I also knew convicted felons couldn't congregate outside of an institution."

I used to live in Harlem, the only white guy for miles, because that's where the drugs were, so I stayed. But I wasn't very good at stealing because I kept going to jail—Sing Sing, Rikers, Westchester Penitentiary—I've done them all. When I was in the institution I'd say to myself, *I can make it, I can stop,* but when I got out there were three or four cars waiting to take me back to Harlem. I didn't stand a chance.

I went to AA one step from jumping off a cliff, and it was the hardest thing I've ever done, so scared I couldn't make it, but I had a great sponsor and I did whatever he told me. I went to a meeting where they had two sizes of coffee cups. My nature was to grab the big one and my sponsor said, "Put that back." "Why?" "Because when you're clean for a year you can get the big cup." I followed his directions. After I got a year I asked him, "Can I get the big cup now?" He said, "What do you mean?" and I reminded him. He told me he was only kidding. That's how serious I was about getting clean.

By the time Ray H and Big Dave started attending the

meetings, the hospital officials had agreed to allow the Back to Life members to start a regular NA meeting in the hospital, open to the public, but insisted that they be supervised by members of their staff. The prevailing attitude at the time was that addicts were mentally ill, and the idea that they should be allowed to run their own meeting didn't sit well with them. According to Ray:

> We had to talk to these people. They were psychiatrists, and they were running a detox for rich dope fiends. A guy named Dr. Wolf was giving them Demerol first plus a new drug he had come up with, and then they went to methadone. We had a little thing because they wanted to stick the staff at the NA meetings. I said we can't do that so they gave in. I knew a guy in AA from California who told me about the groups out there, and Dave had told me about the meetings he had gone to down in Florida. He hated AA because he never drank, so he was all for getting this going. I wrote to California for literature. I also talked on the phone to Johnny A and others in the NA group in LA. There wouldn't be meetings in New York if it weren't for these guys in other states.

No one who was at the first meeting of the Port Chester Group remembers the exact date, and many of the early NA meeting lists are undated, but it must have been sometime before April 1982. Members from Awareness and Getting Straight as well as Back to Life kept the meeting going, and Ray H and Big Dave started attending meetings in the city, especially Back to Life, as it was the closest. With their two-plus years of recovery they were regarded "as gods."

> We'd go to Morris Park and they'd say forget about the other speaker. Let's have them speak. It was rough, trying to send the message. Everybody with 15 days, 30

days, go to a meeting, fall in love, both of them go out. I sponsored 18 guys in Morris Park. My mother was alive then, and she was a sweetheart. She was like my secretary. The guys would call up and if I wasn't there she'd tell them, "Just don't use and go to a meeting. Ray will be there." I'd been a taker all my life. Now I wanted to be a giver, and pass on what I had learned from my sponsor. My job was to get the newcomers through the 12 Steps and then they could become sponsors and that's how it grew. We didn't even bother with the Traditions in the beginning. It was don't use, go to meetings, be of service. My sponsees would go to Florida and come back and we'd discuss things.

After earning his GED, Ray H went to art school, then got his BA and a master's degree, but in those early years, in the words of Billy S, one of his sponsees, "He was one scary guy. You did what he told you."

Saturday Night Live

Eventually the NA meeting at Port Chester hospital closed, but the people who started it went on to open Saturday Night Live. Steve S, newly clean, asked Guy H to come with him to talk to the priest at Christ the King Church in North Yonkers about having an NA meeting there, as he needed moral support for making a request that was, and still is, an anxiety-inducing experience for any recovering addict.

And so I did. The priest's name was Father Foley. He asked me, "What kind of meeting is it?" I said, "Well, it's kind of like AA," because in those days you didn't say drugs. He kept asking about what kind of meeting it was and I kept hemming and hawing and finally I mumbled "Narcotics Anonymous," and he said "For

> junkies? No problem." That priest was one of the best friends NA ever had. It was a candlelight meeting and it opened on Christmas Eve, 1982, and it really took off.

Saturday Night Live, an offshoot of Back to Life, became the first non-institutional meeting in Westchester County and one of the most memorable. By the following month, two more meetings had opened, offshoots of SNL. Mike K and Jimmy M started Lost and Found in Tarrytown, and Open Door in White Plains. This was to become the pattern of growth north of the City, where the motivation for starting new meetings was much more likely to be convenience than a resentment: Why travel so far when we can start a meeting in our hometown?

First Meeting in Putnam County: Hope Without Dope

Graymoor is a monastery in Garrison, New York, run by the Franciscan Friars of The Atonement. Located at the top of a steep hill overlooking the Hudson River, surrounded by greenery, with a beautiful chapel built in the style of the Basilica of Assisi, birthplace of the friars' patron saint, and a bell with a ring that can be heard all the way to Peekskill, Graymoor couldn't have been a more unusual setting for a Narcotics Anonymous meeting. Thanks to Father Dan Egan, it was. For half a century, from his work with women addicts in New York City in the late 1940s to his death on February 13, 2000, Father Dan was a passionate and outspoken advocate of addicts everywhere. He was called the Junkie Priest by cops who kept seeing him at court on behalf of women they had arrested for drugs or prostitution, but Dan Egan wore the epithet like a badge of honor, even though he was not an addict. As a friend of Jimmy K, Rae L, and Dorothy Berry, his roots to NA go deep, and he also had a longtime connection with many recovering addicts who in the early 1980s helped resurrect the fellowship in New York. Like a father to a family of prodigal children who knew him from their using days on the street, they were reunited with him years later

when they found a home in NA. One of the prodigal sons was John McM.

> I grew up in the Bronx, and I knew Tony D from the street. His wife, Fran, was beautiful and sweet, a knockout. In the book [*Junkie Priest*] she's the one who Father Dan has to go to the Women's House of Detention to tell her the guy she was arrested with had died in the Tombs. Both Fran and Tony had a struggle getting and staying clean, but sooner or later me and Tony and Kevin F from Queens, Bobby P from Brooklyn, Ralphie from 14th Street, and Joe D, a Con Ed guy from the Bronx, we all ended up in that room at Graymoor, and it all came about through Father Dan.
>
> I had known him and his whole family since I was a little kid, and so did my whole family, because we were all in St. Benedict's Parish in the Northeast Bronx. I used to sell the Catholic newspaper outside the church every mass until they caught me thieving. Many years later, I moved to Garrison, right below the monastery. Someone had told me there was a meeting up there, but it wasn't sanctioned NA. My mother came on a visit and told me she wanted to get some mass cards. I asked her where she wanted to go. "Well, we're right at the foot of Graymoor." "What are you talking about, Ma?" She told me Dan and his brother Joe were there. They had both become friars of the Atonement. I said, well, wow. That was how we got reunited.

No one knows exactly when Hope Without Dope started, but it was at least by April of 1982, as the first mention of an NA meeting north of New York City is documented in the Regional archives for that month ("We hear there is a meeting at Peekskill"), but it may have been in existence as early as 1981. Father Egan's motivation

for starting the meeting was to accommodate the many addicts in New York State, New Jersey, and Connecticut who wanted to see him, and he received permission from his superiors to hold a Thursday night NA meeting at Graymoor.

According to John McM, "Father Dan would tell them to go to the quadrangle, where his little garden was, and to direct you how to get there he made signs out of plywood—they're burned into my memory—black with a yellow 'NA' in a circle." Tuki D also attended these early meetings of Hope Without Dope. "Father Egan would sit in and also his brother Joe Marie and Father Jack, but it was a real NA meeting and it was well attended."

There was only one problem with this idyllic location: access. In the wintertime, provided the road to the monastery had been plowed, a vehicle with a four-wheeled drive was required to make it up that steep hill. To say nothing of the fact that most people coming from the city did not have any kind of car. Hope Without Dope first appears on Regional meeting lists in May 1984, still at Garrison. For a time it relocated to Huguenot, a hamlet near Deer Park in Orange County, where it met Monday nights.

> The signs came with us. After the move the superior general, Father Albion, called me and asked to see me, and I went up there. He told me the friars thought we left because they had done something wrong, so we started a new meeting up there because the fathers wanted us back. There were twelve of us, and we called it Unity for Life because there were twelve letters in the name. After two years it became Never Alone, a book study. That room is still used for meetings today, and it holds a lot of memories. Father Dan and the friars touched many of us in so many ways.

Eventually the Hope Without Dope group moved back to Peekskill, where it still meets on Thursday nights at the United Methodist Church on Main Street, now in its fourth decade of

keeping its doors open to addicts seeking recovery.

The First Meetings in Orange County

The phenomenon of people starting meetings at the same time in various locations, unaware of each other's existence, was also happening north of New York City. In March 1982, around the time that the first meeting started in Westchester County, across the Hudson River in Newburgh, sixty-five miles from Port Chester, a former Brooklynite named Raheem started Hill Climbers, the first meeting in Orange County. It met Tuesday evenings at the Outreach Center on Lake Street, and later moved to Christ Lutheran Church on Fullerton Street. Raheem had found recovery in 1974 at New Horizons Rehabilitation Center, a treatment program in Brooklyn, and later moved upstate to Middletown, where he continued to be active in Alcoholics Anonymous.

> A lot of addicts started coming to the meetings in the early eighties, and they were disrespecting the meetings by talking about drugs. The people in AA knew that I was a heroin addict and they said to me, "You've got to get them out of here." So I went over to St. Pius XII Outreach Center in Newburgh, and in March of 1982 we started Hill Climbers. They gave us a room to use on Tuesday night. There were three of us at that first meeting: Pinky, a guy I grew up with in Brooklyn, a woman named Helen, and myself.

A few weeks later they started Orange County's second NA meeting, Reflections, which met Saturdays at one o'clock at the YMCA in Middletown, 30 miles away. It soon moved to St. Albert's Seminary, where it held a Saturday morning meeting. These first two NA meetings west of the Hudson quickly attracted addicts from nearby counties. Like so many addicts in recovery at that time, Tuki D first heard about NA from someone in an AA meeting. "He heard me

share a story laced with drugs and told me about a fellowship called NA. He invited me to go to my first meeting at Hill Climbers in Newburgh. There were two groups, another in Middletown, and they were incredibly supportive. There were ten to twelve people at a meeting from various counties, as many as we could muscle together at one time. Because of the availability—two meetings—it took me 45 weeks to make 90-in-90 in NA."

Sidney C had the experience, rare at the time, of actually getting clean in NA. In 1980 he was incarcerated in Camp Pharsalia near Rochester, New York, where the first Narcotics Anonymous meeting in New York State was started by Lin A. Most likely, an H&I committee from the local group brought in the NA meetings to this facility. "When I came home to Poughkeepsie they didn't have any NA in the area so we had to go to AA, and there were a lot of drug addicts at these meetings. Eventually we found out about the NA meeting at Middletown. I met Tuki there and he told me to get involved, and so I did."

Reflections still meets on Saturdays, at noon, at the Summitfield Library in Middletown, in continuous service to recovering addicts in Orange County.

The First Meetings in Ulster County

The meetings in Middletown and Newburgh were also where Billy D was welcomed back into Narcotics Anonymous after a twenty-five year interval of using. He had attended his first NA meeting in 1957 in the Brooklyn House of Detention when he was seventeen years old (see chapter 2). "When I left the House of D I went to a treatment center for adolescent drug addicts at Riverside Hospital, and then I split and went back to using until January 1983. A friend of mine asked me if I would attend an NA meeting in Newburgh with him and I did."

In March 1983, barely two months clean, Billy D started Lifeline, the first NA meeting in Kingston, a Wednesday night meeting at St. James Methodist Church on Pearl Street, and a dozen

people from Newburgh drove down to give it support.

> The only people who showed up were the people from Newburgh. Then we started getting the word out and it grew fast, word of mouth. A funny story: In those days they still had the unlawful assembly laws and we had to register the meeting with the local constabulary, and they sent an undercover detective—I knew him, so he wasn't all that undercover—to monitor our comings and goings. He came to about three or four meetings, saying that he was an addict, and when he found out we were legit he stopped attending them. I don't know what he said to the police, and he never said anything to me, but it must have been favorable because they never bothered us.

Within a year, these pioneers of Narcotics Anonymous in Orange and Ulster counties had started meetings in Poughkeepsie, New Paltz, Hudson, and several other meetings in Kingston. Lifeline still meets, same time, same place, celebrating three decades of keeping the doors open in Kingston.

Back to Reality: Brewster and Carmel

The appearance of women is rare in the history of the earliest meetings, where they were often likely to be the only one in the room, even though women suffered from active addiction as well as men. Sandy F observed many female addicts come into the rooms but mostly go. She also struggled in the beginning.

> I copped in abandoned buildings, put my hand in the hole at four in the morning in Harlem, and here I am, a Puerto Rican from the Bronx, living in Carmel, a very exclusive area, with a husband and three kids. I'm living the American dream, and I've still got to leave

my house every morning and go cop. I would make farina for the kids, put them on the school bus, and I wasn't even Catholic then but I went to church because the cop man didn't open till one. I was just killing time.

Sandy F's first meeting was Back to Reality in Brewster, a ten-minute drive from Carmel. It opened in January 1983 and was still small and struggling.

I went to Brewster that Friday night and saw a few people sitting around a cafeteria table, and it was clear to me that everybody was shaking in their boots. I said, "Hey, is this NA?" and they said yeah. I said, "Great. I'll be back." That was my first meeting. Somebody ran after me and gave me this tiny, tiny meeting list—one page—all of New York State and hotline numbers. The next meeting I went to was on a Sunday. It was the same people sitting around another table in Carmel. That meeting also opened in January '83. There was some discussion about pot being a drug. I said, "Wait, stop the music. What do you mean, pot's a drug? I've got a half ounce right here." I proceeded to open up my pocketbook and these guys are saying, "Don't take it out, put it in your car. You're welcome but not the drugs," and so I did.

I went to that Sunday meeting in Carmel, and I went to the Friday meeting ten minutes away, and other than that I traveled from an hour to an hour and a half to Queens, the next nearest meeting, I went to the Bronx. I had a running partner. I stayed clean for 27 days. I was so happy. Then I relapsed, and that first relapse was a horrible thing, but even though I kept relapsing I kept going to meetings. I had a good friend I call Brewster George who kept calling me up even

> though he knew I was using. "Let's go to a meeting," he'd say and I'd tell him, "I've got to go cop," and he would tell me, "Let's go to the meeting first and you can go cop after. No problem."

The Brewster group got their information on how to run a meeting by calling California. They were pretty sure they weren't supposed to drink, but a member called up California, just to make sure, and was assured that alcohol was a drug. They were also unaware that there was supposed to be clean time requirements for service commitments. In fact, Sandy F became the first treasurer even though she was still using because out of the ten regular members she was the only one who wasn't financially in dire straits.

> They insisted I had to be the treasurer because they were afraid anyone desperate for money would cause problems. I asked them if I could take the money and make the group some more money. The price of gold and silver was really high. The said they didn't think that was the way it worked, so once again we called those people in California and they said, yeah, we don't do that. I had issues with that, but they wouldn't let me.

Sandy F was finally able to get clean when she found out she was pregnant. "I knew it was dangerous. My daughter was born clean, and I can't tell you how grateful I am." When she went to a doctor in the upscale town of Carmel for a post-natal checkup, she told him she was a recovering addict, as it was suggested that members let a physician know not to prescribe a narcotic drug. "He didn't believe me. He looked at my face and said, "I know what addicts look like. I work in Lincoln [a State prison in the Bronx]," so I rolled up my sleeve to show him that my tracks were old. He asked me how I did it. I told him about NA. He asked me for literature. I gave him what I had, and once the *Basic Text* came out I gave him that, too, and he read it from cover to cover." At that time, rare was

the medical doctor who would even entertain the idea that addicts could stay clean.

H&I Before There Was H&I

There are twenty state prisons (half of them maximum security), one federal prison, and a county jail for each of the seven counties in the Hudson Valley, and by the early eighties, due to nearly a decade of Rockefeller Drug Laws, the majority of the inmates were addicts. From the beginning, H&I outweighed any other service. In 1982, as soon as the meetings were up and running, a small number of recovering addicts in Westchester, Ulster, and Orange counties—less than a dozen—set out to carry the message to this enormous population. They did so before the Westchester Area was formed, without the benefit of the coordination, guidance, and official sanction that the Narcotics Anonymous service structure provides, or any literature other than the *Little White Book* and a few pamphlets.

In Orange County the effort was spearheaded by Hill Climbers and Reflections. Both groups had been started by Raheem, who had the kind of credentials that only an ex-con can bring in from the outside, and he had also worked as a counselor in Otisville and Fishkill Correctional facilities.

> There was no H&I back then that I knew of, but the prison system let me start a meeting in Otisville Correctional, but it wasn't H&I, it was a real NA meeting, with readings and everything. I brought in people I knew from the meetings to come up and speak. A lot of these inmates were from the city and, being from Brooklyn, I went to a lot of meetings down there—Brooklyn, Bronx, ENTER. They were very different from the meetings upstate, a lot more street dope fiends. The people upstate didn't hit their bottom like the people in New York did. I got a lot of information in the city that

I used in Otisville.

Ray H was instrumental in starting these pre-H&I meetings in Westchester County and other upstate facilities. He also had a connection within the system. "I had been in prison a lot, so I knew where to find out where they had addicts. I went to an assistant warden I knew and I told him we'd like to bring a meeting into his facility. He said yes. That was the way H&I spread early on. Later it flowered."

In Ulster County, Tuki D, Sidney C, and Billy D brought the message into numerous facilities west of the Hudson River. With the lasting memory of the first H&I meeting he had attended as a teenager at the Brooklyn House of Detention, Billy didn't need to be convinced of the importance of bringing meetings into prisons. Neither did Sidney, having been recently introduced to Narcotics Anonymous while he was incarcerated. At one of his first NA meetings after his release he met Tuki.

> Right away it was H&I, me and Tuki and Billy D. In '82 we started H&I meetings in Downstate Fishkill, Camp Beacon, and Peekskill. There weren't so many prisoners who came in the beginning, so we started bringing in women, Elizabeth H and some others who names I can't remember, but that's when the inmates started coming to the meetings. The women attracted them to the meetings but after they got there they got interested. When we opened up the Downstate Fishkill meetings there were a lot of people who were hooked up with the Rockefeller Laws and they didn't have any hope. Because we listened, and because we talked about it, they kind of opened up.

Tuki remained active in upstate H&I for many years, aware from the beginning of the urgency of the need and so few recovering addicts to meet that need. "There's an incredible prison population

up here. I used to get down on my knees and pray, a lot, before I went in, and in the bathroom if I had a chance. Whatever I said, it stuck, and people kept calling us back, and this was wonderful, especially when people I met in prison would get out and come to a meeting and tell me I was responsible for their getting into the fellowship. Although I was uncomfortable when they said that. I always told them if it wasn't me it would have been somebody else but I'm glad to be a part of your recovery."

He attributed literature as the major reason for the success of this handful of people doing service to such a large number of incarcerated addicts. "Literature was the responsible means of carrying the message for us. It gave us a lot of clout. It helped turn around other groups like Cocaine Anonymous and Pills Anonymous because, believe it or not, literature was what swayed them to join NA. It was why we became the go-to people when an addict was reaching out for help. Wherever we went, we carried literature. The meeting lists especially carried a lot of clout because most of the people who were sent to a facility were from New York City."

Unity in Diversity

New York City residents can be pretty provincial when it comes to knowing about the rest of the state. When the New York Region was formed, an upstate Area service representative got a phone call from the office, asking him if someone could drive to Buffalo and bring a newcomer to a meeting. "It's 350 miles from Middletown to Buffalo, a twelve-hour round trip." Unless they have the luxury of a car, most downstate members of Narcotics Anonymous have no clue as to what upstate New York is like, not just about the geography but the great diversity of the counties north of the city. By the end of that first year of meetings opening upstate, the geographic disparity was already enormous: a north-south distance factor of ninety miles from Yonkers to Kingston, and sixty-five miles from Port Chester to Middletown east to west. In between is a natural diversity of

lakes and rivers, forest and farmland, valleys and mountains with hollows deeper than the mountains are high. There's also great cultural and economic diversity: farming villages, college towns, prison towns, suburbs, upscale commuter towns, and the many depressed river towns, the refuge of many who have been priced out of their city apartments after decades of gentrification.

And then there's the difference in temperament. "I used to be a city boy," says one member, a veteran of thirty years of service to the upstate fellowship, "Now I'm a country boy. We do things up here with more deliberation because of the way we live. We sit back, look at the river, and contemplate things. We're a lot more patient up here. I can't say we're more open-minded, but in our service meetings we will sacrifice some of our own ideas for the greater good of the whole." This atmosphere was much more decorous than what he experienced in service meetings in the city. "It was wonderful that we had that moment of spiritual prayer, having to interrupt the meeting for a moment of silence to center us. That was a great difference between meetings south of us. It still seems to be the case today."

Recovering addicts who were heavily invested in the forming of Narcotics Anonymous north of the City tend to be more aware of the unity that comes out of the New York Region's great diversity because they have the benefit of comparison:

"The nexus of the fellowship was the City, north to Westchester. City meetings were wild and crazy and not in a stupid way, but in an exciting way: Come join us, we're gonna have a great time and we're gonna stay clean."

"You walked through the doors and you got a hug. That's particular to our fellowship. We give hugs instead of handshakes. In the city was the first time I'd seen that done and we carried it back to our meetings, to spread that kind of recovery."

"We didn't have local guidelines for how to set up a meeting. We only had California guidelines for how to make it happen, various positions we could use that worked. The strength of our Region's diversity came from the ability of one group doing things

its own way. Whatever worked, worked."

"I've never heard of one group folding because of something another group did. So many people treat the Traditions like they're laws and restrictions and they're not. They're about autonomy. That's what we learned from New York City. Who are you to say what's going to work in a certain neighborhood as opposed to your own neighborhood? That's been the mindset of New York NA from the beginning, and what has kept the Region's diversity intact, its flavors distinct, all the while supportive of our many differences. Is that a miracle? You tell me."

Chapter 6 The First Year: Nassau and Suffolk

"It was greater than all of us and no one knew that. If we knew then, we would have treasured it. Maybe that can happen now."

"We were like kids in a sandbox who grew up without parents. We didn't see the pioneering, the gift that was being given to us."

"Coming from a little town like Long Beach, I'd go to Bleecker Street and all the city meetings and I could never understand, like, how do you stay clean in the middle of all this? And we did, and it didn't matter whether you were in the middle of Manhattan or Stony Brook, Long Island, we stuck together and we just kept coming back."

A 1981 World Service Directory lists three meetings for downstate New York, two in New York City (Awareness and Back to Life) and one in Central Islip. It is listed as "Hauppauge: Saturday 2:00 p.m. Open Discussion, United Methodist Church, Wheeler Road and Oakdale Avenue. Contact: Zoe." So far the history of this group—how it got started, who Zoe is, and when it closed—remains in the file labeled "More Will Be Revealed." Nevertheless, it is the first duly registered Narcotics Anonymous meeting on Long Island.

The story as we have been able to document it so far begins in December 1979, during the celebration of Ernie C's first anniversary in Alcoholics Anonymous, when a woman named Bonnie M came up to him and introduced herself. Although Ernie had been careful to follow AA protocol by not mentioning his drug use, Bonnie had identified him as another addict. Ernie recognized her as an addict as well because she had needle tracks on her arms. "She said she'd

never heard anyone share the way I had at a meeting. Then she told me she had heard of a program called Narcotics Anonymous, and that it might be around but she didn't know where."

The impact of identifying a fellow drug user at an AA meeting, picking up on clues that only have meaning to another addict, motivated Bonnie to go on a quest for this group called Narcotics Anonymous that was so difficult to find. The first meeting she discovered was in Princeton, New Jersey, a two-hour drive from her home in Rockville Centre. She made regular trips to meetings in New Jersey, from Princeton all the way down to Atlantic City, until in the spring of 1981 she heard that the fellowship had started in New York City. That year she expanded her NA road trips to include meetings in Jackson Heights, Queens, and Morris Park in the Bronx, then to East Harlem and the East Village as new meetings kept popping up around the city. In the process she learned a lot about NA, but her ultimate goal was to start a meeting close to home.

One Little Group in All of Long Island

On a Monday night in April 1982 Surrender, a candlelight meeting, opened at the elementary school of the Central Synagogue at 430 DeMott Avenue in Rockville Centre. In the beginning most of the people who attended were from New York City, having heard about it from Bonnie at meetings she attended in Queens, the Bronx, and Gracie Square Hospital. These addicts came to support the new meeting, but slowly the word got around to the locals that NA had come to Nassau County.

Ernie C found out about Surrender from Bonnie M at an AA meeting. Aside from the convenience of having an NA meeting that was a ten-minute drive from his home, "there was an immediate attraction for me that the other fellowship never had—that I was an addict, and this was my tribe. The experience was magnetic, the yelling and applauding, people genuinely happy to see you. It was rough and it was wholesome."

Buddy K also found out about Surrender from Bonnie M at an AA meeting. "I ran into her at a Pot and Pills Anonymous meeting in Rockville Centre. We had every kind of anonymous meeting you can think of and so many people didn't know which way to go, but when Bonnie told me she had just started NA I got involved with the group and we just kept going." Buddy K had two years of recovery in AA as well as an understanding of the many newcomers had who were coming to the meetings from therapeutic communities with no knowledge of the 12 Steps.

> Most of them were just torn down. Few of them stayed. They would get a couple of weeks or a couple of months and then go back out. They really had a difficult time. I'd been dragged to one of those TCs, even though a friend had warned me not to go. She told me, "They will take you out on a limb and leave you there." TCs didn't believe in the NA program back then. They didn't recognize alcohol as a drug, and our concept of a higher power was against what they believed in. *They* were the higher power, and had their own methods—big-shot-ism, Wild West stuff, authority figures who humiliated you with, "Who do you think you are?" I didn't have to think about that. I knew. I had to have everything taken away except my life, sleeping in a lawn-leaf bag in my car, asking myself, *What happened?* TCs would beat you with a bat, and I was already beaten.

Bobby D was another local who found out about Surrender in another fellowship. Upon his discharge from a detox in South Oaks Hospital in Amityville that April he had been advised to go to AA, where someone told him about the Surrender meeting and he decided to give NA a try. His initial reaction was not promising.

> The most important thing for me back then was what I call the "days of fear." I was going to AA but

there were bad feelings. Three times I was physically removed from some meetings because I was holding myself out as different. I taunted them into it. I forced them to remove me, unknowingly. I realize now they were very concerned about *their* welfare. I was afraid, they were afraid, fear breeds fear. It was a real mess. I had a friend who mentioned NA to me that I might feel more comfortable there, and that's how I ended up at the Surrender group. I walked in and saw about a dozen people and my first reaction was that AA was this big fellowship and NA was unheard of, small and scattered. I felt I needed to be taken care of and didn't see an opportunity for it to work. So my reaction walking out of that first meeting was, "I'm doomed."

But that didn't last long. I found out that Surrender wasn't the only group in NA. There were also meetings in the city—the STAR Group in Brooklyn, Back to Life in the Bronx, Bleecker Street downtown, ENTER on 113th Street, one in Yonkers I believe, two in Queens. And the wonderful thing about it was that everybody went everywhere.

Robin was one of the few women who came to those first Surrender meetings. She was still using but kept attending because "nobody judged. You come to a meeting high and you were invited to stay."

When I heard Bonnie's story it was worse than mine. She shot dope in her feet. I hadn't gotten to my feet yet, so I was very impressed. My most vivid memory from that time was sitting in a circle on my chair, shaking, cold, and kicking, but for the first time I felt like I was picking up pieces of myself and putting them back on. Basically, I just talked to my dog. I couldn't talk

to humans. Bonnie saved my life. I looked like I could function and played that card for a long time but with her I didn't have to. I just went along for the ride. She took me to Awareness, Horizon, a woman's meeting in Queens, ENTER, meetings in Brooklyn, Jersey and Westchester. I didn't choose her to be my sponsor, didn't even know what a sponsor was. The women chose you back then.

Jersey Joe was living in Nassau County at the time. He had known about NA since his first detox in Paterson, New Jersey, in 1979, but gave up looking for it and started going to an AA meeting near his home. He was twenty-two years old, the youngest person at the meeting was forty, and he started looking for an excuse not to be there. When an elderly man responded to his complaining with the comment, "Maybe you don't belong here," he found it.

I went back to the races, but they kept moving the finish line on me. I lasted 25 months chasing oblivion, from acute alcohol poisoning to a heroin OD, and ended up at South Oaks in January of 1982, where I met Bobby D, who was detoxing, too. When I got out of rehab in May of '82 I went back to AA. That summer Bobby called me and said there was a meeting "just for us" in Rockville Centre, about seven minutes by car from where I lived. He called me a few times. Then one day the thought of the taste came back and I called him. He said don't worry about it, the meeting was the next day.

I took the train to Rockville Centre, Bobby picked me up, and I made my first NA meeting. It was small, eight addicts attending—Bobby, Bonnie, Debbie, Jon, Conrad, Amy, Stew—I remember everyone there like it was yesterday. At that time we had no *Basic Text*, just the *Little White Book* and each other. That was the only

meeting we had on Long Island in the summer of '82. We had to car pool, six or seven of us, and we would go up to the Bronx, where there were about 20 people—Tony D, Sal, Rosie, Fat Mike, thin as a rail—and we'd go to Union Turnpike, and it was a real struggle.

We made a lot of mistakes, not knowing about taking directions, the meaning of the Steps, making amends, and there was a lot of unnecessary suffering, either playing the victim or blaming others, a lot of growing pains. But through all this not knowing there were two things we did know at that time—no matter what, you don't get loaded and you go to meetings—and a lot of us got through it, got involved with service, and did all right.

It's easy to conclude at this point that the single greatest contributing factor to the growth of NA in Long Island in those early years was addicts in other fellowships turning on other addicts to NA. Butch S had been clean a year going to AA on the North Shore when somebody at a meeting handed him a *Little White Book*. "I went home and started reading it and just cried my eyes out. I said, how can somebody write down what I feel inside? I was pretty much illiterate. It took me forever to get through it and it was difficult, but the feelings and the words they were using, they were exactly how I felt. I had to go and find that place."

There were no NA meetings on the North Shore—still aren't—but I found the Surrender Group about 20 miles away. I already had a year clean when I went in and I was a little cocky, that street stuff, you know, but I was like, holy mackerel, these are real addicts, the dope fiends I hung out with and got high with, not like the old alcoholics I could bullshit. I was so psyched. There was nothing like it. It was the excitement of

being able to talk about drugs. Some people went a little overboard, but it was a freedom to be able to talk about that stuff. This was where I shoulda been in the beginning but there was no NA then, so you did the next best thing. When I qualified in the other fellowship I said my first drink was a blackout at 16 but I didn't say I'd been sniffing glue for three years. All you could say was you used drugs for a little while. A little while? I'd been shooting dope for ten years. So I was so excited about this thing. I wanted to get to know everyone. I went to every meeting I could find. We didn't have the readings, we just passed around the *Little White Book*. It was all the literature that was available and I carried it with me all the time. In those days I was delivering oil. I read a little bit while I was delivering the fuel and when the tank was filled up I'd put it back in my pocket. It was my lifeline.

The Surrender group was eventually evicted from the temple after members were blamed for a theft (some say it was candlesticks, others an old record player, and it will probably never be known if the addicts were responsible), but they were able to find another meeting place at the Lady of Lourdes Convent on Sheehy Avenue in nearby Malverne. According to Buddy K, "All the groups that came later are a spin-off from Surrender, and it still exists, in West Hempstead, and it was Bonnie who got it going, who was everywhere, out in the rain and snow, unselfish, who kept the candle burning for us all today."

Surf City

Debbie T found Narcotics Anonymous in Fort Lauderdale, Florida, after a series of near fatal misses. Desperate to help their suicidal daughter, Debbie's parents, who lived in Long Island, had emptied their bank account to pay for her admission to a psychiatric hospital,

where she was diagnosed as having grand mal seizures and put in a locked unit.

> By the first night in that psychiatric hospital I had copped every kind of anxiety-reducing pills and sleep medications because I was a dope fiend and I knew how to get what I needed. I had this incredible doctor who used to save me for last when he went on his rounds because he thought I was the most interesting. Three days into my stay I whispered to him, "I think I'm a drug addict," and he said, "There's no such thing as a drug addict!" Meanwhile, I'm writing about slashing my wrists or killing myself with whatever drugs I could find. I was obviously in bad shape. Fortunately, there was a mental health technician who used to come in at night and I shared with him that I was a drug addict.
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> The day I was leaving he approached me and said, "Listen, there's somebody I want you to talk to. Her name is Sherry and she's going to give you a call when you get home." She did, and with this other guy on the phone they asked me a bunch of questions like, "Do you ever use in the morning?" "Do you ever use when you said you wouldn't use?" and I kept answering, "Yeah," and all I remember them saying was, "Pick her up!" The next night people came to my house and they just scooped me up and took me to a NA meeting and right from the beginning I got involved.

With two children, no car, and the only available meeting miles from her house, Debbie decided to start new ones. "I went all over Lauderdale on foot with the *Little White Book*. There were 28 meetings in Florida at the time and before I left for New York I had started seven of them."

Debbie T moved to Long Beach, where she was living with

her parents, and began a desperate attempt to contact someone in NA. Terry R had stayed at her house when he came down to Florida for the World Convention in 1981, so she knew there was NA in New York somewhere, but she had no idea how to reach him. "Finally someone told me to go to one of the other fellowships, which I didn't even know about, and look for dope fiends, go up to them after the meeting and ask them where I could find NA. That was how I found Surrender, and I became the secretary."

Then Debbie T did what she had done so well in Fort Lauderdale. "I went to every church in Long Beach with my *Little White Book*. The priest at the St. Ignatius Church on West Broadway told me, 'I guess you could have Saturday nights.' That was the Fall of '82. I sat there so many nights by myself until this one guy came and sat with me, and I also found out about meetings in Brooklyn and Queens. One night a bunch of people from New York came to the meeting in a truck. We didn't even have a name yet, but by that time I had gathered some people from Long Beach, surfer dudes, blond hair and all, and this guy from the city named Frankie said, "What is this, fucking Surf City here?"

The name stuck. Debbie T became the first chair of Surf City, and she also holds the distinction of becoming what is likely the first unofficial NA Public Information Committee on Long Island. "I typed up meeting lists, took them to a local stationery store, mimeographed them, and me and my kids would fold them and I would carry them to meetings in this big duffle bag. I would crawl into a methadone clinic around the corner and leave meeting lists around. I would go into all the bars with stickers that said CALL THE NA HOTLINE and put them on the phone booths. I was a little bit, you know, gung ho I would say."

Following a period of insecurity when Bobby D continued to go to other fellowships, he made a wholehearted leap to NA and became the next chair of Surf City.

> Tony D used to say that service is what you do while you're waiting to recover. I took his advice. At first I

had an AA sponsor named Jimmy O, a defrocked priest who lived out in Long Beach. He sat in with me at a couple of AA meetings, when I was still straddling a little, and then he told me, "I can't sponsor you." I asked him why. "Because I don't know your affliction." He was telling me the truth in a kind and loving way. Then he told me about Surf City. When I started chairing the meeting he would call me up on Sunday and ask me how the meeting had gone the night before. He'd asked me questions, one after the other. "Do you have literature? You've got to have literature. (We had no literature other than pamphlets. I photocopied the Steps and put them all over the place.) Whose coffee pot are you using?" We were using the AA one. He said, "You've got to get your own coffee pot. You've got to be self-supporting."

He was adamant about a lot of things. "You really need some unity. You need to do something that sets you apart, that makes you feel like who you are." He said to get the Steps and Traditions shades and hang them up. Put out some cookies. Make tea. Before you know it we had a regular dessert bar. It was a wonderful, homey place. There was smoking in the meetings then and Jimmy was very adamant about not using anything that belonged to AA, to break free and build. We were using their shells, because the beach was right across the street, so we made these little ashtrays out of cat food cans with slogans on them. Believe it or not, people would pick up on the can and make the connection. What I didn't know until later was that Jimmy was looking in the window every Saturday night to see what we needed. Yeah, I'll never forget that. So indirectly he helped. He knew there's a real need to recognize the difference between alcoholics and drug

addicts. For whatever reason, God has always supplied me with, for want of a better word, connections that were rich in nature.

Another expression of appreciation for AA comes from Buddy K: "I asked a fellow from AA to speak at one of our meetings on the Tenth Step. He said, 'I can't. That's breaking your Traditions.' I said, 'Oh, really?" They enforced them on us. We didn't know what we were doing most of the time."

Fern T is another addict who did service while waiting to recover. She went to her first meeting at Surf City straight from a detox at St. Johns Hospital in Rockaway. For two years she kept going in and out, all the while hanging on to her service connection with the group.

The first time I walked into a Surf City meeting there were 30 people, maybe more, and I knew I had to be there because it was junkies who were talking about getting clean, not society that was telling us to get clean. But the meeting was not just for junkies. There was a blanket statement at the beginning of every meeting: "This is Narcotics Anonymous, not Needles Anonymous. You don't have to put a needle in your arm to get here." I had the coffee commitment for two years because I wasn't really staying clean, so every time they had a business meeting I'd say, "Don't take away my coffee commitment because then I'll be able to do drugs on Saturday night," and with my commitment at least I had to be clean on Saturday night. I used to put cinnamon in the coffee pot because I wanted someone to say, "Oh my God, this is the best coffee in NA!"I can remember going up that driveway with the coffee pot and the baby and it was snowing, or it was hot, or there was a carnival next door, but I couldn't take my kids to the carnival because I had to be in that church or I was

going to cop.

It took me two and a half years to make 90 in 90. It was hard for women because there were very few of us around who were staying clean. The first woman I heard speak who had a lot of clean time was Doreen from D.C. She told me, "Baby, it's going to be all right." That can still make me cry when I think about it, because nothing was all right. Then Rosie found me at a meeting in Rockaway. She grabbed the back of my neck and said, "You. Come with me. Stick with the women." So that's what I did. When I had my first anniversary at Surf City, the room was packed, hundreds of people. My little girl brought me my cake. She sat on everybody's lap in the room. There wasn't a dry eye in the house. We cried and hugged each other to death, which was just what happened back then when junkies got clean.

"I'll Meet You at the Gate": Early H&I in Long Island

Once Surrender was up and running, Bonnie M began talking to Buddy K about starting an H&I meeting in Nassau County. At that time, addicts who sought hospital treatment were typically sent to psychiatric wards where they were treated as mentally ill, chemically addicted (MICA) patients, but rarely did these hospitals have a program solely for addiction. Bonnie had been to meetings at Gracie Square, one of the first hospitals in New York City to hold in-house NA meetings for patients in their drug and alcohol unit. Many hospitals in Long Island had similar rehabs—Long Beach Memorial, South Oaks and Brunswick in Amityville, Smithtown, Northport, and West Islip to name a few—and the need to bring H&I into these facilities was urgent because addicts were sent to other 12 Step fellowships when they were discharged. Most counselors didn't even know NA existed on Long Island.

While this project was still in the planning stage, Buddy

got a call from Bobby Moore, the director of the drug and alcohol rehab unit at the Nassau County Jail in East Meadow. He knew both Buddy and Bonnie from AA and wanted to talk to them about bringing an NA meeting to the jail.

> Before we even said yes we went into the City to Gracie Square and found out about doing H&I meetings, the requirements and such, so we would go in with the right information. We met with Bobby Moore, the warden, and the head sheriff of the Nassau County Jail and they were all very supportive. We found out they didn't know how to deal with drug addicts, only alcoholics, so it was clear that we would make their jobs easier. We then went back to Gracie to get literature and learn the basics for starting a meeting. Gracie had all we needed.
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> We started the first H&I meeting shortly after that—an H&I meeting before there was anything like an H&I committee—and it got kicked into high gear. Bonnie chaired the meeting for the women and I did the one for the men. But it was very difficult. It was my first time behind bars and I was groping around in the dark. It took a long time for the prisoners to trust me. They wouldn't talk to me for months. They liked to challenge me: "You aren't clean. You're smoking cigarettes." So I stopped smoking. It was the incentive I needed to get nicotine out of my system. That was 30 years ago.

The first request from a MICA unit came from Charlie Fuller, the director of Brunswick Psychiatric Hospital in Amityville, who had found out about the group and asked them if they could bring in an NA meeting. Another of the first H&I meetings got started because of a call from the director of the MICA unit at Smithtown. Buddy K was sponsoring his son. "When he found out that his son was getting help from us he asked if we could bring in a meeting.

He said so many kids were coming in and their counselors didn't know how to deal with drug addicts, only with alcoholics." Other meetings were started after calls from people in AA. "They would be doing H&I in these units, they'd tell us about the addicts in need, and we went in right behind them. At that time, if patients in MICA units got the NA message, they got it from our H&I." Many of these Long Island rehabs became an important conduit for recovering addicts who then became active members of NA and contributed to the amazing growth of the fellowship in its first five years.

At first it was just Bonnie M and Buddy K doing this service, but once they got it going other members were encouraged to come to the H&I meetings that were held regularly in the basement of Buddy's home in Rockville Centre. Growth was slow. "Drugs were everywhere. Dealers even came into the meetings to do business, and hardly anybody at that time had more than a year clean. A few months was the norm. Because so many people couldn't stay clean we reduced the service requirement from six months to ninety days." Then Richie S., an "old-timer" with a year and a half clean, moved to Nassau County from New York City, and he became an H&I mainstay. He invited Butch S, another so-called old-timer, to speak at Nassau County Correctional.

> I told Richie I've never been in prison. I don't know what to say to these guys. He said, "You don't tell them how to be in prison, they know how to do that. You can tell them how to stay clean." I went in there, and there were 85 guys at the meeting. I shared. He said that went pretty good. I said, yeah. He said, next Friday you're gonna run the meeting. Pick somebody up and take them along. I got Vinnie. Next Friday night, there we were, taking all our metal off, going up and doing the meeting. The name of the group was The Way Out. We set two precedents in the New York prison system. We were the first meeting to have a one-year anniversary. They baked a cake, made coffee, and we had two

> speakers come in. They had over 150 inmates at that anniversary. They gave me a plaque that they made. The other precedent was that this guy was getting out and he was the first inmate to get a pass to go out to an NA meeting. The chaperone was the prison chaplain.

Then Debbie T and Ellen, a biker girl, joined the H&I group and with their active members now at eight, they were able to bring the NA message to addicts at Long Beach Memorial and South Oaks Psychiatric in Amityville.

Literature was cheap back then, but they needed a lot of it, so they started passing a coffee can at the Surrender meeting. Somebody made a nice sticker for it that read HOSPITALS AND INSTITUTIONS, and even though no one had much money "we did pretty well."

Then, in March of 1983, Vitamin Joe ended up in the Brunswick drug and alcohol rehab. He had heard about Narcotics Anonymous a long time ago from Father Dan Egan.

> I got in trouble after being expelled from parochial school and he got called in. He asked me if I had ever heard of Narcotics Anonymous. I said no. He said, 'You will.' And lo and behold I did. I ended up in rehab because of job jeopardy. The aircraft industry decided they didn't want me stoned while I was building airplanes and they sent me to Brunswick. While I was there Narcotics Anonymous H&I came in. It was on a Wednesday night down in the basement of the rehab. That was April of '83. They brought in this guy who said there's life after drugs, that we go places and we do things and hang out together and find out we're not unique, we're part of.

Vitamin Joe got out of rehab and on his 91st day clean he was doing H&I at the Nassau County Jail. Now there were nine

recovering addicts doing H&I service on a regular basis. They expanded the meetings at the Nassau County Jail to three a week, on Mondays for inmates ages 16 to 21 and on Wednesdays and Fridays for adults. Jail mail also became part of H&I. "We had a list of volunteers who were assigned specific names. If somebody was getting out of jail or rehab they also had a contact: 'My name is so-and-so. I'll meet you at the gate and take you to a meeting.' That's the way it was. I'll meet you at the gate. We went to Gracie regularly for more literature, bought recovery books for their library. People locked up 24/7 have nothing but time. That H&I can supplied the whole effort."

Many of the inmates at the Nassau County Jail were facing 25-to-life sentences under the Rockefeller Laws and were awaiting transfer to upstate prisons. According to Buddy, "When they went upstate they started meetings at prisons like Attica and Dannemora. We'd been seeing them in jail for a year, and as they got receptive we took them through the Steps and gave them assignments. Our meetings were kind of like group therapy and they got very involved. We and Bobby Moore would meet with these addicts who were being transferred and give them literature to bring upstate. There was no coordination with these prisons. Strict regulations prevented that. It was the inmates' idea and they did this all on their own. Twenty-five-to-life didn't stop the message."

All these accomplishments, however, do not minimize the hard going that first year, or the frustration over not being able to do more with so few people. For every institution they serviced there were a dozen more that went without.

Growth was slow and sporadic that first year, but by early 1983 there were sometimes as many as 50 people attending the two meetings in Nassau County, although a lot of them were still traveling in from New York City. In February, motivated by the growing number of members who lived in Suffolk County, the Surrender group started Real People, a Monday night meeting at St. Anne's Church in Brentwood. At the time they thought it was Suffolk County's first NA group, but meetings had also opened

more or less simultaneously in West Hampton on the south shore and in Greenport on the eastern tip of the North Fork. "In Nassau we didn't even know that people out there were starting meetings," Buddy K explains. "That's how little coordination was going on."

The Brentwood meeting was one of Richie Red's unforgettable recollections of early recovery. "As you came downstairs into the cafeteria of this old school there was a statue of Jesus with no hands. Someone had made a sign that read: WILL YOU BE MY HANDS? Everyone at Real People identified with that statue. It made such an impression on me." So few hands, so many addicts still suffering.

The Moveable Feast

Long Island is that—long—more than a hundred miles from the New York harbor to Montauk Point. In the early years, when meetings were few and far between, addicts in New York City could rely on the subway. Sixty cents would get them from Far Rockaway to the Bronx, 24 hours a day, seven days a week, but the only kind of mass transit that spans the entire length of Long Island is a commuter railroad whose primary purpose is to transport workers to their city jobs on time. Addicts without cars who wanted to get to evening meetings at Surf City on Saturday, Real People on Monday, or Surrender on Tuesday were fresh out of luck, to say nothing of the strong desire they had to go to an NA meeting on the other four days of the week. The solution was the car caravan. One of the drivers was Bobby D.

> There were usually groups of people who had "the" car. Not too many people came in with wheels. I was one of the fortunate ones. We all know each other and where we lived. Sundays they piled into "the" car and drove to Manhattan to The Only Game in Town at Gracie Square. Mondays were Morningside, Back to Life in the Bronx, or Horizon in Queens. Some people got picked up for a ride to Surrender on Tuesday nights; others went to

Awareness in Queens or the STAR Group in Brooklyn. Wednesdays was Midtown Connection, Thursday was Bleecker Street or ENTER East Harlem, and the entire fellowship showed up at the not-to-be-missed Friday night meeting at Back to Life. Saturday afternoon was Clean and Serene in Queens, but come Saturday night *the* place to be for any recovering addict who could find a way to get there was Surf City, especially in the summertime with the beach right across the street.

Of that small nucleus of recovering addicts in those early years, living on Long Island as well as all over the Region, many look back on a time when circumstances forced them into expanding their horizons—and not just geographically. Some fond memories of those days:

The wonderful thing about it was that everybody knew everybody and everybody went everywhere. People from Harlem were coming down to Long Island, people from Long Island were going up to the Bronx and even up to Westchester out of pure need, hanging on to each other. Prior to this none of us would have ever crossed certain boundaries to be certain places with certain people. All of a sudden I felt a connection with every part of the city I'd never felt before. Did the meetings have different personalities, different flavors? Absolutely.

The first meeting that for want of a better word "sold" me on Narcotics Anonymous was the Back to Life group in Morris Park. There was an excitement, an electricity, something that said, this is okay. This is a safe place to be. The secretary's report just blew me out the front door. Why? It was given by Tony Daddio. Need I say more? He was loud and in your face and it was just

huge when he spoke. He didn't ease into it. I used to tell people at our Long Island meetings, which were still pretty small, "You think this is good? Come with me." And I'd take them to the City, up to the Bronx or to Gracie Square, another great big meeting.

You were scooped up. There was no way you could get in and out of a meeting without somebody grabbing hold of you. I always had trouble being social. Meetings were fine, but as soon as they were over I was gone. I'd slip out early, maybe, but somebody always eyeballed me and told me later I didn't have to do that. One meeting Mary M invited everybody to her house for her anniversary and there was a fellow, Lucky from the Bronx, tall, bald black man, and he saw me starting to slip out the door and said to me, "Are you going to Mary's?" I said no. And he goes, "Yes you are." I went. When we got there he said, "You can just sit here by the stairs and have the most miserable time you want, but just stay here, for me." And I did, and he would come over every fifteen minutes and ask, "Are you all right?" People who didn't know each other would step out that far.

It was a family feeling. I knew it wouldn't last, that when it wasn't new anymore, when the work got done and everything settled back down, that it would be how it is today.

We were the cognoscente, "the few who knew," and in the beginning the ones who were at meetings consistently could have traveled in one school bus together.

So Few Hands

This small group of characters had the privilege of enjoying the intense camaraderie that happens when a small number of like-minded people form a group that for the first time makes them feel as if they belong to something bigger than themselves. It's true that, so far, the word had spread kind of miraculously across 12 New York counties in a very short time—running into someone who knew someone who had heard about this thing called NA, trawling for addicts at meetings in other fellowships, finding a sticker on a phone booth in a Long Beach bar. In each of these counties it was an uncoordinated effort, seat-of-the-pants, catch-as-catch-can, that had gotten them through the challenges of the first year, but the number of addicts in the know was insignificant compared to the number of addicts who were still in the dark. A drug epidemic was raging and people were suffering and dying from not knowing what this little group knew.

Nevertheless, this phase of early development, when addicts were so strongly motivated to travel to distant neighborhoods and form close ties with strangers they never would have met on their own, created a geographic unity of purpose that would one day be called the Greater New York Region of Narcotics Anonymous. Without this early cohesiveness, born out of dire need, the Regional Service Committee might never have formed.

Chapter 7 People Like Us

"No longer did we feel like aliens, strangers wherever we went."

-Just for Today, May 21

What was it like to get clean in the beginning, with so few hospital detoxes or rehabs or halfway houses, without a meeting up the block or a subway stop away, or the guidance of predecessors, or even the assurance that getting clean, let alone staying clean, was possible? We asked more than a hundred recovering addicts who helped establish Narcotics Anonymous in the Greater New York Region to reflect upon that experience. Here, in their own voices, expressing the wide diversity of opinion that is the hallmark of the New York fellowship—strong, unvarnished, and from the heart—are some of the things they had to say about everything from their initial gut reaction to NA, making the decision to stick and stay, kicking their physical addictions and helping others kick theirs, to the impact of the outpouring of unconditional love they received from fellow addicts.

Attraction not Promotion

It's a magical moment when people so close to death's door get a glimpse of an alternative they never thought possible.

I got clean at AA meetings although I wasn't a drinker. One meeting this guy raised his hand to share. He had those heroin hands, all swollen, and I thought, I've got company. I walked up to him, introduced myself and said, "I'm an addict. None of this is

okay with me here." He said, "Have you ever heard of NA?" I had, in California. He said, "They're here." I said, "Where?" He said, "I don't know. I think they're underground. I can't find them." Then he came up to me at another meeting and told me he had found NA on Bleecker Street. I remember the first person I met there. He came from the Bronx, and he said, "Hi, I'm Bonafide Billy." Back then the guys used to have two names with some kind of adjective. Don't know why. Then someone in the back raised his hand and said in this deep, deep voice, "Hi, I'm Steve and I'm a junkie," and all of a sudden I knew, I'm home. This is it.

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My home group was Back to Life. I wanted to be a member of this group right away because I was attracted to the insanity. I just knew that this was not a sane place and it's cool. It's like going to the neighborhood for the first time and hitting that corner and seeing a whole bunch of people that you're going to hang out with for the rest of your life. Sometimes the meetings lasted for two hours. We let you share as much as you wanted to share. We didn't have old timers. The girls came around and served the coffee, we had sugar and milk on the table. We couldn't let you leave that room! There were people getting off in the bathroom, doing what they needed to do, but the bottom line was we wouldn't let you leave that room. You needed to hear the message, man.

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My girlfriend gave me one last chance. She said, "Get the garbage can," and we threw out thousands of dollars' worth of marijuana and beer into that can. Then she said, "That's very good, now here's a phone number for Pot Anonymous. Call these people up." I go to this meeting on Lexington Avenue in the hospital and find out it's Pills Anonymous. It's really about Quaaludes, all these nice girls with their high fashion and grandmother's checkbook and such. And then Mike B, he walks in, spots me, and says, "What are you doing here? Come with me." We go down to Gracie Square Hospital. I wasn't looking for Narcotics Anonymous and I couldn't see any commonality. My brain was saying, these guys are full of

shit. I wouldn't steal with them. But I showed up the next night and the night after that and I'm still coming.

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I was still shaking and baking. I went up to get coffee but my hand was so jittery I couldn't get the sugar in the cup, and I'm half facing the meeting and waiting for people to laugh at me because I'm ready to explode if they do. I put the spoon down and walked away. A guy comes over and says, "How many sugars you want?"

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I had been horrible for so long that slogan "Never Alone" really meant something. I could tell somebody the most fucked up thing I'd ever done and hear, "Yeah, I did that."

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The first time I raised my hand I said, "I'm Tommy. I'm definitely an addict." And that was like the most embarrassing, shameful, the most awkward feeling that I had in my entire life, but it was so sincere when I said it that I felt like something was lifted from me, all those years of lying and scheming and denying that I didn't have a problem. I felt naked, let's put it that way.

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How do you stay clean in the middle of the drug capital of the world? In the middle of a drug epidemic, walking past junkies lining up to cop around the block? The strength we were given. I vibrate when I think about it.

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Saturday was rough. I needed to eat up my time. Get up in the morning, no work, go to the park and swing on the swings for a while. It's eight o'clock in the morning, the meeting in Queens doesn't start till three, everybody I know in Greenpoint is getting up to get high, and I'm here swinging on the fucking swings. "Hi Donnie, what're you doing?" Oh boy, you know what I mean? Hey, I'm playing in the lion's den. I've got to get out of here. I'd walk up and down Queens Boulevard for hours waiting for that meeting to start because I didn't know anybody there. I did that every Saturday for a good year and a half. We loved that meeting,
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Clean and Serene.

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When I lived in Philadelphia I had to pay someone to drive to New York and cop for me, twenty dollars for a ten-dollar bag. Or go to North Philly where there was horrible dope, like purchasing Comet. I moved to the Lower East Side three months before I got clean and I could cop anything a block from my apartment. I don't think there is any way I can articulate how I got the message. I was so out of it in those days that NA could just have passed me by, but when I went to that first meeting and saw the motorcycle jackets and the Mohawks dyed red, I wanted to be like them, have what they had. I don't think I could have got clean anywhere but New York City because I was so wrapped up in image, but here the message was, you don't have to get clean and be a nerd.

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I got clean in Harlem but I went to meetings all over, from one borough to the next. New York is New York; you can take public transportation. I went to the STAR Group in Brooklyn to get another flavor. We used to get some guys from that group to come uptown to Life Begins Again. This guy from the Bronx named Nick, and just his whole terminology, he had that Italian swagger. You can go down to the East Village and get the gay's perspective. I didn't know much about diversity before. I learned that in NA.

The Gift of Desperation

Many of us were convinced years before we got clean that our addictions would mean our deaths and we resigned ourselves to that "fact," but once we came to NA and heard the message of recovery, it would have taken an army for us to throw away what we found here.

I had the attitude that I was going to get clean or die. A lot of people did. My first meeting I went to in Queens I was wasted. People came over and hugged me and I pushed them away, but I knew this was the end of the road. This was going to work or I was

going to die. There was nothing in between. I was 25 years old and I was done.

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I had to read lips, my ears were shut off, my brain was too busy to hear, my distance perception was shot, but I found hope through other people telling me to keep coming back.

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We had such a sense of this is our only shot. God forbid the literature person didn't show up. You had to have literature there because it might be the only piece that person would ever get because they might not be able to get back because there weren't enough meetings. There was always this sense of urgency and desperation about helping a person get the message, about keeping NA alive.

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"Without this place I'd be dead." I heard that a lot then, not so much anymore. We weren't driving cars and living luxuriously. We were down and out and most of us were either hustling or boosting. If you were lucky you came in on welfare. The sheer rawness of living in New York City and trying to survive while trying to get clean is what stays with me. There was no bullshit. It was like, "Sit down. Shut up." We didn't talk about therapy, inner child. I remember my sponsor telling me, "If you have an inner child she needs to get her ass kicked."

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Everyone was a newcomer. It was a bunch of guys sitting around and giving each other bad advice. "Let's do this." Yeah, okay." Scary.

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Nobody felt like a newcomer. Thirty people would line up at the meeting for a white chip—welcome.

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There was no message of hope. I could only talk about my past. My present was just developing. Bottom line, I really didn't have confidence that I'd stay clean. Now we know addicts can

recover. Back then you weren't so sure. Someone asked me a while ago, "What happened to NA? They used to be so rough and tough and now people relapse and get a standing ovation." It was fear. Relapse was a threat. If you relapse I can relapse and oh my God, so you didn't take it too kindly. We were so nervous that this whole thing could just fall apart.

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Your relapse could sink the whole ship. That's why we were harsh. If someone falls you can't go down with them. You have to step over the bodies. You were kind and gentle when someone wanted help but if you go out, don't get upset if you don't see us again because we have to survive.

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I picked up five, six guys to go up to a meeting in Yonkers one night and one of them said, "What are the odds here?" There was this lawyer in the car, half-baked through a detox. He said, "In a year we're lucky if one of us is going to be clean." He was right.

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From day one, even as a using addict I was made to feel comfortable, although a few people would avoid me. I'd be nodding and they'd be afraid my disease would jump on them. But most of those guys snatched me up and saved my life.

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It took me three years to make 90 in 90. I had everything down but the using.

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Two years I couldn't stop using. One meeting two guys came over and put their arm around me. I thought they were going to give me a hug but one of them punched me in the head. "You stupid dope fiend motherfucker, this is it. When you going to stop? Wake up!" When I finally surrendered I took to NA like a duck to water. Jumped right in.

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There was no other option. You got clean, went to jail, or died. People came crawling in off the street and toughed it out,

shaking and baking in the meetings, holding on to the chair with both hands. We had no guidance. We figured it out on our own. We made a lot of mistakes. It's amazing that NA got rooted in the city, amazing that we succeeded in our mission to get this whole thing going because we were all just kids and we were nuts.

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There was a cutthroat vibe, motorcycles, tattoos before they were, you know, a fashion statement, cigarette smoke thick in the air. I was paranoid anyway, but this was frightening. I stayed because it was the only place I could go where people wanted to be clean.

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This guy was a six-foot-three body builder and he relapsed. He came back to the 112th Street meeting and threw a chair across the floor during the secretary's report. T was not a big guy. He went over to him and said, "Sit down. You ain't really bad." He looked at T and, big as he was, he picked up the chair and he sat down. That's how it was. Their life was on the line. They weren't going to let you disrupt the meeting no way.

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The meetings were very raw, at least at night. It didn't faze us early on. Somebody sitting right next to me says he's not getting rid of his weapon because this guy is after him and my reaction is, okay, that's cool. It shows the state of mind we were at.

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I asked for a knife to cut the cake. Switchblades came out around the room.

Detox New York Style

There wasn't an addict alive who didn't dread withdrawal, but when the desire to stop is great enough, miracles happen.

Newcomers would come in strung out like research monkeys and had nowhere to go. There was no place for addicts to go for

We'll Love You till You Learn to Love Yourself

On page 20 of the Basic Text it says, "We didn't stumble into this Fellowship brimming with love, honesty, open-mindedness or willingness..." and the last thing any of us expected was to be shown love by total strangers just because we showed up at a meeting, but that is what happened and for many of us, it is what kept us coming.

I was very reclusive when I was using. When I found the right combination of drugs that made me feel comfortable around people, nobody wanted to be around me. Without the drugs I was so miserable it was a huge miracle I didn't blow my brains out. It was all about staying clean. Forget trying to relate to anyone. People didn't hug me. They saw I was not okay with that.

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I liked the candlelight meeting because nobody could see me. I was one fearful guy.

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After a meeting I got grabbed by a bunch of people and told I was going dancing. I'd never danced in my life but I had a car. It was so traumatic just waiting for the night to be over, wanting to crawl out of my skin, hoping they didn't want me to talk to them in addition to driving.

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I got taken everywhere. Every time I tried to pay for something out of the three or four dollars in my pocket they said, "We've got this. You'll get your turn. Your day will come to do for someone like we did for you." I get emotional just thinking about it.

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When a new guy would come in a small cluster would gather around him. "C'mon, you're coming with us," and wherever we were going for the next three months he'd be a part of it. And then all of a sudden the new guy was taking people around. People who didn't do it didn't stay. You were either a part of the growth or you didn't stick around.

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The love of the fellowship was the most powerful attraction. Couldn't buy it. Couldn't steal it. Had to be given away.

Hugs Heal

The slogan says "Hugs not Drugs" but the hugs weren't a replacement for drugs, they were a lifeline, a warm welcome in from the cold that many of us never thought we would feel again, let alone deserve.

People who have not been seen as lepers, pariahs, gutter scum, the untouchable dregs of society, will never be able to understand the importance of a hug.

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Hugs were the pure love they were trying to give you. It emanates from this fellowship. It's infected society as a whole, people hugging, even Bush and Obama. Men never hugged each other when I was growing up. It's a direct effect of NA in my opinion—macho men who break down and cry, are allowed to, encouraged—come on, let it out. I never wept until I came into the rooms.

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In AA they shake hands. That's their password. Ours is we hug. That's true in all the places I've gone to a meeting, except maybe some really rural areas in the United States where they're not accustomed to it. It's not right or wrong. It's just what they're comfortable with. Most places they'll say, "This isn't an AA meeting. We don't shake hands here. Give me a hug."

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Touching another inmate in prison is against regulations. It's supposed to be for our safety but it's another way of dehumanizing us. Put your arm around someone who just got bad news and you risk doing more time. Imagine how I felt going to my first meeting on the outside, like my humanity was restored.

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The difference between the addict and the alcoholic is one of the reasons NA started to hug—grabbing on to each other physically as a symptom of the need to be accepted and a part of, because we were so ostracized from society or ostracized from ourselves. Alcoholics were already part of society. The addict lifestyle is a subculture —language, dress, everything—that's all about being separate from society, but I think it was also a big motivation behind the beginnings of NA, wanting to stay separate—to be with people who were like us.

Other Fellowships

There are as many opinions about the relationship between NA and other fellowships as there are NA members.

They talk about the "other fellowship." There is no other fellowship. It's one program that NA adapted. Even say the word "AA" now and the whole room got a problem, but if it wasn't for AA you wouldn't be here. We need to start to grow up.

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These fellowships always form because we have a resentment of some kind. The predecessors in AA talk about when they got started there was a big controversy that got physical and they cut out the whole Oxford Group. In the beginning not even the Catholics could get in. We learn the things that we learn at the time we learn it.

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When I got clean in 1977 I had a hard time in the other fellowship. My needle stories weren't welcome. An approved booklet called *God Help the Heroin Addict Because We Can't* came out but we kept going to meetings anyway because there were some people that really helped us. When NA got started I felt so great. Halleluiah!
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I used to say AA was like your grandfather's funeral. NA was like adult reform school.

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When I started going to NA my AA sponsor told me, "I tremble for your sobriety."

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It's a different social structure. Alcoholics drink in bars and no one pays attention to you unless you talk to the bartender. Go get high and everybody has to know you just to make sure you're safe. Get into the circle. You have to protect each other. You share your drugs. You don't share your drink.

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We would go to AA meetings, listen to people share, and if they had drug stories we'd give them a meeting list. The people in AA were happy for us to do it because they wanted the addicts to go where they could get the identification and feel comfortable. So I have this incredible debt of gratitude to the program of AA.

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The relationship between NA and other 12 Step programs was cantankerous. We didn't like Cocaine Anonymous. They all had like a thousand-dollar-a-day habit, talked all this grandiose bullshit. We weren't comfortable in AA. We let them know it and they let us know it. Gamblers Anonymous, they were fucking arrogant. They thought they were like college and we were kindergarten.

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AA, NA, the madness is still there. You know what I tell them? You're like two groups of people on each side of a stream. You're both dying of thirst and you're arguing about where the water came from. Shut up and drink the water.

Language

Language is especially powerful when it is used to define a group of people. The strength of the emotion behind that need to be defined can be

seen in the controversy over the use of specific words and phrases that exists to this day in our fellowship.

We always identified ourselves as alcoholic/addict, but when new people would come to the meetings it was confusing to them what program they were going to. I was the first one who started just saying I was an addict. I said we've got to start showing them that NA works all by itself, but it was a scary thing to do. We fought over that, oh my gosh, but it was clear to me that NA worked all by itself because it worked for me all by itself when I got clean in NA in another state.

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There was one guy who used to say I'm so-and-so and I'm a junkie. That used to irritate me no end. Sometimes I'd say, "Are you still using? The only junkies I know still are." And he'd hate me when I'd do that. He'd say, "You little pothead, you don't even know what drugs are." That kind of stuff.

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There were a lot of arguments about saying clean and sober. Then the movie came out and that really messed things up.

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The big thing was cross-addiction, which I loved because I love to suffer. Nail me on the cross. You heard "I'm clean and sober" all the time back then and it was okay because it opened the hearts of people from AA who came in.

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The problem was we never had a single name to focus on—garbage head, dually addicted, speed freak, junkie, dope fiend—it took a few years before we got the name down pat, that simply "I'm an addict."

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When people used to say "I'm sober" we'd be all over them. We finally have our own fellowship, our own language, and we didn't have to put up with the other fellowship's bullshit no more. That was a big thing, a real big thing. I was an addict and that
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covered everything. It was our own, finally.

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In AA it's one day at a time. In here we talk about just for today. A little bit of separation. Listen, we have a language we use in NA. You need to learn it.

Literature

We didn't have much in the beginning, but we kept it handy because it was often the barrier between not picking up and a relapse.

I had *The Triangle of Self-Obsession* folded up in my wallet. I was a bartender and when I had ten drunks leaning on my bar I'd pull it out and read it. I pretty much wore that one out.

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Literature was hard to come by, so somebody would type up the pamphlet on a piece of paper, I would take it to work the next day and run copies. That was how we did everything then. Bootleg. We had nothing.

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Two guys from Florida were at our business meeting. They said it's against tradition to make copies of the literature. It's hard to carry the message with literature, it's twice as hard without it, so I said, "What the fuck you going to do anyway, get a couple of dopers from Lauderdale or Miami to come up here and break my legs?" That's how I felt. The message had to be carried no matter what.

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Someone handed me a *Little White Book* in a meeting. I was pretty much illiterate. I could read a little bit and it was difficult getting through it, but the words they used, it was exactly how I felt. How can somebody write down what I feel inside? I read it and just cried my eyes out.

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The meeting list was a mimeographed sheet with ten meetings
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on it. Two of them weren't happening anymore and the sheet was dog-eared and they reproduced it with the fucking dog ear. It was beautiful.

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We were doing H&I. I had a white booklet and they were precious. A guy in treatment asked me for it. I hesitated and Lynne said, "Give him your fucking book." That was how precious it was to me. You may not have gotten another one so easy.

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It was all I had, crumpled up and sweaty, always losing it and stealing another like I did with drugs—"That's mine!" That was the extent of my social interaction.

"Don't Touch My Coffee Pot!" Doing Service

This was a time when people lined up for service positions, when having enough clean time to be elected by your home group was a dizzying moment of joy and triumph. There was nothing we wouldn't do in service to Narcotics Anonymous.

When I had 94 days the chair of Clean Machine came over to me and said, "Guess who the speaker is tonight?" I said, "Who?" He said, "You." I said, "Oh God, I can't. I'm not ready, da da da," and he said, "Of course you can. Go in the bathroom and pray."

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The first time I was asked to speak at a meeting I went out and bought a whole new outfit for the occasion.

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The first time I spoke it was at an open meeting and my parents came. My mother wanted to know how much I was getting paid. Nothing.

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We used to stack the deck to get a service position because there would be a whole line of people running for it, even to make the coffee. So what we did was a lot of street shit. We would get
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together before the business meeting with people who wanted to get a service spot and ask them what position do you want? How about you? How about you? And then we'd rig the voting. Yeah, we did a lot of dealing from the bottom in those days. We still had our addict behavior.

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I lived in Staten Island and I used to take a bunch of meeting lists with me on the ferry. I sat downstairs where everybody smoked pot, cigarettes and drank and because I was attractive and sitting with other women they used to talk with us and I'd give out meeting lists. And I'm telling you, a lot of those people came to meetings, and a lot of them are still clean, and that blew me away.

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My first service position was at Bleecker Street. I was so nuts. I went in an hour early to set out the pamphlets. They either had to be laid out color-coded or alphabetical or thematically. So I had to go early because if anybody knew what I was doing they might fuck with me—oh really? Is that the way you're going to do it? Why not just move the green next to the yellow? No! I can't do that. And then I had to make the perfect pot of coffee.

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I would do whatever they would let me do. It made me feel a part of like nothing else. Coffee maker? Don't touch my coffee pot! Set up chairs, empty ashtrays, giving rides. That was a big thing in Westchester, four of us on a regular basis and we're all still here. I loved nothing more than going on a road trip, drive up to Community Hospital in Ellenville, see Dr. Damico who treated the hopeless cases, tell them when they got out we'd be there for them, drive back, and still go to work the next morning. It was like being 18 years old all over again. Wild and crazy but not in a stupid way, in an exciting way. Join us, let's go, we're gonna have a great time and we're gonna stay clean.

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My brother and I were both involved in service in Nassau County. We had Intergroup, what we called it back then, at Jackson

Heights, and my brother and I made a commitment to go to ENTER House in East Harlem on Thanksgiving Day. We had to leave the family dinner early and my mom wasn't altogether enthusiastic about my priorities, but I told her, "We have to do this." We stopped at a grocery store because there were some people who could leave the facilities and others who couldn't go out, and we made up a basket of all kinds of things. When we got there one of the fellows embraced the basket and said, "And I was thinking about going back to the cooker." All of a sudden it dawned on me, the insight that you can do something nice, it can be appreciated, and it is important. In all my drug-using days I never had those three things come together.

First Anniversary

None of us had more than a few years clean, so reaching a first anniversary was a momentous occasion. It was also the best way to impress upon the newcomer that Narcotics Anonymous really works.

From the beginning we made a big deal out of anniversaries because so many people couldn't believe it could be done. So it became something not just for the celebrant but for the newcomers, to tear down the myth of once a junkie always a junkie. As far as I know New York is the only place where they do it this way, making it such a big deal. If other places have adopted the way we do it in New York it's because they heard about or came to their own conclusions about it.

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My first anniversary was at Lifeline. I thought about it all year. Brian gave me a little coaster with the Serenity Prayer on it. A little plastic coaster. It meant the world to me.

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It was in Brooklyn, first time in my life that people were giving me something for me. I was institutionalized most of my life so I didn't have birthdays. It was amazing to me, the thoughts that

went through my head that day when I looked at all the balloons and the little presents, and I was never really given presents in that way. What went through my head was I went through 365 days without doing something that I always did and couldn't stop doing, and that was the most awesome feeling I've ever had in my life.

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It was in the Bronx, but I probably celebrated everywhere. Every meeting you went to you were going to run your mouth about how successful you were, to try to make it attractive to other people. Cakes, whatever. A year clean I still wasn't convinced I was going to stay clean. I thought this is another one of my own scams. I'm really full of shit. I couldn't trust myself. It wasn't until 18 months that I thought it was real.

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It was at Morningside. I was the only white celebrant. My sponsor wore a black tux, white shirt and a red bowtie. It was like the Academy Awards.

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It was at Free at Last on Macon Street. My mother came. They showered her with love just because she was my mother. She thanked my home group for giving her back her son. She always said she couldn't understand why I couldn't get clean in the church, but that day she got a glimpse of understanding that stuck with her until she died. She had 17 years of seeing me clean. Last thing she made me promise was that no matter what happened, "Don't stop going to those meetings you go to." I said, "You've got that, ma."

You're in the Spirit World Now

Living life based on spiritual principles is the complete antithesis of the life we knew before we got clean, and for many it requires revisiting the past to get connected with a higher power of our own understanding, not the one that was imposed on us at an early age.

Here at my first meeting was this big, tough, recovering dope
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fiend, ex con from Brooklyn sharing about his higher power, and here I was, an ex-Episcopalian girl from Westchester who had no belief in anything at all. That sold me on NA. If this guy could talk about it, and cry about it, maybe I can let this in a little bit. I'm so grateful for the spiritual guidance that brought me there that night. I probably would be dead today or one of those miserable, still-living-but-almost-dead addicts you see and think, there but for the grace of God go I.

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The concept of a higher power in my life was so distorted. It was my mother's God, the church's God, not a God who had done anything for me. I felt like I could never turn to this God they talked about. As far as I was concerned he was kicking ass: world wars, brother strung out on junk, father that drank up most of the money, living in a hell hole. They used to say, have faith, so I was going to save my money and go to the candy store and buy a box of faith. I just knew there was someplace you could get it. In my recovery that's where I got it, for free, a gift.

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I didn't have a problem with a loving God of my understanding. We'd always been on pretty good terms. But I did have a problem with standing in the circle saying the Lord's Prayer. Being Jewish I felt I wasn't part of that "nice way of closing." I was relieved when they changed it.

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I didn't believe in a higher power at first. I'd given up on God in Vietnam. It was like that for a long time and my recovery was slow, but I got to the place where I had no hope and that's when I found God—the giving-not-getting that makes the fellowship grow. I look at my using when I'd size you up and think, what can I get from you? When I really found God is when I flipped the script—what can I give to you? I had something to give that could save a life, and it was free. Then I developed it further when I realized it wasn't me that was giving it, it was *through* me that you were getting it. The message of recovery.
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My running partner and I spoke at a workshop called "Spiritual not Religious Program." Two desperados talking about God.

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God put some truth into this fellowship and it doesn't change. You want what I got? Do what I do. Believe in something other than yourself. Your self-centered little ass is not going to get you clean. The "we" in the fellowship is the beginning of the road to God, and the connection to God is through other people. You hear things and they click.

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My greatest experience getting clean back then was an incredible awareness that blew my mind about spirituality. The God I was introduced to as a Catholic growing up and going to Catholic school, communion, confirmation, and all those things was different from the God of my understanding I found in the fellowship, about creating your higher power, not somebody else creating it and giving it to you but finding it and enriching it. That has been the big difference—finding God and letting God find me.
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Chapter 8 Impossible Dream

"From impossible to improbable to unstoppable. That was the plan."

"We didn't know what the God of our understanding had done – picked a bunch of ragtag addicts who were ready to do it and handed them a script they'd never read."

In June 1981, when Narcotics Anonymous in New York City was still in its infancy, barely two months old, Terry R attended the Second East Coast Convention of Narcotics Anonymous in Trenton, New Jersey, where he experienced the magnetic power of numbers – 300 recovering addicts in one room. The tiny New York fellowship – two meetings and a dozen or so members – was not a lonely planet in an uncertain orbit around a possibly unreachable goal. NA on the East Coast was real. Terry R had also met recovering addicts from around the country who were eager to help the New York fellowship take root and grow.

In 1981 there were 55 registered NA meetings in Pennsylvania, where the Northeast fellowship had been launched in 1969, and there were 19 in New Jersey, an outgrowth of the Pennsylvania meetings. But the rest of the Northeast was a barren wasteland for addicts seeking recovery: two meetings in New York City, three upstate, three in Connecticut, one in Maine, one in Massachusetts, three in Rhode Island, and zero meetings in the rest of New England. For some reason the NA fellowship had not caught on in the most densely populated region of the country, but that was about to change.

Bobby B from Philly was also at that 2nd East Coast convention,

newly clean: "It gave you the opportunity to see many people, cold-blooded stuffers just like yourself, and it gave you hope. We hooked up with Terry and started networking—New Jersey, Philly, getting phone numbers, making connections. You'd get in your car and drive to Connecticut, up to Maine, down to West Virginia—but you knew you had to do this in order to stay clean. Whatever was going on in Narcotics Anonymous, whatever was happening anywhere, you had to be there."

Three months later, in September 1981, Terry R and Henry M went to Florida for the 11th Narcotics Anonymous World Convention at the Marco Polo Beach Hotel in Miami, attended by 625 addicts. Once again they experienced the intense high of mingling with hundreds of joyful addicts who didn't use. On Terry's 1980 trip to Florida he had been encouraged to start NA meetings in New York by a lot of people who had who moved to Florida to get clean. Now these same people, along with members from other states, were urging Terry R and Henry M to put in what Terry R called a "token bid" for New York to host the next World convention. According to one non-New Yorker, Terry R and Henry M were quickly surrounded by hovering ex pats "because early on everybody in NA in South Florida were New Yorkers. I was about the only who wasn't. I used to say if you love New York so much, please go back. I made a great hit with that one."

At that time there wasn't anything formalized on the World Service level to handle these conventions, then held yearly. They were pretty much put on by members in whatever cities got the bid at the previous convention, a procedure that was "basically a free-for-all between everybody there who would vote." Four cities put in bids for WCNA 12 at the Miami convention—Hershey, Pennsylvania; Milwaukee, Wisconsin; Fargo, North Dakota; and New York City—and New York nearly won the bid, losing by two votes to Milwaukee.

That a fellowship with a total of two meetings and less than a dozen trusted servants came close to hosting a World convention is indicative of how many people were passionate about helping NA

grow in New York, not just for New Yorkers but for the benefit of the fellowship as a whole. Even at the 1980 WCNA 10 in Wichita, when there was not a single meeting in downstate New York, "a lot of people were talking about how we needed to get NA going in there. San Francisco, Miami, LA, Atlanta, Philly—all these big cities were going strong but no New York or Boston. There were more meetings in Fargo than all of Chicago. You knew NA would take off if New York did because everything goes through New York."

Dreaming Big

Three months after the Florida World Convention, at the second meeting of the newly formed New York City Area Service (NYCAS), putting in a bid for the 1983 world convention was on the agenda: "Requirements to come from Florida." The desire to take on this commitment was by no means unanimous among the New York membership, for a lot of reasons. In 1981 the World Service office in Sun Valley was nothing grand, just a storefront that Jimmy K ran without much help. "For the rest of the country it was like Mecca but it really was not that big. At some point everybody would call California and Jimmy was the only one who ever answered the phone." It would take a few more years before the World Service Conference created a convention corporation, which meant that the host fellowship of a World convention took on full responsibility for its success or failure.

Compounding the risk was the practice of awarding the convention to the fellowship with the greatest need—"the weakest link in an already weak chain. I thought that criterion was stupid and destructive," said a member who served on the World Service Board of Trustees and later moved to New York. "Greatest need for what? To totally extend your resources and burn yourself out doing a convention when we should be starting meetings and getting clean?" Members who opposed this weakest-link approach frequently brought up the 1977 World Convention in Texas, where the fellowship there folded the next year, and they had more

experience, more meetings, and more trusted servants than did New York. "Let's learn something from our own history," dissenters pleaded.

Money, however, soon became the primary concern. By May 1982 the Area was reeling over the theft of $700, the entire proceeds from the Pioneer Dance, their first major fund-raising event. The treasurer at that time was living in a committee member's house. "He went around to all the groups, collected their money, then took off and was never heard from again. Not only that, I had one of those big glass water jugs full of change." In a move worthy of the Grinch, "he took that too."

According to the minutes of the July 11th 1982 meeting of the NYCAS, the most urgent order of business was an unpaid bill for the newly instituted hotline, run out of Terry R's apartment, which was already receiving close to 100 calls a month. A shutoff at this point would have been a disaster. Only by holding an emergency rummage sale were they able keep the hotline running. All other urgent needs, like printing up new meeting lists, were tabled. Nevertheless, in spite of the Milwaukee World Convention being only six weeks away, putting in a bid was still a hotly contested item on the agenda. "There was a whole core of us who said no, people with time I respected who said this was serious business. Listen, we had fifteen dollars in the treasury. How can you be talking about hotels, raising big money, tens of thousands of dollars, and maybe thousands of people coming out of the woodwork while we're trying to launch Area and all the other insanity we were dealing with?"

After taking a precautionary vote at the July meeting that "no major decisions be made by any one person without a majority Area Service vote," which now totaled ten groups, the group service representatives (GSRs) brought back to their home groups the need to have a group conscience about the bid. Due to the shortness of time, they had a deadline of seven days to phone in the results, which required most of the groups to hold emergency business meetings.

One GSR described what happened next as "self-will run riot. Absolutely it was." Another member angrily recalls being at a meeting in Queens when "a whole bunch of people walked in, called for an emergency business meeting, took a vote, they all voted, then said, 'Now this group is for the convention,' and walked out. Okay?" A somewhat milder recollection was, "The guys who were really into wanting it to happen got in a van and went to all the business meetings. I thought the idea of the bid was great but the way we did it was somewhat willful." Nevertheless, even with all the manipulation, the groups' conscience on the bid was, according to the August 1 minutes, to "shelve this due to a lack of support."

What happened after that is conjecture, as it occurred between the lines of the NYCAS minutes. At an emergency meeting held on August 29th the first item on the agenda was the STAR Group's decision to "pull out of Area Service due to the decision about the World Convention." What that decision was is not specified, but apparently it involved taking a second vote. "Area Service has nothing to do with the World Convention," the minutes conclude. "If individual members wish to get involved, it is up to the individual. A double vote on the World Convention wasn't necessary."

What hindsight does reveal is that in those waning days of August through Labor Day weekend, without the knowledge of most New York NA members, we ended up winning the bid to host WCNA 13 at the Milwaukee convention. Exactly how that came about may never be known, but by following journalist Carl Bernstein's dictum to present the "best obtainable version of the truth," what follows is a verbatim account of how a number of recovering addicts who were in Milwaukee remember it, and how the host fellowship then pulled together to put on what was then the largest and most profitable World convention, one that would change Narcotics Anonymous in New York forever.

Going to Milwaukee

Bobby B from Philadelphia was in New York City during the August controversy over the bid, and Terry R asked him to come to an Area service meeting to help him persuade the members to put in a bid.

> I told them I knew what it was like on the Lower East Side when we came up from Philly to cop. It was like people are dying here. Everybody knew. It was a must-sell, a had-to-be happening, and the only way to get New York on the map, get meetings cooking, was to expose it to a World convention, get that kind of enthusiasm about recovery. That evening Terry takes me to a dance at the [AA] HOW Club on St. Mark's Place and introduces me to Tony D. He was an older guy who had done some crazy, outlandish shit but his general persona was that he was very stable and had his act together. He was an immediate draw. I said you've got to come to Milwaukee and pull this off. We'll get Philly and Jersey and Connecticut to help you. We've got to be united. If we don't make this thing stronger than us we're doomed. But Tony was resistant. He didn't want to get involved in anything that might blow up in his face. He was a wait-and-see kind of guy.

Big Richie had known Tony D from the misery of counting days in the heatless basement at Back to Life. "He was always sitting in the back of the room with his hat down. He didn't want to talk to anybody and neither did I. We used to look at each other and nod, both checking out the place, sizing up people. I met him at the coffee pot one night and finally talked to him. I realized he was about as nuts as I was and we kind of hooked up. We were at Clean and Serene on a Saturday when Terry kept talking about the Miami World convention the year before, this big meeting and all, and I said, Tony, let's go to Milwaukee. He said how? I said Sal's

got a van. We talk him into it, he talks his wife into it and we'll go. So we cornered Sal and kind of bulldozed our way in, then he told Shari and she agreed.

"We were all broke so I sold my ten-speed bicycle for 75 bucks so we'd have gas money and we drove to Milwaukee. We didn't have any idea what we were getting into. We knew nothing about a bid. All we knew was the same ten people sitting around at meetings trying to deal with a bunch of people high on methadone."

The fifth passenger in the van was Rosie B from the Bronx, clean for 20 months but a newcomer to NA. For all that time she had been following a long and convoluted path that began in City Hospital detox in the Bronx and ended up at Back to Life. Rosie had stayed faithful to the Clean and Dry meeting in the Bronx, grabbing on to the rare woman who came through the door. One of them was Shari M, and Rosie became her sponsor. Then she met Shari's husband, Sal M. He was doing H&I at Brunswick Hospital in Long Island and asked Rosie B to speak.

> On the way he says, oh by the way, it's an NA meeting. I said, NA, AA, what's the difference? Little did I know the difference that it made. As I'm sitting at Brunswick reading the *White Book* a light bulb is turned on in my head, like, NA, where have you been? This is the truth about me, living and dying for drugs. I grew up with the code of the streets: live fast, die young, and make a good-looking corpse. What kind of thing was that to believe in? It was sad. It was sad. And I've got to speak now?

After the meeting she asked Sal, "Where is this NA?" and he said, "I'll take you."

When she went to her first Back to Life meeting in late August 1982, "there were three women and like thirty men and most of them were loaded, and there was a lot of shooting up in the

bathroom. Back then, the guys from Queens were different. They were just happy they were clean, but in the Bronx they were very apprehensive, always afraid this wasn't going to work. The attitude was, if you make it or if you don't, you're on your own. Now I understood why Tommy told me not to go there when I just got clean."

Rosie B also met Tony D at her first NA meeting. "He did the secretary's report, which was hysterical. The following week we all went to a Lois Wilson picnic and Shari and Sal and Tony started talking about who was going to the world convention. Shari tells me, 'It's next weekend and we want you to come. Sal has a white van. I thought, Milwaukee? I didn't even like to leave the Bronx. Addiction behavior once again. By the next day I thought, they've taken me to NA, I've got the white book, what do I have to lose? So we got on the road, and on the way we told our stories and got to know each other."

The Milwaukee NA helpline people put them in touch with a local member named Jeff, who put them up in his house along with some Hells Angels from San Jose, and they got into a discussion about New York putting in a bid for the next convention with Tony D and Big Richie. "What are you talking about, the next convention?" Richie S asked them. Rosie:

> Later on I went into the kitchen and Tony was telling Richie about the bid and Richie was mostly listening. I had no idea about what this was, so I listened too. Tony was saying there were only a handful of us in New York, and this would be too big for us to handle, and the guys from San Jose said we'd never win the bid. The convention would never let it happen, so why stick our neck out?

As it turned out, the only one who had come to Milwaukee in Sal's van who even knew about the bid was Tony D. He had been a skeptic since Bobby B first told him about it at the HOW Club, and

after talking to the Hells Angels, they confirmed his suspicion that putting in a bid was a very bad idea.

The True Believers

What the three of them didn't know was that the bikers from Southern California by no means reflected the feelings of a number of trusted servants with influence who were arriving from all parts of the country, determined to bring the next World convention to New York. According to George H, who had been on the Miami convention committee, even before WCNA 12 opened, New York was the favorite choice. "There were a lot of people out West with roots in New York who wanted to bring the fellowship to the Big Apple. If we could establish it there we believed it would be the best for the most, helping a lot of people in a small geographical area. That feeling was particularly strong among the older members in LA and San Francisco."

The Florida people had been on board from the beginning. About ten of them had arrived in Milwaukee on a chartered plane, ready to help New York members put together a bid. Other East Coast true believers were Bobby B and his Philadelphia contingent. Meanwhile, back in New York City, Terry R had been working hard with other bid proponents to cobble together a presentation in a very short time, and he had flown into the convention with the fruits of their labor. "Somebody had stolen a letterhead from the office of New York City's mayor, Ed Koch. We wrote a letter about how much he was looking forward to New York hosting the convention, and I forged his signature. We didn't even have a hotel, no fancy presentation, we had nothing. We were just lying through our teeth."

For Rosie B, the sight of hundreds of recovering addicts milling around the lobby of the Hyatt Regency that afternoon was "mesmerizing. We were on a balcony overlooking the hotel check-in and saw all these addicts hugging people, dressed nice, jewelry, clean and happy. It could have been a convention of politicians or

something. We met the crew from Florida and they were hugging us and kept talking about bringing the next convention to New York. I met Terry R for the first time. He was going around with loose-leaf paper and scotch tape, putting up signs all over the place that said NYC NA, THE IMPOSSIBLE DREAM. Tony was critical of that. 'Look at Terry, putting those signs up. They're just going to get ripped down.' I said, 'Tony, stop it. You don't know what's going to happen here.' I was getting a little aggravated. It was just getting under my skin that maybe this *would* be a good thing for New York. Then we met Bobby B and he was with Terry and they were, you know, rah-rah-rah, but I still wasn't so sure."

Sal M was also skeptical. "I remember meeting everybody and it was like 'New York is in the house!' We were being boosted up as superstars and asked to speak. And then I found out about the bid. I don't know how that came about."

The opening meeting that night was Rosie B's second NA meeting ever, and it was packed with addicts with real clean time—years, even double-digit. It was nothing like that first scary meeting in the Bronx where half the men were loaded, including one out of the three women who were there. "I was sitting on the floor in the back of the room taking everyone's inventory when Rosalie R came up to speak, and I was blown away. She was telling my story. I had another spiritual awakening. Afterward we got introduced—Rose from the Bronx, meet Rose from the Bronx—and we hit it off immediately. I asked her, 'What do you think about the bid?' She said, 'I think you guys should definitely go for it. We've all been waiting for New York for so long. We'll help you put together a plan.' That was the clincher. Rosalie convinced Tony, who convinced Richie and Sal. I needed no convincing. I was in love with the spiritual aspect of the Milwaukee convention. Nobody's robbing or hurting each other. We were accepted, and we were from New York. It was, like, wow. We weren't always accepted, you know."

On Friday the members from other states met with the New Yorkers, worked out a plan, and the campaign went into high gear. Bobby from Philly was supremely confident. "So now

we understood the ropes and this was our game. Now we were politic. Everybody who was going to that meeting was going to be tuned in." Doug F from California, another former New Yorker, was the main Saturday night banquet speaker, and he pitched the whole weekend. The Milwaukee convention committee had made up a chalkboard with a list of all the people who were attending and where they were from, and they divvied up names. "We were pulling people over one by one, doing our pitch, whispering in their ear. Hey, you're going to vote for New York, aren't you?" Terry had T-shirts made up that afternoon, "just NEW YORK CITY NA in a circle. Simple. That said it all."

The list of bid requirements were a bit of a problem, because New York couldn't meet most of them. Big Richie: "We sat up the night before the bid making up a phony meeting list because they required you to have so many meetings a week, and so we lied." They also lied about the number of area codes these meetings represented geographically, adding a few they didn't have. "After all, the population density of addicts in New York wasn't about area codes." They also had no accommodations. Other cities would have slick photos of hotels in their presentations, and they had nothing. New York didn't even have a Region! Rosalie invited Rosie to spend Friday night in her room at the Hyatt. "I worked in a travel agency. Hotel, flights, accommodations and all that was going to be my spiel, and I was going to have to wing it. I didn't sleep that night."

For all the above reasons and more, the New York presentation should have been a disaster, an embarrassment to all. Leah A: "The bidding process was insane. Thank God we changed it. But let me tell you—well, I don't have to tell you if you're an addict from New York—when you really want something, how bad do you go after it? Not only do you have the state of New York but you also have the State of Florida on the same bandwagon, the Philly contingent, Jersey, Connecticut, the heavy hitters from California—listen, when we're working together we can steam-roll anything."

The Bid

Eight fellowships made presentations at the Saturday afternoon bid meeting: Memphis; Vancouver, B.C..; Colorado; Chicago; Pittsburgh; Portland, Oregon; Southern California; and New York. When it was their turn, Terry R, Tony D, Richie S, Rosie B, Shari M, and Sal M got up, one by one, wearing their New York NA T-shirts, and made their pitch. It was an emotional appeal that was straight from the heart. They talked about addicts dying in New York, the dope capital of the world, because they didn't know about recovery or a loving God, and that for them getting clean and staying clean was an impossible dream. They talked about NA coming so late to New York because of the Rockefeller Laws that made addicts afraid and without hope, and how bringing a World convention to New York would give them hope and make that dream possible.

Nobody was ready for the outcome.

"When the presentation was over you could hear a pin drop. We knew something was going to happen. You could feel it in the air."

"After we went up Colorado was next. They raised their hands and one of them said, 'I have friends in New York, and they're dying.' The guy broke up. Then he said, 'We withdraw our bid in favor of New York.' "

"Then this whole crescendo thing happened. They all rescinded their bids except Southern California."

"Can you imagine the mania? The cheering and the screaming? It was a God shot. No question."

"All that phony baloney they put themselves through wasn't necessary. There was no way New York wasn't going to get the bid. All we needed to do was make a formal vote."

But the six presenters from New York did not share in the belief that the bid was now a done deal. "We were still in Tony's mode—oh no, oh no. Now we're all worried. Did we do it right? Bob B from California was the hope. He said, don't worry. It's going to happen. Like he knew."

And at the Saturday night banquet that is what happened. When the keynote speaker, Doug F, announced that the 13th World Convention would be held in New York City, pandemonium broke loose. Bob Stone, a non-addict businessman from California, had recently been hired as the office manager of NA World Service, and he was also there, attending his first convention. In his book, *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous,* he describes his skepticism over giving a fellowship that didn't even have a Regional structure the "awesome task of preparing for a large convention while coping with sudden growth. . . . They didn't have much but bravado, bluff, and exaggeration, but despite the doubts of many present, the excitement and support for the growing fellowship won out."[1]

Years later, Rosalie R described the moment from the perspective of a recovering addict.

> What made this especially memorable is what I and other members of the fellowship experienced—a unity of purpose based on the principle of one addict loving and helping another, therefore one area—one region—one world helping and loving each other. Several regions who came to the meeting well prepared relinquished their bid because the fellowship unanimously agreed that New York needed the convention. For the first time ever, New York was getting the message "that no addict need die seeking recovery." This is one of the peak spiritual experiences I have ever had.[2]

After the euphoria, reality set in. Richie S: "I looked at Tony. Tony looked at me, and he said, 'Now what the fuck do we do, now that we've got it?' " Rosie B: "We were disbelieving it ourselves. We knew New York needed this but we didn't know what God had done—picked a bunch of people who were ready to do it but didn't know they were ready, handed a script we'd never read."

But the weight of that shared responsibility soon became a strong motivating factor. "Once we got over the shock of getting

that bid we hit the ground running. New York was going to have the message of recovery delivered to them by the fellowship outside of New York. It was like we had the Olympic torch. We had to get that message to the East Coast. Everybody was going to get this. There were only 500 people in Milwaukee and that was a large convention, so we figured at least a thousand would come to New York, and hopefully the fellowship would get bigger. Little did we know."

Dream Builders

When the members back in New York heard the news, their reactions were varied in the extreme:

"I said, listen, guys, I enjoy doing the groups, helping the newcomer in the corner, struggling. The other stuff I don't know much about. I was like the foot soldier. That's going to be my bag."

"You went and got it. Now you figure it out."

"I was dumbfounded. Biggest ego trip ever seen."

"It was a total shock, like, are you for real? What happened next was you wanted to make it work. You knew New York needed it and it was just going to go crazy once it clicked."

"I was thrilled!"

On September 9, 1982, three days after their return from Milwaukee, a committee made up of Tony D, Larry W, Terry R, Rosie B, Kevin F, Shari B, Jack H, and Richie S formed WCNA 13, an ad hoc group, and elected Tony chair; Richie, co-chair; Kevin, treasurer, and Shari, secretary. They agreed to meet weekly for the time being. They voted on a name for the next convention—The Impossible Dream—a no-brainer—that was to be held Labor Day Weekend, 1983. Of paramount importance was convincing other trusted servants, many of them still reeling from the news, to join their effort. One of the key people was the newsletter chair and all-around go-getter, Brian P. "Tony worked overtime to make sure I was on board. He made a convincing argument in a service-oriented way because he knew that was important to me, that this was a way

of doing service that would reach addicts around the world. At the Florida convention there was almost nobody from other countries, even though this was supposed to be a world convention, and Tony made a promise that they would reach out to recovering addicts in other countries and talk them into coming to New York."

By the next meeting the committee had grown to twelve, the core group plus Therese W, Sal M, Brian P, and Joan V, and subcommittee chairs were voted in: Rosie B, hotels and hospitality; Sal M, fund-raising; Terry R, program; Brian P, literature, graphs and displays; Larry W, tickets and registration; Therese W, entertainment, and Joan V, public relations. Although progress continued to be made at these weekly meetings, it obviously would take more than a dozen people to put on a world convention. "We were way over our heads," says committee member Therese. "At some point in time when we were desperate for help, all of us sudden we got an influx of support from Florida and other places."

Help Is On the Way

WCNA 13 was a magnet for addicts long before it happened, especially for people like Roger T, who lived to make things happen. A brilliant organizer, he had been active on the World Service level as well as in fellowships around the country. He was also something of an outsider and a vagabond looking for a home. Roger T had been part of the Florida entourage at the Milwaukee convention, and not long after that he moved to New York City, living first with Rosie B and then with Sal, and threw himself into the convention effort. Roger had finally found a home.

People from Florida also kept their word. According to Leah A, "Once they got the bid we started coming back and forth, but we didn't want to hover. They'd also call, asking questions, because they knew we did it here." Florida was also aware that as a host committee New York had to be responsible to World Services. "Bob Stone kept saying, 'They're renegades. They wanna go off on their own,' and I kept saying, 'Yeah, they do, yeah, they are, and that's

New York, and you don't tell New Yorkers how to run their show."

The hands-on help came from recovering addicts in nearby states. Dutch from New Jersey and Philly had been clean since 1972. His first New York meeting was at the Only Game in Town, where he was impressed by the numbers. His second meeting was at Morris Park. "I ran into Tony D. He asked me, 'How long have you been clean?' I said ten years. He said, 'You're full of shit. Why do people lie?' He was nuts but I liked him." He also met Sal M, Shari M, and Kevin F. "They had come back from Milwaukee with the bid and they needed help with fund-raisers, and nobody knew what to do. We were all in. We cared so much because, look, as fucked up as Philly was, it was more stable than New York. In New York there were a lot of characters, let's say. We'd do whatever we could, go wherever, because it made us feel good because New York had numbers. What we got in ten years they had in a year."

The Hotel

The Vista Hotel, a sleek, 22-story structure with a glass façade nestled between the Twin Towers, had recently opened to a lot of fanfare as Manhattan's first major downtown hotel in years. As chair of the hotels and accommodations subcommittee, it was also Rosie B's first choice. "It was beautiful. The manager took me on a short preview and then I did some snooping on my own. I went up into the towers, to the Windows on the World, the observation deck, and back to the lobby that connected the two towers. Then it was time to get to the train and head back to the Bronx. When I looked up and saw a sign over a huge room off the lobby that read Nieuw Amsterdam Ballroom (with the old Dutch spelling), I said to myself, NA Ballroom! On my way home I was so happy. Nearby were great amenities, the Staten Island ferry for 25 cents, Chinatown, the Labor Day weekend Feast of San Gennaro."

But to Rosie B the most desirable thing about the Vista's location was that it was far from the cop spots of Alphabet City and especially the open-air drug markets around Times Square and

Grand Central that were right down the street from the other hotels on her list. "This was important. I was getting calls from people all over the country. 'Is it true what I hear about the next convention?' They were petrified about coming back. We had to keep that up front in all the decisions we made."

Bobby B remembers when Rosie B came back to the committee with her recommendation. "They were like, the Vista? What's that? We don't want to be downtown! 'No, no, it's beautiful, great lobby, great ballroom, gigantic!' 'We should be in the fucking Waldorf! The Plaza!' " But the Vista won, and the price was right: 50 dollars a night for a single room, 55 for a double, 75 for a quad—that's $18.75 per person—what a deal! Not only were hundreds of people who liked to shout "I'm an addict!" going to be welcomed into what was commonly known as "the house that Rockefeller built," but they could afford to spend the night.

Theatre of the Absurd

Drawing on the start-up money they had received from WCNA 12, the committee made plans for their first fund-raising event, a dinner dance to be held on the Saturday after Thanksgiving in the auditorium of the Blessed Sacrament School at 1160 Beach Avenue in the Bronx, and they were thinking big: "Only 250 seats, so register now!" read the flyer. "$10 solo, $18 a couple." The committee threw itself into preparations, enlisting the help of relatives and friends on the day of the event to cut up a hundred chickens, cook them in every available oven, then make massive amounts of string beans and potatoes.

"We opened the doors at seven o'clock and nobody was there. A half hour later the guys from Philly came in a caravan, and then there was a caravan from Jersey and a caravan from Connecticut. The ones coming from out of town outnumbered the locals who showed up." Although people had a good time, it was a fund-raising disaster. "We wound up giving most of the food to Father Ritter at the Covenant House. It was horrible," says Sal M,

the fund-raising chair, "and it was all on my head."

The committee wasted no time on bemoaning their failure. Immediately they began plotting their next move. Big Richie: "Tony comes up with this idea. He said, 'We're going to do the Theater of the Absurd.' What's that? 'It's anything you can think of. You're going to be a bumblebee and dance on the stage and sing "Bee-witched, Bothered, and Bee-wildered." ' Okay, so we're going to do the Theater of the Absurd. Then what do we do? 'We'll do Son of Theater of the Absurd.' We did that, and then we did Mother of the Theater of the Absurd and the Uncle of the Theater of the Absurd, and we raised a bunch of money." Within three weeks they put together the first Theater of the Absurd. Opening night was Saturday, December 18, 1982, at St. Malachy's Church on West 49th Street, the home of Midtown Connection.

They quickly found out that there was no shortage of really talented actors, musicians, dancers, singers, and comedians in NA, some of them well-known, who were willing to ham it up for a fund-raiser. A member of a popular rock/jazz fusion band wrote the music to a song for one of the acts. Kristen A, newly clean, wrote the lyrics. "They poured me into a blue taffeta dress and I sang "We're Just Friends" with my seven-foot-long boa constrictor named Pascal wrapped around me. For many of us it was the first time we ever performed clean. For me it was a thousand-megawatt light of hope that I could actually enjoy my life without the use of drugs."

Several well-known musicians performed, including a lead solo guitar player for a seminal punk band who came onstage wearing an American flag cape, but the celebrities with household names mostly worked behind the scenes to maintain their anonymity. "One of them took on the job of stage manager, so the Theater of the Absurd was not amateur night. It was a class act." These events were often followed by dances, like the Downtown Junkies Ball, and they too were wildly appreciated. "To pay for the hall for one of the dances we painted the concrete floor grey. They danced the paint off the floor so we had to go back and paint it

again."

Tony D was always the M. C. at these affairs:

"Tony was my man. He could have been a comedian. He was good at everything he did. In his previous life he was a good burglar too."

"He sang the song from *Man of La Mancha*, 'The Impossible Dream,' at St. Malachy's and brought the house down. I think he lived for NA. I know he did."

"He had this NA chairman of the board persona. He didn't throw his weight around like that but he was so inspirational. As the convention approached he just kept repeating over and over "the impossible dream" when he performed and when he shared, that this was beyond anybody's wildest dreams, that this could not only happen but we could have so much freaking fun doing it."

At that time, this was a revolutionary idea—that addicts could perform without using drugs, that they could get together and have fun—and it had a profound impact on the fellowship, especially newcomers:

"It was my first recovery event. There must have been 200 people packed into the place and it was unbelievable, that this group of addicts could do something so professional, so fun, so out-there-in-the world's-face, having just come from the Rockefeller Laws, not allowed to congregate. And now here we are doing the Theater of the Absurd and we've got famous people up there performing and saying they're addicts. I was blown away. I felt like I was joining a special fraternity."

Although it's impossible to convey the you-had-to-be-there hilarity of these variety shows, it's safe to say that the Theatre of the Absurd events were the most successful in New York NA fund-raising history, and they never charged more than five dollars a head.

The Wit and Wisdom of Tony D[3]

"When my boat came in, most of the time I was at the train station. Oh God! What happened? God, how bloody awful! Oh, God, help me! I don't have the heart to ask him for anything after getting the gift of recovery. To be able not to have to do it."

"A guy said, I use cocaine because it intensifies my personality. I said, what if you're an asshole?"

"I walked into an NA meeting in the Bronx and somebody was reading the First Step: We were powerless. Our lives had become unmanageable. To me this was being extremely kind."

"I wrote down my life and I felt sorry for the guy. My God, how distasteful."

"If you don't pick it up you can't get stoned. Beautiful. Because I must have been perplexed by the profundities of the universe, ya see? Because nobody told me about that."

"I cleaned up and started dreaming about using. My worst night nightmare was that I took a fix and blew up my clean time and broke my link with the fellowship. Then all of a sudden I had a dream that the cops, the *policeses*, surrounded the house and said, all right Tony, throw your coffee pot out the window and come out with your hands up. And I wasn't dreaming about using drugs anymore."

"I don't remember what was troubling me last Friday, but then I'm sure it was of paramount importance, being a cold-blooded exaggerator. This is the kind of person I am and I need help."

"I had to smoke pot to listen to the radio, no shit. Somehow I couldn't hear the music if I wasn't smoking Panamanian Red or Lebanese Blonde or some of those exotic mixtures."

"We used to dream about going to foreign countries, me and my friends, sit around in some cold rinky-dink basement. With a candle. On Christmas Eve. Oh man, we're doing Europe! We never left the Bronx. And years went by. And still we're not going to Rio."

"We have a tendency to separate ourselves. 'Well, I'm not like the rest of them. I only smoked 50 sticks of angel dust a day and these guys did thorazine.' They were doing the thorazine shuffle while I was doing the smoky-pokey dance. It don't matter what you did—shot it or smoked or snorted or gulped it. It don't matter what brand of insanity you had."

"Count Crackula."

"I remember when there was no NA, so every day was like a Lewis and Clark expedition. One never knew where you were going to end up that evening. Sometimes we get high and sometimes we die."

"We deserve a life, and why not?"

The Program

As chair of the Program subcommittee, Terry R's goal was to persuade Jimmy K to be the keynote speaker at the banquet, despite the obstacles involved. One, Jimmy rarely traveled. For him the parameters of his service to NA were sticking by the phone for the next newcomer, for members around the country who were clamoring for literature, help in starting meetings, or keeping the doors open as their local fellowship struggled. "If it ain't practical, it ain't spiritual," was his motto, and that didn't include speechifying. The last time he had spoken at a convention was NA's 20th anniversary in 1973, held a convenient few miles from his house.

Another drawback was his health, which had been poor for some time due to the wreckage of his past, including a recent

hospitalization for emphysema. But the main reason for his resistance was most likely the recent shattering experience of getting locked out of the World Service Office during a major "restructuring." The fellowship was growing so fast it was no longer practical to run it out of Jimmy's house, but the transition was not done very well. As one of Jimmy's close friends put it, "He had experienced a lot of personal betrayal behind the whole thing that went down over the office. People that he loved, sponsored, that were friends of his had all rolled over on him to kind of sneak-Pete the office away from him." So Jimmy had a lot of good reasons to stay home.

Terry R: "I would call him every month. 'Jimmy, what do you wanna do?' 'I don't know. I'll let you know next month.' It took me a year to get him to say yes." Jimmy K had not been to New York City since he emigrated with his family from Scotland as a youngster, and he had written and spoken about going through Ellis Island. It may have been Terry's persuasiveness that finally convinced him, or it may also have had something to do with the sight of Lady Liberty, the emblem of WCNA 13, with its rendition of the Emma Lazarus poem ("Give us your sick, your tired, your humbled addicts, yearning to be free") on all the convention literature coming out of New York. For whatever reason, Jimmy K finally said yes. He would speak at a World Convention of Narcotics Anonymous outside of California for the first time. Historic!

There were other unique aspects to the program plans. One was making WCNA 13 the first truly international convention, capitalizing on the natural draw of New York City. Leading the effort were Tony D, Terry R, and Roger T. "Tony kept his promise to me," according to Brian P. "He worked his butt off. Even at the Miami convention there was almost nobody from anywhere else in the world. Tony found meetings in Ireland and Australia and England and Germany. He found people who were trying to get NA going in different countries and talked them into coming." At the time Terry R was working at Sotheby's. "They had an 800 number so I would call up Jimmy K and he'd give me phone numbers of people in Australia, people in Europe, waking them up at three,

four o'clock in the morning because what did I know about time zones. 'Hey do you want to come to New York City and speak at an NA convention?' It was a God shot. A lot of them came, and for the ones that didn't show we pulled others in to take their place."

Two other efforts on the part of the convention committee reflect the diversity of the host city. One was having a session for LGBT members. The Let It Be group in Queens was the first gay group in the New York fellowship, started by Roger T, one of the first openly gay trusted servants. Soon after it folded, The 208 Group opened at the Gay Community Center in the West Village. Roger T was a strong advocate for including them in the program planning, as was Tony. John F: "Tony was straight but he was the best kind of take-them-as-they come New Yorker, and he understood that there were things going on with gay addicts, a whole variety of things. It was to be the last World convention in a very long time where there were gay meetings. A number of people believed they were tradition violations and they had a fear of the slippery slope. Actually, fear *is* the slippery slope."

The same "special interest" contention was made against including Spanish-speaking meetings, with an attitude among some members of "If they want to get clean they'd better learn English." Although there were no Spanish-speaking meetings in New York before the convention, members were clamoring for them. Even though New York had a large Hispanic population, their numbers were underrepresented in the fellowship, and NA meetings in predominantly Hispanic neighborhoods were few to nonexistent—not a single meeting in the South Bronx and only two in Spanish Harlem—"and that was just unthinkable." The convention planners believed that adding a Spanish-speaking meeting to the convention program would be a way to draw this community into NA, make them feel welcome, and help jump-start Spanish-speaking meetings.

Another program choice that would turn out to be memorable was Father Dan Egan as a speaker at the Sunday morning Spiritual Breakfast. Months before the convention Terry was getting phone

calls from recovering addicts on the East Coast, "People from New Jersey, Connecticut, Florida, Pennsylvania, saying 'We've got to have Father Dan at our convention. He's been helping addicts all of his life.' " Many of them went to the NA meeting at Graymoor. After the June 1983 East Coast Convention, members had asked him to start a retreat, similar to the ones in AA, and he had recently received permission from his superiors to hold them at Veritas Villa. There wasn't anything Father Dan wouldn't do to help addicts grow in their recovery.

Hardly anyone alive at that time had a longer history with Narcotics Anonymous in New York than Father Egan. In an interview shortly before his death, he recalled how he felt about being invited to speak at WCNA 13. "I said I'd be happy to do it. I wanted to talk about the early days in New York City so the new members here could be very grateful to be coming in at a time when the obstacles in the way of recovery weren't so big." When he heard that it was going to be held in the Vista Hotel, his reaction was a euphoric "Woo-hoo!" Dan Egan wasn't the only one enjoying the irony of a Narcotics Anonymous convention being held in the house that Rockefeller built.

Growth Spurt

By April 1983 the number of meetings in the New York fellowship had nearly quadrupled in a single year, from ten to thirty nine. The Bleecker Street meeting had outgrown the room on the fourth floor and moved to the chapel. Then by mid 1983, it outgrew the chapel and moved to the auditorium, where a good forty to fifty people met on a Thursday night. Midtown Connection numbers at St. Malachy's were also expanding. It could be that these two meetings were growing so fast because the Theatre of the Absurd fund-raisers were often held there, but exposure to these events was also stimulating enthusiasm for NA in other places. For over a year there was only one meeting in Brooklyn. Suddenly, right before the convention, there were three. People upstate also got connected.

According to Mike K, "I was living in Rhinebeck, going to meetings in New Paltz and Kingston, and I came back to the city to help, to do anything. These people were like gods to me. They had clean time and I felt so included."

Big Richie also thought the fund-raisers contributed to the sudden expansion of NA into new areas. "I was always telling everybody, this is a white fellowship. You want to get things thing to grow, get it into the black communities and it will take off like wildfire. Sure as hell, when we started doing these fund-raisers for the World Convention and involved a few black guys up there on stage, before you knew it, that's what happened. I went everywhere and talked about it. NA grew one person at a time." Brian P had a different perspective. "Someone would start a meeting and we would find out about it after it started. So many things happened spontaneously without our control. What people underestimated when we were planning for the convention was the number of people from New York who were going to be there. That floored everybody."

Brian P also noted that the greatest expansion was happening outside of New York City. "We couldn't keep up with how we were growing outward, in Putnam, Rockland, Orange, Ulster, Duchess, Nassau and Suffolk—and NYCAS just couldn't keep up with providing them service. We had been toying with the idea of becoming a Region for some time, especially Roger. Now it was clear. We had to be a Region." On top of everything else that was going on in the summer of 1983, the fellowship put on its first Regional meeting in Long Beach, just weeks before WCNA-13. "You can call it piling on, but we did it, meeting all day and into the night. We weren't actually a Region yet but we would be soon." Aside from varying opinions about why the expansion happened, it's clear that all the excitement around putting on a World Convention was energizing the entire fellowship, even the members who had been opposed to it in the beginning, and attracting new people into doing service on every level.

The Literature

For weeks Bob Stone at the World Service Office had been getting calls from Brian P, head of the convention's literature committee, asking him to increase the amounts of literature the office was planning to send, especially the first edition of *Narcotics Anonymous*, the fellowship's own, newly printed, long-awaited "Basic Text," which had been written by recovering addicts themselves in workshops held around the country for the past three years. Stone, however, kept low-balling the numbers. Brian P: "We went back and forth, especially about the need for more copies of the *Basic Text*. People were so hungry for it. He had no concept of how big this convention was going to be. I told him we were getting commitments from people coming from all over the place. This is gigantic. Roger ended up calling him too. When he finally got Bob Stone to realize how much literature and stuff we were going to need, Bob said, 'I'm going to come too.' "

According to Brian P, Roger T had told him that the reason he came to New York to help with the convention was "California didn't trust us." Maybe so. In his book, *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous*, Stone clearly states his reason for coming. "The New York World Convention Committee requested we send literature on consignment. There was worry that the convention might actually lose money, and that income from literature sales be used to help pay for the loss. In this way the office might never get paid for the literature. It was eventually decided that literature would be sent but I had to go to the convention and handle the sales myself." Having insured themselves against the potential of a failed New York convention, the office sent 13 boxes of literature, key tags, and "a large quantity of the special edition texts, as we didn't have any of the blue-covered regular text."[4]

Meanwhile, the convention committee was preparing for exactly the opposite—too many people and not enough literature to satisfy their hunger for it—but no one was prepared for the numbers. Jim F from the entertainment committee: "We had

worked on this for months and it was an exciting time, and when it finally happened we could all take pleasure in being a part of it. But nobody ever realized how this was going to be historical, something that was going to change NA, at least in New York, but it did."

It's Possible Now

Like many recovering addicts who had to leave New York to get clean, Jack B said he was terrified of coming back for the convention. "I first got clean in Los Angeles in 1971. I came back to New York in June of 1972 to show everyone how good I was doing and ended up shooting dope. Since my relapse the only way I was ever going to go back was if it had something to do with NA, and then only if I went with a bunch of people from California who were clean."

These petrified addicts were the ones Rosie B had in mind when she came up with the white ribbon motif for WCNA 13. A few years back, during the Iranian hostage crisis, people all over the country tied yellow ribbons around trees as a symbolic plea to free the hostages. Picking up on that message of desperation and hope, when returning addicts entered the lobby of the Vista Hotel they saw white ribbons, the NA color of surrender, hanging outside every meeting room to welcome them back home. The war was over. Let the revels begin.

When addicts gathered for the Introduction to the Convention meeting on Thursday night they immediately got the message that WCNA 13 was going to be a unique experience. The opening session featured two speakers, John C from Ireland and Laura M from England. This was truly going to be a World Convention. A member of the host committee said, "Hearing these international voices was significant to us, like they were a part of our fellowship and we were a part of theirs." A member of the Irish fellowship, which had already been established for several years but was still struggling, describes how the convention also changed their perception of Narcotics Anonymous. "It was an amazing ride. The

Irish fellowship had nothing—no literature, not even a *Little White Book*. We weren't upbeat. We were terrified, and we walked into the Vista and were met with incredible enthusiasm. We'd never heard speakers like that, with messages that were totally uplifting. We came out thinking, wow, we've got a way. This works."

That pretty much sums up the message of most recovering addicts who attended WCNA 13, from the Thursday night opening to the Sunday morning breakfast: "This works." Some highlights:

First International NA Meeting

Although it was an ad hoc arrangement, not listed on the program, 50 people attended this first international meeting of Narcotics Anonymous. Brian chaired: "At that meeting were representatives of every country outside the U.S. that had NA meetings—Israel, Germany, Australia, Canada, England, and some of the original members of the Irish fellowship. It was put together by people who wanted to help promote a real NA World Service, not just an office."

The Banquet

It wasn't until Saturday night that the enormity of it all really started to hit home: 900 people at the banquet, 1,500 at the keynote speaker meeting that followed. Puerto Rican Tommy from Brooklyn had 40 days clean that night. "I remember going into the Twin Towers and that in itself was amazing. Jose came up to me and said, close your mouth. You're going to catch a fly. We went into the banquet and there was a slip of paper on everybody's plate. It was the words to the song, "The Impossible Dream." A guy in a tuxedo played a good piano and we sang. It began real lusty but then it got real emotional. That world convention changed my life. I'm still living my dream."

It was Bob Stone's first NA banquet, and he wrote about it in his book. "I was not prepared for the rambunctious behavior. I was not accustomed to people shouting so much or having such a good time. It was deafening. The countdown was exciting and when the newcomers were identified and walked to the front of the

room, the roof seemed in danger of crashing down. The noise got so loud that everything in the room vibrated."[5]

The atmosphere got even more explosive over dessert. John C, 90 days clean, was an usher. "My spot was closest to the podium and all the way over to the right. At the corner table there were eight girls, beautiful, from out of town somewhere, and they got served first. They called me over and said, 'The cherries jubilee tastes like alcohol.' I took a sniff and brought it over to the podium and talked to Richie. I says, Richie, there's fucking alcohol in the cherries jubilee. Richie says, Tony, alcohol in the cherries jubilee. Tony grabs the microphone." Pretty soon shouts of "DON'T EAT THE CHERRIES JUBILEE!" were heard around the banquet hall.

"We laugh about it now. It wasn't funny then," says Rosie, who marched into the kitchen and had a few words with the staff. "The entire Board of Trustees was sitting at one table. They could have all gone down." To this day, nearly everyone at that banquet has a tale to tell about the cherries jubilee.

The Keynote Speaker

The banquet was a dress-to-kill occasion with the women in New York black and a lot of the men in tuxedos, but Jimmy K came to the podium wearing a sports jacket and a cowboy type string tie. The first words out of his mouth were, "I've been waiting for a long time to say this—live from New York it's Saturday night!" Jimmy was not a flashy speaker. "He was low-key, a Scottish guy with attitude who taught me humility," says Bob G from Florida. "It was a big deal, having him there."

"Anybody who was serious about their recovery was at that convention," remembers Bobby B. "Jimmy shared a message about what inspired him to put his heart and his spirit and his life into this fellowship, the spiritual awakening he had the night he was going to take his life, and instead his choice to cling to NA and get this thing cooking. It was such a powerful build-up."

The Spiritual Breakfast

After Terry R introduced Dan Egan as the Junkie Priest, "a man who had been helping addicts for most of his life," Father Egan began with an explanation of the name that police had given him long ago out of contempt for his advocating on behalf of addicts caught up in the revolving door of the criminal justice system. "I wish I could say to you that I'm Dan, a drug addict," he said, "because you have found something through your addiction that us straight people have never found. You have found a closeness to God that I envy, and so forgive my tears." Father Egan was also aware that there were people in the audience who strongly opposed to his being at the podium. One person remembers how "a few people walked out because they had a bad attitude about Father Dan not being an addict, but then he dropped a message on the audience that rocked their souls."

Father Egan told them about his long association with Narcotics Anonymous in New York City during the days of Dorothy Berry and Rae L, and how it had changed for the better. He impressed upon them that, "because of the stupid drug laws, if this meeting had been a few years earlier we would have been surrounded by SWAT teams," and how holding the convention in this building was "not just paradoxical but an act of divine justice." He read them a story about an old, beat-up violin that had his audience weeping. He told them that addicts getting together like this in New York without fear of consequences was truly the impossible dream, and that had them all cheering.

That was the last time Father Egan spoke at a Narcotics Anonymous event. "I guess nobody at the time realized it was a Traditions violation, or maybe everyone thought he was an addict. What I will never forget as long as I live was when he read the story about the violin. I started crying and they had to scrape me off the floor and scoop me into the backseat of the car, because I knew it was true. I was touched by the master."

The Touch of the Master's Hand

"It was an old violin, battered and scarred, and the auctioneer thought it scarcely worth his while, so he held it up with a smile. What am I bid? A dollar, two dollars? Only two? Going once, going twice, and almost gone. Far back in the room a white-haired man came forward and picked up the bow and, dusting off the old violin, he played music like an angel sings. The people were quiet. The auctioneer cried, 'Now what am I bid for the old violin? A thousand dollars, two thousand? Going and gone.' The audience cheered. What made the difference? The touch of the master's hand. And many a soul whose life is battered and scarred and out of tune is auctioned cheap to a thoughtless crowd much like the old violin, going once, going twice, and almost gone. But the master comes and the foolish crowd can never quite understand the price of a soul and the touch of the master's hand. The master has touched you. He's touched us all, as we understand him."

Game-Changer

WCNA-13 had a highly emotional effect on the individuals who were there, an impact that had not diminished when they were asked to look back on an event that had happened three decades ago:

"It was so overwhelming, so powerful, I would have to go back to my room and just regroup."

"When we closed out that night singing, I could start to cry right now. I mean, goose bumps running up and down me."

"There were angels there and they were in the spirit of others."

"It was just overwhelming to see that a bunch of people who weeks or months before couldn't get up enough money for a bag of dope, could pull off a stunt like this in such magnificent style."

"By the end of that convention there was no turning back, everybody so full, chest-out. We were on to something that was going to save our lives."

It also had profound and lasting effect on the New York

fellowship as a whole. According to Wisconsin-born Brian P, "Natural-born New York junkies who found some way to get clean had met people from all over the world who were so impressed and so loving and willing to help out. They walked out of that convention knowing they had support. They weren't just doing it on their own."

At that time NA in New York was a rapidly growing number of geographically widespread groups that had formed areas and were in the early stages of becoming the New York Region. In hindsight that didn't have to happen. The density of population was such that it could have become many small regions, but the convention took it to another direction for reasons described by Tuki D from upstate. "As a recovery experience, nothing from that day to this has ever approximated it, bar none. Meeting addicts from all over the world was an incredibly warming experience. Up here in Ulster County we had meetings with five or six attending." But the connection was not just about the numbers. "It was getting a hug. That was where for the first time I'd ever seen it done. We carried it back. I think all of us came away from that event to spread that kind of recovery."

Jersey Joe was living in Suffolk County at that time: "I had no idea what I was walking into, how it physically charged my emotional and spiritual batteries, and we took that energy back to the areas. That's when NA exploded and grew." The experience of already being one big region made tangible the message that was written in invisible ink on the walls of the Vista Hotel that Labor Day weekend: "If NA can make it here, it can make it anywhere."

The convention had a similar unifying effect on the entire fellowship. It further strengthened the Florida connection. According to Bob G, "New York joined the fellowship at that convention and became a part of, not apart from. Everybody had some sort of connection there, and the love of the fellowship brought us together. It's only when we get involved with egos that it gets all split up." The convention also impacted addicts living on the other side of the Hudson River. According to Dutch, "Addicts pulled

off that convention, something nobody said they would because of the Rockefeller Laws, and that affected Jersey, where you still had to wear long shirts in the summer to cover your tracks. When something got weak on one side the other side pulled it forward. That the Impossible Dream and the *Basic Text* came out at the same time had a lot of power, like a double-barrel shotgun."

As the first recovering addict outside of Southern California to be elected to the Narcotics Anonymous Board of Trustees, Dutch also had a unique perspective on the effect WCNA-13 had on the fellowship at the World Service level. "The Impossible Dream in New York was the epitome of recovery worldwide. There were usually some internal screw-ups putting on these conventions because back then there weren't a lot of rules or accountability, but if you lived through it and survived that was good enough. But to pull that off at the World Trade Center? Are you kidding me? Unheard of. I think it turned Jimmy K's head, that we've got the numbers on the East Coast. There was an overflow room for every meeting he saw. Southern California didn't have crowds like that then. New York had more people in the Gracie Square meeting than any meeting I'd been to. That was the first insight. And then you start thinking down the road, multiplying the possibilities, and this could get real crazy. That was the second. New York, Philly, the Northeast Corridor – who's going to be the Big Dog here?"

The power of numbers had a different effect on Bob Stone. "I was leaving with an emotional charge that was translated into more enthusiasm and dedication. Before the convention the size of the fellowship, to me, was measured in numbers of meetings and increasing literature orders. But now there were faces of friendly and determined members that made these numbers come to life. I came home convinced that this was the cause that my entire life had trained me to be a part of."[6]

Addict Pride

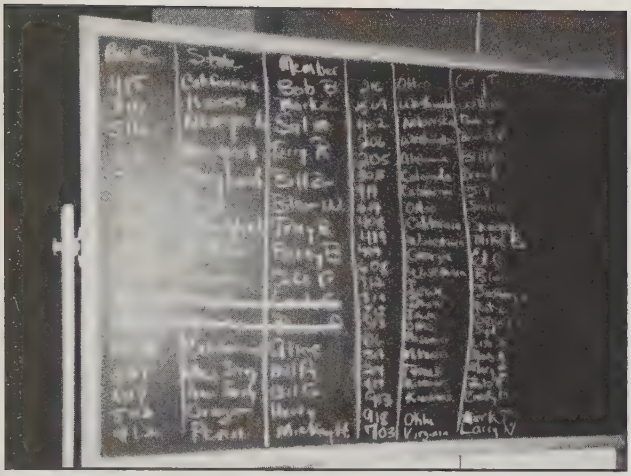
Within a very short time the perception these addicts had of

themselves had changed and, because they were addicts, that change was extreme—they weren't losers anymore, they were cool! "Actually, we thought we were extremely cool when we were using. Then, when we found out what losers we were, and that we didn't have to be that way anymore, that we can hold jobs, have bank accounts, be responsible, we also found out we had never lost anything except active addiction. All of a sudden we were free and it was fantastic. I don't think it would have occurred to any of us that it wasn't cool to be a recovering addict. Would I want my employer to know it? No, but we were proud of who we were, enormously proud, proud of getting clean where you used."

The convention had also given the trusted servants some vindication that, in spite of all their trial-and-error, the structure they had set up was sound. "That had been confirmed by all these people we met who had been around NA for a long time. The message they were giving us was that New York NA was solid, don't worry. Oh, so we *have* been doing it right!" The other important message they received, along with the delivery of all those *Basic Texts*, was that NA was in a new place now, with its own literature at last. It could let go of the mother ship.

"That was really dynamite. We're standing on our own two feet. We recover here. That's what the convention put out there. If you're looking for help we're here. And we're free. You paid already."

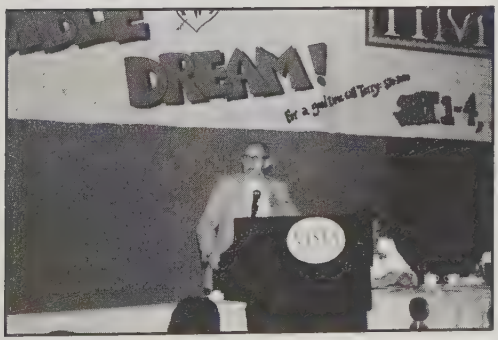
On Sunday afternoon, while hundreds of addicts were heading for airports, trains, buses, ferries, cars, and motorcycles, Lynne V and her sponsor Randee Sue P were packing up the show at the Vista. "Something happened that weekend. After all those days of running around, we were just like, "You wanna start a meeting?"



The "Bid" blackboard, WCNA-12, Milwaukee, Wisconsin 1982



WCNA 13 pre-banquet, 1983



"I've always wanted to say this . . . Live from New York it's Saturday Night!"



Jimmy K. banquet speaker WCNA 13





Program cover

PART III

Coming of Age

In a single year the New York fellowship nearly quadrupled in size—from 22 groups to 80—and 1983 was just the beginning of an incredible growth. By April 1984 it had become the fourth largest Region in the world. By October it was growing at a rate of a new meeting every third day. By the spring of 1985 it had doubled in size again, with meetings now in all five boroughs of New York City plus 10 counties in Long Island and Upstate. The central office at St. Mark's Place kept running out of meeting lists and started ordering them in runs of 30,000, and the office hotline was getting 50 calls a day.

It was a thrilling time to be clean, but there was a negative aspect to all the rapid growth. The post-convention years were also a time of turmoil, when every spiritual principle was severely tested. Without the intervention of a higher power, internal forces might have torn the New York Region apart. Instead, we celebrated our first Regional convention, Freedom One, our unity intact, and broadened the base of the symbolic inverted pyramid that our literature says will make our fellowship "fully whole and wholly free."

Chapter 9 Explosive Growth

Many trusted servants and members left WCNA 13 and hit the ground running, scouting their neighborhoods for potential meeting spaces. In less than thirty days following the convention they had launched fourteen new groups, and by the end of December 1983, another twelve. To put this sudden jump in numbers in perspective, in its first year (spring of '81 to spring of '82) NA grew at a rate of less than one meeting a month. In its second year it grew by one meeting a week. In the month following the world convention a new group opened its doors at the rate of every other day.

A lot of recovering addicts making joyful noises outside meeting places became a concern of law enforcement. A Lower East Side member was witness to this new attention that was being paid: "Apparently, the police department had heard about this thing that was popping up all over, and between '83 and '84 we used to see undercover cops sitting in on the meetings. If you think about it, it makes sense. They're cops, and they had to find out whether we were involved in narcotics trafficking or legitimately trying to help each other. From what I was told, at a certain point the word trickled down that this thing was okay and we were left alone."

The Other Fellowship Pulls the Welcome Mat

Around the time of the convention, the influx of addicts going to AA meetings had become so great that members started hearing that addicts were no longer welcome. "It was in the secretary's report, that if you've got a drug problem there's another fellowship for you. I heard that in the Completely Sober meeting in the summer of 1983. So that kick in the pants was all it took for us to start forming new

groups all over the city." By January 1984, Alcoholics Anonymous made it official policy that their fellowship was to remain strictly for alcoholics, declining help for drug addicts at their meetings, and that members were to refer addicts to Narcotics Anonymous. AA also issued a new pamphlet around this time called *Singleness of Purpose,* detailing how the alcoholics-only policy adhered to their Traditions. "What they were doing was not a bad thing. In fact, it was very helpful to us because they were getting the word out to people who might not even know we existed. They were even announcing NA meetings at AA dances."

Meanwhile, all across the region people in other fellowships were starting to come to NA. Members who once attended the popular Pills Anonymous meeting on Lexington Avenue started seeing familiar faces from that group at NA meetings. Cocaine Anonymous was a new fellowship that had formed in 1982, and its growth was slow. There were two meetings in Long Island when the first NA meetings opened. Two years later there were two Cocaine Anonymous meetings and 20 NA meetings. "Today there's more than a hundred NA meetings and still only two CAs. Can't beat those hugs." Upstate members point to literature as the big draw. "The other fellowships used the AA *Big Book.* We had our own literature now and that was a huge influence in NA's expansion. Cocaine Anonymous, Pills Anonymous, Drugs Anonymous, Dual Disorders Anonymous—we overrode them. Literature was what swayed them our way." Narcotics Anonymous had very quickly become the best of all worlds for people with drug problems: "Whatever they were using, we didn't throw them out. We welcomed them in."

Other outside factors also contributed to this growth. One was the growing recognition among professionals that NA worked. Exit counselors at hospital detox and drug rehabs had been sending discharged patients to AA. Now they were giving them NA meeting lists. Another source of the influx of newcomers was the criminal court system, which was now mandating known addicts on parole or probation to attend NA meetings. "I knew a lot of people at that

time who were introduced into the fellowship by the courts and, in a strange way, having judges and parole and probation officers who normally looked down upon us mandating people to come to us showed the stability and success of Narcotics Anonymous."

The exploding membership was happening in other parts of the country, but in New York the influx of newcomers was titanic, due in part to its population density but also because of the state's methadone maintenance program. For years the Rockefeller Drug Laws had mandated that being on a methadone program was a condition of parole. This actually made it easier for convicted felons to be on methadone than it was for them to be clean. As long as they were being monitored by a methadone clinic and had the papers to prove it, they were less likely to be harassed when stopped on the street by the police. Then the procedure changed, and part of the requirement for getting their methadone was going to NA meetings. "It became a big problem starting in '83, and the methadone clinics were just dumping on us. We had to ask them to please stop, which of course they didn't."

But there was another contributor to the explosive growth of the fellowship in the early eighties, and it may have influenced that growth more than all the outside factors combined.

"It Says in Our Literature . . ."

After thirty years the NA fellowship finally had its own "big book," the *Basic Text*, written by addicts for addicts. For the first time we had literature that spelled out the "exact nature" of what Narcotics Anonymous was about, that provided stories for identification, and in a powerful way, legitimized and unified the program. "We got a book for the meeting, all the money we had. Fourteen people in a circle reading a single copy. We were, literally, on the same page." Having the *Basic Text* come out at the same time as The Impossible Dream was a game-changer, contributing to the incredible growth that followed the convention, but the book had the same impact on the entire fellowship—a threefold increase in membership

worldwide in a single year (between April 1983 and April 1984).[1] In the opinion of an East Coast member of the World Service Board of Trustees who was serving at the time, "That addicts around the globe could now read the same words we were reading, in their own language, was the biggest shot in the arm for the fellowship, ever. Ever."

Growth of the Region: Manhattan

Early on, Manhattan meetings for the most part were geographically limited to a few neighborhoods that were low-rent, high-crime, and where the drugs were—namely Harlem, the Lower East Side, Hell's Kitchen, and the Port Authority. With few exceptions, even in those neighborhoods "any room with a nice table or furniture we didn't get. We got the cruddy ones." But location didn't stop these Manhattan meetings from being a draw, even if it meant having to walk by familiar cop spots or past drug dealers conducting business outside the meeting place door.

Harlem

ENTER, the original East Harlem NA meeting, met Tuesdays and Thursdays in a treatment center on East 112th Street. In early 1982 members of ENTER started Life Begins Again on Saturday nights at the nearby Our Lady Queen of Angels on 113th Street, and in 1983 this group opened Harlem's first Step meeting, Harlem Steppers, which met Wednesdays at the church. Across town at the Colonial House Center on 144th Street and 8th Avenue was Central Harlem's first NA meeting, Just For Today. In the late 1970s its members met in a room behind an accommodating AA meeting to avoid being arrested, but they were hampered in being able to get the word out about NA. It first appeared as a registered group on a Manhattan NA meeting list in in the spring of 1982.

Morningside was the first NA group in Harlem's southwest corner. Started in the fall of 1982 by Brian P from Queens, it met on Mondays at the Broadway Presbyterian Church on West 114th Street,

adjoining the Columbia University campus. "In NA's first year in every meeting they were all white people. I said we've got to reach out, there are more addicts than just us, but nobody wanted to go into an African American or a Hispanic neighborhood because they were afraid." The breakthrough came with an opportunity for Brian to speak at the St. Nicholas Group, Harlem's oldest and largest AA meeting.

> It was in a gigantic church basement filled with 200 people in the middle of Harlem. I told them my story and I mentioned NA. A couple of young guys came up to me after and said they were junkies getting sober in AA and wanted to know more about this NA. I told them about wanting to get a meeting started up here but they look at me like, you're a white guy. We don't get how you think you can help us. I didn't know what to say to them. Then this very elderly woman pulled me aside and said, "Everything that happens to you is a lesson or a blessin' so don't forget that." Then it all made sense.
>
> I had some connections in the Morningside area. I went over to the Broadway Presbyterian Church and said this is what I want. They had never had a meeting there before and they had thick carpets. They were concerned with things like that. But they said yes. At first very few people came, and then one meeting John K showed up. He was also from Queens, and after the meeting I talked to him about the struggle we were having getting meetings to Harlem. He just gave me a smile. This is the guy who did so much to expand NA.

John K had been going to NA meetings in all parts of the city since he got clean in August 1982, and he knew there weren't a lot of black people involved in NA. "When you talk about identifying,

don't compare, we couldn't compare, so therefore if you were a person who was used to being involved in your own neighborhood and your own community, you had to really be motivated to start mixing things up, which is what I wanted to do. Tony D was the one who broke all the barriers, him and many others."

John K got involved in service early on in Queens, and he was one of the few NA members at that time who went up to Harlem. "A lot of people came from other places to start meetings and they were changing the Steps to read 'powerless over drugs' instead of alcohol. I told them that we had our own language now and it was 'powerless over addiction.' We started getting the information right."

By the time John K celebrated his first anniversary at Morningside in August of '83 the place was packed. It had become a two-and-a-half-hour meeting to give everyone a time to share, and still it ran late. "People were coming in like crazy. We had a lot of numbers and not too many meetings, so they were big, but we needed more meetings because Harlem's a concentrated area." Among the new meetings were Recovery on 125th Street, another on 117th, It Can Be Done at St. Catherine's on 153rd Street, and two more meetings at Morningside, Unity, a Wednesday Step meeting and a Monday Basic Text workshop. "By then I knew all the priests and had Harlem locked up. The priest at All Saints, a great big church on 129th and Madison, said he wasn't going to let anybody else use the facility if they weren't NA, and we kept it that way."

Next came basketball games. "That's the way to get black people to get involved in anything. We had the first NA basketball tournament ever in 1985 at Our Lady Queen of Angels. Teams came up from all over the Region—Jersey, up from D.C. in a bus. But let me tell you about the biggest meeting anywhere in the United States that I know of, Friday night downstairs at All Saints. The name of the meeting was You're in the Right Place, but we called it The Zoo because it was big and it was loud—400 people sitting around tables downstairs in the church. It was *the* Friday night spot for people who wanted recovery, and it was the jumping-off point

for Friday night. Early on, more than today with the Steps, staying clean and looking good was the real attraction, seeing hundreds of people clean and looking good, and guiding them back if they got lost."

Brian P left New York in 1984 and came back for a visit a few years later. "I walked into Morningside and it was completely African American, a couple hundred people. I was so shocked that in such a short time it got that big. John K got me to be one of the speakers. I stood up in front of this group with tears in my eyes, the only white guy. John tried to introduce me as the founder and I could tell nobody believed him, but then I told my story and they said you've always got a home here."

John K had got the job done. "My story is a bit of ups and downs, cherries and pits, roses and thorns, but when I first came in to NA it was all white people and I mixed them up. That's my strong point. I brought a lot of people uptown, I got a lot of uptown people to come downtown, I started a lot of meetings, and pretty soon it was all looking good and flowing."

Uptown/ Midtown

"Goat used to say, 'Why y'all say y'all come out of Gracie?' Well, because most of us did." Former patients had a particular attachment to the patients' Monday night H&I meeting where they got their first exposure to NA. "So many of us would go back to this in-house meeting that the director would say, 'Get outta here.' " This may be why The Only Game in Town opened at Gracie Square Hospital in July of 1982, so named because it was the only Sunday meeting in Manhattan at the time.

It was a hot meeting spot from the start. "If you didn't get there early you had the luxury of leaning on a wall or sitting on the floor." By 1984, its numbers blew up along with every other meeting in the fellowship. "It used to rock 76th Street. It would stop traffic, so many people coming out of there."

Another meeting that opened in that neighborhood was Cementing Recovery, which met Tuesdays at the recently converted

Municipal Asphalt plant (Asphalt Green) on FDR Drive and East 90th Street.

Meanwhile, on the West Side, three new meetings opened shortly after the convention. The first was a Sunday afternoon meeting, the Spiritual Workshop at Holy Name on 97th Street and Amsterdam Avenue. "There were fifteen of us to start, and something special happened every week. Going to the Cuban Chinese restaurant after that was just as special—crackling chicken and Chow Mein." Hell's Kitchen opened that October, at Trinity Presbyterian on 57th and 9th near Roosevelt Hospital, a small church, almost like a storefront, that quickly became a Saturday night draw. "It was our first Step meeting, and it started at nine o'clock because I had a Gracie Square H&I commitment that ended at 8:30, so I'd hop a cab through the park. We met upstairs in this lounge area, with couches. At first we didn't have a coffee pot or even a group name, we had nothing. The first meeting Santos got there early. He went to the priest's kitchen, found their coffee pot, and their coffee, and we almost lost the meeting. We talked our way out of that and 30 years later it's still there."

Midtown Connection at St Malachy's had been popular since its doors opened. It joined the Area in October 1982. "Meetings got big so fast, especially at Midtown Connection. A hundred people on a consistent basis. There was such a need." A third new West Side group was Dreams Come True, a Saturday beginners' meeting at St. Paul the Apostle on West 59th, a church that for years had been generous with its space, initially for two-for-one meetings and then for NA. By mid-1984 there was a fourth new West Side meeting, Life at 99, at St. Michael's Church on West 99th Street. All told, there were now five thriving NA meetings between Harlem and 14th Street where a year ago there had been one.

Between 1984 and 1985 a new kind of group, in a new kind of meeting space, was a welcome addition to the NA roster. These groups that focused on city employees and construction workers were Reconstruction, which met Wednesdays at the Building Trades Union on Park Avenue South; and Clean Streets, Tuesdays

in the Sanitation Department's counseling unit at City Hall. The outreach efforts of the Region's Public Information Committee were beginning to pay off.

Downtown

In December 1983 the Region signed a lease for the rental of the New York Region's first Central Office at 19-23 St. Mark's Place in which the Hotline resided, literature was stored and distributed, and the RSC and its sub committees held their meetings. The lease to the building was held by All-Craft, a nonprofit organization that offered space to a carpentry training program and workshop, plus an auditorium for dances and other events. Its owner had turned it into a kind of 12- Step clubhouse that included the HOW Club ("honesty, open-mindedness, and willingness"). It had become a popular hangout with meeting rooms and an auditorium, and Narcotics Anonymous had been holding fund-raising events there since the early eighties. Formerly the site of the Electric Circus, the building was now something of a shambles with peeling Day-Glo walls, a leaky roof, and bad plumbing. "It was disgusting, full of garbage, concrete walls covered with black paint. The place was nasty." The street east of Second Avenue once a notorious shopping mall for drugs was still perilously close enough to hot cop spots. "I didn't go east of First Avenue my first year because I was afraid my feet would take me to where I used to cop. I was safe only when I was standing right in front of the HOW Club. Everywhere else was forbidden territory." Nevertheless, it was an address that became memorable for recovering addicts all over the Region and around the world, quite possibly the most famous meeting place in NA history.

"The deal was, fix it up and it's yours." A lot of people rolled up their sleeves, did the plumbing, fixed the toilets, set up the phones for the hotline, painted the walls, and scoured the streets for chairs and couches. "Sitting there answering that phone—our first for-real hotline, not an answering machine in someone's home—was almost as good as a meeting 24 hours a day. On such a high-

drug-use block newcomers started coming in right off the street."

Mecca

The first meeting at St. Mark's Place, the Eighth Street Workshop, opened shortly after the world convention, meeting on Monday nights in a dingy basement room made cheerful with a homemade banner. "My sponsee came to my apartment and we sewed the group's name in funky gold felt lettering on a maroon field while a newcomer kicked heroin on my bed." By February 1984 the group added a Sunday evening Step meeting and shortly after that, a Wednesday book study meeting. At that time, a group of recovering addicts had been going to Living Now, a popular Lower East Side AA meeting, because there were so few NA meetings downtown. They now got involved in opening meetings at St. Mark's. The East Village Group started back-to-back Friday night meetings, at seven and at eight o'clock.

Within its first month of operation, St. Mark's Place had five meetings on four evenings a week out of seven. By May 1984 two more meetings had opened, Friday and Saturday Midnight Miracles. Addicts could now spend the Friday night danger zone at St. Mark's, from the seven o'clock meeting to midnight Saturday, hanging out in the HOW Club in between. There was also talk of a need for morning meetings, of which there were none. "They had eye-opener meetings in AA at 6:30 and 7:00. We started ours at 9:30. Why I love NA." Nine-thirty a.m. Wakeup was the first Monday-through-Friday meeting in New York City. It was started by Santos and Peter H in the spring of 1984. The success of having a regularly scheduled place where newcomers could get some structure in their life motivated the opening of two more five-day-a-week groups by the fall of '84, the Three O'clock Afternoon meeting, started by Santos, Monday through Friday, and Eleven Alive, a late-night meeting that met Sunday through Thursday.

On the October 1984 Regional meeting list there are 24 meetings at 19-23 St. Mark's Place. Three more meetings filled up the weekend: Just For Today, a Sunday afternoon Book Study, and

two Saturday meetings, Absolutely Necessary at seven and the Eleventh Step Workshop at five. "Later on we added a two-hour Saturday morning workshop where people spoke on the same Step and Tradition—another first. We had the smallest room in the place. People stood outside because we had good speakers." That addicts, some of them clean, would spend two hours standing in a crowded basement hallway on a Saturday morning discussing spiritual principles speaks volumes about the powerful draw of meetings at 19-23 St. Mark's Place:

"In a couple of years it went nuts. I went upstairs, it's all rainbow colored hair. I'm the only one with normal color. Is it me? Or is it them?"

"It was Mecca, crowds spilling onto the streets. Numbers are a magnet, and St Marks was a magnet that brought more people into NA than anything we've had before or since."

Gladiator School, Spiritual Boot Camp—St. Mark's was the gateway for the bottom addict. Kevin F used to go to Grand Central Station and talk to the subterraneans, people who lived in tunnels beneath the station, and brought them to the HOW Club, still using. "People shooting up in the bathroom, falling off the chairs, crazy nuts walking in and out, you had all types, but it was kind of like all the planets going around in a circle but none of them hitting each other. There was an unspoken understanding that 'I'm not messing with you, you're not messing with me, we're both here to live.' And you saw plenty of guys shooting dope in the bathroom and then saw them a few months later chairing a meeting."

In a single year St. Mark's Place grew from one meeting to twenty seven, seven days a week, from morning into the night, and on weekends people came from all over the Region to Midnight Miracles. "The crowd at that meeting would just roar. You could hear it down by Second Avenue." But it wasn't the only attraction the Lower East Side had to offer addicts seeking recovery. A short walk down the Bowery to the Holy Name Center at 18 Bleecker was downtown Manhattan's first NA meeting, the Thursday night Bleecker Street Group. "At first there was just a beginner's meeting

in a room on the fourth floor, five to ten people and the same speakers all the time, a big problem. Then it outgrew the room and moved to the chapel. Then it outgrew the chapel and moved to the auditorium."

In November '83 We Have a Choice, which for months had been meeting on Friday evenings out of doors in Stuyvesant Park at 2nd Avenue, came out of the cold and found a home at Holy Name. By the following February two eight o'clock Tuesday night meetings opened, one for men and one for women—another first. By the summer of 1984 the meeting list included Llegamos, the New York Region's first Spanish group, which met on Monday night, and Bleecker Street, the original downtown meeting, now had a core group of around fifty people on a Thursday night, with a microphone and a podium and a concurrent Step meeting at the same time.

In late 1984 ABCs to Recovery, another Lower East Side group, opened at the Church of the Most Holy Redeemer on East 4th Street and Avenue A, a short walk from the Bleecker Street and HOW Club meetings. All told, there were now over thirty meetings a week in the Lower East Side—more meetings than in all of Brooklyn, the Bronx, and Staten Island combined. No wonder this neighborhood was such a draw to addicts, especially newcomers, in spite of their sponsor's warning to avoid trigger areas. Fern T from Long Island came in to work the hotline. "When I first tried do 90 in 90, every time I crossed a bridge to go to a meeting I copped. I couldn't risk it till I had six months clean, but even then when I went in to work the hotline there were people dealing hash on the block. If you went to the Gem Spa you were waiting to cop. The pizza shop on Third Avenue was forbidden territory. I was only comfortable right in front of the HOW Club where people were coming in and out."

The same was true all over downtown Manhattan. "Especially after crack became major in '84. A bunch of corners were drug spots. Two-three hundred people twenty four hours a day around the Army Navy Store on 13th and Third." One addict remembers moving from Philadelphia to the Lower East Side "three months

before I got clean and I could cop anything a block from my apartment." Around the Bleecker Street meeting "there would be fifty, a hundred whacked out addicts milling around outside. We'd tell them there's a meeting .Why don't you come up? And every week someone would come in."

We're Still Here: Early Manhattan Meetings (1981 through 1985)*

No written documentation has been found for meetings that opened between October 1982 and May 1983. In addition, many groups were in existence before joining the Region. With these limitations on accuracy in mind, we have listed the early groups that are still keeping the doors open in the order they first appear in Area minutes or meeting lists.

*Still at their original location. Many more were forced to move in the mass relocation of meetings that began in 2013 and exists to this day.

Bleecker Street Thursday, now Second Lives
Bleecker Street Tuesday
Life Begins Again
Morningside, now Circle of Miracles
Midtown Connection
*Only Game in Town
*208 Group, now Serenity Sunday
*Hell's Kitchen
*Life at 99
9:30 a.m. Wake-up, now 9:00 a.m. Wakeup
Just For Today
Three O'clock (Mon-Fri), now Recovery in the Afternoon in Brooklyn
Eleven Alive, now No More Excuses
Llegamos
ABCs to Recovery
It Can Be Done
*Uptown Men's Meeting
Village Spiritual Workshop

Growth of the Region: "Stick-and-Stay" Queens

By the time of the world convention, Queens already had three well-established groups: Awareness and Clean and Serene in Jackson Heights, which opened their doors in 1981, and Horizon Steps in Jamaica, in April 1982. By the summer of 1983 four more groups opened that are still around today: Day by Day and Life Line, both in Jackson Heights; Survivors in Woodside; and the first Rockaway Group. Members of these early meetings walked out of the World Convention feeling vindicated that what they had been doing in relative isolation had the support of all the people they had met who had been around NA for a long time.

Not all of these Queens meetings that opened before the World convention continued to thrive, however. The Region's first Traditions meeting, Traditions Workshop in Elmhurst, and the first women's meeting, Women's Side at Queens College, both Sunday meetings, were on the fall 1982 meeting list but were gone by June of 1983. The Region's first LGBT meeting, Let It Be in Elmhurst, was also short-lived, on the June 1983 meeting list but gone by the following August, and Guiding Light in Flushing, which opened that July, was gone by November. But the other seven groups that opened before the convention are all alive and thriving, some of them still in their original locations, a living tribute to the secure foundation these early trusted servants established. "There were more people in Manhattan but a lot of them were coming and going," says a longtime member. Unlike Manhattan, people who were Queens natives tended to go to meetings in the neighborhoods in which they were raised. "Queens was the stick-and-stay."

The spread of NA across the borough had its nexus in Jackson Heights, home of four out of the seven Queens groups that opened before the convention: Awareness, Clean and Serene, Day by Day, and Lifeline. Jackson Heights was also the original home of Both Sides of the Coin, where a firm foundation in the 12 and 12 had been established in the late seventies. Many of the early members still attended this AA-sanctioned meeting for some anchoring and

guidance in establishing structure in the often chaotic new meetings. This was not achieved without problems. "The spontaneous growth sort of had a life of its own, but it bothered people who needed to control things. Certain members were fearful that NA wouldn't survive unless the groups were rigid about obeying rules they had formulated early on to shore it up, such as the use of language." A member who had started the first two-for-one meeting in Manhattan in 1974 and had been active in NA since its inception was asked to speak at Horizons, NA's first Step meeting, only to be told he couldn't because he also went to AA. "I had a resentment but I kept coming back. I had to be around addicts."

For the small number of people who had been the pioneers of these early meetings, the post-convention expansion was "just an amazing time. All of a sudden all these groups opened, many of them without our knowledge. It was also strange to find ourselves being elder statesmen in this brand-new NA fellowship. We called Jimmy K a lot. He said do it with the Traditions, keep them up front. Talk about the Steps. Read them, and so we did." The Queens Area also set up an outreach committee to give new groups a grounding in NA principles as well as some hard-won experience about resolving problems other regions didn't face. "We needed to give these new groups some basic stuff, a packet, to get them on the same page. What California had was not what they needed."

In the year following the convention the Queens fellowship had expanded beyond Jackson Heights, Woodside, and Jamaica into Ridgewood (I Am Responsible, Queens Gratitude, and Ridgewood Group), Ozone Park (Clean in Queens), Glendale (A New Beginning), Elmhurst (NA Midnight), and Astoria (Ravenswood and Bridge to Recovery). In addition, the original Rockaway Group became Rocky I to make room for Rocky II and III, a women's meeting. Rockaway is a part of the borough of Queens but not on the mainland. "It's like being in Hawaii," says one longtime resident. "But once we got meetings going people came from Brooklyn, Long Island, Queens, Manhattan people in the summer—a nice mix." Eventually those Rocky Group roman numerals would top out at VII. In spite of the

devastation caused by Hurricane Sandy, the doors of these and other NA meetings are still open all along that narrow strip of ocean beach, from Breezy Point to Far Rockaway.

The Day by Day group expanded in a different way, eventually becoming the Monday-through Friday noon meeting it is today. I Am Responsible opened Queens' first men's group and women's group. Meanwhile, the Saturday afternoon Clean and Serene just kept expanding in numbers, becoming one of the most well attended meetings in New York City.

Breaking into a new neighborhood usually required a personal connection, of the kind that Terry R had with the priests at Blessed Sacrament, across the street from where he lived, and Brian P had developed with St. Mark's Parish. Kenny M was a native of Astoria. "I went back to the church where I was baptized and confirmed, the same church that had the AA meeting that didn't want to hear about my drug use. Terry, Pat, and I went before the church council and they said yes." Bridge to Recovery grew quickly, drawing in members of Pills Anonymous and Drugs Anonymous, which also met in that church. It still meets there today.

Finding a church council that would allow an NA meeting was not always so successful, especially in the more affluent neighborhoods of Queens, where there were more homeowners than apartment dwellers. Ed D and his wife Meryl D were among the former members of Both Sides of the Coin who made the transition to NA and got involved in starting Queens meetings. "The Rockefeller Law was still a big negative for many churches, especially those in "respectable" suburban type neighborhoods where parishioners and neighbors feared they would be opening their doors to convicted criminals, and we weren't exactly sober AA people who after a meeting got in their cars and went home. Homeowners didn't want addicts congregating down the block or across the street. Their property values would go down."

Ed D and Meryl D scored a real coup in securing the beautiful 18th century Reformed Church of Newtown in Elmhurst, now on the National Register of Historic Places, for a candlelight Saturday

meeting, NA Midnight, the first midnight meeting in Queens. "It was one of the legendary meetings, and we used to stay until the sun came up. The doors opened right onto Broadway and people would walk in and out off the street. In the summer the meeting got pretty crazy, not as crazy as Saint Marks but on a par. We chaired it for four years. Before we left we always did a search to make sure no addicts were sleeping upstairs."

By the summer of 1985 Queens had thirty four groups, many of them holding multiple meetings, and had expanded to Hollis (Two for One), Middle Village (Sunday Serenity), and Rochdale (Keep It Simple), as well as additional meetings in Jackson Heights (Straight at Eight, then Straight at Six until it closed), Rockaway (Heavy Duty Step Shop and Rocky IV), and Flushing (Never Ending Miracles). By March 1986 the Queens fellowship added ten more groups in seven more neighborhoods, and that growth just kept happening.

We're Still Here: Early Queens Meetings (1981 through 1985)

*Still at their original location. Many more were forced to move in the mass relocation of meetings that began in 2013 and exists to this day.

Awareness
*Clean and Serene, Jackson Heights.
*Horizons, Jamaica
Day by Day
Rockaway Groups (Rocky I-V).
Moved to several Rockaway locations
after Hurricane Sandy.
Lifeline
Survivors
*I Am Responsible, Ridgewood
*Clean in Queens, Ozone Park
*Bridge to Recovery, Astoria
Astoria Recovery
*Two for One (I Can Club), St. Albans
*Keep It Simple, Rochdale
Straight at Eight
*Sunday Serenity, Middle Village
*Never Ending Miracles, Flushing
*Straight to the Point, College Point

Growth of the Region: Brooklyn

John F, newly clean in September 1983, remembers his first NA meeting, but most vivid is what happened afterward. "We were at a diner and about 200 people came in. They were all people that had been to the World convention and they were still hanging out on a Tuesday after the STAR group. I remember the tip was over $300 and that was my first recovery event."

Brooklyn had been off to a slow start, with two registered meetings in its first year, but it quadrupled in size by the end of its second year. Numbers matter. But that first year was slow going. "There were so few meetings that people traveled from Brooklyn to the Bronx to Manhattan to Queens, and we'd see the same people at "the" meeting. To this day I know them." But when more meetings started opening up in the other boroughs the need to go to Brooklyn was overruled by convenience. Even Brooklynites found it difficult to get around their own borough. Bob P lived on 8th Avenue near centrally located Prospect Park, but "the STAR was trip and a half—up to Parkside, take the bus down to 18th Avenue, then 18th all the way across to 83rd. But he did it every Tuesday." "It wasn't easy," recalls Jeff, another member who became active early on. "NA wasn't proven back then, and there were very few of us—two, four, six people at the very beginning. We'd hold the meeting even if it was just two of us, but we were tight and saw each other all the time."

Four months after the STAR group got started NA in Brooklyn expanded from Bensonhurst even farther west to Bay Ridge and Dyker Heights, when Brooklyn Survivors, a Monday night meeting, opened at Regina Pacis Church on 65th Street and 12th Avenue. (Although this group does not appear on meeting lists until May of 1984, it is listed in Area minutes as having joined the New York City Area in July of 1982.) And so it remained—two registered groups in Brooklyn but only one on the meeting lists—for another nine months.

When Ed W first got involved in NA he didn't know about

the STAR group "because it was completely on opposite ends of the borough from where I was in Brooklyn Heights." He was part of a group of people going to AA who had found out in Florida there was NA and wanted to start a group in the Heights. They asked a highly respected AA member for help in approaching Grace Church at 254 Hicks Street, "because we were a foreign idea to them, being addicts, and she convinced them to let us have a meeting in a small room in the church on a Friday night. They gave us this beautiful room. It had couches and a fireplace, and it was *not* in the basement." Word spread quickly among NA members in the other boroughs that there was now a meeting in the Heights, just a subway stop from Manhattan, and recovering addicts from already established groups were invited to speak. "At first most of the people who came to the meetings lived in the Heights, but then word got out relatively quickly into Bedford Stuyvesant, because it's right next to Brooklyn Heights, and some people started coming in, the first African American people at meetings that we had seen." Little did they know that these members were no newcomers to NA.

"Do-or-Die Bed-Stuy"

Ron B had been sitting in too many AA meetings with the urge to get high. "I was finished with the drinking, no desire, because the alcohol would only make me fall down. Getting high would make me rise up. Even now, whenever I have to have surgery the very first thing I think of is, 'Oh, they're going to give me some shit.' The reason I got involved with NA was an AA old-timer named Mr. Clarke because he knew I was an addict. He knew I stopped making meetings. He would call me up at eleven o'clock at night and haunt me with 'I just want to tell you something. You can't keep it unless you give it away,' and hang up. Then one day I was walking down the street and I smelled reefer. I found myself taking whiffs of the air trying to get a contact high and I'm messed up behind that. Three years in AA and oh man, what's going on with me? There was a dope fiend in the 22-30 AA meeting that they hated

because he would put up his hand and say, 'My name is Harry and I'm an alcoholic and I want to shoot some dope.' I talked to him about what was going on. He said, 'There's a place for you,' and he told me about ENTER House. I walked in and they had some real dope fiends in there. I went up to ENTER every week, and I took people up there from Brooklyn who didn't know a thing about it."

Finally Ron B gave in to Mr. Clarke's urgent messages, and his favorite excuse of 'Why me?' became 'Why not me?' "Mr. Clarke had a vision that the NA fellowship would flourish as a result of starting just one group, and that this group would be a root developing into limbs that would eventually create branches. Today, we are a living example of the old-timer's vision."

The recovering addicts who attended Welcome to Sobriety until it folded in 1980 became the root of the future growth of Bed-Stuy/Crown Heights NA meetings. Among them were Bashir I, Tom B, Ron B, and Frank P. Ron B was Frank P's sponsor, and he in turn sponsored Willie T. In September 1982 he attended an AA meeting at the Bed Stuy Alcohol Treatment Center on Bedford Avenue, mandated by his city job. "I was still mocus. I had no idea what was going on, but the blessing was that I met a counselor there who told me about ENTER.

"I went up there and met Goat. He epitomized what I thought of as the real dope fiend—emaciated, the way he walked, talking slick, but his mannerisms made you think he's still using. But there was something else about him that was just too believable when he talked about being clean. I remember just sitting there crying. Lucky was another one. Anytime I knew where they were going to be speaking I'd show up. I figured one day they'd let me in on their secret. Those ENTER people were role models who were doing it because it had been done for them, not for recognition. They drilled that into our heads—just pass it on. They were the foundation for a lot of us who came to NA in the early eighties. The identification was so strong."

In February 1983 Free at Last, the first registered NA meeting in Bedford-Stuyvesant opened at the Mid Brooklyn Sobering up

Station at 599 Ralph Avenue. Ron: "It was one of the few places that allowed so-called dually addicted people to meet. But there were only about seven of us at that time who were staying clean, and when the chair and the co-chair went out the meeting closed." Free at Last reopened in 1985 at 272 Macon Street.

Brooklyn Takes Off

Shortly before the World Convention Tommy R started Stop the Drugs and Live, which met on Tuesday at the Greenwood Club on 7th Avenue and 20th Street, the first NA meeting in that part of Brooklyn. Now the borough had four meetings a week, but the era of slow growth was coming to an end. In less than four months, it doubled with New Beginnings on Sterling Place (Thursday), Clean Machine in Park Slope (Wednesday), Steps into Recovery on Hicks Street (Friday), and a Sunday Step meeting, also at the Greenwood Club. By the following December the Brooklyn fellowship was gaining in ground covered as well as numbers, expanding to Greenpoint (Keep It Green and the Greenpoint Group on Saturday), Ridgewood, (Today I Live on Thursday and Together We Can on Tuesday), and Carroll Gardens (Recovery in the Gardens on Thursday). In Bedford-Stuyvesant Welcome to Recovery opened on Bedford Avenue. This Tuesday meeting was the return of the so-called "renegade" meeting, Welcome to Sobriety, which opened in 1979 and met in addicts' apartments to avoid arrest. It had briefly been Brooklyn's first NA meeting.

Brooklyn's real explosion of meetings took place in 1985, when a whopping 24 meetings opened across the borough. In Bay Ridge: Together (Monday), T.G.I.F. (Friday) and Freedom (Saturday); in Bensonhurst: Spiritual Awakening (Sunday), and The War Is Over (Tuesday); in Brighton Beach: Recovery by the Sea (three meetings); in Greenwood: Midday Miracles (Thursday); in Flatbush: Primary Purpose (Sunday) and Recovery from Within (Monday); in Park Slope: Hope in the Slope (Monday), Bridge Back to Life (Thursday), Women on Wednesday, and Ninth Street Step Workshop (Wednesday); in Cobble Hill: Solamente

Today (Tuesday); Crown Heights Recovery (Friday); Brownsville Recovery (Saturday); in Bedford Stuyvesant: Claver Clean and Alive (Thursday) and Chauncy Live Again (Wednesday); Dyker Heights Group (Saturday); in Sheepshead Bay: Men's and Women's Workshops (Saturday), Keep Coming, Keep Clean (Monday), and Serenity by the Bay (Tuesday).

After Stop the Drugs and Live opened at the Greenwood Club, they offered NA a Thursday meeting, Midday Miracles, and then a Sunday meeting, the first in Brooklyn. Within a year or so they became Brooklyn's first Monday-through-Friday meeting. With so many meetings at one location, the Greenwood Club had become Brooklyn's NA clubhouse. Gone were the days when addicts needed to leave the borough to find solid recovery on any day or night of the week.

We're Still Here: Early Brooklyn Meetings (1981 through 1985)

*Still at their original location. Many more were forced to move in the mass relocation of meetings that began in 2013 and exists to this day.

Start Thinking about Recovery (STAR Group)
Brooklyn Survivors
Free at Last
*Brooklyn Heights Group
Stop the Drugs and Live
New Beginnings
*Clean Machine, Park Slope
Stop the Drugs and Live
Sunday Step
Keep It Green
Welcome to Recovery
*TGIF
*Together We Can
*Claver Clean and Alive
Midday Miracles
Hope in the Slope
The War Is Over
*Primary Purpose
Recovery From Within

Staten Island

Staten Island has the smallest population numbers of the New York City boroughs, so, for a time, a drive across the Verrazano Bridge to Brooklyn or a ferry ride to Manhattan was a logical choice for

addicts on Staten Island seeking recovery. It remained a part of the MBSI Area until Brooklyn and Staten Island formed its own Area in 1985, and was part of Brooklyn/Staten Island Area Service for another year after that.

The first meeting, Top O'the Hill opened in early 1983. It was started by Curley, Frantic Fran, and Danny D, and met on Friday night at Wagner College, not far from the ferry terminal. A few months later they started a second meeting, Straight Times, which met on Tuesday in a large construction trailer near the boardwalk on South Beach. It continued to meet there at least until the September 1983 convention because Norman S remembers going to a meeting there when he was coming up on a year clean in AA. "I didn't attend the convention because I didn't know about it but all of a sudden these people showed up from way-out places—Texas, Atlanta, foreigners—more of them than locals. It was a very memorable experience." Undoubtedly it was for the visitors as well to see the lengths addicts in New York would go to." When the meeting outgrew the trailer it moved to the nearby South Beach Psychiatric Center and eventually changed its name to Clean Times, Staten Island's oldest existing group. By the mid-eighties, when the crack epidemic hit Staten Island hard, "we had like a hundred people, one inside in a classroom and then a social craziness thing on the outside."

Crossing the Bridge

The fellowship on Staten Island grew slowly, and it would take years before addicts cut the umbilical cord to Brooklyn. "I'm a frustrated car mechanic, so I was always able to find something that got me to meetings. With that and two dollars in my pocket I'd go over the bridge to Stop the Drugs and Live, Clean Machine, the STAR Group. Initially I went by myself and then I started seeing all my Staten Island mates there and we went together." Norman S became a kind of unofficial speaker exchange person for Staten Island. Later on, "I'd hear them speak in Brooklyn—Richy C, a guy named Larry who died in 9/11, and others who I got to cross the

bridge. I'd tell them, 'Why don't you take a ride?' I was kind of shuffling people back and forth. It worked pretty well."

Two more meetings opened in the summer of 1984, Crossroads on Hyatt Street, right off the ferry, a Wednesday meeting, and By the Book on Saturday, a Step group on Sand Lane. Another year went by before the next meetings opened, Port of Recovery at the Camelot Counseling Center, and Staten Island's first Sunday meeting, Primary Purpose, a Step meeting at Wagner College. But there were still no Thursday meetings on Staten Island. The real explosion of growth wouldn't happen there until the early nineties.

A longtime resident remembers all the traveling addicts did back then, not just across the bridge but on the island. Most of the early meetings were on the perimeter of the island. Despite its small size, "It's not easy to get around even if you have a car. No subway system, just the train to Tottenville, but God knows how many times we went to support meetings in other parts of the island. We were a tight group, and we'd had our own little section in the Country Club Diner. It was a huge recovery place. On Friday or Saturday night the whole crew would be there."

We're Still Here: Early Staten Island Meetings (1981 through 1985)

*Still at their original location.

Straight Times, now Clean Times
*By the Book
*Port of Recovery

We're Still Here: The Bronx

Although the number of addicts in need of NA was overwhelming in the Bronx, it was the last borough to take off in the era of explosive growth. Until the opening of Clean and Crazy at Lincoln Hospital in May 1984, the area south of the Cross Bronx Expressway and west of the Bronx River was NA no-man's land. This section was

called the South Bronx (although the Southwest Bronx would be more accurate). Jimmy Carter called the area "perhaps the worst slum in America," a statement that went viral around the world when he made a presidential campaign stop to Charlotte and 170th Street in 1977 at the height of its downward spiral, when 40 percent of its housing stock had been lost to abandonment or destruction by arson. In the early 1980s "it was still on fire," says a member who grew up in the South Bronx, "very much on fire."

It took an extreme type of addict to plant the seeds of recovery in such extremely un-fallow ground, and that addict was Santos. Speaking at a Regional convention in the early 1990s, he described how he came to NA, with a history of 56 arrests, 15 detoxes, and 4 rehabs. "In 1982 I came to Back to Life, taking inventory, shooting them down, knowing I was the nastiest turkey there, went back out, living in a hole in the wall, what we called abandoned buildings back then, almost died, arms full of holes, until it dawned on me—I've got this disease. For the first three and a half years I never missed a meeting, back to back." Santos became well known in NA for saying, "I hate newcomers, all that complaining and whining," and telling them, "Only punks go out." He could say that with authority. "Surrender or die!" was his motto. "You want to go out? Why not just jump in front of a train. It would be quicker."

Santos made a decision to start more meetings in the Bronx and build them up. The first meeting he opened was on St. Anne's Avenue and 139th Street, which members called "the most drug-infested street in the South Bronx." It was called Nice and Easy, and it met at St. Benedict the Moor Center, a storefront and soup kitchen. Later a second meeting opened there, Steps to Freedom, on Friday. In October 1984, when Toby R found NA, "The only meetings in the South Bronx were all the way up on Beach Avenue so I had to go north to get my recovery, up to Morris Park and Eastchester Road, a couple of meetings at Montefiore hospital. Then I heard about the meeting on 139th Street. It was like the Wild West down there, which was why it had taken so long to get meetings going down there. And that's where the meetings started, on the street that was like

the hottest place in the Bronx at the time for buying drugs. Coming and going, the dealers were standing right by the door."

Santos had chosen well. "He was gung ho, the NA police. One thing he did that I admired a lot was take somebody from the street and give him a hot meal. He'd let him to go his house and kick or whatever and take him to meetings every day. He was a disabled Vietnam vet and didn't work, so he could do that." Nice and Easy became Toby's home group. He also had a car, and Santos enlisted him to drive around the Bronx looking for more spaces to start meetings. "I lived down the block from Montefiore and we started another meeting there, T.G.I.N.A, and from there Santos told me to drive him down to 188th Street and Fordham Road to see if we could open a meeting at Our Lady of Mercy. They gave us a space and we started Hugs Not Drugs, a Tuesday meeting, and from there we went up the block to the cathedral on University Avenue, St. Nicholas of Tolentine, and we started Bells to Recovery. That was on a Wednesday. Once we started expanding in the South Bronx I stayed to give support to the meetings that just opened up. We stuck together. That's how it was."

Aida R remembers going to Steps to Freedom early in her recovery, "cold, dirty, rats running over your feet in the dark, but you know, it was very popular. Santos would annoy and challenge you with his "punks don't go back out," but that made me stay. You wanted to kill him but he saved your life. He opened many meetings and was so instrumental to us in the Bronx, especially for Latinos. There were mostly white people at the meetings in the North Bronx, very few blacks and Latinos. Even though our common bond was addiction and unconditional love knows no boundaries, it was good to get with our own culture."

A third meeting with a very appropriate name opened in the same neighborhood as Bells to Recovery and Hugs Not Drugs, but there was nothing cathedral-like about the atmosphere of Underground Miracles at 184th Street and Morris Avenue. "To get to the meeting you had to go through alleyways that were cop spots. Then you had to walk through a corridor that led to a courtyard,

then another corridor to the meeting."

With so many new meetings opening all at once, members of more established groups worked hard to maintain a clear NA message. "We'd hear about renegade groups and the word would go out—listen, this group is doing whatever they want. What? Come on, let's go. Sometimes we'd put on our NA jackets and give it to them raw, Santos style. We were "old-timers" and we'd set them straight. We were so afraid NA would fold."

More meetings also opened east of the Bronx River Parkway. Two were started in St. Raymond's Church on Metropolitan Avenue in Parkchester. Ties That Bind was on Tuesday and Why It Works, a Traditions meeting, on Thursday. Let It Be, a Sunday meeting, opened at Our Lady of Assumption in Pelham Bay. The easternmost Bronx meeting at that time, Foundations to Recovery, was a Wednesday meeting at St. Benedict's on Otis Avenue.

What's truly amazing is how many of these meetings in the Bronx have kept their doors open, many of them in the same location, some of them for more than 30 years.

We're Still Here: Early Bronx Meetings (1981 through 1985)

*Still at their original location.

Back to Life
One Step at a Time
*Morris Park Sunday Group
Emergency Room
Let It Be
*Recovery in the South Bronx
*Hugs Not Drugs
*Foundations to Recovery
*Bells to Recovery
*Ties that Bind Us
*Why It Works
*Underground Miracles

Long Island

"If there wasn't a meeting within 20 miles we'd start one."
—Butch S

By the summer of 1983 there were as many meetings in Long Island as there were in Manhattan, but a lot of recovering addicts who lived in Nassau and Suffolk didn't even know of their existence. Instead, they continued to make regular trips into the city to go to meetings. For some, that was not the ideal solution. "I felt Long Island just wasn't part of it. We weren't cool enough, like we didn't know how to share or how to use, and it seemed like everybody was fighting all the time, and it was painful to me. So one day I was sitting in New York City Area Service and I didn't like what was going on, and I said to everybody who was there from Long Island, come on, let's start our own Area, and that's how Suffolk-Nassau Area Service started. I was the Long Island vigilante."

Ernie C became the first chair of Suffolk-Nassau Area Service (SNAS), and Conrad W the first Area representative to the newly formed New York Region. Ernie: "In the beginning it was pretty much 'Come to my house on Tuesday' and we didn't even know what an Area was. We had no money for literature, hand-written meeting lists, and we bought poker chips instead of key chains. Then Vitamin Joe found out about the *Temporary Working Guide*. He wrote to World Service and they mailed him one." Unlike other Areas, this pamphlet, which was little known at the time, became the guideline for SNAS from its formation.

Joe G remembers going to WCNA 13 and finding out about meetings on Long Island he'd never heard of. With the post-convention excitement, and a lot of coordinating efforts by the newly formed Area, within three months there were seven new meetings in the two counties: Stony Brook Group, Sunday; Bay Shore Midnight, Friday; Hidden Pond Group (later Twelve Steps to Serenity), Tuesday, in Happauge; Lost and Found, Friday, in West Islip; Long Beach Unity, Thursday; Just Relax, Friday, in Northport;

and New Awakening, Saturday, in Huntington. At first SNAS met at the Long Beach Community Center in Nassau, but when the number of Suffolk meetings started to explode it moved to the more centrally located Northport.

"Our treasurer's father was the captain of the East Northport Police Department, and he got us permission to have the Area meeting in the basement of the police station, which was really unusual. I'd travel from my house the first Sunday of every month with the coffee pot, walk up to the cage where the officers were, say hi, I'm here for the NA meeting, and there was always one who'd give me 'the look.' " The neighboring towns of Northport and Huntington soon became NA Central for Long Island. "They were good to us, very welcoming. I think the police department connection helped. When churches saw we were okay they followed. That's why meetings concentrated there." The town of Islip was also accommodating. Richie R: "When we first started my home group, 12 Steps to Serenity, it was in the Hidden Pond Park Recreation Center. Then the town turned it into an ice rink and they offered to move us to the Town Beach Pavilion overlooking Lake Ronkonkoma, a beautiful place. People couldn't believe it. Being the good dope fiend every chance I got, I wrote a letter to the town supervisor, thanking him for saving lives by giving us a place. That meeting's still there." Joe G got involved in starting the Guppy Group, when "someone had a connection in the Unitarian fellowship in Huntington and they gave us a building that hadn't been used in years. Four of us scrubbed it down on a miserable hot day. We were pretty young and didn't know enough to name it something related to recovery, but it's still called that."

But these places of welcome were the exception, as the attitude toward addicts in many parts of Long Island was downright hostile. "When I first went to meetings, people I knew thought NA was a fraud, an underground drug den where people went to score. I went to an AA meeting once, thinking it was NA, and they told me it was down the hall. 'We might be drunks but at least we're not down there.' Big stigma. Most of the meetings in Suffolk were in the

worst parts of town. The largest were in walking distance from the railroad—Hicksville, Wantagh—in Freeport it was a stone's throw away. Those meetings did well."

The importance of H&I meetings on Long Island also contributed to the rapid expansion of meetings, especially from institutions that had been serviced by H&I within months after the first groups started in 1982. "Nassau County Jail and Medical Center, South Oaks, Brunswick—it's amazing how many people came out of there to our meetings. We were always welcome in these institutions. They treated us a lot better than some churches, where they'd lock up their goblets and collection boxes when we came in."

Asphalt Recovery

Within two years the meetings on Long Island doubled in number, and then, from 1985 to 1986, doubled again, with many nightly choices. "It's interesting, though, how those earliest meetings seem to have a built-in longevity, maybe because they worked so hard to keep them going." But the different flavors of so many groups to choose from were a big draw. No longer did members see the same half dozen people at meetings in other towns that they saw at their home groups. Still, the lure of going to meetings in the city did not go away.

"We hit every meeting on Long Island, and then we started going to meetings all over the Greater New York Region. After we went to a local meeting we'd drive into Manhattan, go to an eight o'clock meeting uptown, then down to the midnight meeting on St. Mark's Place, then go to eat in Chinatown and back to Long Island by three a.m., having made three meetings. Man, that was great. I came in young, but right away I knew this was something I was going to do for the rest of my life. I got the rush I'd been chasing ever since that first high. I'm getting that rush right now."

We're Still Here: Early Long Island Meetings (1981 through 1985)

No written documentation has been found for meetings that opened between October 1982 and May 1983. In addition, many groups were in existence before joining the Region. With these limitations on accuracy in mind, we have listed the early groups that are still keeping the doors open in the order they first appear in Area minutes or Regional meeting lists.

*Still at their original location.

Nassau

Surrender Group, Rockville Centre
Surf City, Long Beach
*Merrick Sunrise
*Living the Steps, Rockville Centre
*Serenity Sunday, Valley Stream
Mid-Island Connection, Hicksville

Suffolk

Real People
*New Awakenings, Huntington
Hidden Pond Step Group, now Steps to Serenity in Ronkonkoma
*Midnight Hope, Bay Shore
*Just Relax, Northport
*This Must Be the Place, Northport
Unity Now, Stony Brook, now in Medford
*Life After Drugs, Cutchogue
Guppy Group, Huntington
Mid-Island Connection, now in Wantaugh

Westchester/Upstate

When the New York Region was formed in August 1983 the largest Area in both size and numbers of meetings was Bronx/Westchester/Upstate, and it was massive—22 meetings in eight counties—from the Bronx north to Kingston, from White Plains west to South

Fallsberg. Mike K, the Area's first Area Service Representative, changed its unwieldy name to Metro North. Unlike other parts of the Region, the explosive growth north of the City started months before the World Convention, and then exploded even more in the months that followed.

By the summer of 1984 the Area had become so large it was divided into Westchester/Rockland Area and Mid-Hudson, serving Orange, Putnam, Ulster, Duchess, and Sullivan counties. Then, in February 1985, Bronx formed its own Area. Mike K: "The growth was so amazing we could hardly keep up with it. Every time we broke up the Area I went with the less developed piece so I could help it grow." Then he went 135 miles north of the city to Albany and opened the first meeting there. "I chaired that meeting until they elected a chair and handed them the gavel. That became the first meeting of the ABCD Region—Albany, Berkshire, Capitol District. I named that too."

People without cars had a tough time. Public transportation was expensive between towns, and sometimes it was nonexistent. One of the ASRs set up a phone response list of members in five towns to the Regional office who could be called on to provide rides. However, New York City dwellers are not known for their knowledge of geography west of the Hudson. "I sent them a folder yea thick, but I'd get calls from them like, "Can you give a ride to an addict in Buffalo, bring him to a meeting?' They didn't have a clue how big upstate was."

Many of the upstate trusted servants called New York City "our nexus," and not just for communication and information but a different kind of an NA experience. "We found a great disparity in the meetings south of us. Ours were pretty tightly run, fewer drug-a-logs, two-minute shares so everybody gets heard, and while downtown meetings sometimes let methadonians share, we said no. You're either drug free or you're not. But it was wonderful going to recovery and business meetings in the city, that when things got too boisterous they'd interrupt the meetings for a moment of spiritual prayer to center us. Not the kind of thing that happened very often

upstate."

Within two years NA north of the Bronx had grown from 7 counties and 16 meetings to 10 counties and 60 meetings in 40 towns. In Westchester County there were meetings in Yonkers, Mount Vernon, Tarrytown, Croton-on-Hudson, Port Chester, New Rochelle, White Plains, Purchase, Yorktown Heights, Ossining, Pleasantville, Peekskill, and Hartsdale. In Orange County: Middletown, Newburgh, Huguenot, Central Valley, Greenwood Lake, Goshen, and Walden. In Ulster County: Kingston, New Paltz, Saugerties, Ellenville, and Woodstock. In Duchess: Poughkeepsie, La Grange, Beacon, and Fishkill. In Putnam: Camel, Brewster, Garrison, and Patterson. In Rockland: Haverstraw and Pomona. In Albany: Troy and Albany. South Fallsberg in Sullivan, Hudson in Columbia, Catskill in Greene—plus twelve hospitals and institutions serviced throughout the two Areas.

And all of this incredible growth in both numbers and size took place within four years.

We're Still Here: Early Meetings in Westchester/Upstate (1981 through 1985)

*Still at their original location.

Westchester/Rockland

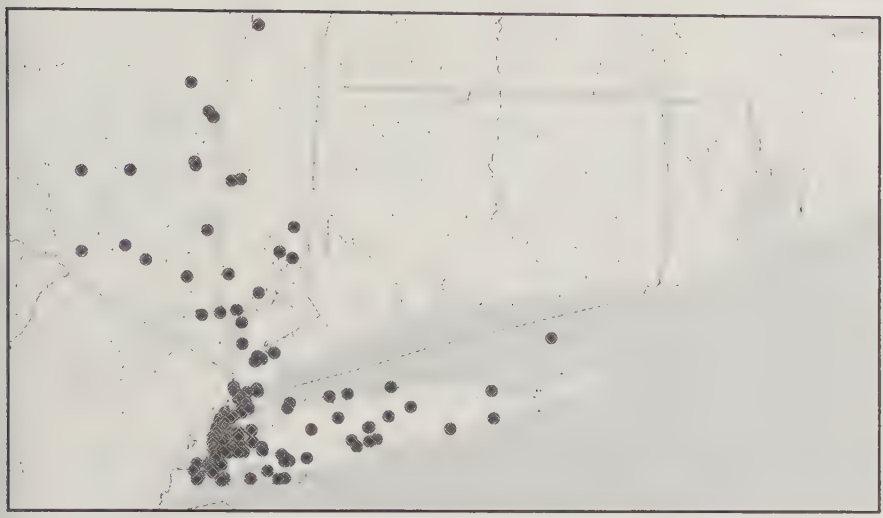
Hope Without Dope, now in Peekskill
Soul Survivors, New Rochelle
Shot at Life, Mt. Vernon
Four Corners of Hartsdale, now Four Corners, White Plains
*Pleasantville Stepwise Group

Mid-Hudson

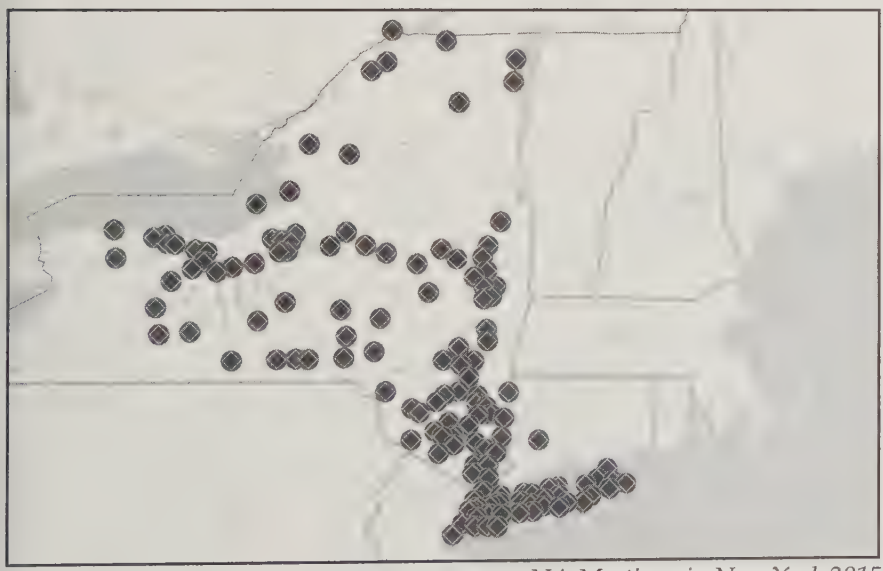
Reflections, Middletown
*Lifeline, Kingston
Pocket Full of Miracles, Kingston
*Clean and Serene, New Paltz
Clean and Free, Poughkeepsie
*Share and Care, Ellenville



NA Meetings in New York 1982



NA Meetings in New York 1985



NA Meetings in New York 2015

Chapter 10 Group Autonomy

Autonomy: The right of self-government; self-directingfreedom, especially moral independence.

—Webster's Collegiate Dictionary, 11th ed.

Each Group does have complete freedom, except when their actions affect other groups or NA as a whole.

—Tradition Four, Narcotics Anonymous Basic Text

"With all our diversity, everybody brings something to the table."

From the beginning, the great diversity that is Narcotics Anonymous in New York is reflected in the choices made by groups throughout the Region when they were first established, and that early history also reflects how hard trusted servants struggled to meet certain needs of the membership that were unique to New York. For example, many of our early members started out in AA, and the meetings they started adapted the AA format as opposed to getting NA starter kits from the World Service Office in California. Although the NA message is the same the world over, certain features of our meetings reflect this unique disparity.

Meeting Format

When groups first formed, the choices they made were often based on the number of addicts who attended meetings on a regular basis. Depending on location, these numbers could vary a great deal.

Although nearly every meeting was small when it started, Suffolk County was an example of what happened in areas where distance and low population density were a deterrence to growth. "We did a lot of things that to this day make meetings in Suffolk so wild compared to anywhere else, but we made these choices because there were so few of us back then. Meetings were two hours long, for one thing. Because they met only once a week and most people drove a long distance to get there, we wanted to keep the doors open in case somebody wandered in late. With four or five people at a meeting, if we all shared we'd be done in 20 minutes, so we padded the format to make the meetings longer, with a lot of readings and a ten-minute coffee break. Funny thing was that, later on, after our numbers started to grow I traveled to other meetings and found that the ones that were an hour long had more people sharing than at our two-hour meeting because of all the BS—just sharing to fill time. So I went back and told the guys this isn't done anywhere else and we don't have to do it anymore, but by then it was, well, this is what we do. Still is."

Groups in New York City had a different set of problems when their numbers started to grow. "There were so many pitch meetings where after a lot of readings and the secretary's report some guy would get up and speak for 25 minutes, then they'd have a five-minute break that turned into 10 or 15 minutes, and then they'd come back, the speaker would point to some friend who would share for seven or eight minutes and then he'd pitch to another guy. So by the end of the meeting three of the speaker's friends would get to share and everybody else in the room would be sucking their thumb. It was terrible.

"So we started what we called a no-frills meeting up in the Bronx. We only read "Who Is an Addict," that was it, because the readings cut into sharing time. No announcements in the secretary's report. We sent a legal pad around the room and people would write down the announcement and we put it on the bulletin board. We asked the speaker to share for ten minutes or less and we tried to break his fucking legs if he went over. Three-minute shares

with a timer for everybody else. We passed the word around NA that this was a no-frills meeting and everybody who comes gets to share. We were mobbed. We used to get sixty or seventy people at that meeting."

Somewhere between these two extremes, groups established a policy that suited their needs at the time, without much consideration for what might be required in the future. Later on, they would need to address a challenge that still exists today in NA—"Addicts hate change."

Kinds of Meetings

For the first year (spring of 1981 to spring of 1982) the choices were simple: every meeting was a beginners' meeting, so no distinction was necessary. "We were all beginners." Needless to say, there were no closed meetings. Newcomers were not going to be turned away because they would not or could not identify themselves as an addict.

Speaker meetings were common in the New York fellowship's infancy, and they would remain a hallmark to this day. The only problem back then was that "people heard each other's stories over and over. They got old real fast. Then this guy Uptight Vince from San Francisco came in. He had sixteen years. In NA! He floated on air for me. Every group in Westchester got him to speak because he was outside blood." Slogan meetings were another popular choice. One member says they worked for him because at that time "slogans were the only thing I could understand." Thirty years later, another says that the slogans are the *only* things she remembers from that first year. "They were beaten into my head, and it's strange how they are still the tool I use more than anything else on a daily basis." According to Ray H from Westchester, who sponsored dozens of newcomers in the early years, "Don't use and go to meetings. That was the program back then."

"The Literature Says..."

The *Basic Text* expanded the NA program's horizons like nothing before or since, not just in New York but around the world. It had been a long time coming. Recovering alcoholics had the *Big Book of Alcoholics Anonymous* within a few years of its founding. It took 30 years before addicts had the *Basic Text of Narcotics Anonymous*, but when the book finally arrived, it had a unifying effect on the fellowship that was immediate and profound.

> Do you know how many people got clean after that book came out? Think about it. This ragtag bunch of characters got together in workshops all over the country and wrote it, by committee, mind you, just addicts sharing their strength. It's choppy, not real fluid because there was a lot of cut-and-paste—for real—swipe the glue stick on the back of a carbon copy and slap it down on the next draft. Imagine 60 addicts in a room debating every word, line by line. There was a lot of stopping to say the *Serenity Prayer* when the fighting got out of hand, and then there'd be peace for about ten or eleven seconds. It was a God thing, a book written by addicts for addicts.

The fellowship would later get embroiled in controversy about editions, but in those early years "I don't think it infiltrated meetings. It was more of a service thing."

In the months after the book came out in September 1983, *Basic Text* study groups started forming all over the region. The first was The Way it Works, a Wednesday meeting in Pomona, followed two months later by The Saturday Book Study at Gracie Square Hospital; Morningside, Monday; Eighth Street Workshop, Wednesday; Staten Island Sunday Night; By the Book, Saturday, in South Beach; Seacliff, Friday; and the Little Door Group, Thursday, in the Bronx. "Oh my God, we had something to read. It was our foundation. It gave us structure. There's always a lot of opinions

in an NA meeting, but you can't change the words when 30 people are reading the same thing. Suddenly we were all on the same page, literally, instead of ad-libbing based on what we had been told. It gave us real direction." Another benefit from these book study meetings was that addicts started learning how to read. "We helped a lot of people learn to read. 'More willingness, less fear,' we told them."

The *Basic Text* even changed the atmosphere in the meetings. "After it came out things calmed down. It wasn't so Wild West. Suddenly meetings started out just reading from the book." It also became a useful tool for sponsors in helping sponsees who had their own ideas about how to seek recovery. "I was in a car with my sponsor. I had two weeks clean, when everybody was reading this book called *The Prophet*. He said, 'Put that shit down. You want to read something, get an NA book.' The next day I got a *Basic Text*."

Step Study

The second year of NA's existence in New York began with the opening of the fellowship's first Step group, Horizons, in Jamaica, Queens. Although a number of groups devoted one meeting a month to the Steps, for more than a year Horizons remained the only group that Step study was the topic at every meeting. Addicts who couldn't make the Horizons group made do with what they had. "We had a makeshift way of doing the Steps. Every time someone came up from Florida we'd beg them to work the Steps with us because they knew how."

In Suffolk, many miles from Jamaica, Queens, Step work was "basically listening to people theorize about what the Step would be about if they actually knew anything about it based on what they're reading about what they think it means. No concept of spiritual principles. You couldn't generate really working the Steps by yourself. It wasn't bootstrap by any sense of the imagination. It was blind leading blind, in Suffolk anyway." Another early member tried going to other fellowships to learn the Steps, "but it was not working for me. My experience was they focused on alcohol, not

what's behind it. It was as empty an experience as trying to take ourselves through it in NA."

Within the span of a few months in the fellowship's third year, six of the founding groups opened Step meetings, all at the same location as the original meetings and most of them on the same night. Bleecker Street started a Thursday night Step group, the first in Manhattan; Clean and Serene started a second 3:30 Saturday meeting for Step work; Back to Life started a Step meeting on Sunday night, the first in the Bronx; Getting Straight opened One Step at a Time; Saturday Night Live started the first Step group in Westchester, Son of Saturday Night Live; and Surrender started the first Step meeting in Nassau. These meetings were also the first closed meetings, for addicts only.

Still, by the time of the World Convention in September 1983 NA New York offered a grand total of seven groups devoted exclusively to Step work—hardly enough to meet the needs of hundreds of addicts who hungered for them. That changed dramatically after the convention, when Step meetings became part of the fellowship's astounding growth. By September 1984 there were eighteen Step meetings; by the end of 1985 there were sixty five. Now we faced a new challenge—how to provide service not just to hundreds but thousands of addicts clamoring to work the Steps. Fortunately, they had help.

John C: "A lot of people in Florida and California treated us like a wounded animal. They went out of their way to make themselves available to us. I used to spend hours on the phone with Bobby R in California. Staten Island guys were coming in off the street or out of treatment and they wanted to do the Steps. I didn't know a thing about them, so Rehmar became our mentor and he would just tutor me. I became a fucking Step scholar from dealing with all these guys. We were doing it in my basement on Seneca Avenue. We would write, we would discuss, Joey would make spaghetti, and that was it, our Step workshop. Seneca House, they called it."

Help also came from uptown addicts with multiple years

of recovery in AA. "My sponsor told me if I was looking for Step work NA was not the place to go. It was too new. So we went to this uptown AA step meeting that was acknowledged to be one of the best—people with thirty, thirty five years. When they spoke they oozed wisdom. But we are NA loyalists. We went strictly as students, just to listen and learn. When we finished that year we felt ready to work the steps in NA. Now we don't have to go outside of the fellowship to get a good foundation and a clear NA message, the one that's like none other—that alcohol is a drug, and that we need to abstain from all drugs in order to recover from the disease of addiction."

A number of uptown addicts who had received a solid foundation in AA had become active in NA early on, including counselors who worked at drug treatment centers, especially the ones at the granddaddy addict recovery institution of them all, ENTER, where for more than a decade counselors been using the AA model in working with "low bottom" addicts. "They adapted the AA Steps and Traditions but they gave us the information in the language of NA."

This approach became known throughout the New York fellowship as the Harlem Way. "There was a whole dynamic uptown that we didn't see too much downtown. It was strict. Goat was a straight-up street version of a dope fiend. He was also the uptown disciplinarian. Every word out of his mouth was 'What Step are you on?' or 'What Step do you think you should be applying to the particular thing you're talking about?' For me he was the epitome of one addict helping another."

"Do You Go to On-and-On-and-On?"

Some members describe the Harlem Way as "sit down and shut up," but Scotty A contradicts that opinion—"It wasn't what we were taught. It was Traditions and Steps, given from God." Keno is another. He attributes "sit down and shut up" as coming not from NA old-timers but recovering addicts who came later. "Goat was my sponsor and he never told me that, but they weren't going to

allow you to disrupt a meeting."

According to the addicts who got clean in those uptown Step meetings, the older members also would not allow any distraction from the format they had learned in AA. "Step meetings were closed. I look in the book today and see they've got open Step meetings. A closed discussion is for someone who knows they're an addict, not if you think you're an addict. It's for us, not for society. It's something that kept us alive and they have no idea about what that means." Not only were Step meetings for addicts only, "if you weren't sharing on the Step they'd say, 'Excuse me, we're on the Step and you're talking about your girlfriend.' 'But I need to share this.' 'I'll see you after the meeting.' They'd do it nicely, but the only way you're going to learn about a Step is to hear people with experience sharing on it." And sometimes, when a member was being particularly stingy about sharing time, they'd do it with humor: "Do you go to On-and-On-and-On?"

"For the first year I never shared at a Step meeting. Our sponsors said we weren't going to open our mouth because we'd corrupt the message, tell a whole bunch of people something's that's not true." The seriousness of purpose of these uptown sponsors laid down an indelible message about recovery through the Steps in the minds of their sponsees, and through them it migrated throughout the fellowship. "We were serious, life-and-death serious. I believe the Steps were more serious then, like we *wanted* to do them, with that honest desire. Out of all the addicts that were out there dying, we were the chosen. So we had to give back, and what we gave back little by little is what NA is now."

The Traditions

Traditions workshop groups, in which each meeting of the month was devoted exclusively to the study of the Traditions, were so rare that they were not officially labeled as such (TW) on meeting lists until the Fall of 1984. The first were Queens Gratitude, Wednesday; Eleven Alive at St. Mark's Place, Sunday; Unity at Broadway Presbyterian on Tuesday; Long Beach Traditions on Thursdays;

and, by the end of 1985, Why It Works, Thursday, in the Bronx. Other groups, like Chauncey Live Again in Brooklyn, had varied formats in which each meeting was devoted to studying the Steps and Traditions concurrently. There was a two-hour Step-and-Tradition workshop on Saturday morning at St. Mark's Place. Still others had alternating formats (the Sunday Eighth Street Workshop at St. Mark's), or devoted one meeting a month to a Traditions workshop (Brooklyn's Stop the drugs and Live, the first Sunday; Soul Survivors in New Rochelle, the first Friday, and Lost and Found, first Sunday, North Tarrytown).

This is not to say that these were the only Traditions workshops offered in those first years, but they were the only ones indicated as such on meeting lists. Still, many old-timers freely admit that they were more interested in working the Steps because they were essential to their early recovery, "While not using was a daily battle, the Steps were all the change I could handle." Others reflect on a logical progression that was not understood at the time: "Steps first, then Traditions. Get some recovery first, get some humility, then you can learn Traditions and get involved with service beyond the group, because if you don't have humility, service beyond the group is just a playground for your ego." The colossal growth of the New York fellowship following the World convention, together with the slow pace of understanding the Traditions, would soon become a volatile combination. "How we survived that time is all the proof I need that we were in the care of a loving higher power."

Special Interest Meetings

In the 1980s a controversy over Traditions and so-called "outside enterprises" arose over a passage in the first edition of the *Basic Text* that implied "one addict helping another" was NA's pure, essential form and all other things were not NA, including special interest groups. Even men's and women's meetings were considered by "NA purists" to be a Tradition violation. The passage was removed from the third edition, but confusion over what constituted a special

interest group continued. Outside enterprise, outside interest, special interest, special need—what exactly did these terms mean? Adding to the confusion in the New York fellowship was that there was no existing policy in the early eighties, or even a clear definition of terms, because defining and clarifying these issues were still being worked out at the World Service level.

Due to New York's great diversity, some of these groups were formed anyway, over the objections of members in the local fellowship who actively opposed them as a Tradition violation. In some cases, these so-called special interest groups were groundbreaking, started not so much out of "interest" but an urgent need that was unique to our fellowship at the time. Two of these groups, "NA approved" by the New York Region alone, were groundbreakers, established without the guidance or support of the fellowship as a whole or even a comprehension of why they were necessary. Soon enough the rest of the world would understand.

"Women with the Women"

It might be assumed there would be no controversy over gender-based meetings because they were already a longstanding tradition in other 12-Step groups, but some New York members strongly objected to the formation of women's meetings as being a tradition violation. A woman's meeting that opened in Staten Island in the mid- 1980s is still called Not for Women Only. "Back in the day, real strict types would go just to prove it's not special interest, that it was open to all." Others were afraid that the fellowship was still too small to accommodate special interest groups, "too few trusted servants trying to keep too many balls in the air." Still, for women who were often outnumbered by as much as ten to one by men in a meeting, the need for their own meetings was so strong they happened in spite of the opposition. "I saw too many women come into a meeting, take one look around, and run out the door before I could reach out to them. It was just too intimidating for a lot of women to handle when they already felt so vulnerable."

Their fear was not unfounded. One of the men who attended

early Bronx meetings explains, "We tried to protect the women because there were a lot of hawks, a lot of buggers walking around who had no conscience about having some kind of relationship with them. We would tell these guys that if that's the kind of behavior they wanted to invest in they weren't welcome around a particular meeting. Our group conscience wouldn't tolerate taking advantage of other people who were here to recover. It was a general thing that most people in the group agreed on, not official policy."

The few women in the fellowship at that time were also vigilant in protecting newcomers. "Rosie found me in Rockaway. She grabbed me by the back of my neck and said, 'You. Come with me. Stick with the women,' and that was that. When we were so outnumbered we had to be there for each other. We stuck together, all right. Like glue."

Not every woman felt intimidated by being outnumbered by the men, but they had other problems: "We didn't know how to rely on each other. I didn't trust other women. A lot of us had that. It was all about the guys." One of the few women with clean time was Fran O, and as a result she had a flock of sponsees. "It amazed me that I always got women who couldn't stand other women. We all had that in common."

"At the first meetings on Bleecker Street I was usually the only woman there. That was fine with me because I didn't like women. I thought I was the queen of Bleecker Street. The big change for me came when I saw a woman come in who looked me—the tattoos, the black leather—and I realized I had something to give to somebody. It was the first time I felt that kind of identification, that it could go both ways."

Women were also deterred by a commonly held belief that they couldn't recover. "The thing was that we weren't outnumbered by men when we were using the way we were in the rooms. "I don't know why that was, but whenever I spoke at a meeting I would always say, 'Women do recover. Just keep coming back.' " As late as 1985 "there were only three or four of us women at my meeting in Brooklyn. It was lonely because I was afraid. I didn't know how to

reach out to them and probably they didn't, either, except for Lucy, God bless her, who had nine years."

Lucy was far and away the exception. Not only were there very few women in NA, there were even fewer who were staying clean, an obstacle for every female newcomer looking for a sponsor. "My first sponsor was a gay man. That was a great solution." Women with too many sponsees and too little time met with them all together somewhere to work the Steps. "NA Marge was a nurse who helped women all over the place, and not just her sponsees. She invited us to go to the Pace College swimming pool on Sundays and meet after. All of us went." Single women with children came to the rescue of each other. "At Back to Life in the Bronx the guys didn't want kids in the meetings so the women took turns taking care of the kids in the hall so each mother could spend some time in the meeting." Single women in Nassau and Queens did the same, starting a Naratot group across the hall from a regular NA meeting.

The natural progression from these informal gatherings was to start duly registered women's meetings, open to everyone, but that happened slowly. Betsey N started the first women's group at Queens College in the spring of 1982, but it only lasted a few months. After that, there were no registered women's groups in the fellowship until Strictly Winners, a Tuesday meeting in Yonkers, opened in November 1983. Like many of these early gender-based meetings, it met at the same time and location as a men's meeting. This was also true at the Tuesday night Bleecker Street women's meeting, which first appears on meeting lists in early 1984. That year, women's meetings opened all around the region: I Am Responsible in Ridgewood, Queens, which met Sunday; two meetings in the Bronx: Women to Women on Friday on Bathgate Avenue and a Tuesday woman's group at Holy Rosary.

By late 1985 there were seven more: Rockaway Women on Saturday; Women Addicted in upstate Patterson, one Wednesday night a month; Oceanside Women, a Sunday meeting in Suffolk County; Sheepshead Bay on Saturday on Coney Island Avenue; Women on Wednesday in Park Slope at the same location as Clean

Machine; Women's Step on Saturday at Gracie Square; and a Pomona Women's group on Monday.

Women in 12-Step meetings are told that they are only as sick as their secrets, and if they want to seek recovery and become happy and free they need to reveal those secrets to the light of day. In the exclusive company of women they felt safe enough to do that. "Women came in with shame issues that men do not have. You'll never hear them say I got pregnant and continued to use, continued to sell my body for dope. It's another layer of shame that is truly on a deeper level." Another was fear. A woman who had been sexually abused by a family member said, "The first time a man gave me a hug in a meeting, a perfectly innocent hug as it turned out, I shoved him so hard he fell down. Talk about being mortified."

Sexual abuse was also "not a topic you'd drop on the floor at a meeting where there were men because that would kind of make you a target of predators." Many survivors of abuse started going to women's meetings and realized for the first time that they needed outside help. "No one was talking back then about domestic violence or rape or, God forbid, incest—never—but when I heard other women talk about these things that were too shameful for me even to think about I realized I wasn't alone and it wasn't my fault, and I got help."

Many women who were there at the time talk about the great benefit of finally overcoming their fear and dislike of other women. "We learned how to rely on each other. It didn't matter whether you were black or white or whatever. It was this nurturing that made me stay. That was the beginning of the NA binding. We didn't know what we were doing, but we were all doing it together."

Another important benefit was one they didn't see coming. "There's a self-destructive self-loathing that women drug addicts have. Men have it, too, but it's covered with macho armor. It's got to be more difficult for them. That was a big moment of objectivity for me. I've learned more about men as human beings in NA than in any other part of my life."

Men's Meetings

The first men's group in the New York Region was Just for Tonight, a Wednesday meeting at St. Peter's Church in Yonkers, which first appeared on the June 1983 meeting list but disappears from these documents after May 1984. Nevertheless, Westchester wins this one. The first men's meeting with longevity is Bleecker Street Tuesday at Holy Name Center, where women had their own meeting concurrently across the hall at 8:00 p.m. It first appears on meeting lists in February 1984 and remained at 18 Bleecker Street until the Holy Name Center closed for renovations five or six years after the men's meeting began. The Uptown Men's Group opened its doors in February 1985. A Wednesday night meeting, it still meets at eight o'clock at the Union Settlement House on East 104th Street. The same place where Jackie Robinson's play, *Dope*, was performed in 1951 as part of his campaign against drug racketeering and promoting NA meetings in Harlem, has been the home for 30 years of the oldest NA men's meeting in uptown Manhattan.

Why, women might ask, did men even need a men's meeting back then, when they were so overwhelmingly the dominant culture? For lots of reasons, according to a member of the Uptown Men's Group. "Many of us, especially in East Harlem, grew up with machismo, this exaggerated sense about what men were supposed to be. We were uncomfortable sharing what's really going on underneath that exaggerated ego in the presence of women because of our rearing. When we first came into recovery we couldn't say stuff around women that showed our weakness, especially about sexual issues, like getting raped in prison or molested by a family member."

A history of drug use from an early age was another reason men needed to go to an NA meeting where they didn't feel vulnerable. "My drug history was a big part of my confusion over what to do and not to do. Even if we had fathers, we were so rebellious we didn't know how to live, with or without drugs. It was real important for me to be around older men with recovery who could guide me. I got rid of a lot of pretenses just listening to their

life experiences. A lot of tears shed, a lot of confusion addressed. These men showed me love and support from day one. A lot of them are no longer with us but they still live on through me. They showed me how to give to others what was so freely given to me."

"These meetings were not a peacock contest," according to a member of the downtown men's meeting. "And they weren't a place for women-bashing like they might have thought they were. One of the biggest issues were how to be a husband, raise a family, how to be a father of children from multiple relationships, how to deal with the wreckage of our past, the financial devastation. There's always a solution, even if it's only being patient and tolerant."

Another benefit men experienced from going to these meetings in their early recovery was that "once we've been accustomed to showing our weaknesses at men's meetings we can share anywhere. We're not afraid to be honest about who we are in a mixed meeting. We can dare to take that risk. After a while it feels good to shed the mask and just be real. Just the other day in my home group a newcomer unloaded his pain over trying to reconnect with his kids after getting out of prison. One of the women went up to him afterward and asked him if he'd ever been to a men's meeting. He told her, 'Do you think I could have shared about this if I didn't go to men's meetings?' "

Spanish Meetings

Betty C, who lived in East Harlem, was still counting days in March of 1984, when there were very few Hispanics in the fellowship. "I said to Santos that we needed a meeting in Spanish so all the people could hear the message. Santos said, 'I think we can do it.' " Even then, a 12-Step meeting in Spanish was hardly what you'd call a radical idea. One of the oldest Spanish-speaking AA meetings in the city had been in East Harlem for years. "We started organizing in June. By July, before my 90 days were up, we had our first meeting. When we held elections my husband David was the first chair. He had 80 days. Llegamos was in existence. It means 'We have arrived.' There were six people in the beginning. Soon a good

turnout was thirty."

Scotty A, an NA "old-timer" with four years clean, was also there at the creation. "Out in LA there was a legendary guy named Pepe from South Central, and he did a lot to bring Hispanics into NA. I heard him speak and he really impressed me. It got us talking about how few of us were in the fellowship, and that we had to do something about it ourselves. Starting Spanish meetings became my big thing, when I really got involved. It was Santos's idea. He brought in NA Ray, and NA Ray brought me in. Then came Awilda, Hector, David and Betty, Ralphie and Esther, Reinaldo, and Frank, a Dominican guy who spoke Spanish real well, but these meetings were mostly started by Nuyoricans [New York Puerto Ricans], and they spoke Nuyorican." Scotty A also remembers that first election. "Santos wanted to call the group Ganadores (The Winners) and David said, "No, Llegamos. We've arrived." Llegamos found its first home at Holy Name and met on a Monday night. By October 1984 they sponsored the Region's first H&I meeting in Spanish at the Bernstein Institute at Beth Israel Medical Center.

Translating the literature into Spanish was essential, and it turned out to be a major undertaking. Although World Service had published a Spanish translation of the Little White Book in 1984, word of its availability apparently had not reached the East Coast. According to Betty, "We were able to get people from Colombia and the Dominican Republic who were truly Spanish dominant to translate the slogans and the Serenity prayer into Spanish. Then we formed a committee to discuss translating the other NA literature and all we did was bicker over stuff we didn't know how to resolve. " David C: "I insisted it should have lexicon typical of the Caribbean as opposed to Mexico, Spain, and South America. It was totally unresolvable. Another Spanish meeting that got started around that time was Ganadores, and they said we'll translate. They couldn't do it either." (The two meetings then quite amicably merged into one.)

Eventually World Service got the job done using professional translators. Typically, New York had some opinions about the

outcome. "It's not as meaty as we would like it. To our taste, written Spanish is stilted. Because we are American born, we were used to reading our literature in English, which is more simply written, so when we read it aloud it seemed laden with verbiage that was totally unnecessary, but that's Spanish."

Another problem was objections from non-Spanish trusted servants. Tommy R (Puerto Rican Tommy) recalled how getting approval to start Solamente Today, the first Spanish meeting in Brooklyn, initially met opposition at Area Service. "We had a problem. They said, 'You people are a special interest group. You all know English,' and Jose got real upset with that. I said to myself, they shouldn't have said that to Jose. He used to go around with *Robert's Book of Rules*,[sic] and if anybody knows that book, there's a lot of information there we don't even use because it's too powerful for us. So then Jose got real tacky, real angry, and he was ready to fight. There were about five of us with him and we all stood up, because we weren't all that well and we didn't have much clean time either." Using some pretty objectionable language, Jose insisted that gays were an outside interest group. "We are not. We just speak a different language. Everybody gets a shot at this and we're here to stay. And those statistics about who dies from this disease? We're still number one today."

Santos also got involved in convincing Areas that Spanish meetings were not an outside interest group. "He went back again, more insistent, and they relented. We didn't think we needed permission. Even Area had a lack of understanding. They could have said, 'Why are you asking us for permission? Just start the meeting.'

Solamente Today, a Tuesday bi-lingual meeting at Bergen and Court Streets, first appears on meeting lists in late 1985. A few months later, Aida, Toby, and other members started Unidos Podemos, the first Spanish meeting in the Bronx. Along with something like 30 Spanish meetings in the New York Region, Llegamos, now in East Harlem, is still a big draw, and Unidos Podemos, the first Spanish meeting in the Bronx, is still in the Bronx. But arguments

continue unresolved over the attitude that some trusted servants continue to have that if Spanish-speaking addicts want to get clean "they'd better learn English." The objection to Spanish meetings is particularly strong among convention planners, says one member. "Just last week there was an argument. Twenty-five years later the Latinos up here still have to work hard to get included." For a number of years they have been putting on their own conventions. "People come from everywhere. Years ago we also got together and raised money to start an NA region in Puerto Rico."

"If the Spanish part of the NA story in New York is going to be told," says Scottie, "I want Santos, NA Ray, and Awilda to get some recognition for all the effort they put into it because they're gone, all died from AIDS. I'm grateful I'm still alive, but there's also survival guilt."

LGBT Meetings

The evolution of meetings for lesbians, gays, bisexual, and transgender addicts is evident by the acronym "LGBT" on current New York Regional meeting lists that now encompasses them all (as well as a lack of meetings with names like Getting Straight), but the early eighties were still the Dark Ages for members of this community. In March 1983, the first openly gay trusted servant in the NYCAS, Roger T, started Let It Be at the Elmhurst Baptist Church in Queens, a Wednesday night meeting. It appeared on meeting lists until July 1983 and then disappeared, but the following month the 208 Group, a Tuesday night meeting, opened at the Gay Community Center on 13th Street in the West Village. "I remember that first meeting well. It was very exciting. I think it was the first-ever gay NA meeting anywhere. There were all different kinds of people there, a mishmash - ages, color, bi, trans - just trying to make it through the day."

When it opened, the 208 Group was the only downtown Tuesday night meeting. "Until Eleven Alive at St. Mark's Place opened in October of '84 we all went to that Tuesday night meeting, gay or straight. There was no you-don't-belong-here feeling. We

were welcome." By 1985 the 208 group met four times a week. "There were up to thirty people at the Sunday meeting, sitting in a circle. It's more segregated now, but then people were color blind. It was all about comfort level, a community of men and women who would never have met if we hadn't had the common bond of addiction—I know you and you know me."

The 208 Group was on the 1983 meeting list, an impressive 11-pager listing 55 meetings throughout the Region that was given out at the World Convention, making an official statement, loud and clear, that gay meetings were not only happening in New York City but were sanctioned by the New York Region and labeled as such--"Gay and Lesbian." By no means did the entire New York membership approve, however. For a time the Suffolk/Nassau Area Service (SNAS) printed up their own meeting lists due to rapid growth. "We had gay meetings in Suffolk County but they weren't identified as such or given an asterisk that indicated they were a special interest group. An ad hoc committee was started over the issue. Two of us were on the pro side, that they should be identified, but we were outnumbered by the ones who said they were a Tradition violation. We compromised: no asterisk or label, but the message could be transmitted in the name. One group called themselves Clean Not Straight. They wanted their own meetings but they were fearful of the reaction of the general population if they came to a meeting unawares."

It's easy to forget that not so long ago the American Medical Association officially listed homosexuality as a "disorder." It was also labeled as such in a draft of the *Fourth Step Inventory Guide* that was disapproved by the membership in May 1984 and referred back to the World Service Literature Committee for revision. Clearly, at that time the New York fellowship was on its own in determining what to do about the issue. "Gay addicts, especially newcomers, said they needed these meetings, and who were we to deny them? Although World Service didn't pressure us, they weren't supportive of us either. It's not like we were approaching them and said we were going to start these meetings. We just did it.

There was a specific need."

According to a member of the Board of Trustees at that time, "Gay meetings were continually discussed among the Board members throughout the 1980s, but World never made an official statement on the subject. So nobody can say, 'The World told us.' Generally, the Board of Trustees was more sympathetic than any other body and the World Convention Corporation was the most conservative. For a long, long time they wouldn't allow gay meetings at World conventions."

There was enough evidence of active homophobia within the New York fellowship for trusted servants to make their own decisions. "I remember a group of young men who used to go from business meeting to business meeting to vote against including gay meetings on the meeting list. One of them, a supposed friend, gave me this argument that it's against Tradition. NA is not a social club, he said. I told him if you continue to do what you're doing I'll never speak to you again. And I didn't. For twenty years."

Although this group did not succeed in getting the Region to vote on eliminating the distinction of gay and lesbian meetings, the 208 Group is the only one labeled as such on meeting lists of the early-to-mid 1980s. It may never be known how many of these meetings existed outside of the West Village, which at that time was the world capital of the LGBT community. "There was one group that met on the top floor of a building downtown. The same faces were there—Roger, Ivan, Danny, John. Bobby the haircutter—very loud but so wise. All of them gone."

"The Virus"

In the early 1980s nobody knew what it was, not even medical doctors. "At first it was all about rumors. We heard the Ayatollah was poisoning the poppy fields. Two guys got sick, I went away for three months, and when I came back they were dead. Two guys from one meeting. All we knew was it was some new kind of virus. Then we heard the same thing about another guy and I got a bad feeling in the pit of my stomach that this was only the beginning."

In 1982 medical researchers gave it a name, Gay-Related Immune deficiency, or GRID, but what caused it and how it was transmitted was still a mystery.

Bonnie M from Long Island, who had been the New York City Area secretary since its inception, got sick in January 1983. By June she was in the hospital and the interim secretary noted in the minutes that they voted to send a plant. "Get well, Bonnie, we love you!"

"We went to see her. They made us put masks on, gowns and shoes. I said to Terry, what has she got? 'I don't know.' We knew nothing. Man, it was terrible. She didn't even know who we were. She was one of the first to get the diagnosis. AIDS. She died. Sweet girl. That was the start of it. The media started calling it a disease of gay white men, but that wasn't what we were seeing. Black, white, gay, straight, men, women—they were all getting the virus, and for the first couple of years no one knew what it was. There was unbelievable panic in the rooms. People were paranoid and skittish about everyone else."

They weren't alone. Medical professionals caring for patients suffering from this mysterious disease were also fearful. "Sandy G was the first guy I knew of who died of AIDS, before anybody knew what it was. He called up Bobby M from the hospital and said they won't feed me. So Bobby goes to the hospital wearing a suit, carrying a briefcase, pretended he was a lawyer, and said, 'Who do I have to talk to around here to get my client fed?' He's dead, too."

Finally, in April 1984 came the news that AIDS was caused by the human immunodeficiency virus (HIV), and that the disease was transmitted by blood. "Nobody expected it would hit addicts. It was gay people dying, and we certainly had a lot of gay addicts, but it never crossed our minds that we could get it by sharing needles. At the Thursday night Bleecker Street meeting they posted a hypodermic needle on the wall with a circle and a line going through it. Too late for a lot of us."

"On the one hand was the terror—am I going to be next? A lot of us didn't practice safe sex when we first got clean. On the other

hand, we were struggling, practicing principles, not shunning people we loved."

That year, as the number of cases in New York started to soar, more NA meetings opened at the Gay and Lesbian Center and other places, but homophobia among some IV drug users prevented them from attending. "One guy refused to go there. When he was dying he said that when he left this earth the only thing he wanted to make sure was that no one would think he was gay." Other addicts who had been diagnosed with HIV started sharing about it in their meetings, only to be shut down. Members who didn't have the virus protested that they came to meetings to learn how to stay clean, not how other addicts were dealing with HIV. "It was an issue that was really tearing us apart, very controversial." The other side of the controversy is expressed by a member who had been diagnosed with HIV. "They said you can't talk about AIDS in a meeting because it was an outside issue. Are you crazy? We can talk about shopping and boyfriends but not HIV, a direct result of my using? I thought I had found unconditional love in NA and now I felt pushed away." Whether to hug members who had tested HIV positive was now a moral argument that played out in everyone's minds. "Can I touch this person? We didn't know. We were so freaking petrified, but above and beyond that we didn't want these people to go out."

Fran O decided something had to be done. She and a few others went to Gracie Square Hospital, asked for help, and were given a meeting space for addicts to come and talk about HIV. Then they made an appointment to meet with the doctor who was the head of the AIDS unit for IV drug users at Beth Israel. "I asked her, would you please come and speak to us at Gracie. We're in trouble and we think the trouble's going to multiply. She said she was sorry to disappoint us, but the gay community realized it had a problem and rallied together to try to solve it. 'You addicts have a disease and that disease involves denial, and that denial is going to cost lives.' I told her she didn't know what she was talking about. I was so mad.

"We went to every closed meeting in every borough, got people to help us do it, and when we formed the circle at the end of the meeting we'd ask them to please stay for a minute because we had an announcement that's not NA business. Then we'd announce this thing at Gracie Square."

But the New York Region decided that meeting the need for addicts to talk about this crisis in a sanctioned NA meeting *was* NA business. In addition to the meetings at Gracie and the Gay and Lesbian Center, where talking about the virus had never been an issue, two of the earliest meetings were Living with the Virus at Mercy Hospital in Rockville Centre and Illness to Recovery at Montefiore Hospital in the Bronx. Others followed as the crisis developed into an epidemic. "These were powerful meetings. At that time nobody thought you could survive being positive, let alone having full-blown AIDS. These people were a power of example, a testament to NA. They were going to die and they're staying clean. That made me stay."

In 1985 Mitchell S, then the New York Region's World Service representative, brought up the issue at that year's World Service Conference. "I told them that we had developed special meetings here, and I was shot down by the whole fellowship that AIDS was an outside issue. It took us two years to argue the point that AIDS was not an outside issue for us because in New York it was everywhere. I guess what happened in those two years was it spread to the rest of the world. Everybody got the point."

"Slowly . . . Over Time"

New York being New York, even in our fellowship's infancy we had a clear understanding of the non-hierarchical, upside-down nature of the NA pyramid service structure. In the words of one trusted servant: "We didn't answer to World, World answered to us." As early as June 1984 the New York Regional Service Conference adopted a policy of "recognizing special interest groups: i.e., Spanish speaking, gays, men, women, non-smoking, etc.," and "it

neither endorses nor opposes professional special interest groups." With the inclusion of the "etc." that allowed for the recognition of groups not yet formed, the RSC laid the groundwork for a "big tent" approach to NA in New York that over the years has not changed. The message is clear: all are welcome.

Identification by special interest has evolved since then, however, blurring the lines that once separated the membership: "In the crack house I didn't smoke no gay crack," explains one recovering addict. A member whose home group is a men's meeting has a "dream that once in a while we could ask a panel of women to speak, just to get some balance and a new perspective." Another says his men's group is 30 percent gay men. "We're connected on a deeper level that's not about sexual orientation." A sponsor tells her sponsees that although she values women's meetings, she suggests attending other groups as well. "It's where we can learn to identify with men as fellow human beings." The same deeper connection exists for Spanish meetings. "Ask a Mexican living in a Dominican neighborhood and you get a different spin on what it means to be Spanish speaking. It's not just the language we share. It's more about the culture."

It is clear by these comments that meetings that once separated us have slowly evolved into a focus on addiction and recovery, the special need that unites us. The same can be said for the number of professional groups that started early on, like Artists in Sanity, a Sunday night meeting at St. Mark's Place. A famous musician started a closed meeting that was only known by other professional musicians. A similar meeting was started for performers. There were meetings for Viet Nam vets, meetings for lawyers, doctors, and nurses who worried about losing their jobs as well as their anonymity in an open meeting. Either these groups disbanded or remain invitation-only. "I think what's happened is that addicts have learned to follow the suggestion we heard early on to leave our professions and our degrees at the door."

Group Conscience: "An Unseen Spirit"

Many decisions were made in the early-to-mid 1980s out of a sense of urgency, an atmosphere that is not conducive to the "slowly, over time" approach to understanding the Traditions. "In those days it was simply do what you have to do to keep the doors open and keep meetings alive." Expediency was everything. "We were on a mission from God, like the Blues Brothers. Addicts were dying, and now that we knew the compulsion to use drugs could be lifted, we had to share that or we wouldn't stay clean." But the principle that resisted the compelling urge for the immediate solution was the understanding of group conscience, the mysterious, "spiritual-not-religious" concept that guides decision-making in a 12-Step program.

With great care the AA founders described this spiritual component without employing the word "God" to avoid being perceived by the wary as a "religious cult." A 1954 AA meditation book called *Twenty-four Hours a Day* describes group conscience as being guided by something called "The Great Reality", "an unseen spirit deep down within us." In NA literature of the 1980s the mysterious spiritual-not-religious nature of group conscience at work is called "a dynamic thing—sort of like mercury—that can be felt as it moves and changes during a meeting. . . . When we pin it down, it seems to vanish." In an atmosphere of hostility this elusive element can never be "felt," let alone become a driving force in carrying the message of recovery.

If nothing else is conveyed in this account of our early history that is meaningful today, may it be that our founding members, newly clean, driven by many fears, including a return to the living hell of active addiction, managed to keep the fellowship alive *without* a real grasp of the meaning of group conscience, and how, in spite of their lack of understanding, the "unseen spirit deep down within us" saved the day. And still does.

Group Conscience...A Feeling

"Group conscience is a dynamic thing—sort of like mercury—it always exists. It can be felt as it moves and changes during a meeting. The most obvious example of group conscience seems to be during a meeting while members are sharing and empathy exists, alive in the room. If someone is very honest, group conscience becomes very intense and loving. When someone is full of hot air, group conscience gets bored. The difference is easily felt. One problem with group conscience is that it seems to be sort of shy. When we try to pin it down, it seems to vanish. Like mercury, when we think we can put our finger on it, it moves out of the way. One responsibility of our representatives is to be aware of this conscience above and beyond any votes or decisions the group might make. Perhaps monitoring this intangible group feeling and carrying its message is the hardest thing a Trusted Servant has to do."

(*NA Way*, March 1983)

Chapter 11 Culture Change

In the beginning, the primary drug of choice for most of the addicts in Narcotics Anonymous was heroin. As one member recalls, "... we ran the show. We were manipulators, con artists, and we did what we wanted to do because we didn't have any recovery, no principles. We were about getting clean. We had dope fiends coming to NA from all over and, just by virtue of hanging out with us, they were getting clean. We wanted to shout and holler."

Junkie Elite

The feeling of exclusivity got to a point where some heroin addicts wanted to start a meeting where "if you weren't a hope-to-die dope fiend or a hooker" you couldn't share. They didn't get their way, but the general attitude in the rooms sometimes made it hard for newcomers who didn't shoot dope to identify, or even feel welcome.

"I was a garbage head—angel dust, acid, pills, cocaine. When I came in I felt like I was in a shooting gallery and my story wasn't bad enough. Maybe I didn't belong. Let me go out and get a story and come back."

For some newcomers, this feeling of being in the wrong place was strong: "If you weren't a heroin addict, if you hadn't done time, you were kind of looked down on. I was a heroin addict. Did I have that attitude? Yeah, I'd have to humbly admit I did. How could you be an addict if you hadn't shot heroin?" Not all addicts felt that way, however. Groups started trying to defuse this junkies-only attitude by beginning their meetings with the message that this was Narcotics Anonymous, not Needles Anonymous, and that you didn't have to put a needle in your arm to be a member.

"There was this insane bravado about being a street junkie. These rat bastards, old crusty sons of bitches, could not give up the image. So if you came in and you were taking pills and snorting coke—aw, you know—go out and get some more pain. You bring that into the rooms and it was killing people."

Then outside forces mandated that this early drug hierarchy within the rooms of NA, with the junkies dominating, had to change.

"They Lied to Us"

In 1977, at the height of the era of drug tolerance in the United States, the Carter administration's top expert in drug policy called cocaine "most benign . . . not physically addicting, acutely pleasurable . . .promoting cheerfulness and industry with no negative side effects." Top psychiatrists concurred: "Used no more than two or three times a week, cocaine creates no serious problems."[1] Because of the high cost of this drug, it was also a status symbol, available by the bowlful at parties of the elite where guests snorted lines through rolled-up hundred-dollar bills. Many people went on to freebasing, the more intensely pleasurable form of cocaine in its smoke-able form, as absorption of the drug through the lungs instead of the nose produced a much more potent high.

The era of cocaine as the drug of the terminally hip officially ended on the cover of *Newsweek* in September 1982 with the announcement that cocaine was no longer socially acceptable. On the contrary, quite suddenly it was a highly addictive menace to society. Under the Reagan administration the country had a new drug policy of zero tolerance that was called "Just say no." This about-face, however, was too late for the people who had already become addicted to cocaine, and they felt betrayed: "They lied to us. We bought into the hype that it was a social drug and we went with that until we found out we were in serious trouble."

Pretty soon cocaine addicts started coming to the rooms of Narcotics Anonymous, desperate for a way out. "When I came in

everybody was a dope fiend from the methadone clinic. How could I identify with all these junkies? But I hurt so bad I stayed." Cocaine addicts' identification problems went beyond drug of choice. Because of the high cost of cocaine they made up the minority in the socio-economic mix of NA, but that was changing faster than you can say Cocaine Anonymous. This newly formed fellowship was hard to find, however, so the coke heads with a desperate need to talk about their drug use needed to go to NA, and they did so in numbers that changed the demographics of the rooms. From the street to Wall Street and beyond—teachers, lawyers, financiers, real estate brokers, ad executives, actors and musicians—all kinds of people had come to the conclusion that cocaine was wrecking their lives.

The new crowd also changed the atmosphere in the meetings. A school teacher recalls: "When we came around in 1984 it was the beginning of the coke heads. Most of the members already there were heroin addicts, just quiet, at peace, and all of a sudden you've got all these wired people coming into the meetings and they used to tell us to shut up. We knew nothing about recovery and in reality they were right."

One of those newer members was an investment banker with a six-figure income. "In the late seventies the drug scene I was in was cocaine, heavy-duty use at all levels. It was acceptable in the society I ran in just like drinking was." In fact, it had become more socially acceptable to get high than it was to get drunk, and safer, too, as reliable sources had assured them that cocaine wasn't addictive.

By the time his firm sent him to treatment for alcohol ("If they had deemed me a drug addict they would have fired me") he and his wife, who was also using, were about a million dollars in debt.

His wife got clean first, in AA, "I tried it, but I sought out the guys who said it was okay to use cocaine, so that didn't work. Then, at the end of my run, I found the Bleecker Street meeting and St. Mark's Place... At the beginning, showing up in a Brooks Brothers' suit, custom-made shirt, and hundred-dollar Hermes tie,

I had trouble relating to anybody."

He and his wife became mainstays at the Hicks Street meeting in their neighborhood. "I became the hospitality person... I bought cinnamon sticks and made a wonderful pot of coffee. We had fruit, crackers and cheese, coffee cake, cookies. I stood right by the coffee table because I wanted my ego to be fed. Then I became part of the group. I stopped going to meetings in a suit. I took Area service and then Regional commitments. At first it was because I wanted to be an NA big shot... However, right behind the ego was wanting to use my business background to serve this fellowship in the best possible way."

B.C.: "Before Crack"

"I was a heroin addict for thirty years. It wasn't until I started smoking crack that I realized I had a drug problem."

In those first years, when the primary drug of choice for the majority of NA members was heroin, people in their early twenties were considered the kids, and they tended to use drugs indiscriminately—acid, pills, marijuana, angel dust—whatever high they could afford. "In 1983 there were only three of us who were twenty and we ran together." The baby of the family was fifteen-year-old Willy Z, who had been using since he was seven. He found St. Mark's Place and ended up living there. "My job was to take the garbage out to the pit. Unfortunately, I didn't get warm greetings from everyone. A lot of people didn't believe meetings were for children. Like, how much drugs could I have done? But there were people who told me, 'You know what you did and you're welcome here.' What attracted me to St. Mark's was the people who smiled. I never smiled on the street because there was nothing funny to smile about, but they had a glow about them. 'But I have reservations,' I'd say. 'I'm only fifteen!' They took me for who I was. It was like being a little kid at a big block party. Not only did they know you but they knew you belonged there."

Early on, young people were so rare at meetings they stood out. Cocaine users were also in the minority compared to the number of recovering heroin addicts. Crack changed that demographic in a hurry.

In the early 1980s a drug ring in San Francisco began selling a smoke-able form of cocaine called "crack" to street gangs in South Central LA at bargain-basement prices. Crack was powdered cocaine mixed with water and baking soda, baked into a rock, then "cracked" into small pieces that could be smoked in a pipe. The absorption of cocaine through the lungs was much more effective than snorting it in powder form through the nose, producing an instant high that was as intense as freebasing but without the danger of having it blow up in the user's face. Crack soon spread like wildfire across the country, especially in large cities.[2]

In August of 1984 politicians and the media finally figured out what was going on and announced that there was a crack epidemic of major proportions. "It slammed into New York like a Mack truck out of control," said Senator Charles Schumer, "because we didn't see it coming."[3] The reality was that crack had been on the street for years, but by '84 there was so much cocaine coming into the country that the price had plummeted even further. Marketing crack had become big business. It was immensely profitable, easily produced in a kitchen, sold at "ghetto market prices"—as little as two dollars a hit—and suddenly it was everywhere in New York City. "I was part of that first wave of crack heads. I started using it in '82, around the time Richard Pryor burned his face up freebasing, but it was not like freebasing. The urgency wasn't the same when I freebased. Maybe crack was cut with speed or something. All I know is the urgency came two minutes *before* you took the first hit. You were already thinking, oh shit, what do I do when this is gone? It was irresistible, and it was impossible to stop. Take one hit and you were in that crack spot until your money was gone and they threw you out."

The crack epidemic played a big part in the explosive growth of NA throughout the 1980s and beyond. Heroin addicts could use

for years before hitting their bottom. Crack addicts could crash and burn in six months. "Hitting bottom was real quick, like falling down an elevator shaft." Even recovering cocaine addicts had a hard time wrapping their minds around how powerfully addictive crack was and how quickly it could bring users to their knees. "I tried to relate, but crack was in its own category. They came in whipped, much younger, with a nonexistent attention span, pacing so bad they couldn't even sit down. They needed to talk with people who had the experience, and in the beginning there weren't many. It was so hard to help them, harder even than helping people on methadone."

The difficulties NA members had with crack users caused some of them to re-examine their experiences trying to get clean in AA. "I had been really pissed off at AA because of their attitude toward me as a heroin addict. When the crack epidemic started a lot of things became clear to me. Number one, that people in AA were concerned for the survival of their fellowship, and here I was all of a sudden feeling like they did."

In a strange way crack also became a unifying factor in breaking down the hierarchy of the junkie elite. "When I came in dope fiends dominated everything, and they were a lot older than us. There was a whole crew of young cats under 25. The dope fiends were over there talking about eye droppers and balloons and two-dollar bags. We were the deadheads, grown-up boys who smoked weed and dropped acid, go to meetings and spend all night playing video games. We felt segregated. But when the crack heads came in we signed up with the dope fiends because we realized the crack heads were crazy. I used to go around saying, 'I'm a B.C. guy – before crack.' But by that time we'd been there long enough to identify, to see past their insanity and carry the message of recovery."

Famous People Can Get Clean, Too

Gene G was a drug counselor in the Breakthrough program on the fourth floor at Gracie Square. Before that he was a drug counselor at

ENTER and one of the eleven founders of Life Begins Again. Before that he was a musician who got clean in AA. Chris J: "Gene was my sponsor, one of the greatest people I ever met, the most genuine and true in regards to recovery. Every other thing with him was 'Watch Harvey.' That was his code word for drugs. He was a drummer, and he sponsored a lot of well-known musicians or got them into Gracie because he could show them that you could play without drugs. I used to carry the drums into the set for him and met a whole lot of guys that had issues with drugs. Until he died about fifteen years ago from a liver ailment, Gene was *the* recovery guy for the musicians." The same could be said for Michael B downtown at Bleecker Street. "We'd find ourselves sitting next to someone whose record albums we had at home, and it was Mike who brought them in."

Seeing famous musicians, artists, actors, and comedians at meetings became part of the draw: "Wow, this is pretty fucking cool. These cats are getting it too. That made you feel like you weren't alone on an iceberg just drifting along, because there was nothing stable back then. No guarantees whatsoever."

It would be a while before the subject of celebrities going in and out of rehabs became a regular feature on the gossip news, but at that time, if the word got out that an entertainer used drugs it could kill a career. Celebrities were taking a risk just by showing up at a meeting, but they did it because that's where recovery was. One of them showed his gratitude at a fund-raiser and dance at St. Malachy's by putting a check for a thousand dollars in the basket. "There was a big discussion. We gave it back." Protecting their anonymity was another Tradition that was followed with extreme vigilance. "I was chairing at Morningside and three celebrities showed up at one time—two musicians and a movie actress. Afterward someone said, all excited, 'Did you know who they were?' I said sure. 'Why didn't you say something about it?' I said because they're here for the same reason we are. So don't tell anyone about it, you hear? They deserve a greater anonymity than we do because they're going to be recognized."

Many years later, a singer-songwriter with a household name who got clean in New York City meetings in the eighties was featured in a PBS special. At one point an interviewer got right in his face: "You used to have a big drug problem, didn't you?" Keeping his anonymity intact, he replied quietly, "I've been in recovery for 24 years." That phrase, "in recovery," has become a code for "one of us," and the fellowship continues to protect his anonymity. That's why "What you see here, what you hear here, please leave it here" will often be heard in the rooms of Narcotics Anonymous.

One Program, One Disease

Age, life style, economic status, drug of preference—the many forms that diversification took after WCNA 13 was a turning point in the New York fellowship, and it was about a lot more than growth. The flood of people coming into meetings with drug problems of all kinds opened the door to a deeper understanding of the meaning of addiction—that it wasn't about the drug. Pot heads had a particularly hard time reaching that understanding—"You say you're here because you smoke weed?"—but if they kept showing up, marijuana smokers often heard a story that made them feel like they, too, really belonged in NA.

> I was a teenager who basically jumped off a cliff and hit bottom very quickly on pot. I was telling my story at St. Malachy's, and this guy we called the Silver Fox was there, probably the oldest guy coming into NA at the time. I had listened to his story and cringed at the things he'd been through. He comes up to me afterward and says, "It didn't even occur to me until I heard your story tonight that we hit the same bottom." I looked at him like he was nuts and said there's no way we hit the same bottom. And he tapped me on my chest and said, "Yes we did. Here. You just knew sooner than I did. I spent thirty years on the street. That's the only

difference." He did more to keep me clean than anyone else, that one moment.

But the transformation of the drug culture that was happening went well beyond what we used to who we were. "Bikers, blacks, Latinos, Wall Street types, teachers, truck drivers, Park Avenue pill-poppers, famous people, street people, wise old junkies, teenage stoners and crack heads, it didn't matter. I was one of them and they were one of me, and it was magical."

Going to Extremes

For addicts, the middle ground is a foreign land. Now consider a bunch of self-described manipulating con artists banding together, newly clean, mostly young, without predecessors to guide them, the vast majority doing Step work with each other like the blind leading the blind, new to the slow-understanding-over-time of the Traditions, whose idea of a group conscience is putting together a posse and crashing another group's business meeting, who yesterday had internalized society's view of them as gutter scum, and today are hanging out with celebrities. There's no doubt that diversity was our strength, but with what was coming down the pike due to the addict's propensity for extreme thinking and behavior, we were going to need it—badly.

The NA Police

In 1984 the first *Purist Newsletter* came out, published by some NA members in California who had formed a group to purge the fellowship of "AA jargon," particularly the use of the word "sobriety," and identifying oneself as an "and-a" (an addict and an alcoholic) as Jimmy K did, to a chorus of mild boo's, when he spoke at the World Convention in New York. In his book, *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous*, World Service office manager Bob Stone describes how the influence of this highly vocal group was spreading throughout the fellowship and made a prediction:

"Because so many members had used these words for a long time, a bloody fight was to come."[4] He was right.

Looking back on the first wave of language controversy, some NA members are philosophical: "NA was so young. The purists were trying to establish an identity that was separate from AA, and carving that out in the beginning was difficult what with the availability and convenience of going to AA meetings. I understand the feeling people have that they want it to be just NA." Others defend it: "Why get upset about their strictness? AA strictness forced you to NA. Wake up!"

Still others saw red: "The vigilantes from California started coming to meetings and telling us we weren't NA. They tried to get the whole country to march with them, and some people here jumped on the band wagon. I started hearing stuff like, 'If you make fifty percent NA and fifty percent AA you've got a hundred percent of nothing.' Bring all that anger and fear into meetings, that if you don't do it my way I'm gonna use again, and everybody feels uncomfortable, and newcomers feel inadequate because they're told they're not doing it the right way."

One member recalled an incident that happened thirty years ago and got angry all over again: "I was the speaker at Horizons, the first Step meeting group in New York City, while I was still going to Clean and Dry. Somebody yelled out, 'He's from AA. He can't speak here.' After all the NA meetings I'd help start, boy, did I have a resentment. NA was doing exactly what AA did! We didn't learn shit!"

The purist movement still exists, although the vehemence is not as extreme as it was in the early days. Now the typical approach is to inform newcomers in private that we have "a language all our own." Nevertheless, the zealots are still out there. A member forty years clean laughed about recently being asked to leave a meeting by a member of the NA police. "I said I was clean and sober and one of these kids with four years asked me to leave. I just cracked up laughing. I've been thrown out of a lot of places, but I'm not going to get thrown out of an NA meeting. The madness is still there."

Inflated Egos and Bullies Behaving Badly

A number of trusted servants who struggled through the era of explosive growth are convinced that "the New York Region is alive today because so many power-hungry people were keeping each other in check. I can't begin to explain how nasty we could be. Each one wasn't going to let the other get away with anything. You needed that power in the room because otherwise the biggest bullies would have run rampant. And the women were just as powerful as the men."

Nevertheless, it was a struggle to keep people with clean time around because of all the craziness. "We had an expression—"Five years and out"—about members who left NA and joined another fellowship. Maybe we were all just expressing our feelings because we didn't have recovery to talk about. Or maybe when people got some sanity in their lives they didn't want to put up with our insanity anymore."

A shift in priorities was another reason. "What drove me out was the star personalities. It was no longer about getting to the meeting early to make sure the coffee was ready on time. Now it was about California and going on the speaker circuit. It was one thing to feel manipulated or bullied, but this other stuff was more devious. It was icky, and it was dragging me down."

Another recalls the exact moment he was done. "A guy I'd known since he was detoxing off methadone in that grimy, unheated basement at Back to Life told me he could get me a seat at the executive table at the convention. I told him, 'You know what? Not for me.' This is an ego-deflation program. I thought, this is where we part company."

Power, greed, lust for attention, nasty personality clashes—the many character defects of addicts in early recovery were frequently on display for all to see, especially in business meetings, and it wasn't pretty. Maybe it was inevitable: "We grew ahead of ourselves. Recovery is a day at a time. The number of people with clean time changed at the same rate, a day at a time, while people kept pouring out of treatment centers, all needing sponsors when

we were only just starting to get a handle on our own recovery."

The scarcity of people with a solid foundation in the NA Steps and Traditions became a big problem, and it seemed to be unique to New York at that time. Unlike other states with well-established fellowships, New York simply didn't have NA old-timers who could provide guidance for the mass influx of newcomers, although it did benefit from members who had gone to AA specifically to get that foundation. "We were not a bunch of newcomers trying to figure it out by trial and error, thanks to AA. I'm sure I wasn't the only one to tell sponsees not to go near Area or Region or do any service on that level. My mantra was, without a good understanding of the Steps, that level of service was a playground for egos, an anti-humility environment." The only problem was that these members with some clean time who had received a good understanding in AA were vastly outnumbered by newcomers. "In a typical meeting, when the secretary asked how many people were counting days, nine out of ten raised their hands." Many sponsors did group Step work with their sponsees, "not ideal, but the only way I could manage, having so many." It was a situation that only the passage of time could resolve.

But New York was not the only fellowship undergoing severe growing pains. Bob Stone also observed it on the World Service level, which was coping with the phenomenal growth of the entire fellowship—an incredible one hundred percent increase in the number of meetings between 1984 and 1985. He described the actions of what he called "the standing minority," a strident group that became an ever-present obstacle to conducting business: "People and things they could not control or intimidate became the objects of vicious attacks. . . . Seemingly, with clear conscience and intent, they would decide that the things they did were indeed at the direction of God and not their own choosing. It had been some time since I had met people who communicated directly with God. I knew these were going to be interesting times."[5]

Approaching the mid-eighties, it was clear that something was affecting NA as a whole, a phenomenon that was more apparent

at service levels beyond the groups, where the focus still remained primarily on the next suffering addict who walked in the door. But why *then*, and why everywhere? "I have a theory," said a member who had commitments on many levels of service, from Area to Region to World. "Before this whole period in our history you got slapped right down if you tried to mess with this fellowship in any way, shape, or form, and you didn't bring any of your own personal agenda in. Selfless service—I can always remember this good feeling, and what a great bedrock it was. I think what eventually happened was, as people became more assured that this thing was going to work, now was the time we could play around with our character defects."

The situation was the downside of rapid growth. Burned out, spread thin, so big it had begun to splinter, the New York fellowship found itself in an epic struggle between self-will and spiritual principles, in danger of tearing apart what had recently, and with enormous effort, been cobbled together.

Chapter 12 "Indivisible"

"Some of our most painful growing experiences have come as a result of decisions made in the name of group conscience. True spiritual principles are never in conflict; they complement each other."

--*Tradition Two,* Basic Text

As New Yorkers, we know how to take a stand against adversity. In this early period, we went through many growing pains about how to conduct business and deliver service. We struggled to work our way through many issues, such as HIV decimating our membership, the H&I Can, methadone, special interest meetings, and differing interpretations of group conscience. In spite of these struggles, in spite of our lack of experience, it seemed we could do no wrong. Every challenge was met, and the result was explosive growth. In the process we also underwent another kind of growth, which was a deeper understanding of the principles that are the spiritual foundation of the Narcotics Anonymous program.

The acceleration of this growth began with the development of the service structure. In September 1982, after New York won the bid at the Milwaukee World Convention to host WCNA 13, Roger T was having a conversation with Leah A and George H from Florida, who were both serving on the World service level at that time. Leah: "All of a sudden Roger thinks it's a perfect time to start the New York Region. I said to him, 'What the fuck is wrong with you? Let these kids focus on the convention.' But he was insistent. It wasn't a question of too soon, it was too much. Let's do one thing at a time."

Such is not the addicts' nature. Their standard operating procedure for getting things done is more likely to be the same

as their approach to using drugs: "Let's do it all and let's do it all right now." From the beginning, when the New York fellowship was barely a blip on the radar, that attitude had prevailed. Compounded by a real sense of urgency that addicts were dying because they didn't know about NA, it created both excitement and agitation, conflict and concord, during this turbulent period of rapid expansion.

Birth of a Region

Several months after Leah's and George's strongly worded advisement to Roger, he moved to New York City and become an active member of New York City Area Service (NYCAS). Charming and brilliant as well as persuasive,[1] he joined forces with the members who had been pressing for a year that New York City Area Service become a Region. In keeping with their preferred M.O. of "Damn the torpedoes, full speed ahead," at the January 1983 meeting (when the fellowship still consisted of a single Area with 24 groups), NYCAS voted to propose to the groups to create three Areas—MBSI (Manhattan, Brooklyn, and Staten Island); Queens/ Long Island; and Bronx/Upstate. They then voted in a committee that would formulate Regional procedures and elected Roger to a newly created position, Regional Service Representative (RSR), to become the voice of the as-yet-to-be New York Region at the World Service Conference (WSC). Although the 1983 WSC would not meet for another four months, where a Region could be officially seated, they even set a date of August 13th for holding its first formative meeting.

At the May 1983 World Service Conference, the body voted unanimously to recognize New York as a bona fide Region of Narcotics Anonymous,[2] and three months later the first meeting of the Regional Service Conference was held as scheduled in Long Beach. By the end of that conference the Region had expanded to four Areas, creating another major shuffling in responsibilities: Bronx-Upstate became Metro North. Queens and Long Island became separate Areas, and Long Island renamed itself Suffolk-Nassau

Area Service (SNAS). They also voted in six Regional officers (the Regional Steering Committee) and ten standing committee chairs. Then, seventeen days later, the Convention Committee hosted the wildly successful WCNA 13. The rapidity with which our fellowship was evolving was breath-taking. Only those members in the thick of the action could not foresee that the speed with which all of this was happening was going to contribute to conflict once the dust settled.

Still, becoming a Region, with designated committees responsible for serving the Areas, as well as the groups popping up all over the place that had yet to become part of an Area, provided immediate benefits to the fellowship by meeting a number of pressing needs. Paramount among them was creating a unifying structure for H&I committees already operating across the Region. Some of them had been functioning in the dark for over a year, bringing meetings into hospitals, prisons, and jails without NA sanction, and they were calling out for guidance.

Hospitals and Institutions (H&I)

In May 1982 Gracie Square, a psychiatric hospital at 420 East 76th Street, became the fellowship's first Area-sanctioned Hospitals and Institutions meeting, but before that there was Breakthrough, an alcohol treatment program at the hospital run by Monica Wright and Laverne W, and among the first addict patients Laverne W counseled was Frankie G. "He was one of our first NA guys. I remember his hands, like boxing gloves from injecting so much dope."

In a tape-recorded convention speech Frankie G later described how it all began: "Weekends in rehab were blue. The counselors were gone and there was nothing to do. I saw them leave on Friday—these addicts who were recovering other people, dressed sharp, talking about jazz—and they came back on Monday looking and feeling good. How could this be? My counselor said, 'You don't ever have to have drug-related problems in your life

ever again if you don't pick up when you leave this hospital.' That was my spiritual awakening. If you don't pick it up. Nothing more profound than that have I ever heard."

When Frankie G got discharged Laverne W encouraged him to go to the Clean and Dry meeting at Roosevelt Hospital. "He fell in love with it. Boom—he made a connection. Then more drug people began to come to Gracie through Frankie and others and we started the first H&I meeting, bringing NA on to the unit. We had a captive audience there and it worked out pretty good."

Frankie G and Randee Sue P made the first New York NA H&I presentation at Gracie: "Frankie and I went up there to tell them what NA was, and it was kind of heavy. We never had anything to do with authorities, and here we were, talking to people with degrees. But it was cool. They loved it. That's how the hospital meetings got started and they're still running today."

After this uncertain beginning, when New York City Area Service was all of six months old, and the *H&I Handbook* was still an idea under heated discussion at the World Service H&I Committee, addicts started coming to NA meetings straight from the hospital, prison, or jail, with their suitcases or clothing in a plastic bag, and getting a hit of what the *Basic Text* calls "the magic of a single exposure to NA."

Meetings at VA hospitals in Brooklyn and the Bronx soon followed, although these first attempts were short-lived. Then, in the late summer of 1982, a meeting opened at the Nassau County Jail. It was started by Bonnie M and Buddy K from the Surrender group, and they made frequent trips to Gracie for literature and information. An H&I meeting that used NA literature at Brunswick Hospital in Amityville was also in operation that summer, but it had yet to be Area sanctioned.

These early meetings were put together without guidance from members with solid NA H&I experience because "there weren't any," at least not locally. Gina S's first commitment was in October 1983 at Gracie Square when she was five and a half months clean. Roger T, the first Regional H&I chair at that time, asked her

to chair the Saturday night meeting at Gracie Square. "He said he couldn't do it anymore. He handed me a couple of *White Books* and said, 'Go to Gracie every Saturday night at 7:30.' There were no presentations, no panel meetings or training sessions. You just showed up." For the meeting that Christmas Eve she got permission from Laverne to bring soda and chips to the unit. "There was a guy on 79th Street selling little table-top Christmas trees. I told him where I was going and he gave me a half dozen trees in a box. That's how we did service then. No policy or committees. Our hearts were in it. Everyone's hearts were in it."

Running on eagerness to serve and not much else, was also true north of the city. Joe A in Rockland remembers bringing a meeting into a detox in Liberty Hospital when he had 90 days. "It wasn't officially H&I but people had the enthusiasm to go." But the lack of guidance also had the potential of doing real damage to the fellowship, especially in developing relationships with correctional officials. Tuki D remembers a man who was there early on, operating on his own. "He chaired some meetings in correctional facilities, very enthusiastic about NA, and then he disappeared. Why we needed structure."

Lack of experience also could be potentially dangerous. Tommy R: "Everything was word-of-mouth. Curley asked me to chair a meeting at Arthur Kill in Staten Island. I walked in and there were seventy five addicts in the room. I introduced myself and said I was an addict and then we went around the room and they all said they were dealers. I said, 'You mean the only dope fiend here is me?' That was my first experience. We didn't know shit. We didn't know how dangerous it was to have seventy five convicts and one officer in the room, but we learned fast because everything was taught by mistakes."

The same lack of policy and structure beleaguered H&I committee members serving in hospitals. They struggled with so many unanswered questions. Bob Stone: "Patients started asking about the propriety of staff conducting meetings, which happened too often back then, where they'd be taking notes about what patients

said and then counseling them afterward. . . . Should hospital staff even be allowed to participate in these meetings, where they could give feedback and even misuse the NA concept to accomplish their own treatment needs?"[3] Another big question with no easy answer was how to carry the message to patients on medication, especially the heavily medicated criminally insane. "There was an urgent need for a publication, an approved set of guidelines, and out of that slowly evolved the idea to write a handbook for H&I." That task was given to Bob B, then World Service H&I chair.

"Bob quickly put together a draft, but more input was needed from addicts formerly in institutions." At the 1982 World Service Conference "Bob's committee had collected tremendous amounts of information from addicts around the nation . . . a tremendous success in organizing disjointed H&I efforts."[4] Unfortunately, development of these much-needed tools, the *H&I Handbook* and a pamphlet called *Do's and Don'ts*, a service guide, would take three more years before they were fellowship approved.

In the meantime, Bob B traveled the country, visiting local H&I chairs and discussing problems. One of the areas that had the greatest concentration of need was upstate New York, with its massive prison population. There H&I far outweighed any other service, but according to John M, "For a while we had a hard time keeping people committed. We lost Sing Sing for not showing up. But we got Otisville, which I think was the first federal prison we got into in New York State, and they called *us*. We did so much better once we had structure."

In Nassau-Suffolk the Area H&I committee found themselves inundated with requests from the many psychiatric hospitals in the two counties. Buddy K: "I knew the director of Brunswick. He called me up and wanted us to start an H&I meeting there and the word started spreading. Smithtown General, South Oaks, Nassau County Medical—none of these hospitals had a drug program." Then the Long Island Correctional meeting started to explode, "eighty-five guys on a Friday night," according to Butch S. When it got to the point where SNAS didn't have enough committee

members to service all these meetings, they held a "people-raiser."

Bob B, the World Service H&I chair, also circulated a handbook for H&I service, still in draft and informally called the "red book," which he made available to local H&I chairs because of their desperate need. One of them was Betsy N, who became chair of the Regional H&I Committee of the New York Region in January 1984, and started introducing some structure. Until that time there had been little or no communication between Region and Areas, and virtually none at all among the Area H&I committees, or even a comprehensive list of all the meetings operating in the Region. The February Regional minutes of the H&I committee report for the first time the total number of meetings being served—28.

A complete listing of hospitals and institutions appears for the first time on the back page of the October 1984 meeting list, indicating that the number of meetings had doubled in eight months. The Region now held monthly meetings where Area H&I representatives gathered to discuss problems and how to resolve them. They also had received Bob B's invaluable "red book," and were able to formulate temporary guidelines and training sessions for members who wanted to take on an H&I commitment. "People fought to get on these commitments, and to get one you really got grilled."

The H&I Can

In 1984 a single Area, SNAS, spent $3,000 on H& I literature, of which $426 was for meeting lists so that addicts could successfully navigate the make-or-break transition from the confines of a hospital or penal institution to the nearest NA meeting. At ten cents a copy, that translates into 4,260 meeting lists distributed by a single Area in a single year.[5] For the work of any H&I committee, the high cost of providing literature had always been the number-one hurdle, which was resolved by passing what was called the H&I can in addition to passing the Seventh Tradition basket at NA meetings. The can became official at the 1980 WSC, where after much debate

it was finally approved. "Bob B, jubilant in his victory, raised his red-covered can and, shaking it loudly, proclaimed, 'Okay, you m-f's, here's your first chance to put your money where your mouth is!' and started it around the room."[6] Not everyone agreed with passing the can, complaining about lack of accountability over large amounts of money, but it certainly solved the problem.

From three H&I meetings in May 1982 to seventy six in May 1985—in a span of three years this small, struggling, overextended fellowship made that happen. In another two years that number was 400. How many suffering addicts were saved from the horrors of addiction in these institutional meetings may never be known, but many became active members of NA, joined H&I committees, and were glad to give back what had been so freely given. Craig S was one of them. "I do H&I service to this day. It's what brought me in."

H&I Meetings: A Countdown

This list, compiled from Area and Regional minutes,[7] tells the story better than anything else we could write about the work of countless, dedicated, trusted servants in establishing H&I meetings in the Greater New York Region from May 1982 to May 1985.

May 1982: Gracie Square, Brooklyn VA, Bronx VA (closed February 1983)

August 1982: Nassau County Jail, East Meadow

February 1983: St. John's Hospital, Far Rockaway

May 1983: Nassau County Work Release Program, East Meadow; Cumberland Hospital, Brooklyn; Bernstein Institute of Beth Israel, Manhattan

July 1983: Bridge Plaza Treatment and Rehab Clinic, Long Island City; Bone and Joint Disease Hospital, Manhattan, Gracie Square Saturday night

February 1984: Regents Hospital, Manhattan; Red Cross, Jay Street, Brooklyn

April 1984: Queensboro Correctional Facility, Long Island City

July 1984: Mid-Hudson Psychiatric, New Hampton; Creedmore State Hospital, Queens; Vietnam Vet's Outreach Center, Jamaica

September 1984: Otisville Homeless Shelter; Brooklyn Correctional; Reality House, Manhattan; Edgecomb Dept. of Correction Work Release, Manhattan; Pilgrim State Hospital, Brentwood; South Oaks Hospital, Amityville; St. John's Psychiatric, Smithtown; Brunswick Psychiatric

October 1984: Bernstein now has six meetings. Green Hope House, Project Contact, Metropolitan Hospital, and Bayville Correctional, Manhattan; Brooklyn Veterans Outpatient Drug Treatment; Bayville Correctional, Staten Island; United Hospital Substance Abuse Unit (three), Port Chester; Beacon Correctional; Mid Orange Correctional, Warwick; Long Beach Memorial; Pilgrim State, Brentwood

November 1984: Riker's Island; Damon House, Brooklyn; Bernstein Spanish meeting; South Beach Psychiatric, Staten Island, Nassau County Medical Center

December 1984: Hospital for Joint Disease Wednesday meeting; Smithers, Manhattan

March 1985: Brooklyn Navy Yard Brig; Montefiore Hospital, Burnside, Prospect Halfway House, and Lincoln Drug Abuse Center, Bronx; Rikers Island Women's meeting; Queensboro Correctional (second meeting); Harris Hospital; Beacon Correctional; Downstate Correctional, Fishkill; Goshen; Putnam County; Napanock Annex; Rockland County Jail, Rockland State; Harlem Valley; Bedford Hills Correctional

April 1985: Brooklyn Men's Shelter; Bernstein Sunday Night; Bathgate Halfway House, Bronx; North Shore Hospital; Riverhead Jail; Rikers C-95 and C-96

May 1985: Bernstein now has ten meetings, seven days a week; Gracie Square has five. Manhattan House of Detention (The Tombs) and Su Casa (Spanish), Manhattan; St. Barnabas Hospital, Women's Halfway House, Bronx Psychiatric Center, and Holy Apostle Halfway House, Bronx; Westchester County Penitentiary (now three meetings), Valhalla; Middletown State Hospital; Veritas Villa, Kerhonkson; Hope House, Amityville; Glen Cove Community Hospital, Middletown State Hospital, Harris Hospital.

The First Public Information Committee

The acronym "PI" stood for "public information," but during the era of Just Say No it also stood for "public image." One of the many successful projects of New York Region's first PI Committee was producing a public service announcement for television. It was called the "best of the lot"[7] of four PSAs that the World Board of Trustees had commissioned in 1984 to provide a much-needed vehicle to change the image of addicts as they were typically portrayed on TV. The media preferred a sensational "scare them straight" approach, with images of addicts in a state of degradation and misery, rather than the "less sexy" depiction of the promise of addicts in recovery through NA.

Since the 1983 World Service Conference the trustees, headed by its PI Committee chair, had been working on developing a public service video that would change that image. The chair had found NA members who worked in the TV business to help them, but the trustees were not very happy with their submissions, finding they "strained the traditions" and were "less professional" than they required. The search went on into 1984, an election year, and the anxiety over finding the right vehicle increased.

> Politicians and media executives were using drug addicts as a way to get attention. It didn't matter to them at all what the repercussions such notoriety had on the addicts' prospect for recovery . . . [and] the media didn't care about or understand anonymity. In fact, it was against their perceptions of what was important in a story. Reporters wanted the drama and the emotion of the using addicts. We would not consent to be part of those kinds of stories. Public Information committee members across the country were being confronted by reporters. Every day we were being called for advice. We couldn't control what local PI folks did, but we gave as much advice as we could.[8]

New Yorkers lived in a city where the sight of TV network trucks barreling in on the scene of the latest catastrophe was an everyday occurrence. New York Regional PI Committee members were already cynical about the motives of the television media, and needed no advice about approaching the cameras with caution. Matt from Brooklyn remembers when Don Johnson, a popular newscaster from ABC local television news, came out to the STAR group, ready to beam in on something controversial. "He came down because we were the new boys on the block. We were in conflict with another group at the time, I think it was Day Top, which had drinking privileges, so he wanted the story. We said, 'We can't get into that. You know what AA is?' He said yes. We said, 'Well, we're the same thing. We don't touch anything, no drinks, no drugs, no nothing, and we don't knock anything. So we can't give you a story.' He appreciated that." Instead, ABC did a story on drinking privileges at Day Top. "Kid's coming home, getting drunk on the weekend, and in three weeks he's got the needle back in his arm. Those TCs actually changed some of their rules after that. They said no more drinking privileges." That's called media savvy.

The first Regional PI chair was Frankie G, and he ran a tight

ship. After a *New York Times* reporter came to a closed NA meeting to interview addicts Frankie sent out brisk announcement to all Area services for distribution to all their groups: "There are still many members who feel they are the voice of NA and refuse or are ignorant of the fact there is a PI Committee. Can PI please be handled by the PI Committee and not by well-meaning addicts?"

In the beginning, radio was the preferred media outlet because it protected addicts' anonymity. Frankie produced and read the first radio public service announcement (PSA) in August 1983, shortly after the formation of the Region. The PI committee carefully selected music stations like WNEW and WPLJ, the African American-owned WLIB, or WBAI, the Pacifica network's progressive voice in New York City. "We knew where addicts went for their music and their news." The response to these stations' continual broadcasting of the hot line phone number was also gratifying. After WBAI interviewed a PI member, the hotline "had a flood of calls the next day." Early on, the committee took a conservative approach to video PSAs out of concern that they would bring in an influx of new people. "We were scared that if we let them know that NA is here that we wouldn't have the numbers to give them the service they needed. We were not set up for that yet, so when we first put PSAs on TV, a video cassette produced by the New Jersey fellowship, we showed them late at night, like two or three in the morning, and still the membership blew up."

The media spots also resulted in a flood of responses from groups and institutions that wanted to know more about NA—not just hospitals but high schools and colleges, substance abuse centers, industrial rehabs, police precincts, therapeutic communities, City employee counselors, clergy curious about this "spiritual program," psychotherapy centers, block associations, the United Way, the Lower East Side Community Council—and the PI Committee soon faced the same problem as did the H&I Committee of too few members to meet all the requests.

Frankie G brought in two of his sponsees, Bob P and Bob W, and trained them well. Bob P: "We'd go to presentations with

Frankie and watch him do it. We brought in other people and got PI going in the Areas. I made people with nine days come in and lick envelopes. I'd say, listen, you'll be good at this. Don't worry, I'll help you. We'd bring them along, take them on presentations." When Frankie stepped down Bob P became the chair. "I did it for 12 years. When we did presentations we loved to bring a panel of people of all different races, different religions, Tommy L with his yarmulke, to show people that everybody needed Narcotics Anonymous. People went wow, this must be pretty good. We were so committed." One of the presentations was to the United Nations Mission of the Islamic Republic of Iran, a prophetic choice. In time Iran would become the fastest-growing NA fellowship on earth.

In late 1984, after many months of searching for a PSA announcement that met the guidelines they had worked so hard to establish, the World Board of Trustees started viewing a number of videos and scripts for consideration. One was sold by Hazelden, which they found "offensive to our traditions," and they had "various objections" to other contestants from local PI committees. They finally agreed on a script, then began a search for production companies, and selected four PSAs to underwrite for a screening at the April 1985 World Service Conference. Two were from California ("not as good as we hoped") and the other two were from New York. One was a computer graphic of the *Basic Text*, and the other depicted a woman writing at a kitchen table as a camera on a crane circled around her and a voice was heard reading from the *Basic Text*. According to Bob Stone, it was "most dramatic . . . the best of the lot . . . wildly applauded. It contributed to considerable improvement in our public image, a key element in bringing many addicts to meetings."[9]

The New York Region's PI Committee had made some important image choices. One was portraying a woman. Even though addiction was an equal opportunity disease, female addicts were a target audience because they were still so reluctant to come to NA. The second choice was not portraying the woman as drug-addled and staggering down the street but at a table, engaged in

a practice unique to Narcotics Anonymous—to write-write-write your way into recovery—reading, consulting a dictionary, and then writing some more, guided by what was then a photocopied makeshift version of what would one day become the *Step Working Guide.* And then there was that powerful voiceover delivering a calm and meaningful passage from NA's own "Big Book," *Narcotics Anonymous*, commonly known as the *Basic Text.* New York's winning PSA delivered a message of recovery that was spiritual, inspired, and—let's not be so modest here—spectacular.

The Policy Committee

"As our trust in a Higher Power grows, it gets easier to let go of our personal desires and stop fighting for what we want."
– Tradition One, It Works How and Why, *p. 13.*

Of all the areas of contention in this early history of the New York fellowship, establishing policy was the hands-down winner. For some issues nothing has changed: The controversy over methadone maintenance that flared up when New York NA was three months old is still being debated today, along with all the new pharmaceuticals that pose the same problem—are addicts clean or not clean, using or not using, when they take these prescribed drugs? Establishing policy about thorny issues is particularly difficult on the group level, especially in New York where there's high rent to pay for that extra half hour or more after the meeting, or the next group scheduled to use the space is knocking at the door. "We didn't have the luxury of time." To this day, some groups never reach the point where they have a written policy, and others struggle for years trying to change it. "There's no time for discussion about abstract matters like policy at our business meetings. We've got too many fires to put out."

The time, dedication, patience, and reflection essential to resolving policy disputes, together with a long delay in resolving them on the World Service level, exacerbated the New York Region's major controversies in the first years of its existence. At that time the *Temporary Working Guide to the Service Structure* (aka *TWiGS*)

was being revised, but here is how it described the purpose of a Regional Service Committee: ". . . to be supportive of its areas and groups and their primary purpose, by linking together with areas and groups within a region, by helping areas and groups deal with their basic situations and needs, and by encouraging the growth of the fellowship."[10] Although that statement of purpose seemed high-minded and reasonably simple in the abstract, as usual the devil was in the details—the practical how-to's of providing service to those groups—and that's where the challenges began.

Accountability

In September 1983, at a euphoric post-convention meeting of the RSC, the WCNA-13 Convention Committee made its final report. The lion's share of the profits went to World Service, a total of $17,500[11]; $3,000 bought *Basic Text*s to be distributed to all the local Areas; and the balance of $8,000 was deposited into the Region's bank account. The newly elected Central Office Committee then began to look for a place where the Region and its committees could hold meetings, run the hotline, store their stuff, and sell literature. In a very short time they found a location. In December 1983 a lease was signed for space at 19-25 St. Mark's Place, also known as the HOW Club, for a monthly rent of $700. Six months' rent was paid in advance. The problem: this decision of a few members to spend $4,200 was made without the knowledge or consent of the body. Completely left out were the Area Service Representatives (ASRs).

A heated discussion followed at the January 1984 meeting. The ASR from Long Island read a letter expressing his Area's "disgust and confusion" over the move. "This has the earmarks of California in the past, no control." As for the location, "even to use the term 'central' is a joke. My Area would like to know who's kidding who." The reason for not bringing the matter before the membership was that "committees are formed that don't get any support . . . and decisions have to be made . . . with the input of some of the other members of the region."[12] The body then voted to

hold a monthly dance at the HOW Club to help defray the costs of the new office.

Then came the double whammy. That same month, three members of the Convention Committee made another major decision without consulting the Regional body after finding out that the Vista Hotel was threatening a lawsuit over an outstanding bill from the convention. "In order to retain the good name of NA in New York," they explained, "that bill had to be paid." Therefore they took immediate action to raise money by holding two dances in January at the HOW club. But when people found out that the profits from these dances were not going to support the Region, they felt they had been misinformed. The counter argument was that, seeing as how the Convention Committee had contributed $11,000 to the Region, the fund-raisers "did go toward bills incurred by one of our committees."[13] Nevertheless, people complained that these members were not going through the proper channels in the service structure. "It seemed to us that they did not believe they were obligated to provide transparency and accountability to the ASRs," and an us-versus-them mentality began to divide the membership.

One trusted servant who was there at the time describes what hindsight has taught us since then: "I'm sure the fear was that if we let the body know what happened, oh my God, everybody's going to go use. We have to do this secretly and it can't wait. When you have very little clean time, you're not aware till somebody points it out that it's kind of arrogant to think that we can't handle it. Besides, saying we can't wait doesn't fly because we saw each other at recovery meetings every night. And guess what? When you let everybody know, it's everybody's problem and more than one solution is on the table. When there's transparency, suspicion goes right out the window."

Another point of contention was the use of *Robert's Rules of Order*. Some members saw the need for an established parliamentary procedure as necessary because so much was happening on many different fronts by a rapidly growing number of committees. For

them, *Robert's Rules* was essential. "Otherwise nothing got done. That's what happened in our first meetings—all day and into the night with a break for dinner—it was chaos, exhausting." But the opinions of other members who opposed to the manual were just as strong. "A lot of us were street addicts and we didn't know *Robert's Rules*, but the ones who were well versed in it could manipulate the RSC like a lawyer can manipulate a courtroom. They would use *Robert's Rules* and it would make people feel stupid. There's a motion on the floor, you think you know what's going on, and suddenly you're out of order."

Balancing Group Conscience and Delegated Authority

The voting procedure was to become a major cause of the growing discontent at the RSC. At the heart of the controversy was the difference between authority delegated to the service structure necessary to fulfill its responsibilities and the final authority for NA service resting with the groups, and the lack of a clear distinction about *how* that balance was to be maintained. This issue had been an ongoing problem for the entire NA fellowship long before New York came on the scene. For years the only guideline it had was the stopgap *Temporary Working Guide*, which briefly stated that "Group Service Representatives are the only voting members at Area Service meetings. Area Service Representatives are the only voting members at Regional Service meetings." The *Twelve Concepts for NA Service* would clarify some of these issues but not for many years.

Although the statement in the *Temporary Working Guide* was clear and unequivocal, it still didn't address the problem of how to apply the spiritual principle of group conscience to voting procedures. According to Bob Stone, members of the World Service Board of Trustees worked many hours preparing a comprehensive revision of the service structure for the 1984 World Service Conference, "loaded with details and specifics," but the Conference was "not very receptive to the draft we had so laboriously assembled" and sent it back to committee.[14] It would take 15 years

before the WSC could reach an agreement on those specifics and approve the *NA Guide to Service.*

According to the minutes of the New York City Regional Service Conference (RSC), the body's original voting policy was established in September 1983. Of the total voting participants, the representatives (ASRs) and alternates of the four Areas (Manhattan/Brooklyn/Staten Island, Queens, Metro North, and Suffolk/Nassau) each had a vote, for a total of eight votes. The Regional Service Representative (RSR) and alternate also had a vote, as did the hotline and H&I representatives. The Steering Committee (collectively) had one vote, with the chair voting in case of a tie.

After six months, it became apparent that the RSC members found themselves in the same predicament as did the members of the World Service Policy Committee, who continued to hammer out a more specific and detailed language for a revision of the *Temporary Working Guide.* At the March 1984 New York RSC the body did the same, revising their original voting policy by passing an ASR's motion that members of the Steering Committee be given one vote each for "ongoing RSC business."

The process of refinement continued in June 1984, when the first item on the agenda at the Region's first General Service Conference was "Resolution #1: All group conscience matters and major decisions shall be voted on only by the Area Service Representatives and the H&I chair. Major decisions will be determined by a majority vote of the NYCRSC." Resolution #1 passed overwhelmingly, but it failed to answer some burning questions: What is the difference between a "group conscience matter" and "ongoing RSC business?" How is a group conscience carried? What is a "major decision?" And what, precisely, is a "majority vote of the RSC?" New York could not wait for the slow evolution of voting policy being worked out by the World Service Conference. The RSC had to come up with immediate solutions to serve immediate needs that were unique to New York—the exponential growth, both geographically and in numbers, of a new and highly diverse membership.

A trusted servant since the 1970s describes how he perceives that longstanding debate about the meaning of group conscience: "The issue seems to be around this concept of delegation versus representation—between receiving instructions from the group and carrying out those instructions versus being given the responsibility and authority to carry the group conscience from one service entity to the next. I think that's the root of the division for as far back as I've been involved in service, and it's still operating. It's a division so deep that it's almost like, never the twain shall meet."

Extreme thinking seemed to prevail on both sides. One faction said that everything should be group conscience, "in each group and in each Area, with only Area delegates voting. Anything beyond the group just becomes a power play." The other side declared that approach was "totally unworkable. That the groups have all the information they need to make decisions is and always has been a complete fantasy. We are trying to do things based on a system that absolutely cannot, does not, and never has existed. It's really that simple—that some people believe it's less spiritual to give authority and responsibility to trusted servants and others like myself believe it's less spiritual not to. Because there's no trust. That's why we're called trusted servants."

When spiritual principles were applied to the actions of addicts in early recovery they often got twisted. Those who believed they were messengers of group conscience were accused of manipulation: "They say it's a group conscience but that's because they got the group to vote the way they wanted them to. It's not *how* they got the conscience, it's *that* they got it, and that's not spiritual." The group conscience advocates in turn accused the other side of arrogantly overstepping their authority. "They think there's no way the ASRs or the groups could possibly understand what's happening at the Region, like how can we entrust the treasurer to take care of our money and not entrust the treasurer to say what to do with the money? And that's not spiritual."

The more the accusations flew, the less either side was able to negotiate a middle ground.

If the World Service Conference was embroiled in the same conflict for fifteen years without a resolution, imagine what the members of the New York Region were up against thirty years ago, running to keep up with rapid growth on all service fronts, with a limited amount of recovery or understanding of the Traditions. Trouble ahead was inevitable.

Showdown

By August the situation was already starting to unravel. The Region was in dire straits financially, and the treasurer complained about a general lack of accountability: "After the Conference decides these policies, what do we do when self-will prevails?" At the September meeting the officers were concerned about a "general malaise" among the RSC and made a plea for unity. The impact of the General Service Conference's Resolution #1 was beginning to be felt in unforeseen ways.

By October the concern about a "general malaise" had become a stern lecture, calling on members to "cease from malicious gossip." By November the struggle to conduct the business of serving a Region without a workable service guide—exacerbated by personality conflicts and increasingly polarized views about the meaning of group conscience—is made evident in the minutes of the RSC. At the November 1984 meeting the ASR from Queens added a motion to the agenda, which passed, to review the body's voting procedures. The motion was "to change the method of voting to give the Steering Committee one collective vote, excluding the RSR and RSR alternate. After a flurry of motions[15] they voted on the ASR's original motion—8 in favor, 6 opposed, 2 abstentions—but it failed to obtain a two-thirds majority. The ASR from SNAS then made another motion that the item be the first order of business at the next General Service Conference. That motion passed, 8 in favor, 5 opposed, 2 abstentions, because it did not require a 2/3 majority.

It was now becoming clear to some members that they had

voted for Resolution #1 at the June General Service Conference with little understanding of the potential consequences. At that time "very few attendees had experience with this type of service. . . . Due to these circumstances, policy was voted on that no longer works for us. The voting structure we incorporated at our RSC to help us function more effectively is now causing dissention among the Areas."[16]

"April Is the Cruelest Month"

The ASRs of MBSI and Queens came prepared to the April 27, 1985, meeting of the RSC, with reports to read before the body that included motions passed by GSRs at their Area service meetings. At MBSI, 29 GSRs had voted on a motion that the "RSC voting procedure adhere to the *Temporary Working Guide* that ASRs are the only voting members." The report from Queens Area Service went further. There the GSRs had voted unanimously that "if the NYCRSC does not accept the *Temporary Working Guide* as a basis for all policy, QAS will no longer financially support the Region."

After some procedural delays, a motion by the MBSI representative that the RSC "adhere to page 9 of the *Temporary Working Guide*" was put on the floor. Thirteen voted in favor of the motion: all the ASRs plus the Regional vice chair, the treasurer, the RSR, and the H&I chair. Four members opposed and three abstained. According to the minutes, the motion failed. "Not a 2/3 vote."

The fallout was immediate. The ASRs and alternates of MBSI, Queens, and SNAS wrote and signed their names to a letter to the fellowship, with a copy to the World Service Board of Trustees, asking for support. "The Areas have consistently made motions at a number of RSC meetings to change the voting procedure at the Region, but since the Steering and Standing Committees have fifteen votes, and the Areas only twelve (usually less) the Areas are outvoted by those who want to keep their vote. . . . All we are trying to do is follow the service structure the way World Service

suggests, NOT CREATE OUR OWN. We urge you to discuss this matter at your next group business meeting, and support us in our efforts." This letter resulted in many heated discussions at recovery and business meetings, especially when a Regional trusted servant was in attendance.

At that time it seemed as if the RSC had reached a total impasse, with both sides blaming the other. George H and Leah A, now the chair and co-chair of the World Service Conference, flew in to try to calm things down. George H: "In New York the environment was, it could get pretty raucous pretty soon. There was a lot of back-stabbing going on, like they couldn't stand each other at times. For a while it was just insane. We'd fly in like Superman and try to put everything together in a weekend, then fly back and find out that what we had put together had already dissipated by the next week."

How could recovering addicts who regularly saw each other at meetings continue to be unable to resolve their differences while at the same time doing their utmost to give service, the sole purpose of which was to carry the life-saving message of recovery to addicts that they didn't have to die from the disease of addiction?

Freedom I

The Omni Park Central was a behemoth of a hotel on Seventh Avenue and 56th Street, just south of Carnegie Hall and three blocks from Central Park. Its choice as the location for the New York Region's first convention was certainly the fulfilment of the wishes of members who had clamored for an uptown address for WCNA 13. Still, it was risky business for the Region to go uptown for its first convention. Fran O was the treasurer at the time. "I went to the hotel and signed a $60,000 promissory note. I look back and go, what was I thinking?" Others were more optimistic. "It was easier this time because we'd been through the pressure before, trying to find out what needs to be done, and we didn't feel like the oddballs of the year. Besides, putting on a convention back then

wasn't about making a ton of money. It was about being unified, and letting people know we were free from drugs, let them see us celebrate in a nice public place."

It was a shock, though, when they found out they would have to spend $14,000 just on coffee. "That's what the union made us pay. After that we never did coffee at a convention again. Another lesson learned." But the pre-convention problems and worries about pulling it off had little effect on the members who were attending their first big NA event, particularly the newcomers. "I was in awe of the numbers, addicts in an upscale place, all dressed up like it was an Elks convention, big shots coming all the way from California to speak." A newcomer from Suffolk County, WR, was another. "The first thing I did was buy the T-shirt and put it on, wearing the NA colors. Freedom One blasted my recovery to a whole new universe, a picture of recovery and the life I wanted to be a part of." The program was all-inclusive as it should be at a New York NA convention, with meetings for bikers, beginners, gays, Spanish-speakers, non-addict loved ones, and even non-dancers, who instead of going up to the ballroom had the option of attending an event called "I Am Not at the Dance Because . . ."

The emotional highlight for many attendees was a candlelight meeting in the ballroom. "Terry R passed out the candles. Back then you didn't have the fire issues. One person lit the next person's candle and we were singing something like "We Are the World," and pretty soon everyone in the room was holding a lit candle. 'This is how it works,' Terry said, and you've got this indescribable feeling of joy that you can get only by being with so many others like yourself."

The Convention Committee had an arrangement with the hotel that the final payment would be made Saturday midnight, and by the time the banquet started it was clear they were not going to break even. They passed the basket but still they were short. "At the last minute someone checked into the hotel. That brought the number up to where you could get a free room and we broke even. We took a picture of us with thousands of dollars on the bed in

Fran's room. Then we went down and paid the bill. We were out of our minds with joy. We didn't make any money but we broke even and every bill got paid."

Visible, Indivisible—and Free

The theme of freedom—freedom from drugs—was still very new to this group of addicts, and for many it was still hard to believe it could last. But one thing was clear—they knew in all the years of their using that, try as they might, they had never succeeded in being free from drugs by themselves. For that they needed other people who wanted the same thing they did with the same sense of urgency, and "man oh man that was hard, the unity thing, harder than when I stopped using drugs, so very hard for a bunch of self-involved, opinionated, closed-minded addicts like myself." After the convention was over and the celebrants were leaving for home, still in that post-convention afterglow, the trusted servants of the Region faced what they could only assume would be yet another round of strife that afternoon at the May 26th meeting of the Regional Service Conference.

The previous month, at a meeting of the board of trustees at the World Service Conference in Los Angeles, one of the topics discussed had been "under what conditions should the trustees become involved in local problems around the fellowship? . . . It was alleged that irreconcilable problems had been causing great controversy in the New York Region. The metro area was considered to be a key growth center for the fellowship and warranted some attention. It was decided that Bob R [former World Service Conference chair] and Jack B [newly elected chair of the World Service Office Board of Directors] would be sent to New York City to wade through the problems and help solve them."[17]

Jack B, who had been the keynote speaker at the banquet the night before, and Bob R attended the meeting that afternoon, as did every voting member of the Steering and Standing committees and all the representatives and alternates of every Area of the New

York Region except one, Westchester-Rockland, including the representatives of the newly formed Manhattan Area. The meeting opened with a motion from the Bronx ASR, seconded by the Queens ASR, "to suspend the rules for a special order of business. PASSED, unanimous."[18]

"What's going on?" would have been an appropriate fly-on-the-wall response at that moment, in light of the body's previous inability to vote unanimously on a motion on an issue of rigorous debate. Another motion followed, made "by Areas (unanimous) for all non ASRs to voluntarily give up their vote at the RSC and adopt the voting procedure in accordance with the *Temporary Working Guide*. PASSED, 18 in favor, 2 opposed, 1 abstention."

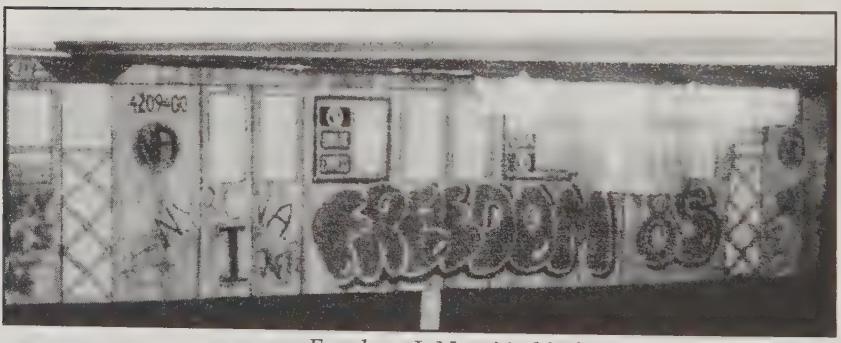
And then, the culminating motion: to change the name of the New York Region to the Greater New York Region of Narcotics Anonymous. "PASSED, unanimous." The growth had been so phenomenal we had even outgrown our name.

Whatever happened between the April and the May Regional Service Conferences is not part of the written record, but the end result is evidence that a reconciliation of the New York fellowship's "irreconcilable differences" had taken place. That coming together did not happen overnight by any means. By July the conflict had heated up "to a boiling point once again. Jack B, George H, and Leah A flew in and spent four days interviewing each area rep one at a time and a long list of others. It was almost like a star chamber inquisition at times."[19]

Nevertheless, just one year later, in July 1986, the Greater New York Region became the largest Region in the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship, with 1,700 meetings and 1,300 groups. In spite of all our difficulties, we were unified in our ability to achieve our primary purpose of carrying the message to the still suffering addict. The progress we had made in moving toward spiritual growth was part of a rapid but painful coming of age of the fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous as a whole. Although a comprehensive history of the World fellowship has yet to be written, this new direction is corroborated by the one source we do have, *My Years with Narcotics*

Anonymous by Bob Stone, which we have relied on many times to put the story of the New York fellowship into the bigger picture. The author was not one to indulge in overly optimistic statements, but he expresses the joy he felt over events that occurred that spring and summer of 1985: "It was a turning point, a leap forward. Unity was visible at the end of the tunnel of darkness and disunity from which we were emerging."

Our journey continues, still guided by the power that is greater than ourselves. Today the fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous in New York is alive and well, still growing, still willing to help the next suffering addict who walks through the meeting room door. And that, truly, is The Impossible Dream.



Freedom I, New York's first regional convention

Epilog
"We Are the Old-Timers We Never Had"

"NA doesn't change. People change."

Something like 140 recovering addicts were asked a number of questions when we interviewed them for this book. Some of their answers were close to unanimous. "What would you do differently?" we asked. "Nothing." Another question was, "What literature was important to you back then?" Nearly everyone told us, "The *Little White Book*." One addict, clean since 1976, had an interesting take on the importance of that single piece of literature and how it defined the "founding" members not only of New York but the entire East Coast fellowship.

> Here's my theory on how we got recovery with just each other and that little booklet: Greg P, who passed in 1999, got clean in the early years of NA in Southern California. He once asked an NA old-timer, "Who was the first person you ever knew who didn't go to AA, who was just NA-dependent?" and the old-timer said, "Well . . . you." Greg's reply was, "I had no idea there was no one before me, but I don't know if I would have done it if I had known I was the first." If you got the message in Southern California you got the *Little White Book* in your hip pocket but you also got the old-timers in NA along with it. But on the East Coast—Pennsylvania, New Jersey, Connecticut, New York—we had the white book but no old-timers, and we believed that it would work by itself, and we started acting as if it would work by itself. We staked our life on it without knowing for

a fact that it would work by itself, and so it did. We bet our asses on something that didn't exist. Just my theory.

Our final question to these self-made old-timers was, "What do you think about being a part of this history book?" Their responses were varied, from "I'm thrilled" to "It's of no consequence. If you wasn't there you wasn't there." In between there were a lot of observations about how NA today is not what it used to be. One addict took a philosophical approach: "NA has changed, but so have I." The response that sticks in our mind is one with an entirely different focus: "Here's what I want to say to the people who are in NA today. Remember that song about 'these are the good old days'? What I really hope you get out of this book is that what's happening right now is historic. Be involved, and remember."

And take good notes.

A Tribute to Our Predecessors

"I want to tell you what's astounding about being up here. The first meetings I went to in 1981 there were 20 people in a place called Queens. You'd see the same 20 people at the meeting in the Bronx. But I hear there's five thousand people here. Damn! We've come a long way from 20 people in Queens, and I thank God for everybody who stuck around."

So many members have died who were there at the creation of NA in New York, memorable people whose words and acts of compassion are still talked about today, that paying tribute to them all would require another book. Here are some messages from a representative few, excerpted from our interviews with them, or from speaker tapes, or, when those were lacking, the recollections of addicts whose lives these predecessors continue to influence.

John T, Bronx: "I used to be a tough guy like my father. As I get older I've become my mother. I start to cry at anything. Now

I've got grandkids. I'm going to the gym, then go with my partner and plant flowers in the backyard. The guys on the street would smack me around if they heard about this, but I love my life today. I'm a happy man. My spiritual conviction is that I am connected to anyone who has attended any 12-Step group on this planet, and anyone who will attend even when I'm gone. My hope is they'll keep carrying the ball, keep the doors open, because I want to stay connected with a whole bunch of spiritual people. There's power in numbers."

Lucky, Uptown: "Lucky was my sponsor's sponsor. I was chairing a meeting six months clean and he would show up every Friday in a three-piece suit, take his jacket off, put it on the back of a chair, help me set up the meeting, make coffee, and we talked. This wasn't just talk. He taught me how this program worked and how to use my sponsor. When I told him I didn't have a problem calling my sponsor when there's something going on but I did have a problem when everything was right, he told me, 'If you don't have a problem it's something that you're not doing.' After he was gone I realized I never heard him complain. He gave away hope from Day One. He showed us how to grow up. He used to tell us, 'Never forget the shoulders you rode on to watch the parade of life.' "

"I celebrated my 19th anniversary on a Thursday. That Tuesday Lucky was in surgery. They put a trache in his throat and discharged him. On Thursday he came to my anniversary. The day before Thanksgiving I get a phone call. It was Lucky, first time in 19 years. All he said was 'I love you.' That was his way of telling me he was going home."

Kevin F, Queens: "He was a rough-looking Irishman, hard core, hard-nosed, squinty eyes, raspy voice, don't-ask-don't-tell attitude, and one of the most generous human beings you'd ever meet. He taught us that the real focus is about service, helping people get clean."

"Kevin was one who brought in the low-bottom addicts, the "hopeless cases" who didn't know how to find NA. He knew where the stairs were that led down to the abandoned tunnels under

Grand Central where homeless addicts lived. He'd go down there and bring them to a meeting. When people with the virus were being shut down in meetings when they wanted to talk about what they were going through, it was Kevin who was behind starting the first HIV meeting. He was committed to serving the addicts who were suffering the most. That was his mission."

Tommy R, Brooklyn: "There was one speaker that I always remember. That was Pepe, when he summed up what NA is all about in three things. He said, 'I don't look the same,' and that's true. I was about 75 pounds soaking wet when I came in. He said, 'I don't think the same.' All I ever thought about was who could I beg or steal from to get the next one. And he said, 'Above all, I don't feel the same.' For me that is the most awesome part of my recovery, that I don't feel the way I felt when I walked into the rooms in 1983, wanting to die. Today I can feel awkward, I feel indifferent sometimes, but never, ever the way I felt that day when I came into the rooms of Narcotics Anonymous."

Vitamin Joe, Long Island. "This guy who was in recovery came to Brunswick. He said there's life after drugs. We go place and we do things and we hang out together and we find out that we're not unique, we're a part of. I'm not alone today. I'm one little cog in the wheel that's going around and if I don't do my part, the wheel's going to wobble."

Tony D, Bronx: "There I was, practicing the Third Step. Turn my life over . . . turn it over...turn it over. Had a sign on the fridge, turn it over, one on the wall, reminding me, and there I was, turning it over, until something happened that I didn't like and my will broke down the door and took me over again and it all went right out the window. I became like a lost-weekend person, peering through the blinds. I'd fix it! Me! Left to my own devices I don't need to tell you where I was, on the brink of the precipice ready to cross over, self-obsession, bad feelings, and my friend says, 'For God's sake, will you give yourself a break? Gee whiz.' And I did. And this too shall pass. And it did. And I was okay. This is how it works. This is what we do."

Bonnie M, Long Island: Robin H: "Bonnie was my sponsor. She had long, black, wavy hair and almond-shaped eyes. She was a beauty, but not the threatening kind. Bonnie was just a very comforting person to be around at a time when I wasn't comfortable around anyone. She was the one who started the candlelight meetings. She just had this intuition about how to make people feel safe. It was scary then to be a woman in NA, and most of us were super young. Bonnie would wrap her arms around every newcomer who came to a meeting. She had a car and organized everybody getting to meetings. The best thing about that time was, there was no judgment about using. A lot of us, men and women, weren't staying clean. It was a real struggle, everybody just hanging on, figuring out how to do this, and Bonnie didn't make you feel ashamed if you were using.

"I finally got a year and then I relapsed, but when I found out Bonnie was in the hospital I made a commitment to stay clean. At that time they didn't even have a name for HIV or AIDS, but when it started to spread it was like heaping shame on top of shame. First you were judged for being an addict and then you were judged for getting this disease. When they started the first HIV meetings I got involved in her honor. If it wasn't for people like Bonnie, who had so much integrity, I don't think the rest of us would have had the courage to go to those meetings. Bonnie had a really tough story. She knew about suffering, and yet she was a healer. She taught me that the extent to which you suffer is the extent to which you can serve."

Ron B (Kumba), Brooklyn: "Bashir kept his promise. He came back and after he got clean he started up Welcome to Sobriety again, but this time we changed the name to Welcome to Recovery. I've still got the sign here. You can see where the old name was painted over. For a time we met in an abandoned church. There was no heat and no electricity, so we lit candles and took turns feeding newspaper and wood into a makeshift coal burner. Remembering our experiences around the fire barrel when we were 'out there,' we were grateful, and suddenly we forgot we were cold."

Randy L, Westchester: "Sunday it was Tarrytown, Tuesday it was Yorktown or White Plains, Wednesday it was Yonkers, Thursday back to White Plains, always traveling 25 or 30 miles to every meeting. I was the only one with a car. Pick up guys out of the V.A. hospital, take them to coffee after, religiously. I loved that camaraderie. The availability of meetings has risen the bottom since then but when I came in it was people with boxing-glove hands, abscesses—scared, hopeless people. Now we can congregate without fear. We can talk to doctors about a substance abuse problem and they tell you to go to NA. That's one of the biggest things. We've arrived."

Butch S, Long Island: "Now you go to a meeting and you don't know anybody. It's a good thing because it means more people know about NA, but they don't come up to you and introduce themselves. They don't make you feel welcome. They hand the book around and everybody signs it and give it to the guy—here you go, buddy. I mean come on. You think if I'm a newcomer I'm gonna look down and say, uh, I think I'll call Charlie? Bullshit. I'm not gonna call anyone. But if I go over and say, I'm Butch, see that name? You can call me anytime. In fact, give me your number. I'll call you."

Frankie the Fireman, Manhattan: "I want to talk about pride. I have a history of sleeping for ten years on the floor because my parents wouldn't buy me a bed and I wouldn't ask why. When I came to that meeting in Queens in 1981 there was no hope for me, no help. I was the guy standing in the back of the room, stoned out of my face. In those days they allowed me to share and every time I cried and said, this is horror. It wasn't that I didn't think this program worked, but it was not for me because I'm different. Did you sleep for ten years on the floor? After a few months I couldn't deal with being around people getting better, people who had hope and health in their life, so I went out with a vengeance. I came back four years later. A while ago my sponsor told me, 'That first year all you did was say that you were a worthless piece of shit.' I remember doing that. One day he grabbed me and he was so angry. 'I'm not

kidding, Frank. I don't ever want to hear you say that again.' It's been two years since I've said that. Because I'm not.

"I want to talk about dignity. We have an issue that we tiptoe around. It's called AIDS. I only want to mention one thing. I keep hearing a phrase – dying with dignity. It's about living with dignity! We're not dying here. Nobody is dying today. We are living today. You know, it's sad when a child is afraid of the dark. It's a waste when a man is afraid of the light. This is the light. All I have to do is live. I wake up and it's sunny out. I never used to notice that. All the good things in life, they're waiting for me because there isn't anything I don't deserve. It doesn't mean everything will pan out but I'm getting better. I love you all."

Betsy N, Queens: I need to stick around and do service to help young service people because the new generation of people in NA doesn't know how it was when it started. They have the confidence that NA will always be here. I'm here to tell you that it won't be here if you don't do service. A lot of things are not being done. Addicts who are not hearing the message. People writing letters that no one is answering, leaving messages that nobody returns. Many times I've wondered why I'm still here, but now I know why, because my Higher Power has a purpose for me. If you're here, your Higher Power has a purpose for you. We're all here for a reason. Just please recognize that."

Santos, Bronx: "I was the dirtiest person in the world when I came back. I sold my soul to the cop man out there, never mind the body. I sold my self-respect, my dignity, my pride. Came back. Empty void in my stomach. I heard that and I said, yeah. Empty to an extreme, so empty, and then I began to salvage my life, to bring back some integrity. I began to make friends, be a part of something, first time in my life, hang out with people who stood for something.

"I've got this disease, and it's going to kick my ass before I die, but when I die I know it's not going to be a waste. Nobody that's died ahead of me has been a waste. We've all got to go. Some of us go sooner. I live today. I don't know what's going to happen tomorrow and I don't give a damn."

"The last time I saw Santos he could hardly speak. He whispered straight into my ear, 'Work the hotline.' "

Goat, Uptown: "If you go across 110th Street Goat is as much of a legend as Santos is. He was my sponsor and his sponsor was Lucky. Those were the two shoulders that carried me. They gave us the program in their own words as they saw it."

"Goat told us some things. 'I'm powerless only when I pick up,' he said. Respect is not something we demand, he told us, it's something we give. He didn't make stuff up. This was not the gospel according to Goat. It all came from a close reading of the literature, like, "It doesn't say don't get angry. It says don't get too angry." Now you hear people say their disease is out there somewhere doing push-ups. He told us a long time ago, 'I am the disease.' That let us know to keep the focus on ourselves and stop blaming people, places, and things for our negative attitude. He said, 'I never wanted to be myself. Today I'm the man God intended me to be.' These things he told us over and over still resonate today."

"When Lucky met me he said to Goat, 'So, you've got a new pigeon.' The reason they called you that is a pigeon is a message carrier, and our job as a sponsor is to teach you how to carry this message. How they did this was, they didn't tell us what to do, they showed us."

"Goat wore his hat at an angle. We called it cocked aceduce. No matter what he did, it never moved. Pigeons would ask him, why doesn't it fall off? He'd tell them it's hanging on to the knowledge. Even in his coffin he had his hat on like that."

John C, Staten Island: "We're different in New York. Come-on-come-on-let's-go-let's go—fast—we've got that. It's nice when you're clean and you put a harness on that. When it gets bridled and channeled it becomes useable. But I've been all around the country, got in that trailer and just went from town to town and met all the pioneers. Every place we went there was another me, another you. You don't know what they're doing but it's the same thing you're doing. Amazing—the same setbacks, same disappointments, same champions—again and again you could see how God takes certain

people and infects them and makes them jump, just replicates them. You can find that everywhere you go in Narcotics Anonymous. One of us is there, absolutely.

"Look at this phenomenon called the 12-Step movement, how it might be what's going to save mankind. We're overcoming something that hasn't been overcome by anybody else, no matter how they applied themselves to it. And if there was trouble, some helter-skelter that went down, what would be the first thing that we would do? Make a meeting, that's right. We'd meet and we'd pray. We'd do some service. We'd embrace each other."

Leah A, Florida: How did World Service view what was happening in New York? Let me tell you, we were thrilled. Bob Stone kept saying, 'They're renegades. They wanna go off on their own,' and I kept saying, 'Yeah, they do, yeah, they are, and that's New York, and I'm so glad.' If there ever was a city in the world that needed Narcotics Anonymous, New York is it. There's no city in the world like her. She has a heartbeat all of her own, and the only way to keep that heart beating is for the heart of NA to stay alive there. And the fact that we are there, getting progressively stronger, is the message—if you can stay clean in New York you can stay clean anywhere. That's what I want to put out there. If you're looking for help we're here. And we're free. You paid already. We recover here. So can you."



Leah



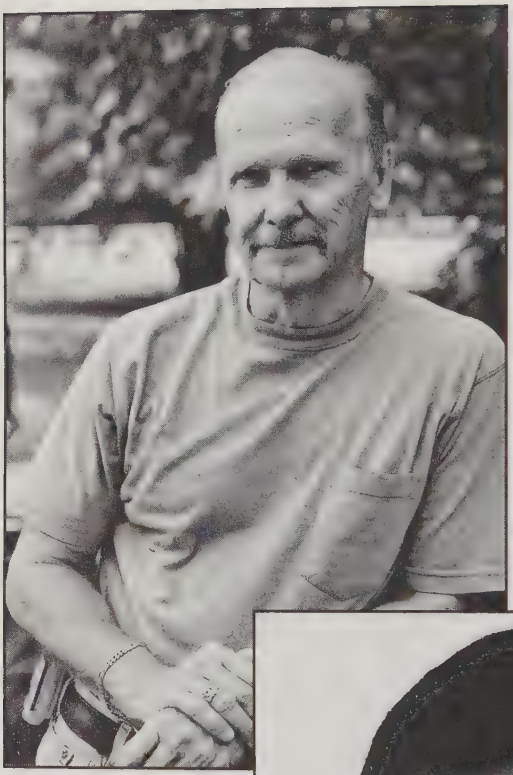
Ruben



Al W.



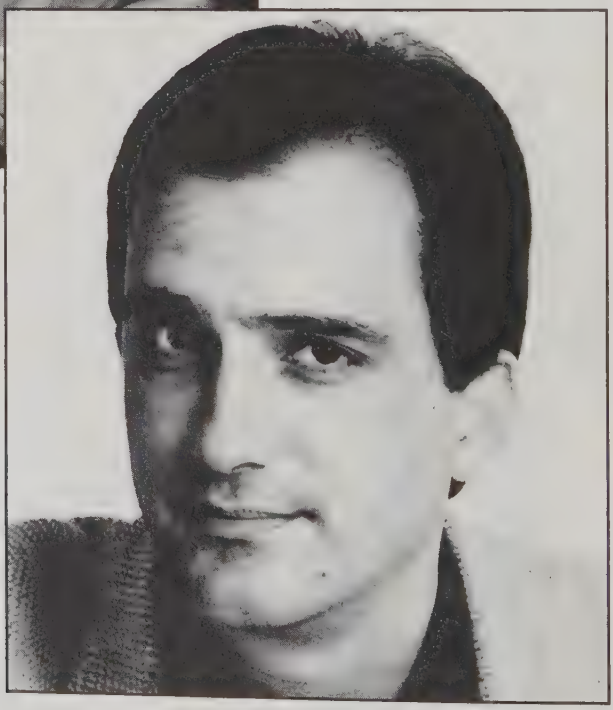
Gene G., courtesy of Angel Ibanez



John T.



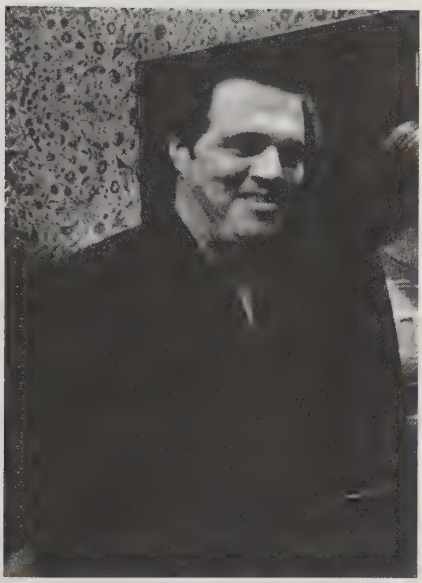
"Dollar" Bill B., courtesy of Angel Ibanez



Michael B.



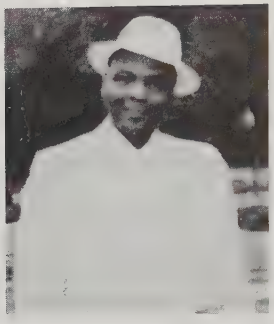
Betsy N.



Tony D.,
courtesy of
Chris Keeley



Ron B.

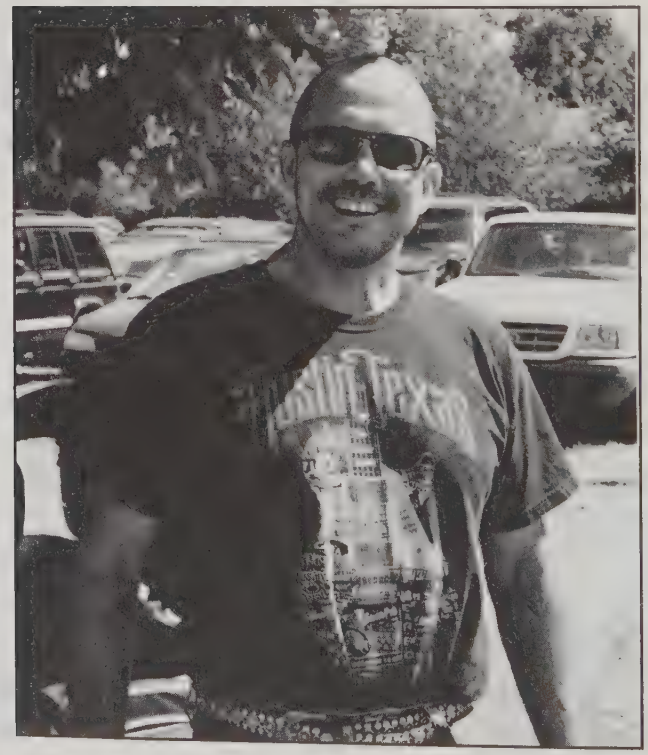


Wilbur W.
aka Lucky

Curley

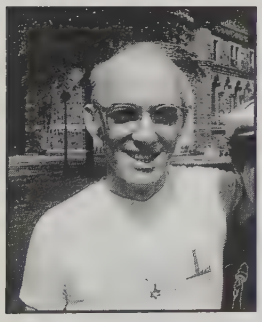


Randy L.





Anna



Roger T., courtesy of Chris Keeley



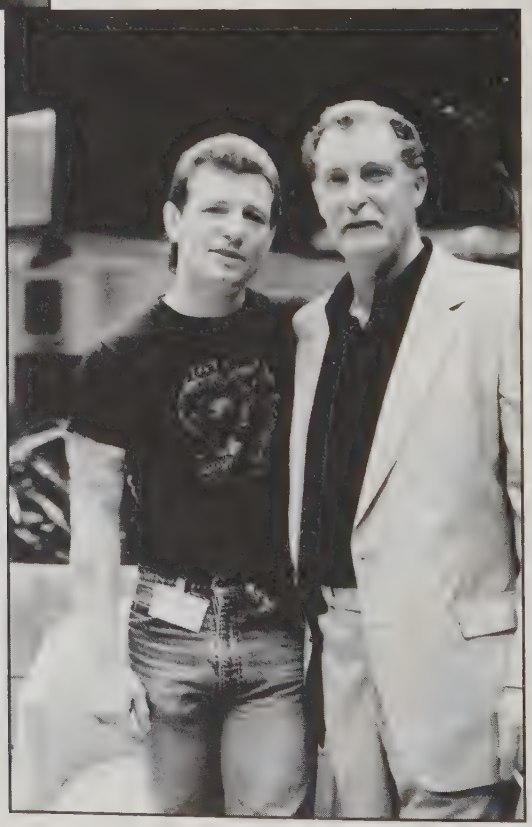
Awilda

Jamil





Vitamin Joe



Danny B. and Billy Red



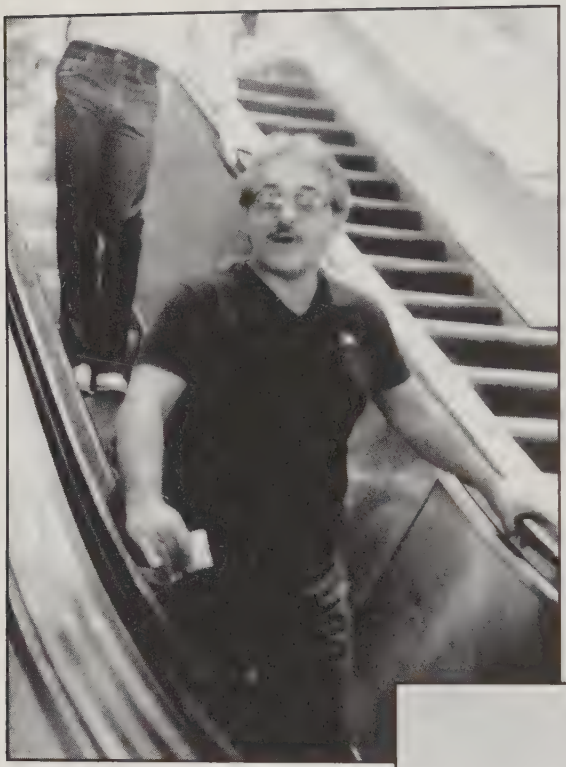
Dave M.

Reynaldo





Butch S.



Frankie G.



Wendy



Bishop

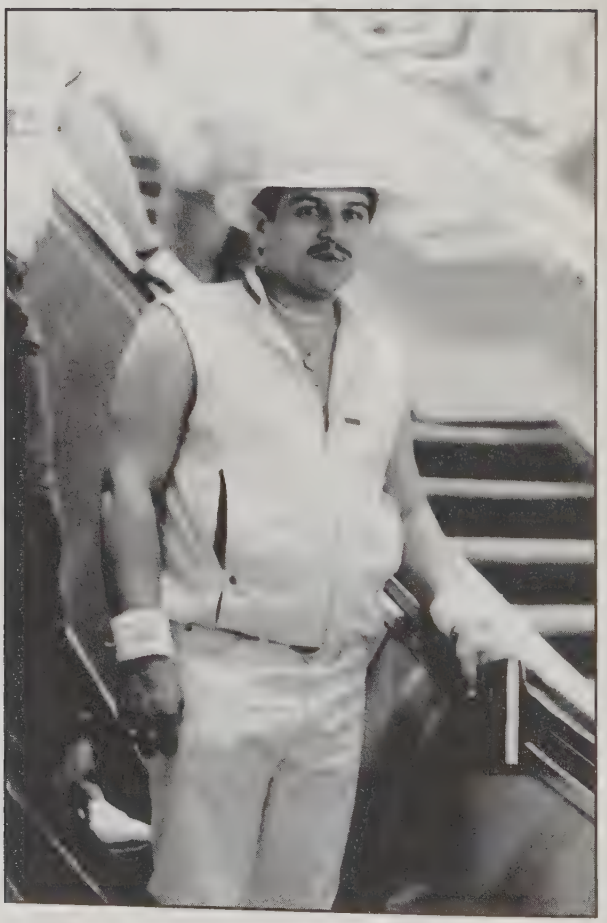


Kevin F.



Lawrence

Santos





T, Spadey, Will T, Big Mike, and Marvin on bottom



Goat



John K.

Acknowledgments

We wish to express our deep gratitude to the hundreds of people who made this book possible:

Interviews with NA Members

In our effort to present a comprehensive oral history, the History Book Subcommittee interviewed something like 140 recovering addicts now living in the Greater New York Region, upstate New York, New Jersey, Pennsylvania, Connecticut, Florida, California, Michigan, Rhode Island, North Carolina, and Georgia. The year indicates when they became members of NA.

1960: Vito L

1964: Hughie C

1968: Jim M

1970: John T

1971: Tom M, Laverne W

1972: Dutch, Jack B

1973: Lin A

1974: David F, Raheem

1975: John F

1976: Ron B, A. J.

1977: Bob G (Florida), Mike D, Richie D

1978: Bob G (Queens), Tommy E, Maureen F, Ernie C

1979: Terry R, Ron H, Dave M, Ernesto M, Frank P, Kerry R, Ray H, Tom B

1980: Buddy K, Chris J, Leah A, Ed D, George H, Merri D, Paul E, Randee

Sue P, Rose B, Terese W

1981: Bobby B, Debbie T, Jeff W, Maria M, Matt H, Paul S, Richie S, Sal M, Brian P, John C, Sidney

1982: Bobby D, Brian P, Conrad W, Guy H, John C, Meryl D, Jersey Joe, Jerry W, Jim F, Keno, Lois G, Mike K, Mike Z, Norman E, Peter H, Phyllis, Robin H, Scott A, Shane, Tuki D, Tom L, Willie T, John K, Ben C

1983: Antoinette D, Billy D, Bill M, Bob P, Ed W, Fran O, Gina S, Janet S, Joe A, John F, Kenny M, Kristin A, L'il Donna, Lynne V, Maggie M, Randy L, Richie Red, Sandy F, Steve B, Steve M, Tommy R, Vitamin Joe

1984: Arline C, Betty C, David C, Debbie L, Fern T, Gary D, Hank B, Jeff R, Joe G, Johnny A, John McM, John S, Kim S, Larry J, Lynn C, Maurice S, Miles, Mitchell S, Steve F, Tana A, Toby R, Tom S, Richard L, W.R., Willie Z

1985: Aida R, Angel P, Billy S, Craig S, Curtis W, Ian, Manny R, Michele E, Roddy C, William J, Curtis W

Non-NA Contributors and Advocates

We also interviewed the following people who told us invaluable information about our early history:

Kay Bauman, whose husband's family connections included a "great aunt Jane." In researching this family member's genealogy, she supplied us with a short biography written by Dr. Jane Dunaway about her adopted son, Danny C.

Donna Carlsen, Danny C's granddaughter, who looks forward to "reading about the grandfather I never knew."

Salvation Army Major Edward Dimond, ret., who gave us the earliest account we have so far of Dorothy Berry's work with addicts.

Charles Winick, PhD, founding member of the National Advisory Council on Narcotics, NA, Inc., who played an active role in NA's formative years and was a powerful advocate for the rights of addicts around the country.

Arnold Bernstein, PhD, founding member of NACON, another eye witness to the events of the early 1950s

Father (now Monsignor) John Ahern, Holy Name Center, an early believer in the value of NA.

Frank B, who was instrumental in starting Both Sides of the Coin in

Queens.

James Cusack, founder of Veritas Villa and great friend of NA in the early years.

Angel Ibanez, photographer, ENTER staff member during the 1970s,"just one of the little guys trying to fight Goliath."

We also acknowledge the contributions of the following advocates of the NA fellowship in its formative years:

Father Dan Egan and the Franciscan Friars of the Atonement at Graymoor; Father Terry Atrich, New York Archdiocese; Father (now Bishop) Rene Valero, Church of the Blessed Sacrament, Jackson Heights, Queens; Father Joseph Martin for his NA retreats; Father Raymond Hand, ENTER, East Harlem; Father John J Foley, Christ the King Church, North Yonkers; Father (now Monsignor) Vito Buonanno, Brooklyn VA; The Very Reverend Edward J Whalen, St. Cecilia's Church; Reverend Norman Eddy, East Harlem Protestant Parish; William C (Mr. Clark), Bedford-Stuyvesant; Bobby Moore, director, Nassau County Jail Drug and Alcohol Rehabilitation; Reverend Stephen Chinlund, Associate Director, East Harlem Protestant Parish Narcotics Committee; Bob Stone, WSO Office Manager and author of *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous;* Salvation Army Brigadier Dorothy Berry; and Burton Lindheim, journalist

Churches and Institutions

Our profound gratitude to those who opened doors to desperate addicts seeking recovery in our early years, at a time when we were rarely welcome anywhere, with a special thanks to the Salvation Army and the McBurney Y. The Y provided addicts with a safe haven at their 23rd Street location from 1950 to the early 1970s. During the seventies, when there were no NA meetings in New York, addicts could seek help from the following institutions in Harlem and East Harlem: ENTER, Our Lady Queen of Angels, St. Cecelia's, the Union Settlement House, and the St. Nicholas, Salem, and Convent groups of Alcoholics Anonymous.

The following are some of the pioneers—congregations and institutions that were the first to host NA meetings in their localities: Church of the Blessed Sacrament, St. Nicholas of Tolentine, and St. Mark's Parish, Queens; 600 Morris Park, Holy Rosary, and Blessed Sacrament, Bronx; Holy Name Center, St. Malachy's, Gracie Square Hospital, and St. Paul the Apostle, Manhattan; New Utrecht Reformed Church and Grace Church, Brooklyn; Wagner College and South

Beach Psychiatric Center, Staten Island; St. Ignatius, Long Beach; Our Lady of Lourdes, Malverne; St. Anne's, Brentwood; Christ the King, North Yonkers; St. James Methodist, Kingston; St. Pius XII Outreach, Newburgh. And many more.

NA Historians and Archivists

NA members David F, Danny M, and Kur B, Pennsylvania; Boyd P, North Carolina; Jay R, Florida; Mike R, Maryland; Chris B, South Carolina; Willie Z, New York. Also: William L. White, Chestnut Health Systems, author of *Slaying the Dragon*

Greater New York Region History Book Ad Hoc Review Committee

Ben C, Richy C, Bobbi H, Tom L, Jessie M, Mitchell S

In loving service,
The Greater New York Region
Ad Hoc History Book Subcommittee
Hank B, Rose B, Ben C, Terrie C, Terry D, Peter H, Elwood K, Chris M, Francisco M, Rose P, Catherine R, James R, Omar R, Lauren S, Lynne V, Russell Z, and Willie Z

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Carlsen, Donna, Danny C's granddaughter

Egan, Father Daniel, interviewed by John McM

Cusack, James. Founder of Veritas Villa

Dimond, Edward, Salvation Army major, ret. Started NA in Cleveland, Ohio

Ibanez, Angel, photography instructor at ENTER House in the 1970s

Winick, Charles, PhD, founding member of Narcotics Anonymous, Inc.

End Notes

(See bibliography for full citation of sources.)

Chapter 1: "Our Way of Life"

1. "Daniel L. Carlson [sic], Adopted Son of Dr. J. E. Dunaway" in Dunaway-Allder-Pyle Family, ca. 1959, pp. 81-82.
2. Danny Carlsen, "Morphine and Codeine" in Really Living, p. 155.
3. Op cit.
4. Campbell et al, The Narcotic Farm: The Rise and Fall of America's First Prison for Drug Addicts, 2008, p. 30.
5. Interview with Donna Carlsen, Danny C's granddaughter and only surviving descendant. According to Donna, her father did not know Danny was his real father until he was in his early twenties. "I was never able to find anything out about him until now. All I had to go on was what my mother had toldme, that he was famous for doing something for drug addicts. Unfortunately my father passed away three years ago and he never spoke about him."
6. "Statement of Education and Experience" of H.P. Sewell, 11/1/46 Boyd P, Chris B,and William White, Narcotics Anonymous Chronology, Vol. 1, 1892-1976, www.williamwhitepapers.com, note 49.
7. "An Open Letter to The Key," 8/17/54, in NA Chronology, note 225.
8. Bill W, "The Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous" in Alcohol, Science, and Society, 1945.
9. Houston S is quoted in "These Drug Addicts Cure One Another," The Saturday Evening Post, 8/7/54.
10. Communication with Boyd P and Chris B.
11. Saturday Evening Post. Dates for Danny C's last two incarcerations are not consistent in the number of books and magazine articles written about the early history of Narcotics Anonymous, and Lexington hospital records no longer exist.
12. Quoted in "The White Stuff," Time magazine, 5/7/51.
13. Op.cit.
14. Sherman Patrick, "Our Way of Life: A Short History of Narcotics Anonymous Inc," in Drug Addiction in Youth, p. 148
15. Wenzell Brown, Monkey on My Back, 1953.
16. Saturday Evening Post.
17. "A Short History," p. 149.
18. "Addicts Anonymous Group Founded with Aim: To Help and Be Helped" by Jack Lewyn, Lexington Herald, Lexington, Kentucky,

4/26/50.

19. Interview with Salvation Army Major Edward Dimond, ret.,11/11/10, who was instrumental in starting Narcotics Anonymous meetings in Cleveland in the early sixties. He met Dorothy Berry in October 1948 while he was a cadet in the School for Officers Training in New York City. Asked to describe this woman who looms so large in the early history of Narcotics Anonymous, he replied, "Nothing special. When I say she didn't make much of an impression on me at first, she obviously did, because she was the one I wrote to when I wanted to get NA going in Cleveland."
20. Dorothy Berry quoted in "From Crisis to Crisis," The War Cry, 4/24/65. A date for when these meetings in the Women's House of Detention started is hard to come by. The most reliable is "the atter part of 1949" in the preface to Really Living, a collection of Danny's articles published posthumously in 1958. Confirmed verbally by Dr. Charles Winick.
21. Monkey on My Back.
22. "From Crisis to Crisis."
23. New York Times, 1/9/49. "$1 million opium, heroin seized on French freighter Bastia. Luciano, in Italy [deported], denies trafficking."
24. Lexington Herald, 4/26/50.
25. "Short History."
26. Section 240.36 of the New York State Penal Law, a Class B misdemeanor: "A person is guilty of loitering in the first degree when he loiters or remains in anyplace with one or more persons for the purpose of unlawfully using or possessing a controlledsubstance." Although this law is still on the books, apparently it is now enforced at the discretion of the police.
27. Until a 1962 ruling by the U.S. Supreme court, it was a crime in most states to be addicted to narcotics.
28. "Drug Addicts U.S.A.," New York Post, 1/15/58.
29. Billie Holiday with William Dufty, Lady Sings the Blues, 1956.
30. "Short History."
31. Nation magazine, February 1960.
32. Harry J. Anslinger, The Traffic in Narcotics, 1953.
33. Jane E. Dunaway family papers. Dr. Dunaway "withdrew any further support and interest" when Danny was 22. "Apparently, being uprooted and moved to a strange and foreign environment had little (or nothing) to do with his delinquency, as both his siblings were psychopaths and caused their foster parents endless trouble. . . .Lately I have read that such inadequacies may be due

to a great difference in the ages of the parents."

34. Danny Carlsen,"Morphine and Codeine" in Really Living.
35. Traffic in Narcotics.
36. "A Policeman's View," in William Bier, ed., Problems in Addiction, 1962. Lt. Arthur M. Grennan, member of the NYPD Narcotics Bureau since 1951: "Addiction is not spread by large-scale peddlers but by proselyting of the addict himself, belligerently asserting vices are his own affair."
37. Testimony of Peter Terranova, former head of the NYPD Narcotics Squad, Kefauver Hearings, 4/2/57.
38. Interview with Dr. Charles Winick by Chris B and Boyd P, 2/27/13.
39. Dr.Winick, "Addiction and Its Treatment" in Law and Contemporary Problems, p. 21,1957.
40. Harry Anslinger, "Jazz and Junk Don't Mix," in The Protectors, Narcotics Agents, Citizens and Officials Against Organized Crime in America, 1953. Anslinger is reported to have said, "The only way to save her is to have her knocked out by the government." In 1947 he ordered the New York Bureau to find a "colored agent to work on getting a case against her." When she was sent to prison, it was not to the rehab mecca of jazz in Kentucky but the Alderson Reformatory in West Virginia, where the treatment for withdrawal was cold turkey. See also With Billie: A New Look at the Unforgettable Lady Day by Julia Blackburn, 2005.
41. Quoted in "The Czar Nobody Knows" by William Dufty and Fern Maya, New York Post, 1/17/58.
42. Although the dates cited for Danny C's last two incarcerations are inconsistent, two primary written sources, Ray L and Marie Nyswander, MD, have him at the Narcotics Farm during the time this pamphlet was being written.
43. The pamphlet was originally published in the Cleveland Plain Dealer as a series of articles written by a newly sober journalist, Elrick B. Davis, five months after the first AA group formed in Cleveland.
44. "Barbiturates—potential disaster when abused; contrary to belief, they are habit-forming" in the Lexington Herald, 4/19/50. The article describes barbiturates as "worse than narcotics."
45. "The Junk War," Newsweek, 9/17/51.
46. Nancy Olson, With a Lot of Help from Our Friends: The Politics of Alcoholism, 2003.
47. Although marijuana is not on the list of addictive drugs, Danny C later makes it clear that addicts must also abstain from it. See: "Marijuana, the Assassin Flower" by Daniel Carlsen in Really

Living.

48. The Narcotic Farm, p. 30.
49. Ibid.
50. "Addiction Is Recognized as Illness by AA Group Founded to Fight It," Lexington Herald, 4/27/50.
51. Twenty-Four Hours a Day, Alcoholics Anonymous meditation book, 1953. Our Way of Life states repeatedly that it is a spiritual and not a religious group. The pamphlet ends with the nondenominational "Serenity Prayer" rather than the Christian "Lord's Prayer."
52. Slaying the Dragon, p. 251.
53. The Narcotic Farm, p. 26.
54. Ibid.
55. Victor Vogel, MD, "Treatment for Drug Addiction" in Facts about Narcotics, p. 34, Addiction Research Center, USPHS, Lexington.
56. Really Living.
57. Charles Winick, Alcoholism Treatment Quarterly, 1/17/13, p.20.
58. Brooklyn Daily Eagle, 2/9/54.
59. Dr. Winick, interview with Chris B and Boyd P.
60. Interview with Arnold Bernstein, PhD, October 1, 2010. Now in his nineties, he continues practicing psychotherapy in his Greenwich Village office.
61. Slaying the Dragon, p. 119.
62. In addition to Dorothy Berry, Dr. Winick, and Dr. Bernstein, two other influential Board members were Marty Mann, executive director of the National Committee on Alcoholism and Drug Abuse, whose mission was to popularize the disease model for addiction; and Joseph Galiber, a lifelong advocate of the decriminalization of addiction. Later, as a state senator from the Bronx, he was one of the few legislators in Albany who spoke out against passage of the Rockefeller Drug Laws.
63. The New York Age, once an influential African-American newspaper, folded in 1953.It was the only newspaper that published this Jackie Robinson story, discovered by NA historian David F in archives of Newspapers.com.
64. Man Is the Cruelest Animal: The Story of "Trigger" Mike Coppola, Gangstersinc.com; Anthony Bruno, The Wives of Trigger Mike, Crimelibrary.com/gangsters.
65. Ellsworth "Bumpy" Johnson, blackpast.org.
66. Samuel Roberts, "Narcotics Addiction Policy in New York City 1951-1962" in Social History of Alcohol and Drugs, p. 154.
67. Brooklyn Daily Eagle, 6/13/51.

68. Marie Nyswander, The Addict As a Patient, p. 145.
69. People Today, 12/5/51.
70. Terry Morris, Confessions of a Freelance Writer: How I Got Started, 1951, p. 113.
71. The Labor Temple was not a conventional church but a meeting hall and school for workers of all faiths founded by the Christian pacifist A.J. Muste. The second anniversary of Narcotics Anonymous is described in detail in Monkey on My Back. Although no date is cited, the event was also covered in the New York Times ("Second Anniversary Today," 2/27/52).
72. According to Gene H, speaking at the November 2010 History Conference in Connecticut, this letter was discovered in November 2010 by Jimmy's daughter Cathy "in the bottom of a box of junk sent to her by her sister-in-law." It is the only written documentation we have so far of contact between early New York and California NA.
73. Bill W to Betty T, Habit-Forming Drugs, 5/19/54, in NA Chronology, note 216.
74. In the early fifties Narcotics Anonymous meetings were available only in New York, Los Angeles, Chicago, and Montreal. The Key became a communications forum for recovering addicts in the rest of the country.
75. This lack of understanding continued to be a problem for Bill W. In the 1954 Saturday Evening Post article he reiterated what he said about addicts in 1945 that "AAs don't understand them."
76. Sedatives: Are They an A.A. Problem? Alcoholics Anonymous approved literature, 1948, NA Chronology, note 61.
77. Jimmy K, 1984 interview with Gene H.
78. Letter from Bill W to Jerome Ellis, 6/28/54, in NA Chronology.
79. The exception was the Salvation Army. Although it did not provide social services to Narcotics Anonymous or sponsor the group by giving monetary assistance aside from free office and meeting space, any addict in need could receive food, clothing, and a place to sleep through their Social Welfare Department. Interview with Major Dimond re: Salvation Army policies and the meaning of sponsorship.
80. Among East Coast 12-Step fellowships at that time, this was not unusual. Alcoholics Anonymous had the Alcoholic Foundation, a nonprofit organization with a board of directors, two of them members of the Rockefeller Foundation.
81. Really Living, p. 147.
82. Speech by Rae L to narcotics-related institutions. Robert F. Wagner

Documents Collection,
April-May 1964.

83. "A Short History of Narcotics Anonymous." These contributions were generous enough
to pay for a burial by New York City's most prestigious funeral home, Frank G. Campbell, but not for a headstone. Danny was buried in an unmarked grave in a Salvation Army plot in Flushing Cemetery. After a year-long search, NA historian Danny M located the burial plot, and a group of Narcotics Anonymous members, together with Danny C's granddaughter, contributed to the installation of a headstone. It was commemorated at the grave site in on August 19, 2012, the 56th anniversary of his death.
84. David Musto, The American Disease: Origins of Narcotic Control, 1999.
85. Harry Anslinger, The Protectors, p. 295.
86. Within a year the first person received the maximum sentence, a 21-year-old who sold heroin to a 17-year-old addict informer. He was sentenced to life without parole and died in a federal prison. "In 1962 President Kennedy quietly used the pardon power to release several dozen of the most hapless victims of the 1956 Act." See: Mike Gray, Drug Crazy.
87. Rufus King, The Drug Hang-up: America's Fifty-Year Folly, 1972.
88. "Drug Addicts U.S.A., 1/19/58. Accused of being a "Communist front," the Presbyterian Labor Temple was evicted in 1957. Village Voice, 2/6/57.
89. "Drug Addicts U.S.A."
90. Interview with Father Dan Egan by John McM, December 1999.
91. According to Dr. Winick, NACON, other addict advocates, and a number of important musicians filed a class action suit, "which eventually we won, that the police card system was illegal and had never been authorized by law."
92. Ibid.
93. Donald Clarke, Wishing on the Moon, 1994. Among the groups picketing the hospital were Reverend Norman Eddy's East Harlem Protestant Parish, the Salvation Army, and Father Dan Egan's Village Haven. Corrections Commissioner Anna Kross, who had long been in the forefront of the fight for hospital treatment for addicts (and would soon be working directly with New York NA), also expressed her outrage. "Why did the nurse turn Lady into the police instead of medical authorities for a methadone detox?"

94. Ibid.
95. Alexander King, May This House Be Safe from Tigers,1960.

Chapter 2: The Long Bad Dream

1. Interview with Father Daniel Egan by John McM, December 1999.
2. Miracles Happen: The Birth of Narcotics Anonymous in Words and Pictures, p. 57; see also Counselor: The Magazine for Addiction Professionals, vol. 1, no. 2, April 2011, p. 32.
3. Interview with Jimmy K by Gene H, 8/27/84. World Service Archives.
4. Interview with Ed Dimond, Salvation Army major, ret. November 11, 2010. "When we started NA in Cleveland, we didn't know there was NA anywhere but in New York."
5. Commander Charles Ramsey, head of the Chicago Police Department's Narcotics Division, "who could have been speaking for urban police everywhere," Report of the Public Policy Project of the Correctional Association of New York, 2001.
6. Miracles Happen, p. 49, with credit to The Key.
7. Narcotics Anonymous Chronology, vol. I, 1892-1976, 2/5/57.
8. Soledad Handbook of Narcotics Anonymous, 8/5/57 in NA Chronology.
9. World Service Board Dinner Discussion, 11/14/86. NA World Service archives.
10. NA Chronology, Note 306. Jimmy K exchanges recorded meetings, 1962.
11. Father Egan interview and subsequent quotes.
12. Sherman Patrick, "A Short History of Narcotics Anonymous," 1965, p. 148.
13. Gabe Pressman interviews Rae and guests, CBS TV, November 19, 1959.
14. No Man Stands Alone: The True Story of Barney Ross, 1957.
15. Anna Kross quoted in "Drug Addicts U.S.A," New York Post, 1/19/58.
16. "A Short History." See also Cleveland, Ohio, Narcotics Anonymous newsletter #1, January 1964: "For information contact the Office of Narcotics Coordinator, 325 Broadway, Room 425."
17. Speech by Rae Lopez at the Gracie Mansion Conference, Mayor's Temporary Narcotic Commission of New York City, February 3-5, 1965. New York NA started prison meetings in Cleveland, Ohio; Jackson and Marquette, Michigan; Sandstone, Minnesota; Lorton, Virginia, three correctional institutions in New York;

Newark, Passaic, Hackensack, Hoboken, and Jersey City, New Jersey, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania; and Fort Leavenworth, Kansas.

18. William Butler Eldridge, Narcotics and the Law, 1967. "In New Jersey all persons convicted of narcotics offenses had to register with the police in any place where they remain for more than 24 hours." The law also applied to drug felons in New York who went to New Jersey. If apprehended the penalty was a year in prison.
19. "From Crisis to Crisis," The War Cry, April 24, 1965.
20. NA Chronology, note 239, ca. 1957. At the Addicts Anonymous Terminal Island Prison meeting in L.A. County "they had two podiums. One had AA 12 Steps, the other for addicts had 13 Steps." Conversation with Bill B, Greg P archives.
21. The earliest documentation of the 13 Steps being used outside of a prison meeting is in the Cleveland NA Newsletter #2, February 1964. They are also mentioned in "A Brief History of NA" as being part of the Fellowship House meetings.
22. Danny C file, ca. 1970, NA World Service archives.
23. Soledad Handbook of Narcotics Anonymous, 8/5/57. Reproduced in its entirety in NA Chronology.
24. Rae L speech at Gracie Mansion Conference.
25. Mike Gray, Drug Crazy, 1998.
26. Proceedings: White House Conference on Narcotic and Drug Abuse, Washington DC, September 27-28, 1962. NA Chronology, note 313.
27. Ibid.
28. Mayor Wagner's speech to the National Association for the Prevention of Addiction to Narcotics, June 22, 1964. Robert Wagner Document Collection.
29. Ibid. "More staff to strengthen Office of Narcotics Coordinator to expand central registry," June 6, 1962 press release from the mayor's office.
30. Ibid. Catherine B. Hess, M.D., assistant commissioner, Office of the Narcotics Coordinator, Report of Activities to the mayor, April 1964. How deeply entwined NA was with the Civil Commitment Law is evident in a letter dated February 28, 1964 from Rae L to Salvation Army Captain Edward Dimond in Cleveland. Under her signature is a request to "please reply to Office of Narcotic Coordinator, 325 Broadway, Room 325.
31. "Implementation of New York State's Civil Commitment Law Criticized, NAPAN Newsletter, May 1964. Robert Wagner

papers.

32. Nat Hentoff, A Doctor among the Addicts, 1968. A biography of Marie Nyswander, p. 49.
33. Ibid, pp. 132-33.
34. Ibid., p. 120
35. New York Times, 2/27/65.
36. Doctor among the Addicts, p. 120.
37. Ibid, p. 125.
38. David F. Musto, ed., The American Disease: Origins of Narcotic Control, 1999.
39. Interview with Jimmy K by Gene H, 1984. .
40. Tom Patton, "Some Notes on the Synanon Game," synanon.org/Synanon/Museum.
41. Daniel Casriel, M.D., So Fair a House: The Story of Synanon, 1963.
42. Op cit.
43. Interview with David F, NA Way magazine.
44. "The Bronx: Puerto Rican and African-American History Project," Article 525, BrownPride.com/articles.
45. Robert Leuci, The New Centurians: A New York City Cop Remembers His Years on the Street, 1961-1981, 2004.
46. T. J. English, Savage City: Rape, Murder, and a Generation on the Edge, 2001.
47. Leonard Shecter with William Phillips, On the Pad, 1973; "Knapp Urges Permanent Body on Police Corruption," New York Times 10/25/71; "Patrolman Says 'All But Two' of Colleagues Got Bribes," New York Times, 10/23/71; "Cops as Pushers," Time magazine, 11/8/71.
48. Edward J. Epstein, "Nelson Rockefeller" in Agency of Fear, 1990.
49. "Shocking Facts about Drugs Revealed: Ex-Addicts Address Nurses," Syracuse Herald- Journal, 10/11/68.
50. A Doctor Among the Addicts, p. 134. The biographer's own doubt about the spiritual aspect of 12-Step programs are expressed in his comment: "Let us grant that assumption for argument's sake. Is, then, self-reliance absolutely synonymous with being drug-free? . . . I have a question, for example, whether the need to believe in a God indicates absolutely self-reliance."
51. Danny C File, WSO archives.
52. Nancy D. Campbell, The Narcotic Farm: The Rise and Fall of America's First Prison for Drug Addicts, 2008; William L. White, Slaying the Dragon: The History of Addiction Treatment and

Recovery in America, 1998.

53. Ibid, White.
54. New York Times, 7/2/73. Manhattan District Attorney Frank Hogan also complained about Operation Drugs for resulting in "unacceptably high dismissal rates." In The American Disease author Musto wrote, "No president has equaled Nixon's antagonism to drug abuse, p. 248.
55. Slaying the Dragon, 1998 edition, p. 255: "Richard Nixon was very much concerned about the rise in urban crime following his rise to the presidency." He was advised that the only way to reduce urban crime before the next presidential election was "a massive infusion of methadone maintenance in America's inner cities." The author also states that the vastly expanded program of the early 1970s was "not based on the model whose success Dole and Nyswander had demonstrated." Rehab was no longer part of the program. Instead, it was administered in "exceptionally high doses" by addicts on methadone maintenance and run like a business with "enormous profit-making potential."
56. Ibid.
57. Vanessa Barker, The Politics of Imprisonment, 2009.
58. Ibid.
59. The Nation's Toughest Drug Law: An Evaluation, Final Report of the Joint Committee on New York Drug Laws, Association of the Bar of the City of New York Drug Abuse Council, 1977; New York State Penal Law, 220.00 to 260.10; Rockefeller Drug Laws Information Sheet, Partnership for Responsible Drug Information, 2004. www.prdi.org/rocklawfact.html.
60. Ibid. In 1979 the law about lifetime parole was no longer mandatory, and possession of 25 grams or less of marijuana was decriminalized as long as it was "not in public view." But to this day people on the street who undergo stop-and-frisk by the NYPD are ordered to empty their pockets and are then liable to arrest because the marijuana is now "in public view." All other penalties in the 1973 Rockefeller Drug Laws remain essentially the same.

Chapter 3: Stepping Stones

1. The Our Way of Life pamphlet Lin A received is the same as the original version that was printed in Riker's Island ca. 1950-51.

2. Lin A, The Dream Builders, an unpublished manuscript.

3. Jimmy K's incorrect statement about the New York Fellowship's failure to follow the 12 Steps is another indication of the lack of communication between the East Coast and West Coast fellowships.
4. Interview with David F, NA Way, vol. 1, no. 3.
5. In chapter 3, addicts at Reverend Chinlund's East Harlem Protestant Parish Narcotics Committee at 306 East 103rd Street (next door to Dr. Nyswander's clinic) give a negative assessments of methadone maintenance. The Rev. Norman Eddy, head of the EHPP since 1956, considered narcotics maintenance "wrongheaded," and disagreed with the Nyswander/Dole claim that addiction was a "metabolic disorder." Although he called it a disease, it was also "a symptom of a deep-rooted spiritual sickness." Due to this institution's understanding of addiction, the EHPP has remained a staunch advocate of NA since the 1950s.
6. St. Cecilia's: Our History, 1873-1973. Written for the 100th anniversary of the parish in 1973. "In a true spirit of ecumenism and love for one's fellow man, the people of St. Cecilia's together with those from Our Lady Queen of Angels, under Father Raymond Hand, O.F.M., Cap, have formed a narcotics treatment center called 'Enter.' "
7. James S. Cusack, Always Aware, 1995."At one time the NYPD commissioner dispatched an order stating that if any member of the force was found to be a member of AA, he wanted to know about it so he could fire him," p. 170.
8. In 1976 public intoxication was removed from the New York State Penal Law, requiring the creation of sobering-up stations. These often became meeting places for AA-sanctioned two-for-one meetings.
9. David Musto, The American Disease, p. 264. In a single decade illegal use of drugs among the U.S. population had increased 30 percent.

Chapter 4
The First Year: New York City

1. New York City Area Service Newsletter, vol.1, issue 1. April 1982.
2. Ibid.
3. Nona B speaking at the Spiritual Breakfast, WCNA 13, September 4, 1983.
4. David Musto, American Disease, p. 253. "While methadone treatment

expanded, some communities grew suspicious that those administrating the federal program had insidious motives and that the drug was actually extremely dangerous." Stephen Kendall, MD, Substance and Shadow, 1996. "Political forces reduced methadone to an inexpensive, stripped-down way to "control" a generation of addicts without having to provide essential rehabilitative services. . . . The vastly expanded program of the early 1970s was not based on the model whose success Dole and Nyswander had demonstrated."

5. Op cit.

Chapter 8: The Impossible Dream

1. Bob Stone, My Years with Narcotics Anonymous, pp. 230-31.
2. Rosalie R, letter to the GNYRSO, June 1, 1995.
3. Tony D, excerpts from speaker tapes ca. 1984-1987.
4. Bob Stone, 271, 274.
5. Ibid, 279.
6. Ibid, 280.

Chapter 11: "Culture Change"

1. David Musto, The American Disease, 251-261. See also: "Cocaine creates no serious problems" in H. I. Kaplan et al, eds., Comprehensive Textbook of Psychiatry, 1980, pp. 1621-22.
2. The Crack Epidemic, www.drugfreeworld.org.
3. History of South Central Los Angeles, www.southcentralhistory,.com/crack=epidemic.php.
4. Bob Stone, My Years with Narcotics Anonymous, p. 356.
5. Ibid, p. 380.

Chapter 12: "Indivisible"

1. Bob Stone, My Years with Narcotics Anonymous, p. 194.
2. Ibid, p. 250.
3. Ibid, 201.
4. Ibid, 173.
5. September 1984 RSC minutes, Area reports.
6. Op cit., 232, 272.
7. The only Area minutes in our archives are from MBSI (formerly NYCAS), and H&I meetings did not appear on meeting lists until October 1984. The NYRSC is in need of additional

documentation so that the fellowship's archives can compile a complete and more accurate list of these earliest H&I meetings and when they started.

8. Bob Stone, 291-292.
9. Ibid, 344, 339-342
10. Temporary Working Guide to the Service Structure, 1984.
11. The breakdown of the $17,500 that the WCNA-13 Convention Committee sent to World Service is as follows: $4,000 to WCNA-14; $7,000 to World Service Conference; "$4,000 to World Service Office; $500 to World Literature Conference; $1,000 to International Conference Committee; $500 to World H&I; $500 to World Public Information.
12. January 1984 RSC minutes.
13. Letter from the Steering Committee to RSC members, February 2, 1984.
14. Bob Stone, pp. 296, 298.
15. From RSC minutes, November 23, 1984:

    (With names of members deleted): "4) review of NYCRSC voting procedure:
    MOTION: Refer item to Policy Committee. MOTION: Objection to consideration. MOTION failed to obtain 2/3 majority, 9 in favor, 3 opposed, 2 abstentions. MOTION. To change method of voting to give Steering Committee one collective vote, excluding RSR and RSR Alt. MOTION. Objection to consideration. MOTION FAILED to receive 2/3 majority, 5 in favor. . .
    ORIGINAL MOTION FAILED to obtain 2/3 majority, 8 in favor, 6 opposed, 1 abstention. MOTION. Make item first order of business at General Service Session. MOTION PASSED, 8 in favor, 5 opposed, 2 abstentions."
16. Letter from anonymous member of MBSI Area, April 19, 1985.
17. Bob Stone, p. 352.
18. RSC minutes, May 26, 1985.
18. Ob cit., p. 355.

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